

EMPTY ORIGIN

NORA WHITCOMB

1

CHAPTER ONE

“Don’t follow me. Wait for the fire.”

Vharos has almost nothing left in his health bar. Neither do I. Twelve of us have spent three hours learning how to die in this room, and Liam is about to die trying to heal me.

“Nyx, you’re out of range.”

“I know. Stay there.”

Black flame spreads across the obsidian between my character and the raid. There’s a gap opening on the left, the same gap that killed me on the last pull. I keep my thumb off Blink. My damage numbers stop. For one horrible second I can see the argument we’re going to have if this costs us the record.

The flame thins.

“Now. Left. Everyone left.”

Nyx flashes through first. I turn the camera, count the bodies coming behind her, and start hitting the boss again before I’ve finished counting. Liam’s heal lands. Somebody is yelling the last percent into my ear as if the game needs encouragement.

“HE’S DOWN! HE’S FUCKING DOWN!”

The scream detonates through my headset half a second before six other voices pile on top of it, and Discord stops being a conversation and becomes weather. Somebody wants the timer checked. Somebody is already clipping it. Somebody keeps saying my handle like a chant, Nyx, Nyx, you beautiful bitch, and I’m laughing too hard to answer any of them.

On my monitor, Vharos the Undying collapses to his knees in a storm of black fire, his enormous health bar finally, finally empty. His sword hits the obsidian floor first. His body follows with enough force to shake the camera.

[VHAROS THE UNDYING: DEFEATED]

[MYTHIC CLEAR]

[NEW SERVER RECORD: 06:42]

“Six forty-two!”

“Somebody send it to Derek.”

“Don’t,” I say, laughing into my hand. The bedroom wall is thin enough that I can hear my neighbor’s television through it. “Let him find it.”

A notification flashes in the corner of the screen.

Derek: fuck all of you

Too late.

There are eleven people watching my stream. Eleven. Not exactly the screaming stadium I picture whenever I tell myself NyxLive is going to take off someday, but eleven people just watched us beat Derek’s group by thirty-seven seconds, so tonight those eleven beautiful bastards are enough.

pixelwitch: LMAOOOOOO

BoredAtWork88: DEREK IN SHAMBLES

ManaAddict: nyx carried

Derek: banned

I lean toward my mic. “Thank you, ManaAddict. Finally, someone recognizes talent.”

“You died twice,” Liam says.

“Mechanics.”

“You blinked into lava.”

“Advanced mechanics.”

My chat fills with laughing emotes and I grin at the monitor, because this stupid, perfect little pocket of the night is why I keep doing it. I want eleven thousand someday. Enough that NyxLive stops being the thing I squeeze between classes and closing shifts and becomes the thing that pays rent, enough that I can hand in my apron at Brewed Awakening and never again ask another human being whether they want room for cream. For six hours I haven’t thought about tomorrow’s class or the milk crusted under the steam wand at work. Liam is still arguing with chat about my damage numbers. I turn him up.

And Nyx just killed Vharos the fucking Undying.

My stomach growls loudly enough that Liam hears it through the mic.

“What the hell was that?”

“Betrayal.” I pull the headset off one ear. “I need food.”

“At two thirteen in the morning?”

“Yes, Mom.”

“You have food?”

I look toward the kitchen. Technically. “Fuck you.”

More laughter follows me into the kitchen, headset hanging off one ear. Seven steps from my desk, eight if I avoid the floorboard that sounds like a

dying goose. The refrigerator hums beneath a cabinet door that hasn't closed properly since I moved in three months ago. Inside: ranch, three eggs, pickles, one slice of cheese, and a takeout container I am unwilling to acknowledge as mine. My emergency energy drink waits behind the milk.

Mom stood in this spot on move-in day with both refrigerator doors open.

"You know you can still come home, right?"

"I know."

"You could save money."

Dad appeared behind her carrying a box marked BATHROOM that contained my gaming speakers. "Your mother means please come home before this building kills you."

"This building is fine."

Something crashed upstairs. We all looked at the ceiling.

Dad waited a beat. "Convincing."

My bedroom at their house is probably cleaner than this entire apartment. Mom would feed me. Dad would pretend he wasn't checking the oil in my car every time I visited. Another year there and I could save enough to transfer somewhere better than community college.

I nudge the crooked cabinet shut with my shoulder. It swings open again. Mine, at least.

I take two of the eggs and reach back for the ranch. Mom would have questions. I close the refrigerator before I can start answering them.

My phone lights up on the counter while I'm cracking them.

MAYA SZCZEPANIAK

My college email insists on displaying my full name in aggressive capital letters. I used to dread the pause before it on an attendance sheet. In fourth grade Mrs. Henderson made three attempts before I interrupted.

"Sheh-PAN-yak. Like chef, but he lost the F. Then pan, like you cook eggs in. Then yak. Like the hairy cow."

"Chef without the F. Pan. Hairy cow."

"Yes."

"Sheh-pan-yak."

I gave her a solemn nod. "You may continue."

She had to hide her mouth behind the sheet while the class laughed. Nine-year-old me would still have traded it for Smith. At nineteen, I smile at the whole ridiculous thing on my phone before the screen goes dark.

The eggs hiss in the pan.

"Shit."

I rescue them a few seconds before they become charcoal, dump them onto a plate, and head back toward my desk with the food in one hand, the ranch bottle tucked against my ribs, and my phone gripped in my teeth, because I am not making two trips.

The boss's corpse still sprawls across my screen. Discord is still going, my stream is still live, and Nyx stands in the center of the shattered throne room looking fucking immaculate. Long pointed ears rise through silver-white hair. Her fitted black spellblade armor catches the dying glow of Vharos's flames in sharp lines of dark metal, with just enough exposed skin to make it abundantly clear that whoever designed the female elf armor understood their audience. I made her face as close to mine as the character creator would allow, same cheekbones, same mouth, same slightly upturned nose.

Better hair, obviously.

I set the plate beside my keyboard and the phone faceup by my mouse pad. By the time I've settled the headset over both ears, Liam wants another run.

Derek joins our voice channel just in time to say, "Absolutely fucking not."

"We have the strat now."

"I have class at nine," I say around a mouthful.

"Nyx, it's two fifteen."

"Six hours of sleep. Practically responsible."

"That is not how math works."

I grin and take another bite. My shoulders ache from the hunch, my eyes are dry, and Nyx is still standing over a dead king. I should log off.

I drag my mouse over his body and open the loot window. Three items. The first is useless to me, the second is useful to somebody else, which makes it almost as boring, and I'm already moving toward the third when I read the name.

My fork stops halfway back to the plate. "Oh, you have got to be kidding me."

"What?" Liam asks.

I click it.

[VHAROS'S EMBERGLASS SABER]

The preview opens across the center of my screen. The blade is long and narrow, black enough that the edges almost disappear against the interface, and translucent fractures run through the metal from hilt to tip with something molten glowing beneath them in slow golden pulses.

Discord detonates.

“That’s spellblade.”

“You already got the shoulders.”

“You’re insufferable.”

“I know,” I say, and hit Need.

The roll spins. Ninety-eight.

“Oh, fuck off,” Liam says, and I laugh hard enough that I almost choke on cold egg.

pixelwitch: RIGGED

ManaAddict: streamer loot

Derek: i hate this game

I equip it. Gold pulses through the blade’s black fractures, lighting Nyx’s hand.

“You’re checking whether it matches,” Liam says.

The violet glow on her shoulders looks awful beside it.

“I might need to change my shoulders.”

“You changed your mog between pulls.”

“It gave me confidence.”

Derek launches into a speech about how people like me have destroyed gaming, and I’m still laughing when something slips sideways inside my head.

The laugh fades. My chair seems to lean beneath me, and I set the fork down before my hand can decide otherwise.

“You okay?” Liam asks.

“Yeah.”

The monitor is suddenly too bright. Embers in the throne room sharpen into orange needles. A high tone starts inside my ears; I lift an earcup, but it stays.

I look at the eggs. When did I buy them? Last week? I can’t find the purchase in my head.

“I think I poisoned myself.”

“With what?”

“The eggs.”

Somebody laughs. I wait for my stomach to settle.

The room lurches. My hand hits the edge of the desk hard enough to rattle the keyboard, the fork jumps against the plate with a metallic clink, and for a few seconds the apartment keeps moving even though nothing in it does.

Nobody laughs this time.

“Nyx?”

I hold on until the floor feels trustworthy again. “I’m...”

The word sticks. I move my tongue across the back of my teeth and it feels thick, slow. Swallowing should happen without instructions. Instead I have to think about it, and even then there’s a delay before my throat obeys.

“Maya?”

That gets my attention. Almost nobody here calls me Maya. Nyx is easier, Nyx is the name over my character and beside my messages and under my stream, and Liam knows my real name but uses it so rarely that hearing it through my headset changes the shape of the room.

I reach for my phone. My hand lands beside it.

The phone is right there, faceup near my mouse pad, and my fingers missed it by maybe two inches. I reach again, and my knuckles catch the case and knock it farther across the desk.

“Shit.”

“Maya, what’s happening?”

“I don’t know.”

The voices in Discord have begun to stretch. Everyone is still talking, but distance has crept into the sound and turned familiar voices thin around the edges. Liam asks me something. Derek says my name. Somebody talks across both of them. I catch call someone and lose the rest.

I push my chair back because I need to do something, and getting water is the first useful idea that survives long enough to act on. The wheels roll backward. The entire apartment rolls with them. Both hands lock around the edge of the desk while nausea sweeps through me, heavy enough to make my mouth flood.

“Maya, call somebody.”

“I’m fine.”

“You are clearly not fucking fine.”

“Maya, call your parents.”

“I’m nineteen.”

“What the fuck does that have to do with anything?”

There should be an answer. I can feel one, but the words won’t come.

My eyes drift back to the monitor. Nyx stands exactly where I left her, silver-white hair, black armor, new saber burning gold at her hip, Vharos on the dark floor behind her. Chat keeps moving. I focus on a message long enough to recognize my own name. The rest smears.

The ringing has swollen until it seems to occupy the space where everyone’s voices used to be. My arms are getting harder to move, the weight settling through them so gradually that I only understand how bad it is when I reach for my headset and my hand rises halfway before stopping.

I try again, catch one earcup with my fingers, and drag it off. It lands beside my keyboard, and Discord becomes a faint spill of voices through the speakers.

“Maya? Can you hear me?”

My phone is less than a foot away. I know what to do. Pick it up. Call somebody.

My arm moves several inches before the muscles give out. My fingertips scrape the desk. I try again, staring at the phone’s black screen. My elbow trembles. Nothing.

I stop trying to remember when I bought the eggs.

I open my mouth. “Mom.”

The word comes out quietly. I picture her asleep with her phone charging on the nightstand, the volume too low, the way I complain about every time she misses one of my calls.

I’ll call twice. If she doesn’t answer the first one, I’ll call twice.

I plant my palm against the desk and try to push myself closer. My arm folds. I catch myself on both forearms before I can slide out of the chair, and the movement sends another slow wave through the room. Lowering my forehead onto my arms eases it a little. The skin there is cool against my face.

Just until the room stops. Then the phone.

Liam’s voice leaks from the headset beside me, joined by several others now, the urgency legible even where the words aren’t. Someone says ambulance. Someone asks where I live.

I know my address. Of course I know my address. I try to give it to them, and nothing useful leaves my mouth.

I can see Nyx’s boots from here. The lower edge of her armor, firelight on obsidian. I try to lift my head enough to see the rest, and nothing happens.

Class at nine. I need to call Mom. My phone.

“Maya?”

The last thing I know about Earth is the hiss of my headset, the smell of overcooked eggs, and eleven people watching Nyx stand victorious over a dead king.

Cold touches my cheek.

I flinch away from it without opening my eyes, turning my face into something soft and damp, and another drop lands near my temple and slides into my hair. For a while I lie there trying to understand why my ceiling is leaking on me. The thought doesn’t survive long. My ceiling is six feet above my bed, for one thing. Also I’m not in my bed. I wasn’t even in bed.

I was at my desk.

My eyes open.

Gray fills my vision, enormous and shifting. It isn't drywall and it isn't the weak predawn light that leaks through the bent blinds in my bedroom. It moves, clouds folding over one another across a sky so wide my brain refuses to make sense of it.

A raindrop hits me directly in the eye.

"Fuck."

I squeeze it shut, turn my head, and grass brushes my lips. Actual grass.

I go still. Rain taps against leaves somewhere nearby, thousands of soft impacts gathering into a steady whisper. Something cold has soaked through the side of my shirt. Damp earth presses against my hip and shoulder, and the air smells green and wet, rich with soil and crushed plants and something faintly sweet I can't place.

I push myself onto one elbow, and the world tilts hard enough that I stop there, breathing through a wave of nausea that brings the eggs back with unfortunate clarity. The eggs. My desk. Liam saying my name through the headset. My phone sitting just out of reach. Mom. I remember trying to get to it, and then nothing.

"What the fuck?"

My voice disappears into the rain. I sit up, and forget about the eggs.

I'm in a clearing. Tall grass bends beneath the rain in every direction, silver-green blades brushing my bare legs, tiny white flowers clustered among them with their petals folded tight against the weather. Beyond the clearing a forest rises beneath the bruised sky, and for several seconds all I can do is stare.

The trees are enormous. Their pale trunks climb straight out of the dark undergrowth, broad enough that I couldn't get both arms around one even with three people helping, smooth ivory bark darkening in the rain, the lowest branches beginning high enough to scrape the roof off my apartment building. The leaves are wrong too, long and narrow and almost blue beneath the clouds, overlapping in dense layers that turn everything past them into shadow. Rain catches along their edges before spilling toward the ground in shining streams, and mist moves slowly between the trunks.

I stare up through the pale branches until rain runs into my open mouth. I've scrolled past pictures like this and assumed somebody was lying about the filters.

Then I turn my head.

The clearing slopes gently downward before disappearing into another stretch of forest, and beyond that, through a break in the trees, mountains

cut across the horizon. Jagged black ridges spear up through banks of cloud, their highest peaks lost completely inside the storm. Waterfalls thread down the nearest slopes in thin white lines, too distant to hear, bright enough to see whenever the clouds shift.

I have never seen those mountains.

I get to my feet too fast. Blood drains out of my head, the clearing lurches sideways, and I stagger before catching myself with one hand against the wet ground.

“Okay.”

My breathing sounds too loud out here. I straighten more carefully and look down at myself. Bare feet planted in wet grass. Black sleep shorts plastered against my thighs. An oversized T-shirt with CRIT HAPPENS printed across the chest. No bra. My shirt clings cold against my nipples. I pull it away from my skin.

I pat my pockets even though I already know what’s going to happen. Nothing. Of course nothing, they’re sleep shorts. I check again anyway, then turn and scan the grass around me, because my phone could have fallen somewhere, except I remember it sitting on my desk, and my desk isn’t here. Neither is my chair. Or my computer. Or my apartment.

I look toward the forest. There has to be something beyond it. A road. A campground. A house. Some asshole with a camera about to leap out from behind one of those trees and explain whatever elaborate prank I’ve somehow become important enough to deserve.

I turn, listening. No engine, no traffic, no voices. Just rain striking leaves.

Kansas City doesn’t have mountains.

Maybe someone moved me. Drugged me. But Liam was there, and the stream was running. Someone would have seen.

I look down at my hands. Same short nails. Same tiny white scar beside my left thumb from opening a can when I was twelve and refusing to wait for Dad to find the proper opener. I touch my face, fingertips moving over my nose, my cheek, my mouth, then shove wet hair away from my forehead.

I’m me. So where the fuck am I?

Something clamps around my chest. I drag in a breath and it stops halfway. I try again, harder, and somehow get less air.

“No.”

My hands are shaking. I press them against my thighs. A hospital. I could be dreaming in a hospital.

I squeeze my eyes shut. My heart pounds harder in the darkness, and when I open them there are pale trunks and blue-black leaves and mountains and rain.

A sound slips out of me, small and thin, and I don't recognize it as mine until another one tries to follow. My lungs start working too fast. Air keeps stopping high in my chest, each breath arriving before the last one has finished, and my fingers are tingling, and then my lips. I know this. I'm breathing too fast. Slow down.

I can't.

I wrap my arms around myself and turn, searching the clearing again, though I've stopped knowing what I'm searching for. A road. A person. My apartment.

I want my phone. The need hits so hard my hand goes to my empty pocket again. I want my apartment. I want the stupid cabinet that doesn't close unless I kick the bottom corner. I want Liam yelling through my headset. I want my desk, my bed, my fucking shoes.

I want my dad.

Everything stops.

He would know what to do. I need him to know what to do.

"Dad?"

It comes out before I can stop it, too quiet, and nothing answers. Of course nothing answers.

Rain slides down my face. I wipe at it, and my hand comes away wet, and I don't know how much of it is rain anymore.

"Dad!"

My voice cracks across the clearing. The forest takes his name and gives nothing back.

"Dad!"

I claw at the collar of my shirt and drag it away from my throat. It doesn't help. Air keeps coming in tiny useless pieces, my lungs fluttering faster while my heart hammers so violently that for one insane second I'm certain I died at my desk and I'm dying again now.

Liam saw me collapse. He'll call someone. They'll find my apartment, and they'll call my parents, and Mom is going to think I'm dead.

That one gets me all the way to the ground.

I make a strangled sound and clamp both hands over my mouth, which only makes the next breath worse, so I rip them away. My vision pulses at the edges. Some part of me keeps waiting for reality to snap back into place, for my bedroom to appear around me, for Liam's voice to come through the headset, for Dad to answer.

The rain thickens instead. Drops strike hard enough now to flatten the little white flowers around my feet, and wind pushes through the clearing, cold against my soaked shirt, carrying the smell of stone and leaves and distant water.

Then the sky growls, low and far away.

I freeze. The sound rolls across the mountains, deep enough that I feel a faint vibration beneath my bare feet. A pale flash flickers somewhere behind the clouds, and the answering crack comes harder.

Every hair on my arms rises.

The next flash lights the grass all the way to the trees. I'm out in the middle of it, barefoot. I crouch before I know what I'm doing.

"Okay." My voice shakes badly enough that the word barely exists. I swallow. "Okay, Maya."

I don't have to understand where I am. Not right now. I don't have to understand how I got here. Another flash turns the clouds white and the thunder answers sooner, and the only thing I have to do is get out of the open. One thing. I can do one thing.

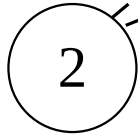
I look toward the nearest trees. The forest that seemed beautiful ten minutes ago now looks deep enough to swallow me, darkness gathering between the pale trunks, mist crawling low through undergrowth I can't identify. I have no idea what lives in there. Snakes. Bears. Wolves. People. Something I don't have a name for.

My feet won't move.

Thunder rolls again, closer, and I force one foot forward, then the other, and somewhere between the middle of the clearing and the treeline I start counting the way Dad taught me on the porch the summer I was seven. One thousand one. One thousand two.

The thunder comes before I reach three.

I go in.



CHAPTER TWO

Ten steps into the trees the rain stops falling on me, which is the last good thing that happens for a long time.

Water collects far above me and falls in heavy splashes through the leaves. The ground is worse. Whatever grows here has spent centuries composting itself into a black spongy layer that swallows my feet past the ankle, and there's no way to tell which parts of it are soft and which parts are hiding something with edges. Ferns as high as my hip slap wet across my thighs. The air smells like rot and green sap, colder under the trees than it was in the open, and every few steps a bead of water finds the back of my neck and runs the whole length of my spine.

Thunder cracks behind me. I flinch hard enough to put my shoulder into a trunk, and the ivory bark turns out to be rough as concrete.

"Okay," I tell the tree.

Talking helps. It shouldn't, but it does, so I keep doing it, narrating like I'm on stream with eleven people watching, because the only other thing to listen to is how quiet a forest gets between thunderclaps.

The plan, such as it is, lasts about as long as it takes to say it out loud. I'd meant to go downhill, since water goes downhill and rivers go past towns and towns have people in them, which is the kind of reasoning that sounds excellent right up until you try to execute it barefoot. The slope keeps folding into little ravines full of standing water. Twice I get turned around badly enough that I have to stop and find the mountains again through a gap in the branches, and the second time I can't, because the cloud has come down into the trees and the world has shrunk to forty feet of dripping gray.

My foot finds something buried and sharp, and my weight is already on it before I understand what's happening.

The pain arrives a full second late, bright and specific along the arch of my left foot. I go down onto one knee in the muck, grab my ankle with both hands, and haul my foot into my lap. It's too dark to see much. What I can see is a clean line about two inches long, open, filling slowly.

“No, no, no, no.”

Some part of me observes that I’m bleeding, that bleeding is a debuff, and that debuffs tick, and I laugh once at how useless six years of raid logic has turned out to be. The sound comes out ugly enough that I stop.

I bite through the hem of my shirt and tear off a strip three fingers wide. I wind it twice around the arch, knot it on top of my foot, and pull the knot tight enough that my eyes water. Cold air moves across my exposed stomach.

I get upright with one hand on my knee. The foot takes my weight until I try to move; then I have to catch myself and shorten the step. I keep that step for the next one.

The light goes while I’m still walking. It doesn’t set so much as drain, gray thinning down through the trunks until I’m navigating by the paleness of the bark, and by then the shivering has started.

It comes in waves, jaw and shoulders and hands all going at once, and at first I’m almost relieved, because shivering is a thing bodies do and I recognize it. Then it stops for a while. That’s the part that frightens me. It stops, and I feel warmer, and some slow flat voice in the back of my skull points out that I have absolutely no business feeling warmer. Off the wet ground. Under something. I say it out loud twice while I look, because the space between having the thought and doing anything about it keeps getting wider.

I find the fallen tree by walking into it.

It came down a long time ago, one of the pale giants pulled over at the root, and the plate of roots it dragged out of the earth stands higher than my apartment ceiling, a wall of dirt and wood and hanging stones. Beneath it the trunk has rotted back into a hollow, dry-ish, floored with years of shed leaves. I crouch at the opening and listen. Something could live in there. I can’t hear past the rain, and my legs are shaking too hard to keep me up, so I crawl inside with one hand stretched ahead of my face.

The hollow smells like a wet basement. I rake leaves over my legs with both arms until I’m buried past the waist, then keep going until the pile covers my stomach and my chest and everything but my face. The leaves are cold. They stay cold for a long time. Eventually they stop stealing from me and start giving a little back, and somewhere in there the shivering comes back hard enough to knock my teeth together.

I lie in the dark of a dead tree with my foot throbbing in time with my pulse, and I let myself think about my mother.

She’ll be at the hospital by now, or standing in my kitchen with a police officer explaining that nobody has found anything yet. I can see her hands.

She does this thing where she holds one wrist with the other when she's frightened, like she's taking her own pulse. Dad will be driving. Dad drives when he can't fix anything, and this is the most unfixable thing that has ever happened to our family, so he'll drive very carefully and very slowly and he won't say one word the entire way.

I press the heels of my hands into my eyes until colors come.

Then a branch snaps outside, and I stop with my hands still over my face.

It's close, close enough that I can hear the separate pieces of it: the suck and release of something heavy pulling its foot out of wet ground, a pause, another step. Whatever it is, it isn't in a hurry. It stops close to the hollow. I press my lips together.

Through the gap between the leaf pile and the lip of the hollow I can see maybe eight feet of the outside world, and after a moment part of that world darkens.

A leg comes into view. That's all I get. It's grayish and long and it bends in a place legs do not bend, and the foot at the bottom of it splays wide across the mud, four toes, no claws I can see, the skin cracked and pale like something left too long in water. It stops. It stands there. Rain runs off it without any of the flinching that rain causes in things I know.

I don't breathe.

Then, above the leg, four or five feet higher than the top of my sightline, something glows.

It's faint, and green, and it hangs in the air the way nothing hangs in the air. I can see the underside of it as a soft smear of light on the wet bark near the creature's shoulder. It flickers once. The leg lifts, splays down again farther on, and the light goes with it, sliding between the trunks until the mist takes both.

I stay where I am for a long, long time.

At some point I fall asleep. I simply stop, and then the world is gray and the rain has quit and my whole body has locked into one enormous ache.

I don't get up right away. I lie in my leaf pile and take stock the way I would after a bad wipe, when everyone is dead on the floor and somebody has to say something useful before Derek starts assigning blame. The foot is bad and getting worse. I work my fingers into the leaves, checking that I can still feel each one. I've been drinking off leaves, which is probably how you contract whatever the fantasy version of giardia is, and I haven't eaten since the eggs, and I am sharing this forest with something whose knee opens backward.

Also there had been a light. I have been carefully not thinking about the light.

I crawl out into a forest gone soft and pearly with dawn, mist lying in the hollows between roots, water still coming down off the leaves in bright irregular ticks. A drop catches the light just before it falls. I watch for the next one, my hand still on the hollow's edge.

The animal notices me at the same moment I notice it.

It's rabbit-shaped in the loosest possible sense, sitting up on its haunches in a patch of low ferns thirty feet away, gray-brown, ears lying flat along its spine instead of standing up. Its eyes are set on the front of its skull, both of them facing me, the way eyes are arranged on things that hunt.

Above it, hanging in the wet air, is a line of pale green letters.

I stop moving. So does it. I look at the words floating over its head, and I know exactly what I'm looking at, because I have looked at ten thousand of them. It's a nameplate. There is a nameplate hovering over a rabbit in a forest, holding perfectly level and perfectly legible no matter which way the head underneath it turns.

The letters are not English. They aren't anything, a dense little run of hooks and strokes, and I stare at them the way you stare at a word you've forgotten how to read, and then they slide sideways in my vision and settle.

[BRIAR-SKIPPER, LV. 3]

"No," I say.

The thing bolts. Its nameplate goes with it, the ferns swallow both, and I'm left standing barefoot in the mist with my hands out in front of me like I'm about to catch something.

I look at my hands.

Nothing hangs over them. Nothing hangs over me at all. I turn in a full slow circle, and the forest offers me one more nameplate, small and dim, over something moving high up in the blue-black leaves, and then nothing else. I hold my palm out and say, feeling like the stupidest human being ever to draw breath, "Status."

Water ticks off the leaves.

"Menu. Inventory. Help."

"Please." I try pressing my palm, then my wrist. Nothing. Then I sit on a root, stretch my bad foot in front of me, and wrap my arms around my ribs. I keep looking for writing over my own skin.

There's a system here. Everything in this forest is inside it.

I'm not.

Nyx had a health bar. She had a resource bar and cooldowns and a little icon that told her when she was bleeding and exactly how long it would last, and Nyx is a set of files on a server in a country I have never visited, standing where I left her in a dead king's throne room with a sword she won on a ninety-eight roll.

Something moves downhill.

It's faster than the wind in the leaves and lighter than whatever walked past my tree in the dark, and there's a rhythm to it, an even one, the kind that only comes off two legs. I'm up off the root before I've finished hearing it, weight on the wrong foot, pain climbing my shin.

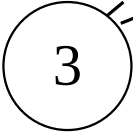
Down the slope, through the mist, a nameplate kindles.

It's brighter than the rabbit's. It comes up out of the gray in clean pale letters, and it holds steady, and it climbs. Whoever is carrying it is walking straight up the hill toward me and making no effort at all to be quiet about it.

The hollow is four steps behind me. The leaves in there are still shaped around where I slept, and I stand with my weight on my good foot and don't take a single one of those steps, because I have been alone in this forest for one night and I already know what a second one would do to me.

The letters come clear about twenty feet out.

[TRAVELER, LV. 11]



3

CHAPTER THREE

He stops farther out than he needs to.

He stays about fifteen feet away, hands loose at his sides. Water falls between us. I have one hand against a trunk, and when I try to shift my weight the cut opens again.

He looks at my foot.

I want him to come closer. That is how quickly it happens.

He is young, not a teenager but not far past whatever this place does instead, and my brain starts handing me observations in an order that has nothing to do with survival. Dark hair pushed back wet off his forehead. A coat that fits like somebody measured him for it. The fact that he is standing in a soaked forest at dawn looking like he slept somewhere with a roof over him. There is a bow across his back and something shorter riding his hip and a strap running diagonally over his chest, and I get to all of that a solid two seconds after I get to his mouth.

I make myself look at the bow again.

He is not looking at my face. His eyes sit higher, angled at a spot somewhere above my head, and they stay there while the rest of him does nothing at all. I put a hand up into my hair, which is currently a knotted disaster with actual forest in it, and his attention does not follow the movement even a little.

Then he says something, and it lands wrong.

It arrives as sound before it arrives as language, dense and clipped, a run of syllables my ear cannot file. I am already opening my mouth to tell him I don't understand when the sound slides sideways behind my eyes, the way the letters over the rabbit did, and settles.

"You're a long way from a road."

His mouth has already stopped by the time I hear it. Half a second, maybe less. I try to fit the words to the movement I just saw, but he is waiting for an answer, and I can understand him. I nearly laugh with relief.

"Yeah." Gravel comes out with it. "I've been having a night."

His head tips a fraction. Whatever he heard in that is apparently worth more than the words, because his attention finally comes down off the thing he was studying and lands on my face, which turns out to be worse. His eyes move over the shirt with CRIT HAPPENS half erased under the mud, the torn hem, the bare stretch of stomach where the strip came off, the shorts, my legs, my feet. At the foot he stops.

“Is there anybody with you?”

“No.”

“Was there?”

“No.”

He takes that in. Behind him the mist is coming off the slope in pieces now, and somewhere below us a bird is making a noise like a spoon dragged round a pot, and I lift my bad foot clear of the mud. He notices that too.

“What do you run?”

The words came through cleanly. I repeat them in my head, waiting for the rest of the meaning. Run what? A business? He is watching me as though this should be easy.

“Sorry. What?”

He waits. I shift my weight, and his eyes follow the movement. I wish he would ask something else.

“What do you run?” he says again, identical, no help added.

“I don’t understand the question.”

Something moves behind his eyes, small, and it is not confusion. His attention shifts above my head again.

Fine. Two can be strange at each other. I lift my palm, feeling like the single stupidest human being to draw breath on any world, and say, “Status.”

Water ticks off the leaves. Down the slope the bird works through its material.

He laughs. Barely, a breath out through the nose and a shift at one corner of his mouth, and there is nothing cruel in it, which is somehow more insulting, because cruel would mean I had registered as a threat. I lower my hand.

“Great,” I say.

“You’re bleeding through.”

I follow him down to my own foot. The strip of shirt around my arch has gone from gray to a color I would rather not name, and while I was up here conducting first contact, a thin dark line has been running the outside edge of my sole into the mud. It does not hurt any more than it did an hour

ago. I have a strong feeling that is not the good news it sounds like.

He crosses the distance without asking, which after all that careful fifteen feet happens fast, and then he is crouched in front of me with a hand hovering near my ankle. "Can I?"

"Yes."

His fingers close around my heel and lift, and I have to grab his shoulder or fall over, so I grab his shoulder. He is warm. He is so warm that touching him actually hurts, a deep ache spreading up through my palm into my wrist, and that is when I understand how cold I have been since yesterday, not as a fact I have been reciting at myself all night, but as something my body has been screaming about underneath the recitation.

He turns my foot toward the light and peels the knot up with a thumbnail. Whatever is under there he does not editorialize about, though something happens along his jaw.

"How long?"

"Yesterday. Before dark."

"You slept out here with this."

"I slept in a tree." Out loud that sounds worse. "Inside one. It was already down."

He sets my foot back into the mud with more care than the rest of him has shown so far, stands, and looks at me from a foot and a half away, and I get the whole effect at once: gray eyes, a scar cut through one eyebrow, leather and wet wool and old woodsmoke. Close enough that I can watch him make a decision.

"Close it," he says.

"Close what?"

The pause after that is the longest one yet, and he spends all of it completely still.

"Your foot." Slower. "Close it."

"I don't." My throat clicks. "I don't know how to do that."

I wait for him to explain. He doesn't. His gaze lifts above my head again. Whatever he is reading there seems to hold him longer this time. I pull the waterlogged shirt away from my stomach.

He reaches past me instead, unhooks a skin from his belt, works the tie loose and puts it in my hands, then goes into the pack at his hip for a folded square of cloth that is clean in a way nothing in my life has been clean since the clearing. He kneels again and rewraps the arch, tight, then tighter, and I hiss through my teeth and dig into his shoulder and he does not apologize.

"Drink that," he says, without looking up. "All of it."

I drink it. It is water, faintly of the skin it lives in, and it is the best thing that has ever entered my body.

“There’s a village.” He ties off the wrap. “Not close. Keep walking on this the way you’ve been walking on it and you get about a day before it stops being about the foot.”

“Okay.”

“You want to come.”

He waits, crouched with his forearms on one knee. I look past him at the trees. I cannot walk another day on this foot.

“Yes,” I say anyway.

He nods once and rises, and then, easy, brushing dirt off his knee, in the voice you would use about weather: “Who set your plate?”

The word comes through like all the others, clean and settled and completely empty. Plate. My head offers me a dinner plate, a license plate, the great disc of roots standing on end behind me where the tree came down. I look at him and wait for the rest of it and the rest of it does not come.

“I don’t know what that means.”

Not a flicker. He puts a hand under my elbow and I lean on him before he has finished getting his arm beneath mine.

“Then don’t say that again until we’re inside,” he says. “Not to anyone. Can you manage that?”

“Say what?”

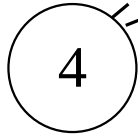
“Any of it.” He starts us downhill, taking my weight on the bad side before I can ask, his voice dropping in low beside my ear. “You’ve got a face people want to help. Let them.”

I should ask his name. I get halfway into it and he is already talking about the creek at the bottom and where the crossing is, and the question folds up behind my teeth, because I am being carried down a mountain by somebody warm who gave me water, and asking for more feels like ingratitude.

He never asks mine, either.

He does not ask where I came from, or how I got up here without shoes, or what happened to the rest of my clothes, or who I have lost. He asks about the foot twice and the water once, and then he tells me a long and genuinely funny story about a mule, and I laugh in the wrong places because I am shaking too hard to time anything. At the far bank he asks whether I can see smoke. I look where he points, still trying to remember what I was going to ask him.

By then the sun is properly up, and his coat is around my shoulders, and I am so grateful I could put my face in my hands.



CHAPTER FOUR

He makes me eat before he lets me ask anything.

What he puts in my hand is a strip of dried something the color of an old belt, and it takes three tries to work out that I am supposed to gnaw at it rather than bite through it. It tastes of salt and smoke. By the fourth mouthful my jaw aches, but I can't make myself save any. I keep tearing pieces off with my back teeth.

He watches me get through half the strip and then holds the water out again without being asked.

"Slower," he says.

"I'm going slow."

"You're going fast in small pieces."

We follow the creek down through the early morning. It is easier than the slope was and worse than it looks, because the bank is all rounded stone and each one presses into the cut in my left foot. He sets a pace that seems lazy for about ten minutes and then reveals itself as the exact speed at which I can keep moving without stopping. He does not comment when I fall behind, and he does not slow down either. He simply drifts wider on the bad side, so that every time my ankle rolls there is a shoulder somewhere in the vicinity of my hand.

Around the second bend the creek widens and the trees pull back off the water, and light comes down into the channel the way it has not since I got here. Steam lifts off the wet stones. Small brown things with too many legs skitter into the cracks when my shadow crosses them, but none has letters over its head. I bend to check the next crack until my foot starts to throb.

He stops at a flat shelf of rock and crouches to refill the skin. While the water runs he presses two fingers into the notch at the base of his throat and holds them there, eyes gone middle distance, the way you check a phone at a stoplight.

"Are we close?" I ask.

He takes his hand down. "Today, if your foot holds. Late afternoon, perhaps."

By midmorning the creek meets something that people made. It is not a road yet, only a groove worn into the turf by a hundred years of the same cart, grass standing up between the ruts and a stone at the fork with marks cut into it that slide sideways in my vision and settle into a word I do not recognize as a place. My chest does something complicated at the sight of those ruts. Somebody drove here. Somebody had somewhere to be.

I have been walking behind a man for four hours and I still do not know what to call him.

“What’s your name?”

He is a few steps ahead. He does not stop or turn, but the answer takes long enough that I hear him decide to give it.

“Tolliver.”

“Tolliver.”

“Toll, mostly. Tolliver’s what my mother uses when I’ve cost her money.”

I laugh. It comes out without a shiver, and for a moment I hear my own voice again. “Maya,” I say. “I’m Maya.”

“Maya,” he says, and keeps walking.

I wait for a question, but he just steps around a puddle and offers his shoulder again. I have only given him the easy part. For now I leave it there.

The lessons start after that, and they come the way he does everything, sideways and without warning. Do not sit with my back to the road. Do not accept a first price. If somebody asks where I have come from, name the last place the two of us have actually walked past and let them do the rest of the work themselves. Do not touch anyone’s shoulder. That last one arrives with no explanation, and when I ask for one he says, “It’s a shoulder,” in the voice of a man being asked why you should not put your hand in someone’s mouth.

Then he says, “And when we get in, keep your plate shut.”

I stop walking.

He goes another three paces before he notices, and when he turns there is nothing at all on his face, which is worse than if he had looked caught.

“What’s a plate?” I say.

The creek fills the gap. Somewhere behind us a bird works through the same four notes it has been working through for an hour.

“You’ve seen one,” he says.

“I’ve seen a lot of things since yesterday.”

He lifts two fingers and taps the air above his own head, twice, without looking up, the way you would point at a hat you were already wearing.

“There.”

And there it is. Where it has been since he came up out of the mist, where it was over the rabbit and over the thing high in the leaves and over whatever walked past my tree in the dark on a knee that bent the wrong way. Pale letters holding perfectly level while he moves underneath them.

[TRAVELER, LV. 11]

“That’s not your name,” I say.

“No.”

“So it’s what, a title? Something you picked?”

“Something I set.” He is watching me the way he watched me on the hill, and I know now that the look means I have handed him something again without meaning to. “Everybody sets one. You set it to whatever gets you through a gate with the fewest questions attached. Mine says traveler because traveler is the most boring word in the world and nobody has ever followed a traveler home.”

“And underneath it there’s...”

“What you’d rather not give a stranger.”

Water catches against a stone beside his boot. I look from his letters to the empty air above me.

“What does mine say?”

Tolliver looks above my head before he answers. I want to grab his coat and make him hurry.

“Your name,” he says.

“My name.”

“All of it.”

I put my hand up over my own head. Nothing. Of course nothing. I did this at dawn. I stood in a dripping forest and turned all the way around and found nothing over myself, and I sat down on a root and told myself the true thing plainly, and the true thing I came up with was that I was outside the machine.

“I can’t see it.”

“Nobody sees their own.” He says it patiently, and the patience is what gets me, because you are only that patient with a person who is missing something enormous. “You’d go mad. It would be like a word stuck to the front of your eye.”

“Then how do you know what yours says?”

“Because I set it.”

Cold climbs my chest and it has nothing to do with the water or the shirt. I have been in this world since yesterday afternoon. I crouched in a rotted trunk and bled into the mud and stood in a clearing screaming for my

father, and every second of it happened underneath my own name, hung in the air over my head in letters bright enough to read across a clearing, in a place where every living person learned to cover theirs before they learned to read them.

“How far away can you see it?”

He looks off down the ruts toward the mill we have not reached, then back at me, and he tells me the truth, which I will be turning over for a long time.

“I read yours from the bottom of the hill.”

The bird runs its four notes again.

He had read my name before he gave me water. All morning he let me answer questions without telling me I was wearing some of the answers.

“Why didn’t you tell me then?”

“You needed to walk.”

“I could have done both.”

He tightens the cap on the waterskin. I wait for him to look up, but he puts it away instead.

“Okay,” I say. “Show me how to close it.”

Something in his shoulders comes down half an inch.

“Two fingers.” He puts his own to the hollow of his throat, and my stomach drops, because he has done that a dozen times since dawn and I filed every one of them as a nervous habit. “Here. Press until it goes soft. Then don’t take them off, or you’ll lose it.”

I press two fingers into the notch above my collarbone. Skin. It stays skin long enough that I begin assembling the joke I am going to make about it.

Then it goes soft.

There is no better word. The pressure under my fingertips stops being flesh and turns into something with give in it, like pushing up on the underside of water, and the creek and the ruts and Tolliver all slide back half a step without moving at all, and hanging in front of my face, close enough that I flinch, is writing.

The letters do what they always do, a dense little run of hooks and strokes my eye refuses and then abruptly accepts.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 1]

[ORIGIN:]

I stop breathing.

My fingers stay pressed to my throat. I read the name again, all the way through, before I remember to let the air out.

Szczepaniak. Spelled right. At work my manager wrote SHEP on my cup. Here, in a script I could not have read yesterday, every letter of my father's name is accounted for.

Something has been keeping track of me.

"Level one," I say. My voice comes out wrong.

"Yes."

"Is that bad?"

"On a child it's nothing." He has come closer without my hearing him. "On you they'll ask who kept you from learning. Or what you did to lose it."

Underneath the level there is a colon and then a clean pale gap where a word should be sitting, and it frightens me more than the number does, because a number can at least be argued with.

"What goes there?"

"Where you're held. Where you're from, if you'd rather have it that way. A holding, a house, a company, a temple. Something answerable." He says it flatly. "Everyone has one. Foundlings have one. The man who clears the ditch outside the wall has one."

"Mine's empty."

"Mine isn't." He waits until I look at him. "That's what turns you away at a gate, Maya. Not the level. The level makes them curious. The gap makes them careful."

"Read it to me."

"You're looking right at it."

"I know."

He does not ask why, which is its own small mercy, and he does not make a performance of it either. He just reads it out. Maya Szczepaniak. Chef who lost the F, then pan, then the hairy cow, every consonant landing where my father lands them, the whole ridiculous machine of it running clean off the tongue of a man who has never heard of any of those things.

Nobody gets it the first time. In nineteen years, nobody has ever once gotten it the first time.

He never looked up to read it.

I keep my fingers at my throat until he asks whether I want to learn the rest.

He talks me through the rest with a hand on my elbow. There is a place inside the panel that gives the way my throat gave, and behind it a short list of plain words, which must be the reason every plate on this road says something boring. He tells me not to take traveler. Two travelers walking in together invites the sort of question he has spent his life not being asked. He

runs through others. Laborer. Pilgrim. Hand.

“Household,” he says, and stops there.

“What’s that one mean?”

“That somebody’s answerable for you.” He is watching the letters and not me. “Out here that beats being nobody’s.”

I take it.

My fingers come off my throat and the writing folds down out of the air, and his eyes track up and to the left, to the place above my head he has been reading since the bottom of the hill.

He nods once.

“What does it say now?”

“Household. Level one.”

“It still shows the level.”

“It always shows the level. That’s what it’s for.” He is already moving, already turning us back down the ruts with his hand under my arm, and his voice drops low and close and easy the way it did on the slope. “Which is why you’re going to let me do the talking at the gate. All of it. Even if they put the question straight to you. You look at me and you let it be rude.”

“They’ll think I’m simple.”

“They’ll think you’re mine,” he says, “and simple, and nobody has ever been hanged for either.”

“Mine?”

“At the gate,” he says. “Only at the gate.”

He offers his arm again. I take it.

“Okay.”

We walk. The ruts deepen and firm up, and after a while there is a fence, a built thing, split rails gone silver with weather, and beyond it a field with rows in it. I have to stop and put my hand on the top rail, because rows mean somebody knelt down and made them.

Tolliver waits.

“Sorry,” I say. “It’s a fence.”

“It is.”

“You don’t understand. It’s a fence.”

Whatever crosses his face is gone before I can name it. He starts us walking again, and I am four or five steps along before I hear my own voice ask the thing I have been carrying since he found me.

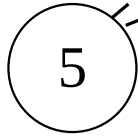
“You asked me what I ran. Twice. I never answered you.”

“You answered.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“I know,” Tolliver says.

Ahead of us the ruts run down toward a line of smoke standing straight up out of the trees, and he tells me the name of the mill we are about to pass, twice, until I can repeat it. So that when somebody asks me where I have come from, I will have somewhere true to say.



CHAPTER FIVE

The first person we pass beyond the mill is a woman with a goat.

She comes up the road in the other direction not an hour after we pass the mill, one hand knotted in a rope, the goat pulling toward the ditch, and I see her plate long before I see her face, riding in the air over her head at the exact height Tolliver's rides over his.

[CARTER, LV. 8]

She nods at Tolliver. Tolliver nods back. She looks at me for slightly longer than she looks at him, and her eyes go up and to the left, and then she is past us and she is swearing as the goat drags her off the road, and my heart is going like I have been caught shoplifting.

"She read me," I say.

"Everybody reads everybody. It's the same as looking at a face." Tolliver does not turn his head. "You're going to have to stop doing that thing where you brace."

By early afternoon the road has become a road, packed and cambered and wide enough for two carts, and there are people on it. Not many. Enough. A boy driving four pigs. Two men with a barrow of cut stone who argue the entire time they are in earshot and the entire time they are out of it. An old man walking with nothing at all, going somewhere with the patience of a person who has already done the hard part.

[HAND, LV. 4]

[MASON, LV. 14]

[PILGRIM, LV. 6]

I look for a name on each new plate and find another job. My fingers itch toward my throat. How many people would have passed before somebody stopped to ask why I hadn't covered mine? Tolliver did not even have to wait for me to speak.

Later that afternoon I smell it before I see it, and the smell is the thing that undoes me. Woodsmoke and animals and bread and a sourness underneath like a wet basement, and something frying, and I stop in the

middle of the road with my eyes streaming, because for one whole second it is the alley behind Brewed Awakening at six in the morning with the bakery two doors down running its first bake.

Tolliver lets me stand there. He does not ask.

“Sorry.”

“Come on.”

Greyward is not a village.

He called it a village this morning and I built something in my head with eight houses in it, and what comes up out of the fields is a wall. Not a castle wall. A working one, timber over earth, twice my height, running off in both directions until the land takes it, with roofs stacked up behind it and smoke standing over the whole thing in a hundred separate columns. There are two towers at the gate and men on both of them. Beyond the wall a bell starts up and then stops after three strokes, the way a bell does when it is telling people something practical.

“You said village.”

“It’s got a wall and no lord in it. That’s a village.” He does something to the set of my coat, tugs the collar of it closed at my throat, adjusts the way it sits on my shoulders. His knuckles brush under my jaw, and I look at the wall until that has finished happening. “Listen to me.”

“I’m listening.”

“At the line, everybody opens.”

The queue is maybe thirty people long, carts and foot traffic separated, and it takes me a minute of watching to understand what he means, and then I cannot see anything else. There is a place ten feet short of the gate, marked by nothing I can see, and every single person crossing it blooms.

The plain little words go, all at once, and names come up in their place. A woman ahead of us who has been ****[WEAVER, LV. 9]**** for the whole hour I have been standing behind her opens her name, three lines of her hanging in the air, name and level and a word underneath that must be her holding, and she does not so much as glance up at it. She holds the fingers at her throat, the warden’s eyes go up, the warden waves, and by the time she is six feet inside the gate she is a weaver again.

Thirty strangers, one after another, walking naked past two bored men and then getting dressed.

“They can make you,” I say.

“Nobody makes you. You just don’t come in.” Tolliver moves us up two places. “It’s older than the wall. Fifty men can hold a gate. Nobody can hold a road.”

“And they’ll see the gap.”

“They’ll see it.”

“And then what?”

“Then I talk,” he says, “and you look at me.”

The line eats an hour and then most of another. My foot has gone from a pain to a heat that runs up the inside of my calf, and there is a smell coming off the wrapping now that I have decided to deal with after the gate. I lean on him. He lets me. Ahead of us the two masons go through, and the boy with the pigs, and then there is nothing between me and the mark on the ground except air.

“Now,” Tolliver says.

I put two fingers to my throat and press until it goes soft, and I walk into Greyward wearing my own name.

The warden is a heavy man in his fifties with a strap of rank over one shoulder and the face of somebody four hours into a six-hour shift. His eyes come up, off Tolliver, over to me, and stop.

They stay stopped.

“Sir,” Tolliver says, pleasant as bread.

The warden reads my three lines. I can feel him doing it. I have never in my life been so aware of the top of my own head, and I have to lock my knees to keep from putting a hand up there, and the only thing in the world holding me on the ground is Tolliver’s forearm under my elbow.

“Level one,” the warden says.

“She is.”

“She’s grown.”

“She is that too.”

“Origin’s empty, son.”

“It is.” Tolliver says it like a man agreeing that the weather has been poor. “Skell’s Holding took a fever the winter before last and the man who kept the book went with the rest of them. There’s no book. There’s no holding. There’s about four of them left and she’s the one who could walk.”

Skell’s. Fever. A dead clerk. I stare at the side of Tolliver’s jaw. He speaks without hesitation, and I try to make my face look like the face of someone who knows those people.

The warden’s mouth works. He looks at me again, at the coat, at the shorts under it, at the darkened wrapping around my foot. “She got no shoes.”

“No.”

“She walked in with no shoes.”

“She did.”

“From Skell’s.”

“From what’s left of it,” Tolliver says, and his voice has gone somewhere quieter and kinder, and it works on the warden the way it worked on me in the mud at the top of the hill. “Look at her feet, sir, and then ask me again if she walked.”

The warden looks at my feet. Something in his shoulders lets go, and he takes a slate and chalk from his belt.

“Hold it open.”

The voice comes from the left, from the gatehouse wall, where a man has been leaning in the shade for the whole time I have been standing here and I have not looked at him once.

He is not in the line. He is not in a uniform. He is somewhere in his thirties, dressed like weather, with forearms crossed and a hat pushed back and a beard three or four days past being a decision. There is a bow across his back the way Tolliver’s is, except that where Tolliver’s looks like a thing he owns, this one looks like a thing that has been repaired more than once and will be again.

He is unmasked.

[EIRAN HALE, LV. 26]

His name is just hanging there in the middle of the day in front of everybody, and after an hour of watching thirty people get dressed as fast as they could, it hits me like somebody walking through a church whistling.

“Hale,” the warden says, and there is something in it I cannot read, but he does not tell him to move along.

Hale comes off the wall. He does not hurry. He stops at a distance that is exactly polite and looks up over my head, and I stand there with my two fingers at my throat and every syllable of my name held open in the air, and he takes his time.

Nobody has taken their time. Not one person in that whole line. Even the warden read me in a second and a half like a man checking a stamp.

The heat goes up my neck and into my ears. It is not fear. People are waiting behind us. A man shifts his sack and looks over. I lift my chin at Hale, wanting him to finish.

He notices. His eyes drop off my plate and onto my face, and if I got anything out of that it does not show.

“How old are you?”

“She’s...” Tolliver starts.

“I asked her.”

I start to turn toward Tolliver. Hale is still looking at me, waiting for me to answer him myself.

“Nineteen.”

Hale takes that. He does not glance up again, and somehow it is worse that he does not need to, with the second line of my plate still between us.

“Somebody’s kept you very safe,” he says.

There is no question anywhere in it, so there is nothing to answer, and I stand in a gateway with my mouth open like a fish while the pigs go on making noise inside the wall.

He turns away before I can put anything together. “She’s fine, Bertran. Let her in.”

The warden scratches the slate and waves us through, and my fingers come off my throat, and my name goes down out of the air, and I am inside.

Behind us, not quietly, Hale says: “She’s yours, then.”

“She’s mine,” Tolliver says.

Ten steps inside, I look back at the gate. Tolliver’s arm is still under mine. I could pull away, ask what the fuck he meant, right here where the wardens could hear. Instead I hold tighter when my foot catches a rut.

Greyward from the inside is a great deal of everything at once. The street is packed earth gone hard and shining, running between buildings that lean their upper floors out over it until the sky is a strip. There are chickens. There are three separate people shouting prices at me personally. A dog with no plate at all trots past with something in its mouth that I choose not to examine, and the smell of the tannery finds me from four streets away and stays.

And over all of it, everywhere, at head height, in every doorway and window and stall, the plain little words. Baker. Hand. Carter. Hand. Cooper. Widow. Hand, hand, hand.

Not one name in the whole town.

Tolliver spends money on me for two hours.

That is the part I will remember. He puts me on a stool in a room off the market that smells of vinegar, and a woman with ****[MENDER, LV. 22]**** over her head cuts my wrapping away and makes a noise about what is under it, and I look at the ceiling while she does whatever she does. It takes a long time and it hurts more than the cut did. When she is finished the skin along my arch is closed and shiny and hot, a new pink seam where the split was, and my leg feels like somebody has taken a weight off it that had been there so long I stopped believing in it.

“You should have closed that the first hour,” she says.

“I know,” I say.

Tolliver counts small metal into her palm. Not a lot. Enough that she counts it back.

Then a stall for boots, and he pays. Then a woman with a chest of secondhand clothes, and he pays, and a skirt and a shift and a woolen thing with sleeves come out of it, none of which fit, all of which are dry. Then bread, and something hot in a folded leaf, and he pays for that too, and I eat it standing up in the street with tears going down my face and I do not care in the slightest who is watching.

I asked the clothes seller for the price, but Tolliver had already paid. She turned to her next customer before I could ask again.

I try adding up the purchases, but I don't know what any of them cost. He catches me watching his purse. I look down at the food and take another bite.

The room is above a tavern at the end of a street that gets no sun. It has a bed with a straw tick, a shutter that closes, a stub of candle, a basin, and a door with an iron bolt on the inside of it. He pays for that too. He tells me to sleep, and that he will be back, and that I should not go down into the taproom, and then his boots go away down the stairs and I am alone for the first time since dawn.

I stand in the middle of the floor for a while.

Then I sit on the bed, and it holds me up, and that turns out to be the thing that does it. A bed. A roof. A door. There is no alarm to set. No shift I can call in sick for. Mom will have called by now. I try to remember whether Liam knows her number, and cannot remember ever giving it to him.

I put my face in the blanket and I make a sound I have never made before.

When I can breathe through my nose again, I sit up. There is a wet patch on the blanket. I fold it out of sight, wipe my face on the borrowed sleeve, and look for my shirt.

The shirt is on the floor where I stepped out of it. Mud to the shoulders, the hem hacked off, CRIT HAPPENS mostly gone, the whole thing smelling like the inside of a dead tree.

I pick it up, and fold it, sleeves in, the way my mother folds things, and put it under the straw tick at the head of the bed.

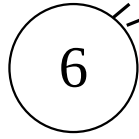
Then I bolt the door.

The iron is heavier than it looks and it goes across with a sound that I feel in my teeth, and I keep my palm against the wood until the footsteps outside pass my room.

The knock comes maybe an hour later.

I am off the bed and across the room and my hand is on the bolt before I have decided anything at all.

“It’s me,” Tolliver says through the door.
“I know,” I say, and let him in.



CHAPTER SIX

The bolt is open when I wake up.

That is the first thing I have, before the light or the ache in my hip from the straw tick or the sound of somebody below us dragging benches across a floor: the iron is drawn back in its bracket, and the door is shut, and Tolliver is sitting on the boards beside it with his boots on and his pack across his knees.

I sit up too fast. “You opened that.”

“Went out. Came back.” He does not look up from the strap he is working. “You want to know what should be bothering you about that.”

“That you can.”

“That you slept through it.” He pulls the strap through and sets it. “Both times.”

The room in daylight is smaller and browner than it was by candle. There is a stain on the ceiling the shape of a bad country. My foot has stiffened overnight into something I am going to have to negotiate with, and when I put it down on the boards the new seam along my arch takes my weight and gives it back, hot but holding, which the mender told me it would do and which I did not believe until now.

The boots he bought me at the stall by the market are by the wall. They are somebody else’s boots and they were somebody else’s before that. They are also the first shoes I have had since the clearing, and I put them on before I do anything else, including think.

Tolliver stands, and the room gets appreciably smaller.

“I’ll be out today,” he says.

I wait for the rest of it. Where. How long. Whether out means the market or the road or something with a name. He crosses to the sill instead and counts small metal onto it, four of the thin ones, laid down separate so that I can see there are four.

“That’s bread and it’s a bowl of something at midday and it’s enough left over that nobody thinks you’re desperate,” he says. “Don’t spend it all in one place, and don’t let anybody see the rest of it after you’ve paid.”

“Tolliver.”

“Bolt it behind me. If somebody knocks and it isn’t my voice, you don’t open it, and you don’t answer either, because answering tells them there’s a woman in here on her own.” He shoulders the pack. “The taproom’s fine in daylight. Don’t sit with your back to the door.”

“Where are you going?”

He stops with his hand on the latch, and for a second I think I am going to get something, because the pause has the shape of one of his pauses, the kind where he is pricing what a piece of information costs him.

“Out,” he says. “I’ll want you here at dark.”

And then his boots are going down the stairs, and the taproom takes him, and I am standing in a rented room in borrowed clothes looking at four coins on a windowsill and waiting for somebody to tell me what happens next.

I stay there long enough to hear a bench scrape downstairs. He hasn’t come back to tell me anything else.

I count the coins again. Four. He has left me food money and an instruction to stay here until dark. I don’t even know when he intends to leave town.

I sit on the edge of the tick and pull the left boot loose where it presses the healing cut. I’m not walking out of that gate. The thought of another night in the trees is enough to make me tighten the laces again. But there are shops downstairs. People getting paid. I used to be one of them.

One thing. That is all it has to be. One thing today that I buy with money that came from me.

I reach under the tick and find my shirt where I put it, folded, sleeves in. The mud has dried and gone pale in the creases. CRIT HAPPENS is down to CRI HAPP and a shadow. I do not take it out. I just put my hand on it for a second, the way you touch a doorframe on the way past.

Then I leave the four coins on the sill, exactly where he set them down, exactly four, and I go out to find work.

—○—

Greyward in the morning is a town with its sleeves up.

Last night it was noise and smell coming at me sideways while I concentrated on staying upright. Today the street is somebody’s job, all of it, in every direction. A woman throws a bucket of gray water into the gutter without looking and a man walks through where it went without looking either. There are two boys carrying a door. A cooper’s yard has four barrels out front and a fifth coming apart under a mallet, and I pass

from the smell of wet oak into old piss, then bread from an open bakery.

And over all of it, the plain little words.

[BAKER, LV. 12]

[HAND, LV. 6]

[COOPER, LV. 30]

By the third street I'm counting plates. The cooper has thirty levels and the boy carrying a bucket has six. Another Hand passes at nineteen; I turn to see what he's carrying. Six years of raid logs, and I'm still trying to work out who can do what from the number beside their name.

Hand, six. Hand, nineteen. Hand, four.

Hand is everywhere. Hand is on the boy walking pigs and the man rolling a cask on its rim and the girl slinging washing over a line above the street, and Hand does not say a trade, it does not say what you were apprenticed to or who your father was, and if there is a word in this town that means I have got two arms and I will do what you tell me for money, that is the word.

That is the entire theory. It takes me most of an hour to find somewhere to test it, because I do not know where anything is, and asking gets me pointed by people who are already walking away, and twice I end up somewhere that is clearly a yard and clearly nobody's business but the people in it. Then I follow a wagon.

It ends at a store by the north wall, a long building with a plank running up into a loft door, and there is a crew of five moving sacks off the wagon bed and up the plank in a slow rotation that does not stop for anything, one man on the bed, three on the plank, one in the dark of the loft.

The one on the bed is broad and gray-bearded and has the flattest word over his head that I have read yet.

[HAND, LV. 21]

I wait for the rotation to come round and put me in front of him, because standing in the middle of it would be like standing in a fire lane, and when he glances down I say, "Are you taking anyone on?"

He looks at my empty hands.

"No."

"For today."

"No."

The rotation goes past me. A sack goes up. Nobody looks at me.

He is still watching the wagon. At Brewed Awakening I used to say no like that when I wanted someone to stop making my shift harder. I look from the sacks to the sky.

“You’ve got five men and a full wagon and a sky that’s going to open on you,” I say. “I’ll do an hour for nothing. If I’m useless you’ve lost an hour of nothing.”

He looks at me properly for the first time, and then his eyes go up over my hair the way everybody’s do, and whatever he reads up there, he does not do with it what the warden did.

“Sacks are on the bed,” he says. “Don’t stand on the plank when it’s got two on it.”

I am so pleased with myself that I nearly say thank you twice.

The sacks are milled barley, half my height, tied at the neck, and I get the first one onto my shoulder by dragging it over the edge. Then I get four steps up the plank with it, and the plank flexes, and my whole plan stops being a plan.

Heavy I know about. I have carried a keg of syrup up the stairs behind the shop and I have wrestled a mattress into a fourth-floor apartment with my father on the other end of it going slow, slow, slow. This is the load and me arriving at a total. There is no more of me anywhere. My arms quit, both of them, at the same time and without any drama at all, and the sack comes down off my shoulder into my hands and I go with it onto one knee with the whole thing across my thighs, and the plank bounces under somebody’s step behind me.

“Off,” a voice says.

I try to stand with it. That is the part I will be embarrassed about later. I get halfway up, I change my grip, I try to lever it against my hip the way the man on the bed does it in one motion like he is closing a door, and my knee goes down on the wood again.

Then a hand comes past my ribs and takes the sack out of my arms.

She is smaller than me. She is a head shorter and forty at the least and there is nothing about her arms that would make you look twice at them in a queue, and she takes the sack off my thighs with one hand under the belly of it, turns, puts it on her shoulder, and walks up the rest of the plank without adjusting anything.

Her word hangs over her the whole way up.

[HAND, LV. 14]

I stay on my knee on a plank in the middle of a working town with my arms shaking and my ears going hot, and I look at that number for as long as it takes her to get to the top, until she disappears into the loft.

Fourteen. Her level is fourteen. My arms are still shaking from a load she carried away one-handed.

The woman comes back down the plank. There is no contempt anywhere in her, and no interest either, and I would take contempt.

“How?” I say.

She looks at me. She looks at the sack going up on the next shoulder, and at my hands, and I watch her try to find the beginning of an answer to a question nobody has ever asked her.

“You just do,” she says. “You’ll get it.”

“Get what?”

But she is already reaching past me for the next one, and the man on the bed says something about the plank, and the rotation closes over the gap where I was standing the way water does.

I get off the plank. Nobody says anything about that either. I stand in the yard for a minute working my fingers open and shut and thinking about the two men at the gate yesterday with a barrow of cut stone between them, arguing the entire time they were in earshot and the entire time they were out of it, cut stone, up a road, arguing.

I left my breakfast money on a windowsill. That was stupid. It does not explain how she lifted the sack. She is a head shorter than me and she took it one-handed after four hours of doing it.

Does the level make her stronger? Or is Hand more than a label? I look at my palms, then at the loft door. She is already coming back for another.

I do not know. The gray-bearded man catches me watching and points away from the plank. I move before he has to say it.

So I put that where I put everything, and I go back into the market to sell my brain instead.

—○—

The market has two rows of stalls with customers crowded between them. I walk the whole length of it once, and by the end of the row I have stopped looking at goods and started looking at queues.

Halfway down the row, a customer puts something back and leaves before the seller can reach him. I stop there.

The stall sells dry goods, spread across a table: salt in a covered tub, thread on cards, needles in paper, tallow, hard soap in bricks, dried peas, buttons of horn and buttons of bone, small nails in a bin. There is a woman behind it built like a fence post with a scale at her elbow and a wooden till box under her hand.

[SELLER, LV. 19]

There are five people in front of her and one of them is a man with a cart of salt who wants to be paid and gone, and she is trying to weigh out peas for a woman who has changed her mind twice while a boy at the end of the table keeps trying to catch her eye with two cards of thread.

I go around to the end of her table and stop beside it, out in the open where the man with the cart can see me and she can see me and neither of them has to wonder what I am doing.

“Do you want the salt off him or do you want the peas?” I say.

She turns her head about four inches.

“I’ve done two years of this,” I say. “Not salt. This.” I put my chin at the five people and the boy with the thread. “Give me the ones who already know what they want and tell me your prices and you can go and argue about salt.”

Everything I have is in the ten seconds after that, and I know it, and what comes up in me while she looks at me is the thing that used to come up when a manager watched me on bar during a rush, which is the good kind of sick, the kind with **watch this** underneath it.

“Peas is two the pound, four the three,” she says. “Salt’s off the tub, a bit the scoop, don’t heap it. Thread’s a bit the card, needles is three the paper and they walk, so they don’t leave your hand until the money’s in it. Soap’s four. Nails is by the handful and the handful is mine, not theirs.” She has already turned toward the salt man. “You touch that till box and I’ll have your wrist.”

“Fine by me.”

“A piece when I close the middle out. I don’t feed you and I don’t lend you anything.”

I have no earthly idea whether a piece is a fortune or an insult, and **do not accept a first price** is a rule I have been carrying around since yesterday morning like a stone in a pocket, and I accept the first price in something under two seconds.

“What’s the boy want?”

“Two cards of thread and he’s got the money in his fist and he’s been standing there since I got here.”

Her mouth does something small and she puts it away again. “Ordway,” she says, giving me her name at last.

The first ten minutes are a disaster held together with string. The prices are simple and the coins are not, and coins are the whole job. The little ones are copper and thin and they come in one size, and I decide inside the first two minutes to call them bits because I have to call them something. The fat dull ones are worth more and I do not know how much more until a woman

buys soap and salt and gets change and I watch Ordway's hand make it, and then I do the sum backward and get eight.

Eight bits to the fat one. Bits and pieces. I do not have time to be pleased about that and I am pleased about it anyway.

After that it is a job. I know how to do this. A man wants a bit's worth of salt and wants to know if I will heap it, and the answer is no, and he tries the answer again on me in a different voice, and gets the same answer. A woman with a baby on her hip wants three papers of needles and I get all three into her hand and her money into mine in one exchange because she does not have a spare hand and I can see that she does not. The boy with the thread turns out to be buying for his mother and comes back forty minutes later for a second errand and asks for me specifically, which is the first time anybody in this world has asked for me specifically.

I keep the queue in order. I hold four prices and two people's changes of mind in my head at once and I do not lose the salt scoop, and when a man in a good coat wants to pay for soap with a bit that has been shaved down one edge until it is a crescent, I put it on the table in front of him and put my hand next to it and wait, and he laughs and takes it back and gives me a good one, and behind me Ordway says nothing at all, so I serve the next customer.

The salt man wants to be paid for eleven scoops and Ordway is elbow-deep in a card of buttons, and I count the tub with the scoop myself and get nine, and I say so, and he says the tub settles.

"Then it settled two scoops on the road," I say. "Nine."

He looks at Ordway. Ordway does not look up from the buttons.

"Nine and I'll take the broken card off you at a bit," I say, and I hear Tolliver telling me not to accept a first price. I push the scoop toward the salt man.

The salt man takes nine and the bit. Ordway sells the broken card twenty minutes later for two.

Somewhere in the middle of the second hour the rush thins and I straighten up and my back informs me about the plank, and I look down the row at all of it, the boards and the scale and the small covered tub and the till box, and I have to put both hands flat on the table for a second.

I look up from the till at the plates bobbing above the crowd.

And I am running a register.

The laugh comes up out of me before I can stop it and I have to turn it into a cough, and Ordway looks over and I say, "Nothing," and she says, "Then look at the peas," and I look at the peas.

She closes the middle of the day out and starts putting things away, and the market noise goes down a step all along the row at the same time, the way a room does.

“You’ll do,” Ordway says. “Tomorrow, if you want it. Early. I don’t hold a place.”

“I want it.”

She reaches under the table for the till box. I stand there with my hands hanging and my shoulders hot and my foot throbbing in the new boot, and I hold my hand out flat, because that is what I have been waiting two hours to do.

She counts out of the box, and her fingers stop with the coin still in them.

She is not looking at my hand. She is looking about two feet above my hair.

“Who receives for you?”

“Sorry?”

“Who receives?” She holds the coin back. “You’re Household, girl.”

My palm stays open beneath the coin. I pull it back before she can look down at it.

“I did the work,” I say.

“You did. You did it better than the last two I’ve had beside me and I’ve just asked you to come back tomorrow.” The coin stays where it is, between her thumb and her finger, six inches out of the box and a foot short of me.

“Who’s your house?”

“Can you not just give it to me?”

“No.”

“I earned it.”

“You did,” Ordway says again, and she means every word of it. “And it’s not yours to take off my table, and it’s not mine to put in your hand, and if I do it, then someday this week whoever answers for you comes and stands where you’re standing and asks me what I paid you and how long you were behind my table and whether I knew you were out without leave. I’ve had that man at my table. He had a stick.” She sets the coin down on the boards in front of her, where I can see it. “It’s not you I’d be paying. It’s your house I’d be taking from.”

Somebody two stalls down is laughing. A dog noses among the peas, and Ordway glances toward it without moving the coin.

“Hold it, then,” I say. “Keep it for me.”

“Until who comes for it?”

I have nothing. She watches me have nothing and does not enjoy it.

“Mark it somewhere. On a slate. That it’s mine.”

“That is what I’m telling you a slate would say.” She wipes her hands down her apron. “It would say the wage is owed to your house.”

The word goes through me again with the whole weight it has been putting on since I picked it out of a short list of plain words in a cart rut, and everything I understood about it yesterday turns out to have been the front of it. *Household. That somebody’s answerable for you. Out here that beats being nobody’s.* He was not lying. He saves the lying for other people. With me he just hands over the true half.

My fingers go to my throat. I could choose Hand. I know where the word is.

But she has already read Household. And the warden wrote something down yesterday while Tolliver said I was his.

“Can I change it?”

“Does your house know you’re asking?”

I lower my hand.

“Whose Household?” Ordway says.

The coin is on the boards eighteen inches from my fingers. Dull, fat, worth eight bits, and I know exactly what eight bits buys because I have spent the morning telling people. It is a loaf and a bowl of something and a candle of my own. It is the one thing.

I counted the salt. Caught the shaved coin. That boy came back and asked for me.

All that is left is being handed it.

“Tolliver,” I say.

Ordway’s hand stops on the way to her apron.

It is a small thing. It is smaller than what the warden did and much smaller than what happened in the gateway when a man with his name in the open air took his time reading mine. Her eyes come off the space above my head and land on my face, and stay there a beat longer than they have stayed on it all morning.

“Tolliver,” she says.

“Yes.”

The dog gets driven out of the peas. Somewhere behind me a shutter goes up on a hinge that wants grease.

Then she picks the coin up off the boards and puts it in my hand, and closes my fingers around it with her own hand over the top of mine, which is the only time she has touched me all day.

“Early,” she says. “I don’t hold a place.”

And she turns to her scale, and a woman is already asking her about soap, and the day just keeps going.

I get about ten steps down the row before I stop between a woman counting change and a boy carrying a basket.

I do not know one thing about what he is in this town. Not how long he has been coming here, not who knows him, not what he was doing on that road in the first place. I have said his name to one woman at one dry goods stall in a town with two rows and a middle, and a coin that was not going to move came off a board.

Maybe she knows his mother. I keep coming back to the way she closed my fingers over the coin. I try to remember whether she looked toward the street first.

I stop looking over my shoulder when a man behind me asks to pass.

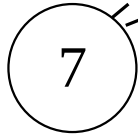
Then I open my hand.

The coin has gone warm off Ordway’s palm and mine. It is thinner than it looked on the boards and there is no word on it anywhere, only a stamp, a crest or a beast or a face worn down past telling. Eight bits. Bread and a bowl and a candle, and enough left over that nobody thinks I am desperate.

There are four bits lying on that windowsill. This is twice all of them.

I close my hand. I counted the salt. I caught the bad coin. She asked me to come back.

And the only way it got into my hand was his name.



CHAPTER SEVEN

I spend the first bit on bread.

The woman selling it takes my piece, gives me seven thin coins and a roll still hot enough to sting through its crust, and does not ask whose permission I have to eat. I stand beside her oven and wait for something else to happen. A question. A look at my plate. Somebody coming down the street to inform me that actually, the bread belongs to Tolliver too.

“You’re in the way,” she says.

I move.

The roll is gone before I reach the corner. I eat the crumbs out of my palm and walk back to the tavern rehearsing questions. This time I get past the first one without wanting to cry.

Inside, a woman with a red cloth tied over her hair is scraping something off a table with the edge of a knife. Her plate says **[KEEPER, LV. 17]**. I have passed her twice without registering anything except the fact that she is large and I am in her way, and this morning she watched me go out without asking where.

I stop at the end of the table.

“What’s a room cost?”

She tests the patch with her thumb. “Which room?”

“Mine. Upstairs. At the back.”

“Four bits a night. Food’s separate.”

I have seven bits in my fist. The knowledge rearranges the entire building.

“How many nights are paid?”

Her knife stops. She looks at me, then at the ceiling, as if she can see the room through it. “Tonight. Leaving in the morning, he said.”

Of course he said.

I tuck one of my coins into my other hand. “Can I buy a candle?”

“Half a one.”

“Fine.”

She gives me a short yellow length with a kink in its wick. I take it upstairs with six bits left, and shut the door, and put the candle on the sill beside Tolliver's four coins.

I put my candle closer to the bed than his coins. Then I move it back because the sill slopes there.

I take my boots off. There is a red place at the back of the right heel and heat along the healing cut on the left, but no blood inside either boot. I press the heel with my thumb and wince.

The six bits go under my folded shirt beneath the tick. His four stay on the sill. I sit down on the bed with my back against the wall and two fingers at my throat.

It takes longer this time. I am pressing too hard. When I ease off, the skin gives, the room recedes, and my name opens in front of me.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 1]

[ORIGIN:]

I make myself leave the empty line alone.

The place Tolliver showed me is beside the name, though beside is not quite right. I can look at it with my eyes and see nothing. I can attend to it and feel an edge. The first time he told me to reach, I tried moving my free hand through the writing, and he caught my wrist before I could do it twice. Now I hold still and think about that edge until the list opens.

Traveler. Laborer. Pilgrim. Hand. Household.

Other words extend beyond them, dimmer, as though there is more of the list than I have space to want at once. I do not touch any of them. Household sits brighter than the rest, and below the list is a little hooked mark I do not recognize until I think about going back and it becomes obvious.

I go back.

I find the list and close it twice more before trying anything else.

Then I sit with the name and the number and try to find another edge.

There must be more than a name and a number. I concentrate on the number.

I attend to the one.

Nothing happens. I hold it in my attention the way I held the list, wait through the urge to move my fingers, and something opens beneath it.

[PROGRESS: 7 / 10]

[RESERVE: 3 / 3]

[RUN: UNSET]

I read the lines three times.

Seven out of ten. I have seven of something. I might have arrived with seven. I might have earned them by surviving the forest or carrying half a sack of barley or convincing a salt merchant that nine is less than eleven. I try to remember whether anything felt different after the salt merchant. Nothing I can trust.

Reserve looks like a resource. Run looks like the question Tolliver asked me on the hill.

I try the seven. Nothing. The ten. Nothing. Reserve unfolds into a ring of three pale marks, and when I pay attention to one, I become aware of my own breathing in a way that makes me stop doing it properly.

I let go. The ring shuts.

“Okay.”

Run does not offer a list. It offers a single word.

[UNSET]

I wait. I try again. I hold my attention there until my eyes ache.

Unset.

My fingers have started to ache, so I take them off my throat, and the room comes forward around me. Nothing follows. No quest window. No congratulations. There is a bench dragging downstairs and a fly repeatedly discovering the shutter.

I sit there looking at the air where the numbers were.

When I crawled out of that tree, I thought the machine had forgotten me. This afternoon it is keeping a score I have not learned to read.

I get the candle, set it in the old stub’s little dish, and use the back of my thumbnail to scratch three short lines into the soft side of the wax. Seven. Three. Unset. I give the last one a crossbar so I know which is which.

Wax catches under my nail. I turn the scratched side toward the bed so I can see it.

—○—

He comes back while there is still daylight on the opposite roof.

I hear him on the stairs and know the step before he reaches the landing. Knowing it makes me angry. Being relieved makes me angrier. I have been sitting here for an hour practicing how to be a person who does not need him, and my whole body goes quiet when his knuckles touch the wood.

“Maya.”

I open the door.

He has a paper parcel in one hand and rain in his hair, though I have not heard rain. His coat smells of cold air and a sharper smoke than the tavern's. For a second I remember his shoulder under my hand in the forest so completely that the room seems warm by comparison, impossibly safe.

Then he looks at the sill.

"You ate?"

"Yes."

He looks at the candle.

I shut the door behind him. "Where are we going tomorrow?"

The parcel stops halfway to the bed.

"Who told you that?"

"The woman you told."

He sets it down. "I said we might leave."

"Then she misunderstood you. So do I, quite a lot."

For the first time since he found me, he has to decide where to put his hands. He settles on taking his coat off, which gives him several seconds and a reason to look somewhere else.

There is only one stool. He leaves it where it is and leans against the wall beside the shutter.

"What happened?"

"I got a job." I say it too loudly, and hear a pause in the footsteps on the landing.

His eyes move to my foot.

"Selling things," I say. "I tried carrying things. That did not work. Selling did. I was good at it."

"I believe you."

"Don't do that."

He stops.

I press my palms against the sides of my skirt. "You don't even know what happened."

The room is quiet enough that I hear the parcel settling on the blanket.

"All right," he says.

"Ordway wouldn't pay me because I'm Household."

His mouth tightens at the name. Only at the name. I have been watching him too closely all day without him even being here, and now that he is, it is almost embarrassing how much there is to watch.

"She paid you," he says.

"After I told her who I was with."

He looks at the candle again.

"Why?" I ask.

"Because she knows me."

"I got that far by myself."

He rubs a hand over his face. He is tired. There is a dark hollow beneath each eye.

"I collected a debt at her stall last autumn. For a house that hired me. Her husband had signed for winter stock and died before he sold it."

I look down at his hands. He follows my eyes.

"I didn't touch her."

"Did you have a stick?"

He says nothing.

I can hear Ordway again. *I've had that man at my table.* I supplied a stranger when she said it. Some other man, in some other coat, a person convenient enough to dislike without having to remember him cleaning my foot.

"What did you take?"

"The stock the house had paid for."

"How much of it?"

His jaw moves. "Half her stall."

I sit on the bed because standing has become a performance I cannot afford. The parcel tilts toward me. Something inside smells of onions.

"Did you tell her to pay me?"

"No. I haven't seen Ordway today."

I look at him, trying to decide whether I can ask Ordway without sounding frightened of the answer.

"So she either thought you'd come and take it if she didn't, or she wanted me to have money because she knows what happens when you do."

He glances toward the door, then back. "You'd have to ask her."

I pull the parcel closer without opening it, making myself remember to ask her in the morning. "Does choosing Household make me yours?"

"No."

The word comes quickly enough to hurt.

"Then why did she—"

"Because people believe plates. A word can be changed. A wage dispute can't be wished away when a house comes to collect. She didn't know what was underneath yours."

"Neither do I."

He looks at me then, properly.

"There's no bond in your origin," he says. "No holding. No house. I couldn't put one there by telling you to pick a word."

"But you could tell a gate warden I was yours."

"I stood answerable for you."

"And forgot to explain the difference."

He grips the back of the stool.

"You were bleeding through your clothes. They'd have kept you outside while they sent for someone to decide whether your story made sense."

"You had all morning to tell me."

"And you'd have agreed?"

I stare at him. He looks down at his hands.

I do not know what to do with that, so I unwrap the parcel. Two thick wedges of pie lie inside, pastry gone soft where the onions have soaked through. I want one badly enough that my mouth aches.

"If I eat that, am I agreeing to something?"

"No."

"If I stay in this room?"

"No."

"If I change my plate?"

He takes longer. "The word won't clear the entry at the gate. If Bertran stops you and you're Hand, he'll ask where your household went. If you tell him there never was one, he'll want to know what else I lied about."

"There it is."

"It's a real problem, Maya."

"I know. I'm the one in it."

The pie burns my tongue. I eat it anyway.

He finally sits, leaving the other wedge untouched. There is nowhere in the room for him to sit far from me, and his knee is close enough to mine that I have to work at ignoring it. I shift my foot so our knees can't touch. Then I have to concentrate on what he is saying instead of whether he noticed.

"Tomorrow," I say around the last bite. "Use place names."

"Rook House. South road. Two days if we can get you on a cart."

"What is it?"

"A company holding. Warehouses, fields, workshops. They take people without an origin and put them in a book. Food, a bed, training in a run. Work in return."

"For how long?"

"A year to start."

"Terms you know?"

"I've seen the usual paper. They'd charge your instruction against the account."

"Do they know about me?"

He watches my face. "A factor here does. I spoke to him today."

My hands go cold around the paper.

"How much?"

"That you're unheld. That you're grown. That your level is one."

"My name?"

"Your first."

I set the paper on the bed very carefully. "What do you get?"

He could lie. He has the room for it. He could make the whole thing into another kindness and I might sit here and want to believe him badly enough to manage it.

"A finding fee. If you enter."

"How much?"

"Six pieces."

Forty-eight bits. Six mornings with Ordway, if she lets me keep coming. Twelve nights in this room.

I look at the four coins on the sill.

"Were you going to tell me?"

"Yes."

"When?"

He has no immediate answer to that one.

I wipe my hands on the paper. "I work tomorrow."

"Maya."

"I told her I'd be there."

"A stall won't get you an origin."

"It got me a candle. I enjoyed the experience. I'm going to repeat it."

He reaches for the parcel, then leaves it where it is. I take the last bit of pastry before he can decide that belongs in the argument too.

"Stay in town a day," I say. "Tell your factor I haven't agreed to anything. Find out the terms. All of them. I'll read them."

"You read?"

I look at him until he looks away.

"One day," he says.

It is not permission. I have to remind myself of that twice.

—○—

He eats the second wedge while I light my candle downstairs, cupping the little flame all the way back up. When I return, he is on the floor beside the door again, his pack open. There is a square of leather in his lap and a bent needle between his fingers.

I put the candle on the sill.

“What’s reserve?”

He nearly sticks himself.

That is worth the price of the candle all by itself.

“You opened your measure.”

“I pressed things. Eventually the universe rewarded initiative.”

He puts the needle away. “How much?”

“Three.”

“Full?”

“Three out of three.”

He nods, thinking, and for a moment we are back on the road with him deciding how much of an answer I can use. I lift a hand before he begins.

“Show me. All of it this time.”

He looks at my raised hand. “Give me the basin.”

“Tolliver.”

“It’s a lesson, Maya. I need something you can drop.”

I get the basin.

He makes me sit on the stool with it on my lap and my boots out of the way. It holds perhaps an inch of cold water left from washing this morning. He has me lift it with my right hand, fingers hooked under the rim, until the weight makes my wrist pull.

“Hold that.”

“I’ve established I can carry crockery.”

“Then we’re starting with a victory. Keep your elbow where it is.”

He kneels in front of the stool. His hands stay on his own knees. He tells me to open my measure with the other hand and keep my attention on the full ring under reserve.

The basin begins to shake before I have the ring open.

“That’s your arm doing it,” he says. “Now find the other weight.”

“Where?”

“Close your eyes.”

“Will that shut the thing?”

“No.”

It doesn’t. The letters remain in a darkness that should be mine alone, and my stomach turns over. I open my eyes immediately.

He waits.

“It’s still there,” I say.

“Yes.”

I look at his face, his actual face, which is irritatingly close and not amused at all. “That doesn’t bother you?”

“I’ve never known it not to be.”

Of course he hasn't.

I close my eyes again.

The reserve sits beneath my attention, somewhere inside the ring and somewhere lower than my ribs. Looking for it directly makes it recede. Listening is closer. The basin shakes, cold water touches my wrist, and I can feel every muscle I am using and, beneath them, something I have not used yet.

I reach for it.

The basin rises so sharply that the water slaps me in the chin.

"Fuck!"

His hand closes over the rim before I can pitch it into his face. Water runs into my sleeve. I stare at the bowl between us, at my arm holding it, at the plain impossible absence of effort.

The letters change.

[RESERVE: 2 / 3]

Then the weight comes back, all of it, and he helps me lower the basin onto my knees.

For several seconds I cannot say anything.

He takes his hand away.

"Again?" I ask.

"You've got two left. Save them."

"How do I get them back?"

"Food. Rest. Time. Usually a measure like yours fills before morning. Longer if you're ill or you keep spending it."

"Usually."

"I haven't taught many people who started at nineteen."

"How old were you? When you learned?"

"Six. My mother put a basket in my hands and kept adding turnips."

"And how old are you now?"

"Twenty-two."

Three years. He has three years on me, and sixteen years of knowing where the extra strength lives. I look at the basin and try to separate those two things.

I look at my arm. It is my arm. Same freckles, same short nails, water dripping off my elbow onto somebody else's skirt.

"The woman with the sack," I say. "She was fourteen. Her level. She picked it up with one hand."

"Could be reserve. Could be her run. Could be both. A number won't tell you what a person's spent it learning."

“And I don’t have one.”

“Not yet.”

“Can I choose one without a house?”

“Yes.”

I look up.

He holds my gaze this time. “Someone needs to show you the work. You need to understand enough of it for a run to take. A house makes that easier. It doesn’t make it possible.”

I set the basin on the floor, very slowly, with ordinary muscles.

The same three points that sat unused beneath my ribs while I bled in a tree. The same body that could do this all along, if somebody had taught it where to reach. I want to be furious. I am furious. I look at the basin. A little water is still trembling at its rim.

I want to do it again.

Tolliver sees it. His mouth softens in a way I have no defense against, and for a moment I forget the pie and the factor and the stick at Ordway’s stall. He is kneeling in front of me with water on his collar because I put it there. I could lean forward a little. That is all the distance there is.

He reaches up, slowly enough that I see the question, and brushes a drop from the edge of my jaw with his thumb.

I let him.

His hand is warm. My breath catches, and he hears it, and his eyes come back to mine.

For one awful second I want him to make this decision too.

I turn my face away.

He lowers his hand at once. Neither of us speaks. Downstairs, somebody laughs hard enough to end in a cough, and the noise gives me somewhere to put my eyes until I can look at him again.

“Not while you decide where I sleep,” I say.

He goes still. Then he nods and moves back, giving me room to stand.

I carry the basin to the sill. My candle has burned down past the first scratch, so I deepen the remaining marks and add two small dots beneath them. Two left. Seven out of ten. No run.

Behind me, Tolliver says, “The factor will want to meet you.”

“He can want things.”

“He’s here in Greyward until tomorrow evening. I can’t promise what he’ll offer after that.”

“Then don’t promise. Bring the terms.”

He gathers his needle and leather, and this time when he gets up to leave I do not reach for his sleeve or ask when he will be back. He pauses with his

hand on the latch.

“Keep two in reserve,” he says. “You can spend them on a stumble faster than you can think.”

“I will.”

He leaves. I bolt the door and wait until his footsteps have reached the taproom before I get the six bits out from under the mattress.

I take four downstairs.

The keeper looks at the coins I lay beside her knife. “You’re paid through tonight.”

“Tomorrow night. Same room.”

She tests one with her thumbnail, then sweeps them into her apron. “Name?”

“Maya.”

She writes it on a slate. Just that. Four letters, as far as I can tell before the marks settle into the shape I know.

“Who’s it against?” she asks.

I keep my hand flat on the table.

“Paid,” I say. “Can you put it against paid?”

She looks at me for a moment, then adds a mark beside my name.

“Breakfast’s separate.”

“I know.”

Upstairs, the candle is still burning. I have two bits of my own left, four of his I have not touched, and a room that will be mine tomorrow whether he comes back or not.

I sit on the bed and watch the flame until my hand stops shaking.

CHAPTER EIGHT

In the morning I am still level one.

I check before I get out of bed. My hand drops to the blanket, then goes straight back to my throat for another look. Seven out of ten. Three out of three. No run.

The reserve has come back. That part matters enough that I sit with it for a while, feeling the three pale marks without spending anything. Last night I dreamed about lifting the basin. Before that I dreamed my mother was washing my hair in the kitchen sink, the way she used to when I was little, except the sink was full of leaves and she kept asking me to hold still.

I put my boots on before that can become the whole morning.

There is no Tolliver on the floor. He did not come back. I know because I woke up four times to look, which is a detail I intend to keep from him until I die.

His coins stay on the sill. I take my last two bits, tuck my shirt farther under the tick, and go downstairs.

The keeper has porridge and no interest in my circumstances. One bit gets me a bowl. I eat all of it, scrape the sides with the spoon, and think of the difference between going to work yesterday and going today. Yesterday I had a point to make. Today I need another piece by noon.

Outside, the gutters are running from rain I slept through. Greyward has been washed badly and left to dry. The market awnings sag in the middle, and people poke them from underneath with poles so the water falls on somebody else.

Ordway is unlocking her till box when I arrive.

"You're early."

"It was mentioned."

She gives me the salt tub. "Check for damp."

I set it on the table, take the cover off, and work the scoop gently through the top. Dry. A few small lumps along one edge, but they break when I press them.

"He didn't send you?" she asks.

I keep the scoop in my hand. “No.”

Ordway fits a pin through the hasp of her box and pushes it under the table.

“He told me about last autumn,” I say.

Her shoulders settle. Nothing dramatic, just the adjustment you make before lifting something you know is heavy.

“How much of it?”

“Half your stall. A debt your husband signed for.”

“My husband signed for it. I ordered it. It was a good price.” She takes the scoop out of my hand and levels the salt. “Then he died, and I couldn’t be here and at his bed, and the good price came due.”

I look at the cards of thread lined up on the dry side of the table. There are fewer than yesterday. I know that now, know enough to count what she hasn’t replaced.

“Did you pay me because you’re frightened of him?”

She looks down the row. A boy is trying to hold an awning pole upright while his father ties it, and the pole keeps describing wider and wider circles in the air.

“I paid you because you’d worked,” she says.

“You weren’t going to.”

“No.”

She lets that stand between us. It is uncomfortable enough that I almost help her get rid of it.

“A proper house can come after a wage,” she says at last. “Tolliver can come after a debt someone gave him authority to collect. Different things. When you named him, I knew which sort I wasn’t dealing with.”

“He could have come back.”

“He still could.” She pulls the first sack of peas toward her. “I’d have had more to say with your coin already spent.”

I look at her hands. The knuckles are red from cold, the thumbnail split along one side. I wanted one clean answer I could put next to his and compare. The split nail catches on the sack. I reach to hold it open for her, still unsure what I wanted her to say.

“Thank you,” I say.

“Hold the sack open. It’s catching.”

She hands me the sack.

An hour later we have customers, and I have sold enough salt to understand why she doesn’t let anyone heap the scoop. The margin is hiding in the part everybody wants for free.

I am better today. I know where the needles live and which corner of the table lists when somebody leans on it. I recognize the boy buying for his mother before he speaks, and have the white thread in my hand when he asks for black. He points to the black. I exchange them.

Once, between customers, I open my measure with my back to the covered tub.

Seven out of ten.

I shut it again.

Seven after yesterday's work, seven after this morning's. I look at Ordway sorting pins. I could spend another day guessing while she stands close enough to ask.

"How did you choose your run?" I ask Ordway.

She is sorting bent pins from straight ones. "Badly. I was thirteen."

"Can you change it?"

"Costs more work than choosing right the first time."

"What were you?"

"A runner. Thought I'd carry messages and see the coast."

I try to picture her thirteen and fail, then try again and get a thin girl with her elbows out, furious that somebody else has a better horse.

"Did you?"

"Saw three towns and a man who paid by the mile he admitted I'd walked. My knees still don't like frost." She drops a crooked pin into a separate dish. "You're not choosing one for my stall."

"I didn't say I was."

"You looked disappointed in your number. People do that when they're trying to make it hurry. You can work a counter without spending your life becoming better at my counter."

I stand with a card of thread between my fingers and feel, for the first time, how big the choice might be.

Nyx was a spellblade because I liked the preview animation. If I hated it, I could delete her and start again. The first time I got a build wrong I watched a video while eating cereal and fixed it in twelve minutes.

My knees are going to have to live here.

"Where do people learn?" I ask.

"Yards. Houses. Temples, if you like being cold on purpose. Depends what you want."

"And if you don't know?"

She looks at me over the pins. "Try the yards. Ask the price before you let them put anything in your hands."

A customer reaches between us for the soap, and we go back to work.

The trouble begins with a man trying to save half a step.

He has a handcart stacked with sealed jars, a delivery for the oil seller on the opposite row. Ordway sees him coming and moves her basket of spare cloth out of his way without stopping the price she is giving a woman. I pull our little stool under the table. The lane through the middle clears by inches.

The cart's left wheel catches the oil seller's awning rope.

I see the rope tighten. I see the pole shift. The man heaves the handles sideways to free the wheel, and at the stall beside him a woman is lifting a kettle off a charcoal pan.

"Wait," I say.

The pole comes down across the cart. A jar breaks. Oil splashes the kettle woman's apron, the table, the pan beneath her hand.

The flame is small at first, a blue curl around the edge of the coals. Then it climbs the spilled oil and the whole front of the table goes orange.

Everybody moves at once.

The kettle hits the ground. Somebody shouts for water. The carter drops the handles and tries to pull the cart backward, but his wheel is still tangled in the rope and the jars roll together with a noise I will hear later when I close my eyes.

"Sand!" Ordway shouts. "Under Hester's table!"

She is already moving. I go after her because her basket catches my knee and because doing what she says is the only useful thing in my head.

Heat strikes my face across the lane. The fallen awning has caught along its edge, and the woman who was holding the kettle is on the ground behind it, pulling at something I can't see. Someone gets a coat over the fire on her apron. Two men grab the cart's handles.

"Leave it," she screams. "Leave the fucking cart!"

They stop.

Her skirt is trapped under the wheel.

There is not much of her visible between the boards of the tilted table and the collapsed cloth. A hand. One bare forearm. Her face, eyes squeezed shut against the smoke. She has turned onto her knees to crawl away, and the cart has taken the cloth tight across her thighs.

The oil seller and the carter lift together. The wheel rises perhaps two inches before another jar shifts. The cart tips toward the burning table and both men let it down to keep the load from spilling.

Ordway throws sand across the fire. Some of it takes. Some lands on wet cloth and slides off.

I crouch where the kettle has rolled and look under the cart.

The awning rope runs around the axle, down under the wheel, then back to the peg on our side of the lane. Pulling the cart back tightens it. Lifting the cart pulls the fallen pole against the table. Everything they do to free one thing moves another.

I know this feeling. Twelve people trying to fix a wipe in twelve different directions.

“Stop lifting,” I say.

Nobody hears me.

“STOP LIFTING.”

The carter looks over, furious. I point to the rope beneath his axle.

“That’s holding it down. Cut it first.”

His eyes follow my hand. He drops one handle, gets a knife off his belt, and kneels.

The burning cloth shifts when the rope parts. The oil seller swears and catches the pole before it can fall farther. A mason takes his place at the cart handles. I get my hands under the lower edge of the overturned table, next to the trapped woman’s shoulder, and push.

It moves about an inch.

Enough for me to understand how much it weighs. Not enough for her to get out.

“Here,” I tell her. “This side. When they lift, come this way.”

Her eyes open. Over her head, tilted with nothing at all though she is nearly lying down, her plate says **[COOK, LV. 16]**.

Sixteen. I push harder, staring at the cloth caught beneath the wheel.

Ordway dumps the rest of the sand. Another person arrives with a bucket, and she knocks his arm away before he can throw it. The movement sends sand into my face, gritty and hot. I cough, lose an inch of table, and hear the woman make a sound through her teeth.

The oil seller cannot leave the burning pole without dropping it across us. The two men at the cart have their hands full. The space beneath the table has me in it.

I find the other weight.

There is no time to open the panel. I reach for the sensation beneath my ribs, where it was when the basin flew up.

I push through it.

The table lifts.

“Now!”

The men heave. The wheel clears the cloth. She crawls, one elbow and then the other, dragging her legs after her while I hold the table above her back.

It is easy for one breath.

On the next breath, the weight begins to return.

She is halfway through.

“Move,” I say, and hate myself for saying it because she is moving, she is doing every bit of moving she has, and one boot has caught the hem that is still bunched beneath her knee.

Ordway reaches past me. Gets a fist in the woman’s apron. Pulls.

I spend again.

This time I am ready for the sudden absence of weight, and I straighten only enough to make space. The woman comes free. Ordway falls backward with her, the cart rolls away, and the oil seller yells at me to get clear.

I let the table go and throw myself after Ordway.

It crashes onto the ground behind my heel. There is a tremendous noise as the remaining jars break, but the cart is out of the flame now and most of the oil runs into the gutter, shining brown through the rainwater.

I am sitting in it.

Somebody pulls me up by the back of my woolen shirt. I try to help and discover that my legs are conducting a private discussion about whether we still do that.

“Stand,” Ordway says in my ear.

I stand.

She keeps a fist in my sleeve while people shovel sand and stamp out the awning’s edges. The whole market is shouting, names and instructions and accusations layered together until I cannot separate them. The cook is sitting against a post with her hands tucked under her arms. Her face is white beneath the soot.

She looks at me.

“Your hair,” she says.

I put a hand up. The very ends on one side feel crisp.

“Great,” I say, and start laughing.

It is not a good laugh. Ordway steers me back to our stool and puts me on it, then goes to fetch water I am actually allowed to use.

I put my hands between my knees until they stop trembling enough to count.

Two. I spent two.

I have one left.



The wardens arrive after the fire is mostly sand and smoke, which seems unfair until I realize it has been perhaps a minute since the jar broke.

One makes everybody move back. The other calls for the mender, and at that word I start trying to stand because I have one bit in my pocket and I have already had an expensive week.

Ordway pushes me down by the shoulder.

"I'm fine."

"Then be fine sitting."

She crouches to look at my face. There is a scrape along the outside of my left forearm, bright and shallow, and the skin across my knuckles is red. My boots are slick with oil. My foot hurts, though in a familiar way that feels almost friendly.

"Open your measure," she says.

I hesitate.

She notices. "Not your name. Just look. Tell me what you've got left."

I touch my throat. Find the number.

The number is different.

I miss everything underneath it the first time because all I can see is that it is different.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 2]

I make a noise.

Ordway's hand closes on my wrist. "How much?"

"One."

"Out of?"

"Four."

I read it again to be certain.

[PROGRESS: 1 / 14]

[RESERVE: 1 / 4]

[RUN: UNSET]

There is no fanfare. No gold light. My arms hurt, my hair smells like a terrible electrical problem, and in front of me the universe has put a two where the one was.

"I leveled," I say.

"Yes. I can see."

She says it so ordinarily that I nearly cry.

I want Liam. The want comes without warning, absurd and enormous. I want to tell him I finally did it, and have him ask whether I blinked into the fire first, and be annoyed with him while everybody else laughs.

Instead I sit on a stool with my fingers against my throat and try to memorize the shape of the two.

I look up at Ordway. She can see the two without my telling her. So can everyone walking past, and for once I want them to look.

I let the measure close.

“Did it fill you?” Ordway asks.

“No.”

“Keep that one. Getting another level won’t fill you.”

She stands and turns toward the warden who is coming down the row. I recognize him before he recognizes me. Heavy face, strap on the shoulder, the same tired eyes that looked at my bare feet in the gateway.

Bertran.

His gaze passes over me, goes up, then comes down again.

“You,” he says.

“That keeps happening.”

Ordway makes a small noise that might be a cough.

Bertran looks at the smoke, at the cook, at me. “Where’s the young man you came in with?”

“I don’t know.”

“You’re working here?”

“Yes.”

“For her?”

“For me,” Ordway says. “She saw the rope. Hester would still be under there if she hadn’t.”

“I’ve heard.” His eyes return to my plate. “You’ve had a busy morning.”

I could leave it there. I can feel the opportunity to say nothing opening in front of me, familiar and warm. He hasn’t asked about Skell’s. He hasn’t asked why I am here without Tolliver. There is still enough smoke to hide an entire conversation.

“I need to change something in your book,” I say.

Ordway goes quiet beside me.

“What something?”

“The part where he answers for me. He helped me get here. I didn’t understand what else you were writing down.”

Bertran looks from me to Ordway.

“Is there trouble?”

“He put me down as his. I want that changed.”

He rubs the side of his nose with one broad finger. Behind him a warden begins arguing with the carter about where to leave the damaged cart, and the ordinary world tries very hard to reclaim him.

“Where are you sleeping?”

I describe the tavern and my room at the back. “Tonight’s paid. I paid it.”

“And you’ll have her tomorrow?” he asks Ordway.

“If she’s got hands enough to count with.”

“She has,” I say.

Neither of them looks at me.

I stand. “I’m right here.”

Bertran’s eyes return to my face. After a moment he nods.

“Come to the gatehouse after the midday bell. Bring your keeper or your employer. If they’re willing to attest to what you’ve told me, we can amend the person responsible for your stay.”

“To me?”

“We’ll discuss that with the book open. It doesn’t give you an origin. It doesn’t give you leave to stay forever.”

“I didn’t ask for forever.”

“After midday, then.”

He goes back to the cart. I sit down again before Ordway can make me.

“Can you come?” I ask.

She looks at her stall. The thread is where we left it. The salt is covered. Somebody has put the lid over the peas while we were across the lane, and I have no idea who.

“After I close,” she says.

I nod because anything else is going to come out embarrassingly.

She touches the back of my neck, briefly, below the place where my hair is ruined. Then she picks up her scoop and asks the first returning customer what he wants.

—○—

Tolliver finds me counting needles with both sleeves rolled up.

He comes down the middle quickly enough that I see three people move before I see him. His attention goes from the burned awning to the stool, then lands on me so hard that I feel it.

“Maya.”

“I’m fine.”

He reaches the table, catches himself, and puts both hands flat on its edge instead of on me.

"You're burned."

"Mostly inconvenienced. The mender looked."

She did. She dabbed something cool on my knuckles, told me I had used more luck than skin, and moved on to Hester, whose apron had saved her from much worse. Ordway told the warden to put the small treatment against the fire account. I do not yet know whose money that is. I intend to find out.

Tolliver's gaze lifts to my plate.

His eyes widen. I sit straighter on the stool.

"Two," he says.

"Two." I can't keep from smiling.

He lets out a breath, almost a laugh, and for a moment the table might be the only sensible thing between us. I want to show him every part of it. Where the rope caught. How I held the table. The exact second I found the reserve without opening the ring.

I stop with my hand above the needles. Let him ask.

"I kept one," I say.

He nods. "Good."

I look down at the needles before that can become worth more than it should.

"I'm going to the gatehouse after the bell. Ordway's coming. To correct the entry."

His hands stay where they are.

"What did you tell them?"

"That I didn't agree to belong to anybody."

"I told you—"

"I know what you told me. I want the book to tell it too."

Ordway is beside us now. She doesn't say anything. Tolliver looks at her, then at the stall, and there is a moment I cannot read because it belongs to a season before I arrived.

He takes his hands off the table.

"I'll go with you if they need me."

It is a better answer than I expected. I am trying to decide what to do with it when someone behind him says, "Before that, perhaps a word."

The man is dressed in a brown coat with covered buttons. He is perhaps forty, with a narrow beard and ink along the side of one finger, and his boots have none of the market on them. Above his head hangs
[FACTOR, LV. 18].

He waits for me to look at him before he comes any closer.

"Master Vey," Tolliver says. "I told you I'd bring her the terms."

“And here I am with them.”

The factor holds a folded sheet between two fingers. There is a small black bird impressed in a seal at the bottom. I notice the bird because looking at it is easier than looking at him.

“I haven’t agreed to go anywhere,” I say.

“Understood.”

He lays the paper on the table, clear of the salt. Tolliver watches his hand.

“Take it,” Vey says. “Read it. Have someone else read it. You’ll find the length of service on the first page, compensation on the second, and the conditions for leaving on the third.”

“It’s folded,” I say. “I haven’t found any pages yet.”

He smiles without showing his teeth. “A fair correction.”

I do not touch it.

“What’s so useful about level one?”

His eyes flick upward. “Level two, now. Congratulations.”

“That isn’t the question.”

The smile goes, leaving something more attentive.

“There are several kinds of useful,” he says. “I would like to establish which applies to you before we waste each other’s afternoon.”

“We’re working,” Ordway says.

“Then I’ll be brief.”

He reaches inside his coat.

Tolliver moves half a step, just enough to put his shoulder between the man’s hand and me. Vey stops, glances at him, and withdraws his hand slowly.

What he brings out is a small leather wallet. Soft, hand-stitched, ordinary. He opens it and takes out something the size of a bank card.

For a moment I cannot see it properly. My mind keeps trying to make it belong on the table, trying to turn it into painted wood or a little piece of enameled metal. There is dirt pressed into one corner. One edge has been cracked and repaired with thread through two tiny holes.

The photograph is of a woman with brown hair and an expression caught halfway between polite and annoyed. She is older than me. Thirty, perhaps. The background is pale blue.

Above her face, in letters that do not shift, do not settle, do not need anything in my head to make them readable, is a word I have seen on my own wallet a thousand times.

MISSOURI.

I forget to breathe.

Beside me, Tolliver says something. I don't hear it. There are numbers on the card and a red mark near the corner and a signature beneath the photograph, and I am reaching before I know my hand has moved.

Vey leaves it on the table. He lets me pick it up.

Plastic. It bends slightly between my fingers. The familiar weight of it is almost nothing.

"Do you know what that is?" he asks.

I look at the woman's face. She has stood in a building on my planet, irritated by a camera and a queue and somebody asking her to take her glasses off. There had been a road outside. Cars in a parking lot. Somebody had printed this and put it in her hand.

I cannot make my voice work the first time.

The second time, it does.

"Where is she?"

CHAPTER NINE

"I don't know where she is now," Vey says. "When I last saw her, she was leaving Rook House on foot. She was alive, and she was angry. That was four years ago."

Four years.

I press my thumb against the woman's photograph. The nail covers one of her shoulders.

"You saw her."

"Yes."

"Not someone who looked like her. Her."

"She had shorter hair by then. But yes."

The card says MERCER, ELENA RUTH. Below that is a birth date in 1993, an issue date in 2023, an expiration date in 2029. An address in Independence. I have driven through Independence. I have complained about traffic there with the air-conditioning on and a drink sweating in the cup holder.

Four years here. A card issued in 2023.

I can't make those numbers useful without knowing when she left, when she arrived, how long she stayed. My brain keeps trying anyway. I start subtracting, lose track, and start again. How old would Mom be? I haven't even got the right year to start from.

"Elena," I say.

Vey's eyes sharpen.

I wish I hadn't given him that for free.

"That is the name we had."

"Why do you have her card?"

"She left possessions in a chest. The chest remained when she went."

"You kept them."

"The house kept them. I brought this one from the collection."

"Collection," I repeat.

Ordway pushes a sack away from my elbow before I knock it over.

Vey looks at her, then at the customers passing behind us. “Would you prefer somewhere private?”

“I’d prefer you answer.”

“Rook buys unusual objects. Some are recovered from abandoned holdings. Some are sold to us. Some are left by people who don’t return. They are inventoried. I don’t administer the collection.”

“But you use it to hire people.”

“Occasionally.”

Tolliver is looking at the card now. His mouth is set in a way I recognize from our room, just before an answer gets expensive.

“Did you know?” I ask him.

“I knew they wanted someone who could read strange writing. I hadn’t seen that.”

“Is that why you found me?”

“No.”

The answer has force behind it. Several feet away, a woman turns with a spool in her hand.

He lowers his voice. “I was coming back from a message run. You were on the slope above the creek. I didn’t go into those woods looking for you.”

“Why did you think I could read it?”

“The marks on your shirt.”

I feel the wet cotton again, the hem torn off for my foot, his coat pulled closed over it. CRIT HAPPENS. A stupid joke I bought because Liam had one in a worse color.

Vey watches us. I want to put something over his face.

“You told him about my shirt.”

“This morning,” Tolliver says. “When he asked what else was unusual.”

There is a needle on the table between us. One small bent needle Ordway missed. I concentrate on it until I can ask the next question without shouting.

“Anything else?”

“That you didn’t know how to spend reserve when I found you. That you learned quickly.”

“Do you want me to leave?” Vey asks.

“I want you both to stop having conversations about me that I get invited to afterward.”

Ordway takes the spool from the waiting woman, names a price, and makes change. It gives me time to breathe. I step closer to the table to let the customer pass, still gripping the license hard enough to bend it.

“How long was Elena at your house?” I ask.

"Nine months, approximately."

"Did she come in like me? Low level. No origin."

"I didn't admit her. I can show you her entry."

"What did she do there?"

"Survey work. Water levels, old culverts, the lower road. She worked with our keeper of records."

"Did she say where she was from?"

"A place called Missouri. Nobody I asked knew it."

Hearing him say it is worse than seeing it printed. He puts the weight in the wrong place, and suddenly I'm hearing an out-of-state caller ask if we're anywhere near St. Louis.

"Why did she leave?"

"She wanted access to a site the house had closed. The south sluice. There was an argument about safety and about what she'd been hired to do."

"And then she left her ID and all her stuff and walked away?"

"I saw her leave with a pack. I didn't search it."

I turn the card over. The barcode is there. The dark strip. Small printed words I have never cared enough to read on my own license.

A thumbnail has worried the plastic beside one of the stitches. Hers, maybe. Someone else's. The card cannot tell me.

"Can I keep this?"

"No."

His first answer without any polish.

"Then I'm going to need something to write on."

Ordway opens her till box and takes out a narrow scrap with figures on one side. She sets it down beside a pencil worn nearly to the wood.

I copy Elena's name and the three dates. My hand shakes badly enough that the first nine looks like a four, and I cross it out. I copy the city. Not the street address. If I ever get to use it, I can look her up. If I never do, another street I cannot reach is not going to help.

Then I put the license down.

Vey slides it back into his wallet. I watch until the flap closes.

"Show me the offer."

—○—

The letters shift when I unfold the paper.

For a second they are all narrow uprights and little hanging hooks. Then I understand them. The shapes don't become English, exactly. The meaning settles behind them, and I am reading a sentence whose individual letters I

couldn't have named a moment ago.

I look back at the name I've just written.

ELENA RUTH MERCER.

Those letters stay themselves.

"Read that," I tell Vey, pointing to the scrap.

He studies it. "I recognize that you've repeated the marks on the object."

"You can't read them?"

"No."

Ordway shakes her head before I can ask her. Tolliver does the same.

I cover the scrap with my palm. There is something here I need to understand, but not with three people watching me discover how useful I am.

The offer is three pages. I read every one.

A year of service. Board and bed. Two pieces each week in cash, with clothing, equipment, and additional instruction charged to an account. A basic course of instruction in one run selected *according to the needs of the holding*. No promise about which one.

I turn the page back.

"What counts as additional instruction?"

"Specialist work beyond the course."

"At what price?"

"The instructor's price. You would be shown it."

"Before?"

Vey points to a line. Before approval. It is there. I mark it with my finger and keep reading.

Leaving requires thirty days' notice and settlement of outstanding charges. Work produced in service belongs to the house. Objects recovered during assigned work belong to the house. The words are plain once I have them, and large enough to fit a driver's license through.

"Does this let you keep somebody until they pay?"

"It lets us pursue a debt."

"That wasn't what I asked."

"Under this agreement, a person with an unsettled account cannot demand release from the service term."

Across the table, Ordway stops winding a loose length of thread.

I fold the third page over the first.

"No."

Vey doesn't reach for it. "Which provision?"

"The year. The unknown bill. You deciding what I learn. The part where anything I find about my own home becomes yours because I'm doing your

job when I find it. Pick one.”

He considers me without smiling. “You haven’t told me where your home is.”

“And yet you brought that card.”

Tolliver shifts beside me. I don’t look at him.

“I cannot open the whole collection to a visitor,” Vey says. “Some pieces are fragile. Some have disputed ownership. Some have harmed people who handled them carelessly.”

“You can hire a reader without hiring a person for a year.”

“For how much?”

I open my mouth, then shut it. Vey waits. He has stopped handling the paper.

One piece for a morning’s work. Two pieces a week on his paper, plus room and food. Those numbers mean different things in different arrangements, and I am tired enough to choose the one that sounds biggest.

“First tell me what you need read.”

“A notebook. Some labels. We have partial copies of inscriptions in the same sort of lettering.”

“Elena’s notebook?”

“We believe so.”

“How many pages?”

“Thirty-six with writing.”

“And you can’t bring it here.”

“I am authorized to take samples out. Not the original volume.”

The bell begins before I answer. Its first stroke travels through the boards under my hands.

Ordway puts the thread away.

“We have an appointment,” she says.

Vey looks toward the gate road. For the first time, his afternoon seems to have developed a problem that isn’t me.

“I’m staying tonight,” I tell him. “I can meet you at the tavern afterward. If you have a short agreement for reading, bring that. If you only have this, don’t.”

“Maya—” Tolliver begins.

“Are you coming to the gatehouse?”

He shuts his mouth, then nods.

Vey collects the unsigned offer. I keep the scrap with Elena’s name.

Before we leave, Ordway pays me.

Eight bits instead of a piece because her till is low. She counts them into my right hand, clear of the sore knuckles.

“Whole morning,” she says when I look at her.

“We closed early.”

“And you got the rest of the market opened again. I’m not docking you for that.”

Nine bits. I curl my fingers around them until the edges hurt. Vey has folded the year-long offer away, and I still have somewhere to sleep tonight.

—○—

The gatehouse smells of wet leather and a pot of something that has been kept warm through several people’s disappointment.

Bertran seats Ordway on a bench and leaves Tolliver and me standing. The book takes up most of his desk. There are slips tucked between the pages, a stone holding one corner flat, and a dark stain where somebody lost an argument with the ink.

“Open,” he says.

I expose my name. Tolliver does the same beside me. Bertran checks us against the entry, then motions us closed again.

“Employer?”

Ordway gives her name and the location of her stall. He knows both. He writes them anyway.

“She worked two mornings. Earned a piece each. I’d have her back.”

“And lodging?”

I tell him what I’ve paid and where. He writes that too.

“The existing entry places responsibility with him,” he says, tapping the page without looking at Tolliver. “Are you withdrawing it?”

“Yes,” Tolliver says.

I wait for the rest. It comes slowly.

“I have no claim on her wages. No service agreement. No debt against her for what I’ve spent.”

Bertran looks up. “Any advance?”

“Four bits. She hasn’t used them. They’re a gift if she wants them.”

“I don’t.”

“Then she’ll return them,” Tolliver says.

“I can answer.”

His jaw tightens. “Yes.”

Bertran dips his pen. “Anything else before I amend this?”

The book is open. The part I asked to change is almost changed. I could take that and get out into the air.

“I’ve never been to Skell’s Holding,” I say.

Ordway turns her head toward me.

Tolliver doesn't move.

The pen stays above the page long enough for a bead of ink to swell at its tip.

"Go on," Bertran says.

"He found me in the woods. North of here. I didn't know what to say at the gate, and he told me to let him talk."

"Did you lose your origin at Skell's?"

"No."

"Have you ever held an origin?"

"Not that I've known."

He sets the pen down.

"Outside," he tells Tolliver.

"I gave you the account."

"I remember who spoke. Outside."

Tolliver goes. There is a window above Bertran's shoulder, too narrow to climb through even if I had the energy. I look at it while he folds his hands.

"Where are you from?"

"Kansas City."

"Whose territory?"

"You won't know it."

"That wasn't the question."

I swallow. "Missouri. In the United States."

Ordway says nothing. No little noise, no helpful interruption. I am grateful enough to hurt.

Bertran makes me spell the words. I can't name a local road from there to here, or a ship, or a person he can send to verify it. When I tell him I woke in the forest, he asks whether I had been struck. Whether I remember being given a drink. Whether anyone took my things.

"I don't know," I say, and finally start crying.

It is quiet, which somehow makes it worse. Tears drop off my chin onto the front of my borrowed skirt while I keep answering. No, I don't know which holding owns the forest. No, I don't remember a gate. Yes, the foot was cut after I woke. I know because I remember stepping on it.

Bertran pushes a cloth across the desk. It smells faintly of onions.

"I can't put a country I've never heard of into the origin field," he says.

"I didn't ask you to."

"I'm telling you what I can do."

He waits until I look at him.

"Seven days' provisional stay on your own responsibility, based on work and lodging witnessed here. If you stay longer, come back before it ends. If you leave, register the departure. Your account of where you came from goes in as unverified. No one here is attesting to that."

"Can I work?"

"Yes."

"Can somebody take my wages?"

"Not on the strength of this entry. A lawful debt is a separate matter. So don't sign one because a factor bought you supper."

The corner of Ordway's mouth moves.

He brings Tolliver back in and asks him the same questions without letting me answer. Tolliver says Skell's was destroyed by fever, but he had no reason to think I'd come from there. He admits inventing that connection because an injured adult with an empty origin was likely to be detained while somebody investigated.

"You made that my decision with false information," Bertran says.

"Yes."

"Two pieces for the false declaration. Your standing as an entry witness is suspended until Hale reviews it."

Tolliver reaches for his purse.

I look at the floor while he pays. For a second I want to tell Bertran it wasn't all Tolliver's fault. I press my lips together. He found me barefoot; I didn't ask him to lie.

Bertran writes the payment down, then reads the amendment aloud. Ordway witnesses the employment and lodging statement. Tolliver signs the withdrawal. I sign beneath my own responsibility, in the English letters of my name.

The pen is unfamiliar. My signature still looks like mine.

Bertran gives me a narrow stamped slip showing the term of my stay and the amended entry number. It has no magical effect. I know because when I open my measure, the origin is as empty as before.

I go into the other list and select Traveler.

"Changed?" I ask Ordway.

She looks up. "Changed."

I let my hand fall. My neck feels exactly the same.

Before Bertran closes the book, I ask about the mender's bill.

"Market fire fund pays immediate treatment," he says. "Stall dues maintain it. We'll settle damage and fault with the carter and the oil seller. Treatment isn't your debt."

Ordway rises with a grunt. "Somebody gets something for my dues at last."

Outside, Tolliver starts to speak. She walks past him and stops in front of me.

"If you stay, come early. If you go, tell me before I open."

"I will."

She squeezes my good hand and heads back toward the market, where half her stock is waiting under a locked cover.

Tolliver and I stand beside the wall.

"I'm sorry," he says.

There is no explanation attached. It leaves him looking strangely unfinished.

"For which part?"

He takes that without looking away.

"The fee. I should have told you about the fee."

"And my shirt."

He looks toward the gatehouse door. "Yes."

I rub my thumb over the stamped slip. He has paid two pieces, lost the finding fee, and let the warden write him down as a liar. I want to take his hand. I put the slip away instead.

"I thought you'd be safer there," he says.

"Do you still?"

"Yes."

At least he doesn't make that easy for me.

A cart rattles through the gate. For several seconds we can't hear each other even if we want to.

"Do you actually know how to get to Rook House?" I ask when it passes.

"Yes."

"Good. I may need directions."

—○—

Vey waits in the tavern with a new sheet and no supper.

I wash first. The keeper lends me ash and a rag for the boots, and I scrub until the soles stop sliding on the yard stones. The scrape on my arm burns under clean water. When I finally sit across from him, my hair is still damp and one side ends in a small, ugly fringe.

I make him move the paper away from a ring left by somebody's ale.

Six days of reading work after arrival. One piece for each day worked, paid that evening. No advances. Meals and bed on the journey and

throughout the visit, including any wait for return passage. A cart seat there, and one back to Greyward on the first house cart within three days after I finish or leave. Those costs cannot be charged back. I may stop the work at any time; pay already earned remains mine. No change of origin. No choice of run made for me.

There is no training course. A short hire doesn't buy one.

In return, Rook gets my translations of the named notebook and its associated labels. No obligation to open mechanisms, enter closed works, or surrender possessions I bring with me. I can keep copies of my translations and notes about Elena. I cannot take the original objects.

"I want her entry and departure records before I begin," I say.

Vey adds the line.

"And if she's in your house now?"

He sets down the pen. "Then you will be allowed to speak with her. But I do not expect that to be the case."

I make him add it anyway.

"Tolliver's fee?"

"Requires a service entry. This isn't one. He earns nothing from it."

Tolliver is at another table, close enough to hear. His expression changes, but he doesn't argue.

Vey signs both copies. The keeper comes over to witness after I ask her. She reads the pay and departure clauses, then turns the page back and starts from the top. I wait with the pen in my hand.

"Return passage includes food," she says.

Vey adds that too.

I sign.

He leaves me one copy and tells me the cart departs from the south gate at first bell. Then he goes upstairs to arrange his own affairs, carrying the card with him.

I buy stew and bread for two bits. Seven left. After I eat, I go upstairs for Tolliver's four coins. He is still at his table when I bring them down and put them beside his hand.

He sweeps them into his purse. One catches on the seam, and he has to push it down with his finger.

Later, alone, I lay out the contract, the gate slip, and the scrap bearing Elena's name. Two reserve now. I set the paper beside the candle.

Under the name I add a question in English.

Did you find a way back?

I stare at it until the candle guttering beside my hand reminds me that I have to pack.

CHAPTER TEN

Everything I own fits inside a flour sack.

The keeper gives me one with a split seam and lets me use her needle while she counts yesterday's money. I mend it badly, turn the repaired side inward, and put my Earth clothes at the bottom. The shirt still smells faintly of the forest. I fold the black shorts inside it and tie the bundle with a piece of string so I won't have to see it every time I need something.

The contract and gate slip go inside a fold of the woolen garment while I pack, then against my chest when I put it on. Elena's name goes with them. The candle is too short to be much use, but I take it anyway.

Breakfast costs a bit. Six left.

"Key?" the keeper asks.

"It bolts from inside."

"Then you're done."

I wait beside the table until she looks up again. Right. No receipt. I shift the sack to my other hand.

"Thank you for witnessing."

"Read it again when you get there. Make sure their copy matches."

She goes back to her counting.

Outside, the town is only partly awake. A baker is shoveling ash into a bucket. A woman passes carrying two live hens under her arms, both straining toward the ground. I keep expecting to feel the empty room behind me. Mostly I feel the sack bumping my leg.

Ordway is at her stall before the sun reaches the roofs.

"I'm going," I say.

She looks at the sack. "So I see."

I tell her about the six days, the pay, the return cart. She asks to see the paper. I hold it while she reads so the corners don't drag through the damp.

"A piece a day," she says. "Would've offered you that for another morning."

"I know."

"No, you didn't. I hadn't offered."

I laugh, and then my throat hurts.

She takes the paper between her fingers at the departure clause. "If they argue with this, send word with a carrier. Put my stall on it. I can't fetch you, but I can get a warden to ask why."

"I don't want you owing somebody for me."

"Then pay the carrier."

She reaches under the table and brings out a small cloth bag.

"Yesterday's heel. Cheese is good. Hester sent the bread when I told her you might leave."

I accept it and feel the bread through the cloth. I had been trying to decide how to ask the price.

"Tell her thank you."

"Come tell her yourself sometime."

She takes the knot of my flour sack apart, tightens it properly, and gives it back. Then a customer arrives for lamp wicks and our goodbye has to make room for him.

At the gate, Bertran reads my departure into the book. I keep the slip; he marks it to show I have left. If I come back after the provisional term, he says, we will make a new entry. I understand the distinction well enough to nod without looking at Tolliver.

He is waiting beside a cart loaded with canvas-wrapped crates. His bow is strung. A second cart stands behind it, higher-sided, with sacks roped beneath a cover. Master Vey is arguing with a woman about whether his chest belongs on top.

"Are they paying you for this?" I ask Tolliver.

"Road escort. Two pieces for the trip. Separate from finding anyone."

"You could have mentioned it."

"Yes," he says. "I could."

"If you want it cracked when we brake, yes," the carter tells Vey.

Vey moves the chest.

The woman has an old scar through one eyebrow and **[CARTER, LV. 15]** above her head. She introduces herself as Nessa, points me toward the front cart, and tells me where my feet may go. Most of the possible places are wrong.

A young woman leans against the wheel eating an apple. **[GUARD, LV. 12]**. Her dark hair is in two short braids, and her nose looks as if it has been broken at least once by someone with a clear intention.

"You're the reader," she says.

"Maya."

She looks at the sack. "Can you sit on a board for a day?"

"I can sit."

She bites the apple again.

Tolliver puts a hand beneath my elbow when I climb, then lets go as soon as I have the rail. I sit on the board Nessa indicated and tuck my sack beneath my knees. The guard swings up opposite me with her pack between her boots.

"Sella," she says.

I nod.

"Don't put a finger through the side rail. You'll want to. Don't."

The bell starts. Nessa clicks her tongue, the cart lurches, and I immediately understand why everyone has been giving me instructions about where to put parts of myself.

Greyward goes away one uncomfortable yard at a time.

—○—

For the first hour I watch everything.

By the second, everything includes an impressive number of hedges. My ass has gone numb. At the next rut I bite the inside of my cheek.

Tolliver walks on the left side of the road, sometimes ahead, sometimes beside us. He touches his throat at a fork, looks along the verge, then keeps going. Sella watches the right. Vey rides in the second cart beside its driver, a quiet man who seems pleased with the arrangement.

"Is Traveler your run?" I ask when Tolliver draws level.

"No."

"I know the label isn't necessarily the run. I'm asking what yours is."

"Tracker."

"Like finding footprints?"

"Among other things."

I give him a look.

He adjusts his bow strap. "I can hold a trail after it stops being visible. Briefly. If I've found enough of it first. I don't ask the ground where someone is and get an answer."

"Could you find somebody after four years?"

"No."

The directness helps, though I hate the answer.

"Four days?"

"Depends on the weather, the ground, and who crossed it after them."

Sella flicks her apple core into the ditch. "And whether they know how to make him follow a goat."

"Once," Tolliver says.

“An entire afternoon.”

I look between them. “You know each other.”

“Work,” she says. “Last winter. He found the goat eventually.”

He walks ahead while she smiles into her sleeve.

For a few minutes the road becomes almost pleasant. I ask about her run. Warder, she says. Her father taught her the first holds before she could carry the shield properly. She has worked caravans for three years, since she was eighteen, and has never been to the coast because every person hiring eastbound wants her for a westbound rate.

“Ordway wanted to see the coast,” I say.

“I want to get past the ridge before the autumn hiring ends. Get a winter berth on one of the coastal runs.”

A bird lifts from the hedge with a clatter like shaken cutlery. Its plate is gone before I can read it.

“Does being a warder mean you have to stay in one place?”

“It means I get paid to keep something from coming through a place. Different amount of standing.”

“Can you fight?”

She looks down at the sword between her knees, then back at me.

“Fair,” I say.

“A run helps. It doesn’t do all of you. Nessa can break your arm, and hers is Hauler.”

“Both arms,” Nessa says from the front. “Stay seated until we stop.”

I settle back against a crate.

My measure this morning was full: four out of four. The two points I lacked last night returned while I slept. My scraped arm is crusted and sore. I ease the fingers of my left hand open against my knee.

“Could you show me?” I ask Sella. “When we stop.”

She studies me more carefully. “Your run’s unset?”

“Yes.”

“What have you spent on?”

“Strength. Once with a basin. Twice with a table that was on fire.”

“We’ll use something less ambitious.”

I tell her about the basin and the fire. She asks which hand held the table, where my feet were, and what happened when the strength ended. The questions make me realize how little of the rescue I could repeat on purpose.

“At the watering place,” she says. “If you’re still interested after you’ve tried walking again.”

I am interested. Walking again is an argument between several parts of me, but I win it.

The watering place is a stone trough beside a stand of low trees. Nessa checks the horses' legs while the other driver looks over a wheel. Tolliver goes a little way up the rise where he can see the road behind us. Nobody has to announce that we are taking precautions. They fit them around eating and pissing and arguing over a loose strap.

Sella gives me a wooden shield with a metal rim. It is the spare, and has a split repaired with two staples. My arm objects before I have it in position.

"No," she says. "Closer. Let your elbow rest. You're holding it too far out."

She turns my wrist, gets permission before adjusting the sore hand, and shows me how the strap takes some of the weight.

She pushes the shield with one hand. The rim turns across my body, my rear foot slides, and I sit in the grass.

"Too narrow," she says, pointing at my feet.

"I noticed."

She offers a hand. I take it with the one that isn't trapped in military equipment.

We try again without reserve. Bend the knees. Don't lock the elbow. Put the shield where the blow is going, rather than chasing it after it arrives. She taps the rim with a stick and I move too far, too late, or occasionally in an entirely unhelpful direction.

I am sweating by the time she has me stand against a tree.

"Your burst makes more force," she says. "What happens if I push you sideways while you're making it?"

"I fall over."

"Spend one. Hold the shield. Don't push me."

I find the reserve. The weight leaves my arm.

Sella presses a hand to the rim. I hold. She moves the hand a few inches, changes the angle, and the shield twists despite the strength. I stumble sideways before catching myself against the trunk.

[RESERVE: 3 / 4]

"Strong isn't planted," she says. "A first warder's hold keeps the force on the line you set. Shield through arm, back, leg, ground. If any of those gives, the hold gives."

"How do I tell it which line?"

“By knowing where you’re braced.”

She demonstrates. I push the shield with both hands. It feels ordinary at first, heavy and difficult to move because she is a trained adult doing a thing she knows. Then something changes. The slight give disappears. I might as well be pushing the trunk behind her.

Three breaths later it is a shield again.

“That’s Brace. One point. Three breaths if you keep the shape. Less if you panic and try to do something else with it.”

“And I need your run to do it?”

“You need a warder’s pattern to hold it that neatly. You can waste reserve getting close without one. Most of us do, learning.”

I let my hands fall.

She lowers the shield and shows me the stance again, this time from the side, then hands it over. I follow without spending. I can feel the difference between holding my arm rigid and letting the pressure find the ground. Mostly I can feel the places where I do it wrong.

“I wanted a sword,” I say.

“Buy one.”

“A magic sword. Fire. Possibly a dramatic coat.”

“You’ll want a better wage.”

I laugh. She waits until I’ve finished, then taps my elbow down.

“Take the run because you want to learn what it does. Don’t take it because I happen to have a spare shield. We can practice stance without it.”

For another few minutes we do. When I open my measure afterward, progress has moved to two out of fourteen.

I show her my face before I can help it.

“What?”

“One point.”

“You learned something.”

“I learned about thirty things.”

“Put the shield back. Nessa’s ready.”

At the cart, Tolliver hands me my cloth bag of food.

“You looked good,” he says.

“I fell over.”

“Sella didn’t let me touch her shield until I’d carried it a mile. She likes you.”

“Is that what the bruises mean?”

He smiles, and I get a brief, deeply inconvenient picture of that mouth against mine. Then I bite into Hester’s bread and discover that I am hungry enough for desire to wait its turn.

After midday the fields fall away. The road runs between shallow pools with reeds standing in brown water. There is a raised stone crossing ahead, no railing, wide enough for one cart at a time. Beyond it the ground climbs toward a low building with smoke coming from its roof.

“Wayhouse,” Sella says. “We’ll stop there.”

“Already?”

“Last dry yard before the long stretch. Tomorrow we start earlier.”

Tolliver stops at the crossing. Nessa stops behind him, and the second driver reins in with enough space left between the carts to turn.

No one looks surprised by the delay. I sit still and try to be useful by occupying exactly the amount of space I have been assigned.

Tolliver crouches beside a low iron grille under the nearest edge of the stonework. One corner has pulled loose. Water slides through the gap with bits of weed turning in it.

“Reed-jacks,” he says.

Nessa swears.

Sella is off the cart immediately, sword out. “Fresh?”

“Mud’s still running.”

“Maya. Feet up on the bed. Stay behind the crates.”

I move before I ask what a reed-jack is.

Something brown and narrow slips through the water beyond Tolliver. My first impression is an otter, which lasts until it rises higher than the reeds and opens a mouth split nearly to its neck.

[REED-JACK, LV. 5]

Its teeth are yellow. I get both feet behind the crate.

Tolliver backs onto the road with an arrow drawn. Sella walks toward the horse’s head, putting herself between it and the water. Nessa turns the animal slowly. Behind us, the other driver is already backing his cart toward the wider part of the road.

“Keep turning,” Tolliver says. “There’s a second.”

The first one comes low and fast, barely lifting out of the ditch. His arrow takes it in the shoulder. It tumbles, gets up, and Sella meets it with the edge of her shield.

The sound is hideous. Bone or wood, I can’t tell. The horse jerks sideways and the whole cart rocks beneath me.

I grab a crate. My sore knuckles reopen against the rope.

The second creature hits the back of the cart.

I don't see it jump. There is a wet slap, then claws drag across the board beside my boot. A narrow head comes over the tail rail with its whiskers spread and black eyes fixed on me.

The spare shield is strapped to the crate at my left knee.

I pull at it. The buckle doesn't come loose. I yank again. My fingers keep slipping off the tongue.

"Back of the cart!" I shout.

Vey shouts something in reply from behind us. The animal snaps at my moving hand and its teeth close on the edge of the sack instead. Flour dust puffs from the seam.

My shirt is in there.

I get the buckle open.

The shield comes free. I put it between us without getting my arm through the strap, both hands on the back, and shove. The creature's forefeet slide off the rail. For half a second I think I've done it.

Then it lands on the road, turns under the cart, and vanishes.

"Where?" Tolliver calls.

"Under me!"

Nessa is holding the horse with both hands on the reins. If it bolts, Tolliver is in front of the wheel. If she lets go to help me, the whole situation becomes faster and worse.

Sella has the first animal pinned away from the horse. I can hear her swearing each time it pulls against her sword.

I drag the sack behind the crate with my heel. The tail rail is barely knee-high when I'm standing. I sit with my back against the load and get my arm into the shield properly.

Something scrapes beneath the bed.

I need it to stay out until someone can kill it. That is the whole job. There is no health bar I can nibble down while strafing. There is a mouth coming over the wood, and my left hand is inside the only thing between us.

My boots find the crossbeam beneath the opposite rail.

Shield. Arm. Back. Legs.

I can feel where the shove would go. Into the crate, through my hips, down to the soles pressed against the beam. The cart is moving slightly with the frightened horse. I am braced against the cart, not the road. I don't know if that counts.

The creature's head rises.

I reach for the shape Sella showed me.

Something answers inside the place where my run has always been empty.

[WARDER]

No list. No pretty spinning model. Just a word, available when I finally have some idea what I am asking it to mean.

I think of Nyx, who would have blinked behind the thing and cut it in half.

I cannot do that.

I can keep this space.

I choose.

[RUN: WARDER]

The new shape closes around the pressure I am holding.

[BRACE]

I spend into it as the creature hits.

The shield drives against my arm, but the force runs through me instead of folding me. The crate creaks behind my back. I feel the impact in my teeth. The animal is scrabbling for purchase on the rim, close enough that spit hits my cheek.

One breath.

“Here!” I yell. “At the back!”

Two.

A blade comes past my right side. I jerk away from it, and the hold breaks.

Weight slams into my shoulder.

“Stay still!” Vey says.

He is on the road behind the cart with a short knife. He has cut across one foreleg, but the thing hasn’t let go. His clean brown sleeve is wet to the elbow.

I set my feet again. The pattern is there, easier to find and harder to trust.

One more point.

This time I hold while Vey gets clear.

Sella pulls her sword free of the first body and reaches us before the third breath. She takes the creature behind the skull with her sword, pulls it off the rail, and uses her boot to keep it down. The body beats against the road. I shut my eyes, which doesn’t make any part of the sound go away.

“Clear,” she says.

I keep holding.

“Maya. It’s clear.”

The strength drains out of the shield. I lower it onto my knees and start shaking so hard the metal rim knocks against the wood.

Tolliver comes around the cart with his bow down. There is blood on one sleeve. He looks at me, at the shield, then beneath the cart, checking even now.

“Bitten?”

I shake my head. Then I look at my arms because being wrong seems possible.

No holes. The old scrape. The broken knuckles. A long red mark where the strap crossed my wrist.

“No.”

He puts his hand on the rim to stop the knocking. He doesn’t try to take it until I let him.

—○—

We do not celebrate beside the dead things.

Sella and Tolliver check both ditches. Vey climbs back into his cart without comment about his sleeve. Nessa gets the horse settled, then we cross the stones slowly with someone walking on each side.

At the wayhouse, a man comes out with a pitchfork, hears about the grille, and immediately calls for his sons. A little girl is sent to keep the goats in their yard. She runs, looking back once at the pitchfork. The youngest son comes out still chewing, and his father points him toward the crossing.

I check the sack before I sit on the mounting block. Two tooth holes near the knot, nothing missing. My shirt is still inside its bundle. I put the borrowed shield in the dirt beside me and open my measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 2]

[PROGRESS: 6 / 14]

[RESERVE: 1 / 4]

[RUN: WARDER]

Under the run, when I attend to it, Brace opens into the same shape I found against the crate. I can recall it without spending. I don’t try to use it.

Sella crouches in front of me.

“You took it.”

“Yes.”

“Any pain when you breathe?”

I test carefully. My shoulder aches. My ribs move without anything sharp.

“No.”

She checks the strap mark after I offer my arm.

“Your back support moved. Next time, choose something that won’t.”

“I didn’t have anything else.”

“I know.” She turns my wrist over to check the skin beneath the strap.

I look at the shield in the dirt. The tooth marks are much deeper than I expected.

“Did I choose wrong?”

She sits beside me instead of answering immediately.

“I can’t tell you whether you’ll want it in ten years. I can tell you that getting scared doesn’t make the choice worthless. You’ll have to learn it somewhere quieter now.”

“Does it always do that? Offer the word when you try?”

“If you’ve got enough of the pattern. Some people practice for weeks. Some take it on the first good attempt. A word you don’t understand won’t hold a run for you.”

I rub the heel of my hand against my skirt.

“I stopped moving. That’s what I picked.”

“For a few breaths. When I fight, do I look nailed to the road?”

I think about her moving from the horse to the back of the cart. “No.”

“I’ll show you. When that arm stops shaking.”

She gets up, retrieves her shield, and carries it to the trough to wash off the blood.

Tolliver brings water in a cup. I drink half before noticing he’s watching my hand.

“I can hold it,” I say.

“I know.”

He sits on the ground, leaving the mounting block to me. There is a slice through the outer wool of his sleeve. The skin beneath is unbroken.

“I thought it got you,” I tell him.

“The blood isn’t mine.”

I put the cup down and touch the torn edge anyway. He goes still under my fingers.

The wool is rough where it tore. I smooth it with my thumb, although I can see the skin underneath is whole. He looks down at my hand, and I nearly take it away.

“You could have been bitten.”

“So could you.”

I leave my hand where it is.

After a while he turns his palm up on his knee. I move my fingers down to it. Neither of us pulls. His hand is warm and has a callus along the base of the fingers where the bowstring must rub.

We sit like that until Nessa comes to tell us where we're sleeping. His palm is damp when I let go.

—○—

The short-hire agreement gets me stew, a place on a shared sleeping platform, and a blanket that smells aggressively of sheep. I eat Hester's remaining bread with the stew. My six bits remain six.

Vey has washed his sleeve. A pale patch remains where the blood was. I keep looking at it while I eat.

"Thank you," I say when he sits across from me.

"You're welcome."

I remember his knife coming past the shield. I had thought he would stay in the other cart. He is waiting for me to say something else, so I take another spoonful.

He puts a folded sheet on the table.

"A tracing from the notebook. I brought it as a second sample. For you to look at, if you wish. You don't owe me a word of work before you've seen the records."

"Tomorrow," I say automatically. My shoulder is throbbing, and I have reached the point where reading prices on a menu would count as advanced scholarship.

"As you prefer."

He leaves it on the table.

Of course I unfold it.

There is a diagram in faded copied lines: a channel, two circles, a box with an arrow on each side. Some of the dimensions are written in local script. The notes crowded against the right-hand margin are English.

Not printed. Handwritten. Crossed out in places. Whoever made the tracing preserved even a small spiral doodle beside one of the circles.

I put my finger below the first line so I won't skip anything.

First gate changes the water level. Second changes where the water comes from.

Below it, underlined twice:

It isn't a drain.

There is one more note at the bottom. The letters get smaller toward the end, squeezed into the space before the edge of the paper.

Do not send anyone through until we know what happened to the rope.

I look up.

Vey has not gone upstairs. He is waiting by the hearth with his hands clasped behind his back.

“Did she write this before she left?” I ask.

“We think so.”

“What happened at the south sluice?”

He draws out the chair again.

“I’ll have the closure record brought with the other documents you’ve asked to see.”

“I’m asking you.”

For a moment the common room seems very loud around us. Spoons against bowls. Nessa arguing pleasantly about the quality of the hay. Somebody shifting a log in the fire.

“Two people went below,” he says. “One came back.”

I flatten the page with my good hand.

“Which one was Elena?”

“The one who came back.”

CHAPTER ELEVEN

“Who was the other person?”

Vey pulls his chair nearer the table. A man behind him laughs at something, loud enough to make me hate him for half a second.

“Iven Orrel. A sluicewright in the house’s employ.”

“Did you know him?”

“Yes.”

“What happened?”

“I wasn’t below with them.”

“Then start where you were.”

He looks at the tracing beneath my hand.

“I was in the counting room. Someone came for me because there had been an accident at the south works. By the time I reached the headwall, Elena was up. Wet to the waist. She had rope burns on both hands. She kept asking them to lower the gate again.”

“The second gate?”

“I don’t know what she called them. They had stopped the inner wheel by the time I arrived.”

“Why wouldn’t they open it?”

“Because the man who worked it had just lost someone.”

I lift my hand off the paper. There is a damp print where my palm was.

Vey takes a slow breath.

“She said Iven was on a stair. There was no stair on the works plan. She wanted the wheel turned to a particular position so she could go back for him. The foreman refused. They’d had water rising in a chamber that should have been drained. His first duty was to the people he could still reach.”

“What did you do?”

“I agreed with him.”

The answer makes his face harder to look at. I can imagine him on the bank saying something reasonable while Elena tears skin off her hands trying to get past him.

I catch myself watching his sleeve again and turn back to the tracing.

“Did anyone look afterward?”

“They sounded the lower pool. Dragged the outlet. Sent men along both banks for three days. Nothing was recovered.”

“A search for a body.”

“Yes.”

“She was asking for a search for a person.”

“She was.”

My thumb catches the edge of the table. A splinter lifts without breaking off. I press it flat again.

“How long after that did she leave?”

“Eleven days. I remember because I was still arranging wages for the search crews.”

“And you decided ‘argument about safety’ covered this when you were hiring me.”

“No. I decided you might refuse to come if I told you before you saw the writing.”

For a moment I have nothing to say.

The common room carries on around us. I had been ready to drag the admission out of him. Instead he sits there waiting while I unclench my teeth.

“You don’t get credit for saying that now.”

“I wasn’t asking for it.”

“Then why say it?”

“Because Dain will tell you tomorrow.”

I look up. Vey’s face has gone red above the collar.

“You could tell him not to.”

“He wouldn’t listen.”

I fold the tracing along its old crease. Carefully. It belongs to a woman who tried to bring somebody back, or to a woman who made a terrible mistake and couldn’t accept it. So far I have one man’s account of both possibilities.

“Who can tell me what happened below?”

“Only Elena could tell you all of it. Dain worked the wheel. He’s still at Rook.”

“And this Orrel man’s family?”

“His sister is our keeper of records.”

“The person Elena worked with.”

“Mara. Yes.”

I lean back. My shoulder complains, a deep ache that travels down the outside of my arm.

"Does she know you're bringing me?"

"She knows I've hired a reader."

"Does she know why you think I can read it?"

"I sent word that you recognized the marks on Elena's card. Nothing about your origin."

I repeat the wording silently so I can ask Mara tomorrow.

Vey reaches toward the folded tracing, then stops short of it.

"You can keep that copy."

"I was going to."

He gets up. Before he can leave, I ask the question that has been underneath all the others.

"Do you think she's alive?"

"I saw a woman leave with food, money, and a walking staff. She had learned a great deal in nine months."

"That's not an answer."

"No," he says. "It isn't."

—○—

Sella finds me beside the wash trough trying to get a strip of linen around my knuckles with my teeth.

"You'll make those filthy."

"I rinsed them."

"Your mouth?"

I lower my hand.

She takes the strip the wayhouse woman gave me and asks permission before inspecting the skin. The bleeding stopped hours ago. Water has softened the edges, and I have been bending my fingers to see if they hurt, which turns out to be an excellent way of keeping them that way.

Sella wraps them loosely. The linen is included in the wayhouse's charge to Vey, according to the woman, who looked much less concerned about this expenditure than I did.

"Does Brace work without a shield?" I ask.

"Yes."

"Could I hold a rope?"

She stops with the knot half-made.

"What rope?"

"Hypothetically."

"No one asks about a hypothetical rope with that face."

I look toward the stable. Tolliver is helping Nessa shift a feed sack. He looks up once, sees us, and goes back to the sack.

“I read something about someone who went missing in water.”

“A shield spreads pressure,” Sella says. “A rope puts it through your hands or whatever you’ve tied it to. Brace doesn’t make your skin stronger. It doesn’t make the thing behind your feet stronger. If you hold against more than either can take, something tears.”

“Even if the hold works.”

“Especially then.”

She finishes the knot.

“You can practice with your forearms on a wall tomorrow. No spending tonight. Those hands need to close.”

I thank her. She accepts it with a brief nod and goes to check the shield straps before bed.

Inside, the sleeping platform has been divided by bags and elbows into territories nobody admits to claiming. I take the space beside Sella’s pack. My sack goes beneath my head, with the tooth holes facing the wall.

My mother keeps her needles in a tin with strawberries on the lid. Even after I knew the cookies were gone, I used to open it. The little paper packets of needles. A tape measure curled like something asleep.

She could fix this sack in five minutes. She’d turn it inside out first and ask why I hadn’t brought it over before the holes got so big.

I put my wrapped hand over my mouth.

On Earth someone may be trying to find me. Liam heard me fall. He knows my first and last name. He knows Kansas City. I cannot remember whether I ever gave him my apartment number.

I try to reconstruct every conversation we’ve had about food delivery until it does something ugly to my breathing.

Beside me, Sella turns over without waking. I count her breaths until I can match them. When I finally sleep, there is no forest in it. I dream of my phone ringing in a room I can’t enter.

—○—

We leave before the sun reaches the reeds.

My reserve is three out of four. I reach for my pack with the wrong arm and have to set it down again. Sella checks the bandage, tells me to leave it alone, and packs her sword within reach.

At the first long stop she gives me a lesson against the side of an old stone cattle pen. Forearms against the wall, feet planted, no shield. She pushes my hip sideways with two fingers and makes my whole carefully

arranged body useless.

“You need to know when you’ve lost it,” she says. “Don’t spend because you wanted the first stance to work.”

We practice moving away, setting again, and admitting when I haven’t got it. Nothing flashes; by the time Nessa calls us back, I have learned that retreat can consist of one extremely unglamorous step.

The marsh opens into fields. Narrow watercourses divide strips of beans and something with a gray seed head. People work along the banks with hooked tools. One waves Nessa down to ask about the damaged crossing; she gives him the wayhouse keeper’s report that a temporary grate was fitted before dawn.

The man lifts a hand in thanks and heads back along the bank. Near midday, the road rises. I see Rook House from the top.

There is a large house, technically. Most of what surrounds it makes the name misleading. Long sheds. A mill. Three yards, two chimneys, narrow dwellings with washing strung between them. Water shines along a raised channel before dropping beneath a wheel. Beyond the buildings, a low wall cuts across a shallow valley.

I look for a forbidding tower and get a man chasing a pig away from stacked timber.

“Which part is the south sluice?” I ask.

Vey points beyond the mill to the low wall. From here it looks about as sinister as a parking barrier.

A cart of empty barrels passes us going out. The driver and Nessa trade complaints about the lower road and an unfilled hole near the lime shed. We roll into the yard while their professional disappointment follows us through the gate.

A clerk checks names against a slate. I expose mine when asked. He looks from my level to my face, then to Vey.

“Reader,” Vey says. “Short hire.”

The clerk writes it down.

A woman shouts that if we leave the carts there, the meal wagon won’t get through.

We move the carts.

—○—

Mara Orrel meets us in the records room with a stack of books already on the table.

She is somewhere in her forties, with graying hair pinned badly enough that I can see where she has given up on the back. Ink stains the side of one

finger. Her plate reads **[KEEPER, LV. 21]**.

“Wash,” she says, pointing toward a basin. “Soap is underneath. Dry thoroughly. No wet hands on the paper.”

Vey introduces me while I wash carefully around the wrapped knuckles and dry both hands. Mara waits through my last name, then asks me to say it again. She gets closer on the second attempt.

“You have your agreement?”

I retrieve it.

She lays Rook’s copy beside mine. We compare them, including the additions about Elena and food on the return journey. The words match. Mara enters tomorrow as the first reading day if I choose to begin. Today is arrival, records, and a bed.

Then she sets the agreement aside and opens the first book.

“Elena’s entry. Here.”

The script takes a moment to become meaning beneath her finger.

Elena Mercer. Adult. Level one. Origin unrecorded. Found on the western towpath after heavy rain. Admitted on paid survey trial. Place of birth declared as Missouri; attestation unavailable.

There is a signature in English beneath it.

Elena R. Mercer.

The looping M is ridiculous, big enough to be showing off. I love it immediately.

“She wrote that herself?”

“I watched her.”

“Could she read your writing?”

“Yes. She found that very upsetting.”

I laugh before I mean to. Mara looks at me, and I press my lips together.

“No,” she says. “It was funny sometimes. She’d be furious to discover I’d made her solemn.”

Vey moves toward the window. There isn’t much space there. The room contains shelves from floor to ceiling, with bundles tied in cloth and little bone tags hanging off the knots. It smells of dust and damp wool.

Mara turns several pages in a thinner volume.

“Departure.”

Elena’s name. A date eight months and twenty-six days after the entry, Mara explains when I cannot make useful sense of the local month names. Level nine. Trial converted to day hire during the first month. Wages settled. Departed by west gate with a pack and staff. No continuing service claim.

“Four years ago?”

“Four years and a little under two months.”

Below the departure is a cross-reference to retained materials. Mara opens that book too, without waiting for me to ask.

One wooden chest. Survey notebook. Loose plans. Measuring line. Writing implements. Small foreign objects, separately listed. Removal disputed under ownership of paid survey work. Chest sealed pending adjudication.

I look up.

“He said she left her chest.”

“She did leave it.” Mara glances toward Vey. “After we refused to release it.”

Vey looks at Mara. Mara keeps one stained finger on the inventory line.

Vey says, “I did not tell you she abandoned her claim.”

“You let me think she could have taken it.”

“Yes.”

My copy of the agreement is still on the table. I press the corner flat. He had sat opposite me in Greyward while I asked about that chest.

I turn back to Mara.

“Her clothes?”

“Released to her. Most personal effects. The card was held with the items whose relation to her survey we could not establish.”

“It’s identification.”

“I know that now. At the time she called it that, and we had no means of reading it.”

“She told you what it was.”

Mara’s stained finger rests on the page.

“Yes.”

I want an explanation that makes it acceptable. She doesn’t offer one.

“The dispute is still open?”

“In this record, yes.”

“Then put the card back under her name when he returns it.”

“It never left her name.”

“Make sure it doesn’t.”

Mara draws a narrow slip toward her and writes a note. I cannot tell whether she agrees with me or is merely competent enough to record a complaint.

The closure book is last.

South sluice. Lower works barred following loss of Iven Orrel. Access to inner mechanism prohibited pending examination. Outlet secured; surface water to be carried by bypass. Authorizing signatures follow.

Master Vey's is the second.

Above them is a short account. Rising water. Loss of visibility. Elena returning along the service passage. Iven unrecovered. Search instructions. Attached witness statements, three in all.

Mara lays them out.

Dain's says the inner wheel moved farther than ordered after a retaining tooth failed. He could not restore it immediately under load. Elena came back during the attempt. By the time he brought the wheel to its prior mark, she was demanding that he open it again.

"So it wasn't just somebody deciding to try a door."

"No," Mara says.

"Was this tooth ever repaired?"

"The broken part was taken out. The replacement was never fitted. The closure made it unnecessary."

The second statement belongs to someone on the bank who heard shouting and helped Elena out. It confirms very little beyond how wet she was and that her hands were bleeding.

The third has been written in local script by Mara, with Elena's signature at the bottom.

I read it twice.

Elena says the chamber beyond the arch was dry. There were steps on the far side. Iven crossed the sill before the light changed. When water entered, he was beyond her reach. She pulled the line and got back a length shorter than the one paid out. She did not see him fall. She did not see a body. She objected to the word drowned.

Near the bottom, another sentence has been crossed through once, still readable.

The steps were lit without flame.

"Who crossed that out?" I ask.

"I did."

"Why?"

"Because I couldn't get her to describe the lights. I thought she'd struck her head."

"Did she?"

"The mender found no wound there."

I look at Mara. Her mouth is pressed flat, but she doesn't look away.

"I left the words legible," she says.

I put the paper down before my hand shakes against it.

Lights without flame. I am picturing a lit stairwell before I can stop myself, the green exit sign above the stairs at college. I read the crossed-out

sentence again. Elena never said green.

“Did you believe her about your brother?”

Mara looks at his name on the closure record.

“I believed that she wanted him back.”

Outside, somebody rolls a barrel over the stones. The hollow bumps reach us through the wall.

“Can I copy these?”

“Yes. The clerk will bring paper. Originals stay here.”

I sit. My feet are grateful enough to distract me for a moment. Then I realize there is a fourth sheet tucked behind Elena’s statement.

It is only a scrap. Six words, written in English, the pen pressed hard enough to tear the paper in one place.

He was still pulling his end.

I don’t know what noise I make.

Mara reaches across the table, then stops before touching me.

“What does it say?”

I look from her hand to the six words, searching for another way to say them. There isn’t one.

I read the words aloud.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Mara asks me to read it again.

I do.

She draws the scrap closer with one finger. Her nail has a split near the edge. I watch it catch on the paper because looking at her face feels like something I should ask permission to do.

"When did she write that?" I ask.

"The morning she signed the statement. She handed it to me afterward."

"What did she tell you it said?"

"Nothing. I thought she had written his name."

There are six distinct pieces of writing. Mara sees me count them.

"I wasn't examining it very closely."

"I'm sorry."

She shakes her head once. "So am I."

Vey stands by the window with his hands behind his back. For once he has nothing to contribute.

I turn the scrap without lifting it. Blank on the other side.

"It doesn't say when the pulling stopped. Or why. I don't know if—"

"I know what you don't know."

The words come sharply. She shuts her eyes.

"I know," she says again, quieter.

A clerk brings paper. Mara shows me how to keep the copying sheet from sliding, and the ordinary instructions make it possible to start.

I copy the records, including the crossed-out sentence and the six English words. By the time my hand cramps, I am finished.

At the door she says, "He had two sons."

I turn back.

"Iven. One was small enough that we had to explain more than once."

"I'll be careful what I say."

"Yes," she says. "Please."

My room is above the west kitchen. It has a narrow bed, a peg, and a shutter opening onto a roof where someone has planted herbs in broken pots. The door bolts. I test it twice, then put my copies beneath the folded Earth shirt in my sack.

Supper is downstairs with people who have opinions about flour deliveries. Nobody asks whether Iven is alive. Nobody knows that I have spent half the afternoon considering a length of rope with a person at the other end.

Tolliver is at the far end of the table. He moves a jug so I can set my bowl down, but doesn't turn the empty place beside him into an invitation I have to refuse. I sit there because I want to.

"Paid?" I ask.

He taps his purse. "Two pieces. Sella too."

"Are you going back?"

"Eventually. Dain wants someone to walk the lower channel with him the day after tomorrow. Tracks, bank damage, animal holes. I've taken two days, paid by the day. After that I haven't decided."

"You don't have to stay because I'm here."

"I haven't asked you to pay me." He tears his bread too hard; a piece drops onto the floor. He bends to retrieve it.

I turn the bone over with my spoon, looking for the meat beneath it.

"I don't know what I want you to do."

"Then don't decide tonight."

I push my bowl away. When someone asks him to pass the jug, he doesn't hear them the first time.

After supper I mend the tooth holes with a needle borrowed from the kitchen. The stitches are uneven and much too close together. I tug the seam twice. Nothing opens, so I return the needle.

I sleep with the repaired sack under the bed instead of beneath my head.

—○—

The notebook arrives in a shallow wooden tray.

Mara puts it on the records-room table the next morning, then sets a separate dish beside it containing a pen cap, a rusted metal clip, and two tags tied to lengths of cord. Vey places Elena's card in the dish and Mara records its return in front of me.

I want to take it, put it with my shirt, have one more object from a world with traffic lights.

I keep my hands on the table.

The notebook is local paper stitched into a soft leather cover. Some pages have warped where they were wet. A corner near the front is missing, neatly cut rather than torn. Thirty-six written pages, Mara says. She puts a numbered slip beside the first.

"Today begins the six?" she asks.

"Yes."

She writes the date. I watch her finish it, with my agreement beside my elbow and the notebook waiting in its tray.

I open the cover.

The first page contains a list of measurements, a rough conversion between local units and meters, and an English sentence boxed in the margin.

Do not trust the old map's north.

"Oh, good," I say. "She's been here."

Mara's mouth moves.

"She said that often. Usually with worse words."

The next pages are drainage notes. Culvert widths. A badly drawn beetle beside a calculation. A list of people owed meals for holding a measuring line. Tiny calculations crowd the edges; an argument takes half a page. Then I hit a word I can't decipher and ask Mara to hold the page toward the light.

Some technical words slow me down. Reading English does not make me an engineer. I write *head* on my paper and explain to Mara that here it seems to mean something about water height or pressure, not a body part. She fetches Dain before I turn an uncertain definition into a confident mistake.

He arrives with a wooden cup and a limp that takes a moment to settle after he sits. **[SLUICEWRIGHT, LV. 24]**. His beard is short and almost entirely white. Two fingers on his left hand end at the first joint.

"That Elena's?"

"Yes," Mara says.

He sets down the cup with unnecessary care.

I show him the sketch. He traces the lines with a clean sliver of wood, keeping his hands off the page.

"Water stacked above you," he says. "More stack, more shove. What's she arguing about?"

"Whether the water on this side can get high enough to do what she saw."

He studies the numbers.

"It couldn't. I told her that."

“She wrote it down.”

I point to his name in local script, followed by an English note.

Dain checked twice. Stop asking him the same question.

He makes a small sound through his nose.

For the next hour he helps us separate what Elena measured from what she guessed while Mara records the local version. The work is slow, exact, and useful enough to steady me.

There is no welcome message for the next person from Earth. No explanation of how to get here or how to leave. Elena has recorded wages in the back, crossed out a shopping list, and spent nearly half a page trying to describe coffee to someone who recommended burnt barley.

I run a finger along the edge of that page. My first closing shift, I spilled steamed milk down my apron and hid in the walk-in because I couldn't stop crying. The manager thought I'd burned myself. I let her.

Elena has crossed out one description and tried again underneath. I linger until Mara asks whether I need Dain for this part.

“No,” I say, and start translating.

Near the middle we find the original of the tracing.

The lines are darker here. One of the apparent circles is a wheel seen from above. The other is a ring around an opening drawn in section. Beside it Elena has made three observations on three different dates.

Cold water, mineral smell.

Warm water, fine pale grit.

Air moving inward when the lower pool is still.

Underneath:

Changing the setting changes the source. It does not tell us where that source is.

I read the sentence twice before translating it aloud.

Dain leans forward.

“She did tell me the first part. Thought she meant an old feeder we'd never found.”

“Did you see the grit?”

“Yes. Cleaned it out myself. Twice.”

“Was it different from what's in your river?”

“Different from what comes down here. That doesn't tell you how far it traveled.”

I nod. He has seen what is written on my face and is being careful with it.

Lower on the same page is the rope warning. Beneath the main diagram, a smaller sketch shows something I took for a handle in the tracing: a metal

tongue sitting in a notch.

Dain recognizes it immediately.

"The retaining tooth."

"The one that broke?"

He nods.

There are two sets of writing beside it. Local dimensions in a tidy hand that may be Mara's. An English annotation crammed between them and the binding.

Secondary inlet still under load with first gate shut. Closing upstream does not isolate. Lock inner wheel before bypass test.

Dain holds the sliver of wood motionless above the page.

"Read that again."

I do, more slowly. Then I explain isolate as best I can. Stop something from still getting into the place you're working.

He gets up.

"Where are you going?" Vey asks.

"To stop the test."

—○—

Outside, the mill makes enough noise that I have to hurry to hear him.

"What test?"

"Bypass draw. Tomorrow we have the lower bank survey. Today they check how far the surface channel can take the head down."

"You said the sluice was closed."

"The sluice is closed. Nobody's supposed to touch the inner wheel."

He takes the corner beside a stack of tiles faster than his limp ought to allow. I slow to keep from slipping in the mud.

"Is somebody touching it?"

"No. But its tooth is in a cupboard, and everyone thinks shutting the river gate took the weight off it."

The watercourse leads us past the mill to an open gravel yard. Sella stands by a rope stretched between two posts, redirecting a boy with a basket. Beyond her, two workers are hauling on a long lever. Water foams from an opening in the side of the raised channel and races toward a ditch.

It looks purposeful enough that I would have assumed it was fine.

Dain puts his fingers in his mouth and whistles.

Both workers turn. One lets go of the lever; the other keeps it where it is.

"Hold there," Dain calls. "Don't move it back yet."

He walks to a narrow sight box set into the stone. A little iron rod protrudes from the top, marked with pale lines. It shakes hard enough to make a ticking sound.

I stop beside Sella. The rope is waist-high. Beyond it a stair leads down to an iron-covered opening in the bank. I can see a lock. Nobody is standing on the stairs.

“Problem?” she asks.

“Maybe.”

Dain crouches at the sight box. He wets his shortened fingers and presses them against the iron. The ticking pauses, then strikes faster; sweat appears along his hairline.

“Two loads,” he says. “One behind the other.”

He takes his hand away, shaking it. Later I will ask how he knew. Now he calls to the worker holding the lever. The worker answers. The ticking speeds up.

I look from the shaking rod to Dain. Brace is there if I reach for it, but I don’t know what I could hold without making this worse. I keep my hands away from the rope.

Dain looks over his shoulder.

“Sella, clear the towpath below the outlet. Everybody up to the yard. Walk them. No running.”

She is moving before he’s finished. She hands me the end of the rope as she unhooks it from the nearest post.

“Across the path behind me. Let the workers come up. Don’t let anyone down.”

I take it in my good hand.

There are five people below, two of them carrying a long rake between them. Sella calls them by their work rather than their names. They know she means them. She gets the pair turned first so they don’t swing the rake into anyone else.

A woman approaches from the yard with a bucket.

“Not that way,” I tell her.

“I use the lower pump.”

“They’re clearing it.”

She looks over my head at my plate.

For one exhausting second I prepare to argue about level two.

Then Dain calls, “Pump as well, Tessa,” and she turns around.

The ticking becomes a rattle. A worker comes up the path too quickly, sees the rope, and hesitates.

I lower it all the way to the ground. He steps across. The next person follows. I count them because counting is available. Three. Four. The last man has stopped for the rake.

“Leave it,” Sella tells him.

He leaves it.

“All up,” she calls.

Dain raises his hand. The worker on the lever eases it back while the other man puts his weight on a second bar. The water leaving the side opening narrows, then surges once before shrinking to a dirty ribbon.

Under the gravel, something knocks.

It is one deep impact. I feel it in my boots.

Everyone stops speaking.

The iron rod gives three more little tremors and settles.

Dain stays where he is for a long time, watching it. Nobody congratulates anybody.

Eventually Dain stands.

“Posts stay. No one uses the lower path until I say.”

“What was that?” I ask.

“A gate taking weight.”

“Which gate?”

“That’s what I’m going to establish before anyone puts a hand near it.”

Sella takes the rope back from me and knots it to the post. My hand has gone stiff from holding it, although I haven’t pulled against anything at all.

“You spent?” she asks.

“No.”

“Good.”

I flex my stiff fingers. There are rope marks in my palm. I rub them with my thumb.

—○—

The argument happens in the yard because Dain refuses to go far enough away that someone might mistake his departure for permission.

A woman in a green coat arrives carrying a rolled plan. Her plate reads ****[STEWARD, LV. 27]****. Vey introduces her as Steward Anja Pell, then gives her the shortest version of the discovery he can manage.

She asks Dain whether the test caused damage.

“I won’t know until the indicators stay quiet and we check the outer fittings.”

“Was anybody below the closure?”

“No.”

"Then keep it that way. The test is suspended."

I had been assembling a speech. It has nowhere to go while she asks who needs to be told about the lower pump.

Only after those instructions are settled does she look at me.

"You read the warning?"

"Yes."

"Can you show me precisely what it says?"

"It's in the records room."

"Mara can bring the copy." She turns to Vey. "You said six days."

"For the whole notebook. We can prioritize the works pages."

"What happens in six days?" I ask.

Pell unrolls her plan on a crate. One corner has been patched with a different color of paper. The lines show the mill channel, the bypass, and three fields beyond the low wall.

"In five, a crew arrives to remove the inner wheel and its spindle. We need the lower chamber safe before they cut out the assembly. The bypass is meant to carry drainage permanently."

"You're taking it apart."

"It has been shut for four years. We still have fields under water twice a season and a works budget paying men to inspect a lock."

"It may go somewhere."

"So does every culvert on this land."

"That's not what I mean."

"No," she says. "I understand what you mean. Vey has explained what you recognized."

The mill wheel groans behind us. I hate hearing that he has explained me to another person, even when it's part of the job I agreed to.

"What if taking it apart opens it?" I ask.

"Then you and Dain have just given me a reason to change how we remove it."

"Or not remove it."

"That will require more than a possibility."

I look down at the map. The flooded fields have names. Someone has drawn small marks for houses along their edges. Whatever this mechanism might mean to me, other people have been trying to grow dinner beside it.

Dain puts his cup on the corner of the plan. Somehow he brought it all the way from the records room.

"No cutting until I understand what took that load," he says.

Pell considers him.

“Agreed. But tell me what you need to understand it. Don’t hand me another four years.”

Mara arrives with the copied page. Pell reads it, asks me about three words, then has Mara add the suspension to the works instructions in writing. The removal crew is still due in five days. Cutting now depends on Dain’s clearance.

Mara finishes the second line. I read it over her shoulder to make sure the clearance is there, then step back against the crate.

Before Pell leaves, I ask whether Elena knew they might remove it.

“The present order is mine. Elena left before I became steward.”

“So you’re not the person who kept her chest.”

“No. I’m the person with the unresolved claim in my accounts.”

“It’s her identification in there.”

“Then submit that finding with the item number. I can review it.”

She rolls the plan up and goes to speak to the miller. I watch her leave, wishing she had either laughed at me or handed me everything. Persuading her will be harder.

—○—

By evening the ink has dried black along my middle finger. I have to cover the pages to stop myself reading them while Mara eats.

Dain returns with the inspection results. Visible fittings intact, access lock untouched, inner-wheel indicator a fraction off its old mark. He shows us the difference on his drawing. Whatever moved beneath the yard left a mark they can measure.

Mara puts his account beside our translated warning. We finish the adjoining copies, leaving the difficult technical words for him. Before she closes the book, I take the card’s item number and submit my statement for Pell: the photograph, dates, and address identify a personal driving credential. Maya Szczepaniak, who used to lose her own ID beneath takeout menus, signs herself as the person who knows.

Mara adds it to Elena’s claim. The card stays in its dish.

At the pay desk, a clerk gives me one piece.

I put it with the coins from Greyward. Five reading days left.

My measure, when I check in my room, has changed too.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 2]

[PROGRESS: 8 / 14]

[RESERVE: 4 / 4]

[RUN: WARDER]

I don't know when the two progress arrived. The wall practice, the work, the yard. There is no helpful receipt.

I write the numbers on my copy paper, with the date Mara taught me. My knuckles are closing. When I reach to set the paper aside, my shoulder catches and I have to lower my arm slowly.

After supper I find Tolliver on the outside stair, replacing the binding on an arrow. There is room beside him, and I sit.

"I heard about the test," he says.

"I held a rope with absolutely nothing pulling on it."

"An advanced road skill."

"Apparently."

He turns the arrow slowly between his fingers. Below us the kitchen door stands open, letting out light and an argument about who took the clean pot.

"Dain's changed tomorrow's work," he says. "We're checking the outer banks only. Sella's on the closure path. I'll be back before the evening meal unless he finds a problem."

"Thank you for telling me."

He nods, looking at the thread.

For a while I watch his hands. I have watched those hands do a lot of things: draw a bow, count money, take mine without closing too tightly. Knowing what they can do is becoming a problem for my concentration.

"I got paid."

"How much did they try to deduct for frightening the steward?"

"She frightened me."

"She's had practice."

I laugh. He sets the arrow aside before turning toward me.

There is a pale line of old scar near his mouth. I noticed it before, but I have never been this close with nothing happening that requires him to help me stand.

I move my hand along the step until my little finger touches his.

He looks at our hands.

"I thought you'd be angry about today," I say.

"Were you hoping?"

"No."

His hand stays beside mine. "Vey gets six days. I couldn't get you to listen for one."

"You sold him what you knew about me."

"I know."

The kitchen door bangs below us. I should go inside. Instead I look at his mouth, at the little scar near it, and he catches me doing it.

"I'm trying," he says.

"I can see that."

"Can you?"

There is an edge to the question. I want him to stop asking me to make him feel better. I want his hand on me. He starts to stand, and I catch his sleeve.

"Wait."

He sits back down. I kiss him before I can turn this into another argument.

For a second he doesn't move. Then his hand closes against my waist and he kisses me back, hard enough that I grip the seam of his coat. The wool scratches my wrist. I shift closer and feel the heat of his leg along mine.

I had forgotten how much I could want someone sitting right there, and how stupidly difficult it could be to get closer.

His thumb catches the bare skin above my waistband. I breathe in against his mouth. Downstairs someone calls his name, and he breaks away to look.

"Not now," I say.

He looks back at me. I can feel myself going red.

"No," he says, and kisses me again.

Later, when I put my hand against his chest, he lets me move back. My shoulder hurts. His mouth is reddened, and I keep looking at it instead of finding the words.

"I'm going upstairs."

"Alone?"

"Yes."

He takes his hand from my waist. I stand, then bend to kiss him once more. I don't know whether that makes anything clearer.

In my room, I lean against the bolted door, shoulder aching, and grin when I touch my mouth.

Eventually I wash, set out tomorrow's clothes, and take the notebook copies from my sack.

I read the first measurement twice without taking it in. My mouth still feels warm. I turn to the last sheet.

On the last page we copied, below a set of measurements, Elena has drawn the stair again. I hadn't looked closely while we were racing the test. Four steps, a flat place, then an empty square outlined twice.

Beside it are three English lines.

No view of the far side from the wheel. Do not let them call turning it a search.

Need a way to see before we cross.

Mirror?

The last word has a question mark large enough to take up its own line.

I pull my blank sheet closer. Tomorrow I can ask Dain whether there is any safe way to look from this side. He may say no. After today, I won't blame him.

Under the question I write another one.

What would have to be true for yes?

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Dain draws a door in spilled flour and puts his breakfast on the other side of it.

"That's you," he says, pointing to the door. "That's the part you want to look at."

"Your egg."

"The arch. Do keep up."

The yolk runs into the flour. I pull my copied page away from his plate.

He draws another line with the handle of his spoon. The kitchen table rocks under his hand. Around us people finish eating and collect tools. My second reading day has not started, and I am trying to get to the important part before he finishes breakfast.

"The service passage goes here. Wheel stands back around this bend, above the chamber floor. Man at the wheel can't see through the arch. Elena was right about that."

"Could somebody hold a mirror at the bend?"

"Yes. Somebody could stand in the passage we closed because water rose over a man's head."

I look at the flour. "Right."

"Could we look from higher up?"

He stops chewing. Then he draws a short line above the door.

"There's an inspection gallery. Separate stair from the yard. It has a sleeve through the chamber wall for checking the gate seat. We used to put a lamp through it. Mirror on a rod, sometimes."

"You already have one?"

"Had. Mirrors break."

"But the hole's still there."

"Yes, if the gallery hasn't shifted." He wipes the spoon on his bread. "I'll inspect the upper access after the bank walk. If it's sound, I can see what the sleeve gives us without unbarring the service passage. Nothing turns. Nobody goes down to the chamber."

I pull the bench out and sit. My knee hits the table, which shifts his cup through our diagram.

“Sorry. If you look through it now, what will you see?”

“I don’t know.”

“But it was closed.”

“The cover was closed. The access was closed. The wheel was at its old mark. Yesterday the last of those changed.”

The locked cover and the thing beyond it are farther apart than I had understood.

I turn my sheet over. “Can you draw it on something I won’t eat?”

He finds a pencil stub in his coat and puts it beside my sheet.

“Put the bend here.” He marks it with a floury finger.

By the time Tolliver comes in, I have made the gallery twice as large as it should be and accidentally connected the mill to a place Dain identifies as a solid hill.

Tolliver leans over the back of my bench. “Planning improvements?”

“Dain says I’ve drawn through a hill.”

His mouth is close to my temple. My attention goes there so fast I lose the end of Dain’s next sentence. Tolliver waits until the old man bends over the corrected drawing, then touches two fingers to the back of my hand.

“Morning,” he says, quietly enough that it belongs to me.

“Morning.”

He smells of soap and the leather of his bow strap. Last night comes back in pieces: the stair under my legs, his thumb at my waist, the breath he took before I kissed him again. I want to pull him down beside me. Dain knocks the spoon against the table.

“Tolliver. The long measure. It’s behind the door.”

Tolliver straightens and looks toward the door.

He goes to fetch it. I watch him get through the kitchen doorway without turning to check whether I follow.

Dain folds my drawing. “Ask Mara whether Elena tried the sleeve. I don’t remember what she left in the book.”

—○—

She did try it.

The entry is six written pages beyond the warning, between a calculation neither Mara nor I can explain without Dain and a complaint about a blister on Elena’s heel. Mara has numbered the written pages on loose slips, thirty-six of them, so we can finally stop describing our place as the one after the beetle.

The unfinished pages wait with their slips sticking out of the tray. Today we follow the works entries.

Upper sleeve. Mirror sees near jamb, floor. Can't see around the return. Need elbow beyond inner face.

Underneath, a little drawing shows a rod with a hinged end. Elena has crossed it out.

Hinge droops under its own weight. String control no good. Lost glass. Dain furious. Correctly.

I look at Mara. She is reading the local sentence she has just written, lips moving slightly.

"Did he tell you?" I ask.

"He sent a charge for the glass."

"Did she pay?"

"She argued that looking at the works was work. He argued that the mirror had belonged to his wife."

"Oh."

"She paid."

I turn the page back, but there is nothing else about the mirror or his wife.

Mara makes room for the next sheet. "Read the rest."

There are sleeve measurements, a note about a stone projection, and three attempts to fit the geometry through a round hole. The last uses two fixed mirrors. There is no result beside it.

"Proposed," I say before Mara writes anything. "She hasn't said she built this."

Mara adds the word.

Farther down, the handwriting changes. Smaller, less space between lines. A date in local script follows the date on the accident statement.

He kept asking whether the light meant morning. I told him I didn't know. Remember that if I start pretending I knew anything.

I hold the page flat at its clean margin.

"Who?" Mara asks.

"She doesn't say."

But I can see her deciding. Her pen stays just above the copy, waiting.

"I think she means Iven," I say. "I can't put his name in the sentence for her."

"Then don't."

Mara writes what is there. Outside, a cart rolls past the window with one bad wheel, a little silence between every knock. When it has gone, she asks me to continue.

The next entry is less kind to hope.

Same wheel mark did not give the same water. Two readings, a day apart. Temperature changed. Mark is a place to start, not an address.

I say *address* and my hand moves toward the scrap in my clothes, Elena's name and the Missouri dates. I don't touch it. I still have ink on my fingers.

"So even if you put it back," Mara says.

"You might not get the same place."

"Or the same water from that place."

"Yes."

I hate that she is better at this distinction than I am. I want a dial with one number that means the street outside my apartment, a road I can complain about instead of one I don't know exists.

Mara sands the copy. "We'll ask him about the readings."

We keep working. Two labels describe outlet samples; one matches the warm water and pale grit, the other has no surviving sample. Another tag reads *not brass?* and is tied to a greenish washer. I translate the question mark too.

At midday I have seven pages of notes, an aching hand, and considerably less faith in a mirror than I had at breakfast.

—○—

Sella is eating an onion like an apple.

I find her beside the closure rope with a heel of bread, a knife, and the expression of someone who has been asked whether the lower pump is open enough times to consider moving it personally.

"That's horrifying," I tell her.

She looks at the onion. "Small ones are sweet." She offers a slice.

"No, keep it." I move my bowl away.

She grins and offers me the bread. I have brought my own food from the kitchen. We eat on a low wall where she can see both approaches to the path.

The sight box is quiet. Below the rope, the locked iron cover lies over the service stair. A second, narrower stair climbs along the bank to a squat stone building I had taken for a shed. Now that Dain has put it on paper, I can see how the upper gallery sits above the chamber, how a wall could hide a whole drop from someone standing in this yard.

"I'd like another lesson," I say.

"Good. I'd like another guard. Neither of us gets what she wants until someone relieves me."

“What about here?”

She looks down at my hands. The linen has come off; the skin beneath is pink and still pulls when I make a fist.

“Feet, then. No shield.”

She puts her bread on the wall and makes me stand with my forearms against a square pier. I know this part. My body takes more convincing.

“Don’t spend.”

“I wasn’t going to.”

“You got the face.”

“What face?”

“You’re holding your breath. Again.”

I let it out through my nose.

We practice the step, reset, weight through my legs. When someone approaches, she leaves me there and turns him back from beside his route, sword still sheathed, without touching him.

When she returns, I ask, “Is there a way to move while holding Brace?”

“There are moving holds. You haven’t got this one yet.”

“Cruel but accurate.”

“What happens at the end of three breaths?”

“It stops.”

“What do you do before that?”

I look at my arms against the stone.

“Hope somebody kills the thing.”

“You have to get out before it ends. Like this.”

She presses against my hip while I hold the ordinary stance. On her count I take my weight back, let my forearms leave the pier, and step. The first time my rear heel catches a stone and she has to catch me.

The second time I do it right.

“Now spend one. End it yourself on two. I’ll count.”

The pattern opens easily. That is the seductive part. No password, no loading screen, just the right arrangement of body and attention, and the stone feels connected to the ground through me.

One breath. Sella’s hand rests lightly at my waist.

Two.

I stop feeding the hold. Pressure returns to my muscles; I step back as we practiced, and for once none of me ends up sitting down.

Sella’s hand lifts away.

“There.”

I grin before checking my measure. Three reserve left. Progress nine out of fourteen.

Only one more than last night, but I know what I did this time. At least one useful thing went into the number.

“Again?” I ask.

“Without spending.”

“My arm’s shaking.”

“Stop, then. You’re going to strain it.”

She lifts her arm to adjust the strap beneath her collar. Sweat has darkened the cloth, and I see the pale skin beneath it. I look away too late.

“Is there anywhere people go here?” I ask. “At night.”

“The west taproom. Why?”

“Do you dance?”

“A little. You asking?”

She gives me perhaps two seconds to do something with that, enough to become completely aware of my boots.

“How old are you?” I ask.

Her eyebrows rise. “What?”

“No. I just— You said three years on caravans. I didn’t know whether you’d had a birthday since.”

“Twenty-one. Summer birthday. You?”

“Nineteen.”

“I’d have guessed younger.”

My face gets hotter.

“Sorry,” she says. “That came out wrong.”

I laugh, finally, and she smiles without rescuing me from it.

Another worker approaches. She goes to intercept him, and I practice my step while watching the turn of her shoulders. I miss her signal to move my foot and have to start again.

—○—

Dain and Tolliver return before the afternoon shadows reach the rope.

Tolliver carries a wooden measure with mud halfway up it. Dain carries a covered jar. They come from the outer road, well above the closed towpath, and stop in the yard while Sella waves over the relief guard.

“Found a feeder?” I ask.

“Found a discharge,” Dain says. “Don’t give it a direction it hasn’t earned.”

He lets me smell the jar. Warm stone, faintly sour water, nothing I can name as another planet. Fine pale grit has begun to settle at the bottom.

“There’s a little outlet under the east bank,” Tolliver says. “Above the main pool. Couldn’t see it from the road. Warm water’s killed the grass

around the lip.”

“New?”

“Bare patch isn’t. Fresh silt over the old roots is.”

Dain takes the jar back. “We’ll measure it again tomorrow. No one puts anything down it. Might be carrying water from the chamber. Might be a separate spring.”

I bring him the page about the same mark giving different water. He sets the jar beside it and reads, then carries both toward the upper building.

At the upper building he leaves me outside with Tolliver while he and two house workers inspect the stair and gallery. The door has its own seal, a crust of wax across a cord. Dain has Mara brought to record its opening. Below us, the service cover remains locked.

It takes most of an hour. I sit on the stair and read Tolliver the mirror entry. He stops scraping mud from the measure at the part about Dain’s wife.

“I won’t suggest borrowing another,” he says.

Dain comes out dusty and annoyed, which I choose to take as encouraging.

“Upper stone’s sound. Dry landing. Sleeve cover holds. There’s light beyond it.”

My fingers tighten on the paper.

“What kind?”

“A strip at the shutter edge. White. I didn’t open it.”

“Could it be daylight?”

“Could be.”

I look at the solid bank behind him. He looks too.

Pell arrives while he is reading Elena’s proposed two-mirror arrangement. She hears about the light, then the outlet, then asks what they cost her. Dain says an inspection mirror from the fitting chest, timber for a frame, and two workers tomorrow. She gives him all three.

“No turning the inner wheel,” he says. “I want a restraint on the upper spindle before we expose the sleeve. The old tooth stays missing. This is a separate clamp.”

“Can you fit it from the gallery?”

“Yes. Socket’s above the floor. Provided the face is sound once we clean it.”

“Then that first. Observation after you approve the fitting.”

I start to speak, but Pell turns toward Dain.

“Can she observe from outside the controls?”

“Behind the frame,” Dain says. “I need her if there’s writing.”

Pell looks at me. "You can refuse. Your reading agreement stands."

"I want to look."

"Then show me the arrangement tomorrow."

She reminds him that the removal crew comes in four days. He says he remembers. Neither of them mentions giving those days to me.

—○—

I take my pay upstairs before supper. The clerk has left ink on the edge of the coin.

Tolliver finds me at supper before the stew has cooled. He has been paid for his first survey day; he tells me when I ask, without showing me a sum I haven't earned the right to count. Tomorrow is the second. After that, he says, Dain might want an escort when the removal crew inspects the outer route.

"You don't have to keep finding work here," I tell him.

"I know where the road is."

I draw my bowl closer. He goes back to eating. After a while I move my knee against his beneath the table. He looks up.

"I like sitting here," he adds.

I leave my knee against his.

Across the room Sella is arguing with a carrier over an eastbound fare. He spreads both hands; she folds her arms and makes him start again. I listen longer than I mean to. Tolliver follows my glance.

"She'll get it down," he says.

"Is she leaving?"

"If she finds the right work."

I look back at him. "Everyone here has somewhere to go."

His knee presses against mine.

Later he kisses me in the kitchen doorway while somebody behind us complains about drafts. I laugh against his mouth and let him draw me aside. He takes his time, and I forget the carrier until we part.

I remember Sella again halfway up the stairs.

I keep expecting kissing Tolliver to make Sella easier to ignore. It hasn't. I can still see her across the room with her arms folded, making the carrier start his price over, and I still want to know what she'd say if I asked her to dance.

Upstairs, I lay Dain's corrected drawing beside Elena's. The sleeve is a small circle on both pages. Beyond it he has drawn blank space where her arch stands.

I hold a finger over that space. Light might be a mineral, a trick of water, something ordinary here that I haven't learned to recognize. My head knows this. My hand keeps trying to cover the distance between two bits of ink.

Before bed I write down the part Dain said twice.

Nothing turns.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Harra, the house fitter, turns the rod in its pipe until Sella appears in the viewing glass. Harra's plate reads **[FITTER, LV. 18]**. A leather guard covers the thumb she rests against the moving bar.

Sella is across the workshop with a slate against her chest. Three fingers raised. Then one.

"One," I say.

The image is small, but I can see her broken nose and the dark edge of one braid. I bend closer until Harra catches my sleeve.

"Stay back. I'll move the glass."

Mara has Elena's drawing open on the bench. I check the angles against it: two mirrors, one at the far end of the rod and one beside my face. Harra angles them until I can read Sella's chalk marks through the hood. A red handle retracts the whole assembly.

Dain makes me retract the cage once myself, then Harra takes the apparatus apart to carry to the gallery.

—○—

At the headwall, the new iron clamp is visible from the gallery door.

It grips the square upper end of a spindle that comes through the floor, with a bar laid across two stone sockets so the whole thing cannot turn. Dain shows me the chalk witness lines where iron meets iron. Below it, through a narrow gap between boards, I can see the top of a much larger wheel in darkness. Nobody can reach that wheel from here without lifting the floor.

"The clamp holds this setting," he says. "Not the one before the test. We'd have to move it to put it back. We're not moving it."

I nod.

Harra has fixed the frame to an old mounting plate. There is barely room to pass behind her. The observation sleeve opens from the far wall at chest height. Its shutter is a round metal disc on a sliding arm, covered with the dark grease Dain uses on everything he would prefer to last longer than

people.

The thin white line beneath it is real.

I stop in the doorway.

A knife of light across dusty stone. I have seen brighter cracks under bathroom doors. This one hurts before I have even tried to identify why.

Sella touches the doorframe beside my shoulder.

“You’re blocking the steps.”

“Sorry.”

“Stand here.”

She puts me on a dry patch beside her, outside the gallery while the fitters finish. Down in the yard, Pell is talking to a man whose trousers are mud-stained to the knees. He has brought drowned seedlings in a basket. Even from up here I can see the way he holds them out and the way she doesn’t turn away.

Four days until the crew, yesterday. Three now.

I had expected a light behind the sealed shutter to buy more than that.

Mara arrives with the notebook in a closed carrying tray. She sets up on a plank across two trestles in the yard, under a cloth awning beside the stair. We finish checking Elena’s measurements while Harra comes down to collect a smaller wrench.

The two-mirror drawing fits the sleeve dimensions. It doesn’t tell us what is on the other side today.

Mara records the displaced indicator mark while Harra verifies the spindle and clamp.

Sella takes her shield off her arm before she climbs the stair again. It would block half the doorway. She puts it against the outer wall within reach and checks the way back to the yard.

Then Dain calls me in.

—○—

Opening the shutter takes longer than looking through it.

Harra works behind a board that shields her from the sleeve. Dain watches a strip of cloth pinned beside the opening. It stirs inward as the disc slides clear, barely enough to lift its ragged end.

Air goes into the wall.

I stand behind the frame with my hands on my own skirt.

“Steady,” Dain says. He isn’t speaking to me.

Harra feeds the caged mirror through the sleeve until a mark on the rod reaches its mouth. She stops there, fixes the stop collar, then steps aside.

“Your place.”

I bend to the hood.

For a second all I get is white. Then Dain shifts the angle, the glare leaves, and the chamber settles into view.

Stone floor. Water in a shallow dark fan below us. The far wall curves into an arch wider than my arms could reach. Most of the space inside it looks like wet black rock.

Along its left edge runs a bright vertical strip.

“Describe,” Mara calls from the doorway.

I describe the water, the dark arch, the strip of light. My voice sounds like somebody trying to give an address while looking for the house number.

Dain adjusts a fraction farther.

The strip widens in the mirror. It hasn’t changed size in the arch; we are looking more directly into it. I can see four steps, a landing, part of a pale wall beyond. The steps are edged with dark bands. On the landing is a metal rail with a right-angle turn, its paint chipped around the bend.

My hand lifts off my skirt.

I stop it before I touch the frame.

There is a door beyond the rail. Gray, with a long horizontal bar across it.

Above it, a red word shines inside a white rectangle.

EXIT.

I pull back so fast my hair catches on the hood.

“What?” Sella asks.

I can’t get the strands loose. I keep pulling at them with stupid, weak fingers while the mirror sits there showing a room that should be on my planet.

“Hold still.”

She frees the hair. I bend down again before thanking her.

The word is still there.

“Exit,” I say.

Dain looks toward the sleeve. “A way out?”

“That’s what the sign says.”

I look at the bar on the door. My college has bars like that. Every store, every back corridor. A boring door whose whole job is being there when you need to leave.

“Can you read anything else?” Mara asks.

“No. Wait.”

There are small letters on the door, but they fall outside the bright strip when Dain moves the mirror. I tell him to stop, too loudly.

He stops.

“Leave it there,” I say, quieter. “Please.”

My eyes water. I blink and the door swims back into focus.

Dain asks about the stair. I make myself look below the sign.

“Four steps and a landing. There could be more below what we can see. I can’t tell if they’re wet.”

“Elena’s sketch?”

“Too little detail to match the door.” My eyes go back to the red letters.

“That’s English, though. The door looks like doors where I come from.”

Mara writes it down. I watch her pen stop short of naming a place.

Harra watches the cloth. It keeps pulling gently inward.

We take turns at the hood. Dain describes the rail in words that mean construction rather than home. Harra says the door has no visible hinges on the side we can see. Mara looks longest. When she straightens, the skin around her mouth is pale.

“That was in her statement,” she says.

No one asks which part.

She takes her copy back outside and sits where the light doesn’t have to be explained.

—○—

We close the shutter for midday.

I follow the others downstairs. Halfway down I turn to look back. Harra has already shut the gallery door.

I sit on the low wall with my bowl balanced between my knees. Sella sits beside me, close enough that our sleeves brush when she reaches for her cup.

“Your place?” she asks.

“Maybe.”

I pick a bit of barley out of the stew with the spoon, then put it back.

“I’ve stood in a hundred places like that. I couldn’t tell you which one if you showed me a picture. There should be a floor plan on the wall. A bin. Somebody leaving a box under a sign that tells them not to.”

“Could be farther round.”

“Yes.”

She doesn’t tell me it will be. I scrape my spoon against the bowl harder than I need to, then make myself stop before I chip it. I’m glad she didn’t lie to me. I hate that she didn’t.

“Was Elena right?”

“About the lights.”

"Then that's one thing."

I look at her. She has set her bread on her knee without taking a bite.

"Were you here when it happened?"

"No. I was seventeen. Taking local yard jobs and lying about how much my father had taught me."

"You?"

"I was very convincing until someone pushed from the left."

I laugh. It hurts somewhere beneath my ribs.

She nudges my boot with hers. "Eat."

"In a minute."

She eats her own bread while I watch the gallery.

I take a spoonful. Warm grain, onion, something green cooked too long. I try to picture Mom opening the gray door and seeing me at the mirror. Would she recognize me before I said my name?

Sella lets me finish without asking why I have gone quiet.

Tolliver returns during the meal break with a fresh jar and news for Dain. The outer outlet is cooler, flowing slower. The shallow water in the chamber had scarcely moved when we looked. I listen to Dain ask about the timing while Tolliver kneels to mark the outlet position on the plan.

He sees my face when he stands.

"What did you find?"

I tell him.

For a moment he looks at the gallery as though it has become farther away. Then he sits on my other side and asks me to describe the door.

I give him every useless detail I can remember.

—○—

Harra adds a hood to the far mirror to cut the glare. The cage has to stay level while she fits it, and the pole wants to roll.

Sella braces its wooden cradle against the workshop pier with her forearms. Harra tightens one screw and frowns at the next.

"I need that washer from the small box."

Dain is washing grease from the lens cloths. Sella starts to lower the cradle.

"I can hold it," I say.

All three look at me. I regret sounding eager. I am eager anyway.

"Bench takes the weight," Sella says. "You keep it against the pier. It can't go far, but if it turns, her screw goes crooked."

"I can do that."

She lets me set my arms, checks my feet, then eases away. The pole tugs sideways. I have the line of pressure; I can feel where it would twist my elbow if I tried to hold it with my arms alone.

“Got it?”

“Yes.”

Sella fetches the washer. Harra fits it, tests the screw with two fingers, and nods at me.

“Hold still now.”

I spend one.

The shape closes cleanly. No panic, no teeth beyond a shield. The cradle becomes steady under my forearms.

One breath. Harra turns the screw.

Two. “Done,” she says.

I end the hold and step back. The cradle stays against the pier under her hand. My shoulder pulls, but the old ache doesn’t sharpen.

Sella notices me noticing.

“Better?”

“Better.”

I had checked a full four this morning. Three now. I keep the number to myself, pleased in a way I can’t make casual.

Harra carries the assembly out. Sella stays long enough to tap the place on the pier where my forearms were.

“How’s your arm?”

“Better.”

She nods and gets the cloth Dain is asking for.

I follow with the lighter end of the cradle, trying not to knock it against the door.

—○—

The second look finds someone on the landing.

I nearly miss them. Harra has made the hood too successful, the contrast sharper but the view smaller, and at first the movement is only a dark change beside the rail.

Then fingers close around the painted bend.

A hand.

“There’s somebody there.”

The gallery stills around me.

“Where?” Dain asks.

“By the rail. Beyond the steps.”

I can't see the whole person. A sleeve, dark at the cuff. The side of a head, mostly gray hair. They lean toward the opening, but the edge of black stone hides their face.

"Can they see us?"

"I don't know."

I want to shout. There is a person beyond the wall, and I have already dragged in a breath hard enough to hurt.

Dain touches my sleeve.

"We can't hear their room. Speak normally first."

"Hello?"

My voice goes into the sleeve. No answering voice returns. The hand stays on the rail.

"Hello. Can you hear me?"

Nothing changes.

Sella moves to the doorway where Mara is standing. Neither woman tries to squeeze past Harra. I can hear someone in the yard asking why we have all stopped talking.

The person beyond the steps lifts something.

A little rectangle catches the light and flashes across our mirror. I flinch. When I look again, the bright patch has gone and a face occupies it, tiny and broken by the angle.

"They have a mirror," I say.

Dain bends beside me without taking my view. "Looking toward us?"

I watch the rectangle tilt. The person pauses, moves it back, then holds.

"Yes. I think— Yes."

My mouth has gone dry.

There are two mirrors between my face and the sleeve, another beyond the arch. I can't work out what they see, so I put my hand beside the viewing glass and raise two fingers.

Nothing.

I move the hand higher.

The distant rectangle tilts. Beside it, fingers rise off the rail.

Two.

"Dain."

"I see."

"Two. They did two."

"Change it."

I raise one finger.

Wait.

One.

My vision blurs so badly that for a moment the entire chamber is light. I blink until it comes back.

Mara says my name from the door. She has said it once already; I hear the second time in her voice.

“Can you see his face?”

“Not enough.”

I change to four fingers. Two could be coincidence. One could be a gesture. I cannot bear going to bed with only that.

Four come back.

Then the person lowers the mirror and leaves the strip of light.

“No. Wait.”

The rail stands empty.

I keep my hand beside the glass until my arm shakes. I want the person back badly enough that if Dain offered me the wheel now, I might forget every agreement we made.

He doesn’t offer.

He has Mara bring a slate.

—○—

We wait through the afternoon.

Dain limits each look to a short interval. Between them Harra checks the sleeve and clamp; the chalk lines stay aligned, and the cloth keeps its slight inward pull. Nobody turns the wheel.

I write *HELLO* large on the slate, with Mara’s local word beneath it. Dain checks its reflection with a hand mirror in the yard, then has us hold it beside the viewing glass. My head keeps blocking the image. Harra moves me, and at last the words have a clear path through.

The next time I look, the person has returned.

They hold a pale board across their chest.

Three broad marks cover it, followed by another word. Local script. I get the same tiny slip in perception that I got with the briar-skipper, the marks becoming readable just before I realize I have understood them.

Who holds?

I read it aloud.

Dain shuts his eyes briefly. “They want to know who’s at the wheel.”

“Write your name.”

Mara does. DAIN, in the letters he uses. She holds the slate for me while I angle it toward the mirror.

The board beyond the steps drops out of sight.

A hand returns against the rail, gripping hard enough that I can see the knuckles from here.

I wait for another word. Instead the person lowers themselves until their face appears in the little rectangle.

A man. Gray beard, one side cut much shorter than the other. Dark hollows beneath his eyes. His mouth is moving.

I can't hear him.

"Tell him we can't hear," Dain says.

I relay it to Mara. She writes. We hold it up.

The man's mouth stops moving. He looks down, then away from us. For several seconds nothing is visible except one hand pressed flat against the rail.

When the board comes back, there is a name on it.

Iven Orrel.

Mara catches the doorpost. Her pen falls onto the stone.

I have spent all day making words into answers. For the first time, I can't make myself read them aloud.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Dain picks up Mara's pen.

He puts it in her hand, closes her fingers around it, and waits until she looks at him.

"What do we ask?" he says.

She pulls her hand away.

"What?"

"Something he can answer."

The board is still in the mirror. Iven Orrel. Whoever is holding it has tucked one corner against the rail because his arm is tired. That ordinary adjustment is worse than if he had stood still like a picture.

Mara comes forward. Harra steps aside just far enough to let her reach the hood. I give her my place.

For a long time she says nothing. Her mouth opens once, closes, then she bends closer until Dain catches her hand before it can change the angle.

"Leave it steady."

"I know."

Her voice is so sharp that I look down. Dain keeps his hand where it is until hers falls away.

"He can't hear?" she asks.

"We haven't heard him," I say. "He answered the writing."

She turns to her slate and wipes Dain's name away with the heel of her hand. Chalk smears across her skin. She writes a question so hard the tip snaps, swears once, picks up the larger piece and finishes.

What did you put in our mother's good pot?

We position it beside the mirror. Mara looks into the hood and stays there while I hold the slate at the angle Harra shows me.

Her brother's board goes down.

I count my breaths until it starts to feel like a bargain.

Mara makes a noise.

"What?" Dain asks.

She has to swallow before she can speak.

“He says which time.”

Her laugh breaks halfway out. She turns from the glass, then back at once, as though a second away might lose him.

“Write Mara,” she says. “Tell him it’s me.”

I can’t form the local letters quickly enough. She takes the slate from me and does it herself.

The man in the mirror disappears downward. For a moment I think he’s fallen. Then his hand comes up against the rail, the fingers spread, and he pulls himself back into view with his head bowed.

We wait.

When he shows the board again, there is one word.

Boys?

Mara sits on the low stool Harra has moved behind her.

“Yes,” she says to a person who cannot hear. “Yes. Both.”

I take the broken chalk and give her the larger piece.

—○—

We tell him very little before the light begins to narrow.

Both sons are living. Mara can bring news. Dain is in charge of the wheel, and the present setting is clamped. No one has entered the chamber. The letters on his board say he has food and water, that he cannot reach the arch from where he stands without stepping beyond the rail onto a section of stair we cannot see.

Missing below third.

He underlines it. I picture the fourth step we counted in the mirror and ask Dain whether we were wrong.

“Could be a break across it. Could be another flight. Ask him to show us tomorrow. No guessing with feet.”

Mara’s fingers tighten on the slate at the word *tomorrow*.

“We can’t leave him there.”

“We can’t fetch him through a gap narrower than his shoulders,” Dain says.

“Open it.”

His face changes.

For half a second I see Elena from Vey’s story between them, hands torn open, asking for another turn. Then I see Dain in front of me, older, holding a pen he has picked up twice today.

“We don’t know where turning it sends him,” he says. “We have him here.”

Mara looks at me.

I want her not to. I look at Dain. He is waiting too.

“The same mark gave different water,” I say. “Elena wrote it down.”

“She didn’t know he was alive.”

“No.”

I grip the edge of the slate.

At the mirror the light has grown thinner. Harra checks the clamp. The chalk lines have not moved. Dain checks too, then asks me to describe the change precisely.

The stair is still there. Less of the landing shows. A dark edge has advanced across part of the rail, as if someone is slowly drawing a curtain from a place we can’t see.

He has Mara write that the view is narrowing, that they will try again at first daylight, that no one will turn the wheel tonight.

The reply takes long enough for me to hate the apparatus.

Will watch.

Then, squeezed beneath it:

Don’t send the boys down.

Mara writes her answer with her head bent so I cannot see her face.

The view vanishes before he can reply to it.

Dain checks the line on the spindle again. Same position. No tremor in the floor, no knock from below. The cloth at the sleeve hangs almost still.

Through the mirrors there is only the black face inside the arch and a thin wash of water on the chamber floor.

Harra retracts the rod. Dain closes the shutter.

Mara stays on the stool with the slate in her hands.

—○—

Pell comes up the stair carrying a lamp.

It’s nearly dark outside. My third reading day has ended somewhere without me, and the kitchen has started putting bowls on the tables. Tolliver is in the yard; I saw him through the doorway while Harra was dismantling the viewing hood. He looked up when the shutter closed and has stayed below since.

Mara tells Pell who we saw.

Then she tells her what he wrote about the pot. Her voice steadies on the household details: tadpoles in washing water, her mother finding them with her best ladle, Iven denying responsibility while the empty jar sat beneath his chair. Pell listens to all of it without once looking toward the door.

“You recognize him?” she asks when Mara stops.

“Yes.”

“And the others?”

“I saw a man answer,” Dain says. “I didn’t get her view of his face. He knew my name when we sent it.”

“He used the mirror to return numbers before we told him anything,” I say. “Then he wrote his name. We didn’t offer it.”

Pell takes the slate when Mara offers it. She reads the chalk, then sets it carefully beside the lamp.

“You still intend to cut it out?” Mara asks.

“The crew is still coming.”

“Anja.”

“I heard you.” Pell sets the lamp on the floor. “I will not have men put saws into a mechanism connected to a living person while Dain tells me he cannot predict what it does.”

Mara shuts her eyes.

“But the fields still need draining,” Pell continues. “Those men can shore the outer bank and clear the upper carrier while we work out what else is possible. That uses their first days. It doesn’t buy us a season.”

“How many days?” I ask.

“I’ll know when their foreman sees the work.”

Dain rubs both hands over his beard. “I’ll need a second inspection of the bypass plan. Someone who hasn’t spent four years telling himself the old closure was enough.”

Pell looks at him for a moment, then nods.

“Name them. I’ll send.”

She doubles the boundary watch, keeps the lower path and pump closed, and orders that nobody open the shutter alone. If the indicators move, the watch fetches Dain.

Mara rises while Pell is still writing.

“The boys are entitled to know.”

“Yes,” Pell says.

“I’ll tell them.”

“Tonight?”

“The elder’s at the north cottages. His brother is staying with him.”

Pell asks whether she wants someone to walk with her. Mara says no, then changes her mind and names the kitchen woman who lent me the needle. Pell sends for her.

I stand beside the door with my copies pressed to my chest, trying not to imagine Iven’s sons learning their father might come home after being taught how to live when he didn’t.

As Mara passes me, she stops.

"You read what was there," she says.

"That was the job."

"I know."

She puts her hand briefly against my arm and goes down the stair.

I don't follow until I can trust my feet.



Tolliver is waiting by the kitchen when I come down. He takes the copies, and I let him lead me to a place at the table.

I eat without tasting much. He talks about the survey until I lose the thread and he stops.

"Sorry," I say.

He slides the jug toward me. My day's pay is beneath my bowl. Mara must have sent it ahead.

"Dain wants the north collector measured," he says. "I told him I'd do it if he can find the money."

I nod. Tomorrow. There will be work tomorrow.

After the meal he walks me upstairs. In the narrow landing, with my door still shut, I put my forehead against his chest. He holds me with one hand below the shoulder that hurts.

There is no speech. I hear somebody rinsing a pot and his breathing above my hair. I stay longer than I meant to.

When I lift my head, he kisses me. I kiss him back, and for a while the day has somewhere to go besides around and around inside me.

Then I think of Sella on the wall at midday and stop.

Tolliver moves back enough to see my face.

"What?"

I could say I am tired. I am tired. There are honest sentences available that would let me avoid the one I need.

"I think I want to kiss Sella."

His hand goes still against my back.

Downstairs, the pot hits a board with a hollow clang. I wait through the noise instead of helping him answer.

"Oh," he says.

"I haven't."

"All right."

"Is it?"

He looks down the stairs, then back at me. "I'm finding out."

His collar is damp beneath my fingers.

"I kissed you yesterday," he says.

"I know."

"And tonight you're telling me about her."

My hand is still on his coat. I let go.

"I'm telling you before anything happens."

"Were you going to ask if I minded?"

"I don't know what I'd do if you did."

He looks at me for a long time. I wish I had said that differently. I don't have a different answer.

"I mind," he says.

"All right."

"No. It isn't." He drags a hand through his hair. "I'm not telling you who you can kiss. I just thought—"

He stops. Below us the kitchen door opens, and both of us move back from the stair without looking.

"I want you too," I say.

He shakes his head, once, as though I have offered him something he cannot use yet.

He picks up the copies from the step where we set them. Their corners are bent. He smooths one with his thumb.

"Do you want me to leave you alone?" I ask.

"Tonight."

He hands me the pages and goes downstairs. I have to move aside to let him pass.

I want to call him back.

If Sella asked me tomorrow, I would still say yes. My chest aches anyway as Tolliver disappears down the stairs.

I open my door instead. My measure blurs the first time I try to read it.

Twelve out of fourteen. Three reserve out of four. Warder.

The morning's lesson, the frame, the hours at the mirror. I can't divide them into a receipt. I write the numbers down, wash, and sit on the bed until I can unfold the page without shaking it.

On it, in Mara's careful letters, is the man's first question.

Who holds?

—○—

At first daylight the strip is there again.

The wheel position and clamp marks are unchanged. Mara records both before handing me a folded sheet, looking as though she has not slept.

"Their letter," she says. "We'll need to show it in pieces."

"Do they want to come?"

“Yes.”

“Are they?”

“Not today. They agreed.”

She looks down at the fold. “The younger one asked whether he should wear the coat his father knew.”

I can’t look at the letter after that. I watch Harra fit the hood instead.

My reserve is full. Two days until the removal crew. I have brought a fresh sheet for every question I thought of in the night; Mara has only the letter.

I barely reach the hood before I see him at the rail.

He has propped his board against it. There are two words.

Still here.

Mara presses her hand over her mouth. Then she takes the first sheet of her nephews’ letter and begins.

It takes nearly an hour.

We hold each section where he can see it and wait for his raised hand before showing the next. Once he goes out of sight and returns with a cloth pressed against his eyes. No one speaks while he is gone.

I learn almost nothing of the letter’s contents. I’m holding the paper with its back to me, following Harra’s corrections, my world reduced to making the right patch of reflection clear enough for a father to read.

When he answers, Mara writes it down.

They will get his words in her hand. The original board stays beside a rail we cannot reach. Mara holds each finished sheet under her palm until the ink is dry.

—○—

Later we move to practical questions.

He is on a stair landing. The flight below him is broken across its width. Beyond the break, the arch appears as a narrow line of light. He has lashed his small mirror to a strip of wood so he can lean it around the rail and see us. The door behind him opens inward to another room. He can open it.

“Ask what room.” I reach for the slate before Mara has finished writing his answer.

“Wait.”

I let go.

Mara writes.

Tables. Pipes. Cups in a cupboard. Beds farther up.

“People?”

None found.

Dain has us ask about water and food before I can ask a hundred questions about the cupboards. Iven says a tap works in the room upstairs. He has food in sealed packages, though some made him sick. He has been sleeping near the stair because the opening comes and goes.

“How long?”

Mara sets down the pen she has been using for our copies and writes the question on the slate herself.

His answer takes more room than the board allows. He shows it in two parts.

Seventy-one sleeps since I began marking. Sick before. Missed some.

Dain sits down on the spare stool.

I put a hand against the wall. Cold stone, grainy under the heel of my palm. Four years and nearly two months here. Seventy-one sleeps since he began counting there, with an unknown amount before. I try to make the numbers meet and get my mother instead, phone facedown because checking it hurts.

“We don’t know,” I say.

Nobody has asked me anything.

“I know,” Dain says.

Mara asks whether there is daylight. Iven says there are windows higher up, but boards cover them and he has not taken them off. There are noises outside sometimes. He doesn’t know what makes them.

Four years here, and only seventy-one marks he trusts. I grip the wall until my hand hurts while Mara writes the next question.

Then he holds up a packet.

White, creased, with a blue edge. He has flattened it carefully so we can see the writing. I read *DRINKING WATER* and part of a volume printed beneath. The rest is too small or hidden by his hand.

I tell them exactly that. I can’t name the brand or make out a date.

Plastic shines where his thumb presses it.

“Can you ask him to keep that?” I say.

Mara writes. Her hand is steadier now that she has work for it.

—○—

Dain takes my place to ask about the missing stair. I linger behind him, watching the door every time the mirror turns that way, until Harra asks me to clear the passage.

Sella finds me outside when Harra changes the mounting wedge. I have been practicing against the pier by the door without spending, step back, settle, feel where my feet are. There is still a sore spot in my left arch when

I land badly. I correct the foot and try again.

"Enough," she says after watching once.

"I haven't spent."

"You're favoring that arm. Stop."

I let my arms drop.

She has a paper tucked through her belt. I look at it before I can stop myself.

"Eastbound?"

"An offer. Five days from now. Warehouse escort as far as the ridge. Wrong direction after that."

"Are you taking it?"

"Maybe. I've asked Pell for paid work until the crew arrives. If I'm standing here keeping people from walking into this, I want her paying for the standing."

"Did she agree?"

"Yes."

I am glad enough that it shows. Sella notices.

"You could ask me to have supper," she says.

"I see you at supper."

"I meant sit with me. On purpose."

Heat gets into my face. She looks pleased, which helps and does not help at all.

"After," I say. "When you're off."

"All right."

She goes back to the rope, leaving me beside a pier with both my hands empty.

Inside, the man beyond the mirror is waiting to show us the measurements of a stair. I go back to work.

—○—

By evening we have a rough account of the landing, an incomplete inventory of the rooms Iven has entered, and a plan to show him a longer measuring rod tomorrow. The view narrows again before supper. He sees our last slate and acknowledges it. We close with the spindle unchanged.

Pell has found the second sluicewright. A carrier leaves with her letter before supper. The removal crew will shore the outer bank while he and Dain work on an alternative drain; the inner assembly stays.

Upstairs I put away my pay and wash my face. Thirteen of fourteen progress. I could find something to lift. Spend until the number changes.

I set the basin down with both hands.

Sella is waiting on the bench by the herb pots when I come back down the outside stair.

She has washed too. Her hair is loose from its braids, waves flattened in places where the ties were, and there is a little crescent of soap behind one ear. I want to touch it with an intensity wildly out of proportion to hygiene.

“You’re looking,” she says.

“I know.”

She reaches behind her ear and finds the soap. Neither of us says anything while she wipes it away.

I sit beside her. The bench has enough room to choose distance. I choose very little.

For a while we talk about the coast. She has never seen a ship larger than a river barge. I tell her about a ferry I rode once with my parents, the wind that kept putting my hair in my mouth, my father trying to convince a gull to take a french fry while my mother told him what would happen next.

“What happened?”

“More gulls.”

She laughs, head tipped back. I have been listening to water and mechanisms all day, and I want to hear her do that again.

“What does the coast look like here?” I ask.

“Ask someone who’s been.”

“You’ve never asked?”

“I’ve heard about the cheap inns and the price of fish. Carters are poets.” She nudges my knee. “I want to see it before someone tells me what I should like.”

I try to picture her on a beach with her boots in her hand. For once the water in my head has no wheel beside it, no broken stair, nobody waiting for us to get something right.

“I’d like that.”

“Then keep something out of your wages for it.”

It is such a small suggestion. A fare. A day I might pay for because I want it. I have been counting coins in meals and nights indoors; now I try to remember the eastbound fare.

She leans back against the wall, leaving her knee against mine. I turn toward her.

“Tolliver knows I wanted to ask you.”

Her gaze returns to me.

“He told you what to say?”

“No.”

“Good.” She rubs her thumb along the bench edge. “I saw you with him. I wasn’t sure what you’d agreed.”

“I told him I wanted you. He’s angry.”

“Did you tell him you’d stop?”

“No.”

She draws her knee away from mine. I feel the empty space immediately.

“I don’t want him coming to me about it.”

“He won’t.”

“You don’t know that.”

“No. I don’t.”

Across the yard someone calls for a missing pan. She waits until the shouting stops, picking at a splinter in the bench.

“I like you,” she says. “I’m also taking work east if I get it.”

“When?”

“Five days, if I accept.”

I want to ask her not to. I have been here less than a week.

“I still want this,” I say.

She looks at my mouth. “So do I.”

She studies me. I keep still, which requires almost as much attention as the lesson at the pier.

“Can I kiss you?” I ask.

“Yes.”

I move too quickly at first and bump her nose. She laughs against my cheek, her hand closing gently around my wrist.

“Slow down.”

“Sorry.”

She keeps her hand around my wrist.

The second try is slower. Her mouth is warm, softer than the sharpness of her grin prepared me for. She turns toward me and I feel her knee against mine, her fingers easing from my wrist into my hand. When I start to pull back, she follows just far enough to make it clear she wants another.

I give her one.

I stay with my mouth against her cheek until my breathing settles. Our joined hands rest between us. I want another hour on this bench, a room with a door I know how to open, my mother hearing me say I am all right without deciding first whether it’s true.

Sella brushes a loose strand away from my mouth.

“Tomorrow?” she asks.

“Yes.”

She stays until the kitchen lights begin going out. When she leaves, I go upstairs alone, carrying the warmth of her hand longer than I can reasonably expect my skin to keep it.

On my table lies the sketch we made from Iven's measurements. The broken stair. The rail. The gray door he can open, leading into rooms where water comes from a tap and food comes wrapped in plastic.

I set my candle beside it and take out a clean page.

Tomorrow he can show us what is beyond that door. He has been living there for an amount of time neither of us can name, deciding which packets are safe and listening to noises beyond boarded windows. I have spent days looking past him for a way home.

At the top of the page I write a different question to show him first.

What do you need?

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Iven needs a saw.

“Small teeth,” I tell Dain. “For metal.”

Mara writes the next question before I finish speaking. Beyond the mirror, her brother lets go of the rail and disappears through the gray door. She keeps the slate raised for a moment, then lowers it to her lap.

“He could tell us where he’s going.”

I pretend to check the copy beneath my hand.

It is my fifth reading day. Four reserve, an aching shoulder, and a man waiting for a tool we still don’t know how to give him. Harra’s mirror-rod extension rests against the gallery wall, a brass washer tied between its forked prongs.

Iven comes back dragging a length of metal. Two shorter pieces hang from it at right angles. He puts one end on the rail and lifts the other for us to see.

“Bed frame,” I say.

Dain takes my place. Through the hood I hear him breathing, then the scrape of Mara’s chalk as he asks about the joints.

One is stuck. The long strip would reach over the broken stair if Iven could get it free. He wants to carry a line across.

“Is he going to walk on it?” Mara asks.

The answer comes back underlined.

No. I’m a sluicewright.

Dain laughs once, sharply, and Mara glares at him. He bends to the glass again. I watch the back of his neck redden.

We show Iven the shape of our access. He knew the lower passage; he has been looking for us down there. Dain’s drawing puts us above the chamber, with a sleeve through the wall and a rod reaching down to the arch. Iven studies it, then points to the floor beneath his own feet.

He has three intact steps. The next is broken across its width, leaving a tilted corner. After that, nothing until a lower stub near the opening.

Six local feet, measured with the sound length of his old folding rule. He marks the bed strip, lays it beside the rail, checks again. The little mirror on its stick moves with him, giving us a sickening glimpse down into the break.

I can see pipes below it. No floor.

Mara puts a hand flat against the wall.

Iven taps the rail post. Dust falls from a crack around its foot. He points at the crack, then crosses his forearms.

“No rope on that,” Dain says.

Iven points behind him, through the gray door. His next drawing shows a thick stone jamb with room to pass a line around it.

Dain leans closer. “Can he inspect the back?”

Iven is already turning his mirror that way. I have to catch Mara’s sleeve before she wipes the question off.

“Leave it. Let him answer.”

She looks at my hand until I take it away.

—○—

Tolliver is outside the workshop when we stop. He has survey cord over his shoulder and mud drying on his knees.

I slow down. He could have gone inside. He stays where he is.

“Dain found the money,” he says. “North collector. Today and tomorrow, eight bits a day.”

“Good.”

He pulls a burr from the cord and flicks it away.

“Did you?”

I know what he means. I wish we weren’t standing where anyone could walk past us.

“Yes.”

He nods. His mouth tightens at one corner. I reach for his sleeve, and he shifts the coil between us.

“Don’t do that because you think you should.”

“I wasn’t.”

“All right.”

But he keeps the cord there.

Inside the workshop Harra drops something metal. We both look toward the noise. I could go and ask whether she needs me. He could go back to work. Neither of us moves.

“I’m not going to stop seeing her,” I say.

“I heard you.”

“And I don’t want to stop seeing you.”

He looks down at my hand, still halfway between us.

“I don’t know if I can do it like that.”

I lower it. I had imagined anger, maybe apologizing for how I told him. I had not imagined him simply deciding he might not want what I was offering.

He does not tell me to choose. He tells me what he may not stay for. I stand there with my hand hanging between us and no argument that fits.

“Tell me when you know.”

He gives a short nod and walks north with the survey cord knocking against his hip.

I stand there until Harra comes to the door.

“Are you eating or helping?”

“Helping.”

She hands me the lower end of the extension.

—○—

The probe reaches farther than the mirror. Harra has fitted it to a separate cradle, so moving one won’t move the other. The brass washer hangs on a short loop of linen cord. If the fork gets to the opening, we can put the washer through and pull it back.

An object from here. There and back.

I watch it while she tightens the fittings.

“Don’t wind that around your finger,” she says.

I let go of the loose cord.

The bolts take the rod’s weight. My job is to stop the cradle twisting while she lowers the tip. There is a catch beneath it; I practice letting the handle go until I can do it without trying to soften the drop.

Harra tests a pin between her fingers. For a moment a pale line shows beneath its surface. She turns it toward the light and swears.

“What?”

“Fold in the iron.” She drops it into a dish and takes another.

“You can see inside it?”

“If I’m holding it. And if it’s worked metal.” She rubs her thumb against her trousers. “Costs a point. I wish the smith would stop giving me reasons to spend them.”

She tests the replacement. No pale line this time. It goes into the cradle.

Two days ago I would have wanted her run instead of mine. Now I press my forearm and find the shape of Brace waiting beneath it.



At the gallery Iven raises an open hand to show he understands. He stays above the missing stair with his mirror propped on the rail.

Harra feeds the extension through beside the viewing rod. I can't see the tip from my place at the cradle. Dain calls the marks as they pass the sleeve.

"Down."

The weight comes sideways. I set my feet and spend one.

The handle steadies. Beneath the side shoe, a little pale dust falls onto the floor.

I watch it for half a breath. Then the pressure changes against my arm.

"Something's moving."

"Where?" Harra asks.

"The shoe."

She reaches for the catch. I am still holding. Foot solid, arm solid; surely if I keep the shape—

"Let go."

I release. The cradle drops onto the catch with an iron knock. Dain pulls his face out of the hood.

"Still on our side. Draw it in."

They retract together. The brass washer comes back dry.

Harra digs a nail beneath the packing and lifts out a sliver of old mortar. Behind it, the new shoe rests partly on a patch concealed under the mounting plate.

The sleeve and wall are sound. The place we put the load is not.

"Did I make it worse?" I ask.

"You told me before it pulled the bolt." She gets a chisel from her bag. "Move your foot."

I sit outside while she cuts a hardwood seat against clean stone and makes Dain load-test it with a lever.

Through the door I see Sella by the boundary rope. She looks up, sees me sitting, and turns back to the yard. I am grateful she doesn't come over, then angry she hasn't.

When Harra calls, I go inside.



The second hold lasts less than two breaths.

One point. The fork touches our sill, Harra fixes the angle, and I release. This time nothing moves under the shoe. I get to the spare viewing glass beside Dain in time to see the washer hanging against the dark stone.

“Forward a finger,” he says.

Harra advances the rod.

The washer crosses the bright edge.

I stop breathing. Ordinary brass swings above the lower stair on Iven’s side, its shadow on the pale wall.

Iven lifts his board.

See it.

Harra brings the fork back. The washer knocks against our sill and comes up through the sleeve, still tied to its cord.

She puts it on the board between us.

I touch it. Warm from the chamber, rough where Dain drilled the hole, linen damp near the knot.

“Again?” I ask.

“Tomorrow,” Dain says.

“It’s still open.”

He catches my wrist before I can reach for the cord again.

“It’s narrowing.”

At the glass, the strip has thinned. Iven has his hand on the rail, waiting to see what we will do. The fork would fit now. In another few minutes it might not.

Dain lets go. I rub the place his thumb pressed.

We send the result, then the time of the next contact. Iven acknowledges both. Harra retracts the mirrors while I watch the washer on the board. No one has reached him. There is still a hole beneath his steps and a door behind him I want to run through.

But something crossed.

Outside, I open my measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 3]

I put my hand down, then bring it straight back to my throat.

[PROGRESS: 0 / 18]

[RESERVE: 2 / 5]

[RUN: WARDER]

Five reserve marks now. Two full. I keep the measure open until Sella comes down the steps.

“You saw?” I ask.

“I saw.”

I laugh. She smiles, and I want to pull her down beside me. Instead I catch her hand and put it on the unhurt part of my shoulder. For a moment I sit with her standing behind me, her fingers warm against the side of my

neck.

Then Harra needs the steps, and we move.

—○—

I collect my fifth reading wage on the way to supper. Pell finds us outside the workshop, reads Dain's account, and examines the returned washer and cord.

"Captain Rusk will be here tomorrow," she says. "She's bringing the lifting rig."

"Good," Dain says.

"She still claims the inner iron."

He sets down his pen.

"The removal contract," Pell says. "The iron was part of her payment. She's been on the road with six people and that rig while we've changed the work."

"Then buy it back," Mara says.

"With what?"

The question comes out sharply. Pell puts the dish down before continuing.

"I can redirect the labor already paid for. New work needs new money. The rents on those drowned fields were supposed to cover the winter purchases."

Mara looks away. I stare at the brass washer. I had thought the hard part would be finding a way through.

Vey reads the captain's dispatch over Pell's shoulder. He is quiet for longer than I like.

"What does she want?" I ask.

"Access," he says. "If we have found something worth keeping open."

Pell folds the paper and gives Dain the arrival time. By the time she leaves, he has covered the dish with a cloth.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The captain arrives holding a horse's face.

One hand on its cheek, the other curled into the head strap. Behind it, a cart leans in a rut with two long timber legs lashed above the load. Each time the horse backs, a timber swings toward the gatepost.

"Brake," she says.

The driver pulls. A man at the rear starts pushing.

"Bren, leave it."

He stops. She waits until the horse's feet settle, then walks it sideways while two crew members put a plank under the wheel. The cart comes level with a long wooden groan.

[SALVAGER, LV. 23] hangs above her head. She has close-cropped hair going gray over one ear and a scar pulling down one corner of her mouth. She wipes horse spit on her trousers before shaking Pell's hand.

Six crew members. A chain tackle with a casing the size of a bucket. At its end hangs a hook I could fit both hands through.

Dain comes out of the workshop carrying his drawing. The captain takes it and walks straight past me toward the headwall.

I follow them until Mara calls my name.

The notebook is waiting. My last reading day, while the people deciding what happens to the door go up the steps without me.

—○—

The last English label says *wrong jar*.

There is no jar. Mara tries the string against two stains in the tray, then puts it in a separate paper sleeve.

We finish before midday: thirty-six written pages, the surviving labels, and a short list of unresolved words and missing samples. On Elena's last page, beneath a purchase crossed out twice: thread, soap, pears if any.

"Was this before?" I ask.

"Before the winter."

I keep a finger under the pears while Mara sands the copy. Then she closes the notebook and lays Elena's card beside it.

Pell still hasn't ruled on the card. One of the old inventory witnesses is upriver, Mara says. I want to ask how long it takes to decide a woman owns her own face. Instead I watch her write another reminder and file it with the claim.

Outside the records room, two young men are waiting.

"I'm Teren," the taller one says. "This is Lio."

"Iven's—"

"We know who our father is," Lio says.

Teren closes his eyes briefly. I step aside to let Mara out.

Lio looks toward the gallery. "Can we see him?"

"One at a time," she says.

He opens his mouth. Teren puts a hand on his arm, and he pulls away.

—○—

I spend most of the contact outside.

Dain has checked the washer again. Harra has examined the wet cord. There is no visible damage, but the water stained it gray. The little dish sits beside the frame while Teren takes his turn at the glass.

Lio waits with me on the wall. His brother's coat lies across his knees.

"Does he look old?"

"I didn't know him before."

His boot scrapes the ground.

"Everyone keeps doing that."

"What?"

"Answering something they can."

I look at the coat. Teren has worn a hole through one elbow and stitched a patch over it from the inside.

"Yes," I say. "Older than the drawing Mara showed me. His hair's gray. He's been cutting his beard himself."

Lio picks at the patch. He nods without looking up.

When his turn comes, he gives Teren the coat and goes upstairs. His brother sits where he was sitting. I stay with him until Harra calls for the packet translations.

—○—

Rusk lifts a sling full of stone while we watch.

Two timber legs stand spread on packing boards. Chain runs through the casing at the top. One of her crew pulls the hand chain, and the stones rise without anyone touching the load.

“Brake holds without a hand on it,” she says.

The operator lets go. The sling stays in the air.

I see Iven in it, boots clearing the broken stair, Mara reaching before the sling stops. I have to look away.

Rusk lays her terms on an upturned crate.

She will supply the rig and crew for the retrieval. Rook supplies materials and access. In return her company gets a season’s exclusive use of the opening, first claim on unattended recoveries, and custody of anything brought through until examined.

“Anything?” I ask.

“Goods inventoried. Persons housed separately during questioning. Thirty days at most.”

Mara takes the paper.

“He has a house.”

“Then he can return to it after examination.”

“A mender can examine him here.”

Rusk looks at Dain. “You said the water comes from somewhere you can’t identify. You don’t know what he’s been drinking. You don’t know what lives in the rooms with him.”

I can see Dain considering it. I remember the packets that made Iven sick.

“And if the mender says he’s well?” I ask.

“We’d still need his account of the place.”

“What if he won’t give it to you?”

“The term is thirty days.”

Mara folds the page so hard it creases through the middle of the clause.

“No.”

Rusk holds out her hand for the paper. Mara doesn’t give it back. Pell takes it from her instead.

“Removal of specified iron,” Pell says. “That’s what we contracted. Not ownership of the route.”

“You stopped removal.”

“We found a living man.”

“You found a valuable road.” Rusk points toward the gallery. “Don’t ask me to pretend you haven’t.”

A worker tries to catch her eye from beside the rig. She raises a finger to make him wait.

“Master Vey?” she says.

He has been standing in the shade with his hands inside his sleeves. He comes forward to read the paper.

“The season might pay for the repairs,” he says.

Mara turns away.

Vey looks at her back. Then at the custody clause.

“Elena wanted her chest,” he says. “We kept telling her she could have it after one more examination.”

“This is not a chest.”

“No.” He puts the paper down. “I won’t witness it.”

Rusk gathers her copy. “Three days on the redirected work. Those are paid. After that I need wages or another job.”

“Price the rescue in money,” Pell says.

“I haven’t seen a place to put the feet yet.”

She goes to her waiting worker. Within minutes the tackle is in a fenced corner of the yard, her apprentice chaining the entrance.

—○—

Pell has six uncommitted pieces in the works chest.

Dain asks her to repeat the number.

“Six after the three days Dain asked for,” she says. “Those wages are set aside. So is the seed purchase. If I spend either, someone else doesn’t get paid.”

“Advance on rents?”

She points through the window at the flooded fields.

“House reserve,” Mara says.

“I’ve sent twice. The owners want the original drainage work completed before they’ll release another allocation.”

Dain pushes his drawing across the table, hard enough to knock Vey’s sleeve.

“The original work could drown us.”

“Put that in the letter,” Pell says. “I’ve run out of ways to say it.”

For a moment nobody moves. Then Vey puts three pieces beside the drawing.

“For the survey and a small trial. That I can pay now.”

Pell takes the coins before he can change his mind.

The proposed drain bypasses the old junction through an abandoned wash channel to the mill tailrace. Tolliver’s levels say it should fall, but roots and silt block the masonry throat, so Dain wants a guarded test draw before committing the rest.

"I can do that," I say.

Sella looks at me from the doorway.

"With you there," I add.

She comes to the table and studies the drawing. "There's no place to stand."

"We'll lay boards," Dain says.

"Then show me the boards before you put her on them."

I wait for her to look at me. She keeps talking to Dain.

They agree on a prepared ledge, an uphill retreat, and three days for test and contact work. My eight bits a day, lodging, and return passage stay unchanged. Sella gets twelve bits a day for guard work; Tolliver gets ten for survey and field support. We are all hired through the same last day. I sign beneath the new dates.

Sella's pen stops over the last date. It is the day she was meant to leave east.

She signs anyway.

—○—

Tolliver is beside Rusk's cart when I come out with my last reading wage. Six pieces earned, plus the Greyward coins. Enough to buy something useful if I stop counting everything as nights in a bed.

Rusk gives him a folded paper. He reads it, asks a question I can't hear, and puts it inside his coat.

I wait by the well until he sees me.

"What was that?"

"Work."

"For her?"

"Once I'm finished here."

I look at the fenced rig. "You heard what she asked for."

"I did."

"And you're taking it?"

"Tracking. The west road. Looking for a missing team and their wagon."

"You'd believe her about what you're looking for?"

His face changes.

"You believed Vey."

"That was different."

"Because you wanted what he had."

I step closer. "Because I read the paper."

"So did I."

He takes it out and offers it. I don't reach for it.

We stand with the folded sheet between us until he puts it away.

"I'm here for these three days," he says. "I'll do the work I agreed to."

"And after that?"

"I haven't signed hers."

I want him to say he won't. Behind him, a crew member tests the tackle chain while Rusk shows the apprentice a flaw near the hook.

"Be careful," I say.

He gives me a tired look. "I do know her kind of work, Maya."

The folded paper disappears back inside his coat. Rusk asked him because he knows exactly how to do her kind of work.

I leave him beside the well and take my money upstairs.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The shield I can afford is green.

Under the dirt it may once have been an attractive green. Someone painted a yellow bird in the middle, painted over it, then wore through enough of the second coat to leave one eye watching me beneath the mud.

I scrape mud away from the yellow eye with my thumbnail.

Harra turns it around. "These straps are new."

The stores shed smells of old leather. Shields lean against a broken wagon wheel, their straps looped over the spokes. My reserve is finally full at five. Sella made me check before breakfast and then refused to let me use any of it carrying shields off the rack.

"This one?" I ask, lifting a larger round shield.

"No," she says.

"You haven't seen me hold it."

"I can see your wrist."

I put it down. My wrist keeps trembling after I've let go.

The green shield is narrower, wood faced in hide, with a metal strip around the edge and a padded rest behind it. Harra shows me an old gouge that doesn't go through and makes me look along the boards for warping. The straps have been replaced. One buckle has three extra holes for an arm like mine.

"Three pieces, fitted," she says. "Pell approved the stores sale. Yours afterward."

Twenty-four bits.

"Can you do two?"

"No."

"Two and four?"

"The straps cost me work."

Sella says nothing. I look at her, hoping for the kind of insider signal that means an offer is secretly terrible. She lifts one shoulder. She checks the rim of another shield and sets it back.

I slide my left arm through and settle the weight close. It is still heavy. It doesn't pull me apart the way the round one did. When Sella presses the face, I feel the force reach the floor before my shoulder tries to take all of it.

I take three pieces from my pouch.

Harra counts them and passes me the shield. The purse is much lighter when I tie it shut.

Outside, Sella presses the face while I hold it. The weight settles against my forearm. It is mine, even if she leaves and the job ends.

I turn it to see the yellow bird again.

—○—

Before she teaches me anything, Sella has me lift my arm without the shield.

Forward. Out. Slowly over my head. I can reach high enough, but the last part draws an ache across the shoulder that makes me turn my face away.

"There," she says. "Below that today."

"It isn't sharp."

"Don't reach that high with weight on it."

We work behind the kitchen, on a broad patch of packed ground away from the carts. Her relief has taken the boundary. We have an hour before Dain wants her at the north collector.

She draws a straight line in the dirt with a stick.

"Brace will keep you in a doorway," she says. "What happens when the doorway is the wrong place?"

"I stop bracing."

"And then?"

"I turn to run."

"And show it your back."

She stands with her shield facing mine and places one foot a little behind the other. "Push."

I push. She gives a fraction, enough for my weight to settle. Then the feeling changes beneath my hands. The shield holds its line while she takes one short step toward me, forcing me back without a shove.

She lowers it.

I look at her boots. "Again."

"That cost two."

My excitement rearranges itself.

"Two?"

“And lasts two breaths. One short straight step, forward or back. You start it already knowing where the foot will go.”

“That’s expensive.”

“So is falling with someone behind you.”

She calls it Stepguard. The pattern moves support from one planted foot to the next without letting the stance or facing fold during the transfer. A shield is the obvious use because it gives incoming force a face to meet, but the pattern belongs to the step, not the shield. At least one foot stays properly grounded. Put that foot on ground that shifts, turn, jump, or reach for another step, and it comes apart. It can carry a bounded load through the line I’ve chosen; anything outside that line still gets me.

“Can I Brace at the same time?”

“No. The patterns fight each other.”

“Finish one. Set the other. Don’t try to fix a broken Stepguard by pouring more into it.”

She has me walk the line bare-handed, then with the shield, then under light pressure. Every time I try to make the step heroic, she makes it smaller. Eventually my body understands what my head has resisted: the weight stays connected if I don’t hurry the back foot.

“There,” she says. “Remember that.”

I go still, trying to keep the sensation without squeezing it to death.

The shape under Warder answers when I reach toward it, less settled than Brace but present.

Sella watches my face.

“Found it?”

“I think so.”

“Two if you commit. Even if you fall out of it. We’re keeping the push light.”

I nod, set my shield, and spend.

The hold catches. Pressure runs down the line, through the back of my arm and into my heel, then changes as I begin to move. For half a step I am doing it.

Sella’s hand drifts toward the rim.

I turn the shield to follow.

The pattern collapses so abruptly that I stagger into her. She catches the top edge and lowers it between us while I hop once to save my balance.

“Why?” she asks.

“Your hand moved.”

“So did your facing.”

“I was keeping you out.”

“You were following me.” She taps the line in the dirt. “You chose there. I invited you somewhere else.”

My boot is well outside the line. I kick dirt back over the mark.

Three reserve left. The failed attempt took both points.

“Again,” I say.

“No. Walk it first.”

I nearly argue. Then she moves her hand toward the rim and I turn again without spending anything at all.

She raises her eyebrows.

“I know.”

She lowers her hand and waits while I set my feet.

We walk it first.

—○—

On the next attempt I watch the ground instead of her hand.

Sella presses straight into the center this time. I choose the patch of ground, step the front foot forward, and follow the pressure instead of her hand. Two points leave me. The shield stays where I intended while my weight moves beneath it.

One breath. Foot settles.

I end the hold before I can decide to improve it.

Sella takes her hand away.

For a second neither of us moves. Then she grins.

[STEPGUARD]

The word sits beneath Warder when I attend to it, beside Brace. I can recall the moving shape now without spending, imperfectly but distinctly. My measure shows three out of eighteen progress, one reserve out of five.

I have a second ability.

I look from the line to my shield. Six inches of dirt. A whole new thing my body can do.

“Again,” I say.

“You have one left.”

I had forgotten. I look at the five marks and laugh.

I put the shield down carefully, straighten, and throw both arms around her before my shoulder reminds me to keep one lower. She catches me around the waist. I kiss her, badly at first because I’m smiling too hard, then properly when she turns her head and pulls me a little closer.

Her palm is warm through the back of my tunic. I pull her closer. Her buckle presses into my stomach, and neither of us moves it.

When we stop, she looks pleased in a way that has very little to do with the lesson.

"I was going to do that anyway," I say.

"I hoped."

She brushes a grain of dirt from my cheek. I want to follow her hand. Instead I lean into it until her thumb stills against my skin.

We stay there long enough for the kitchen door to open and a woman with a bucket to tell us we're standing in the drainage run.

Sella picks up her shield. I pick up mine.

I am still smiling when we reach the yard.

—○—

Tolliver takes the finished levels to Dain at midday.

He spreads the survey on the wall while I eat. The north field collector stands higher than the abandoned wash channel, and that channel falls to the mill tailrace. He has walked the route from the upper bank. At its narrowest point, old masonry holds a mass of roots and silt above a low opening.

"Water gets through," he says. "Very little. There are fresh slides either side. Reed-jack tracks under the willows."

The bread in my mouth loses most of its appeal.

"How many?" Sella asks.

"Two sets I can distinguish. Could be more."

She moves her cup out of the way so Dain can lay the plan flat.

The warm outlet from the earlier survey is somewhere else. Dain puts his finger on it, then takes the finger off. We are leaving that question where it is. This route would carry ordinary field water around the entire old junction.

A woman arrives while he is explaining, carrying a sack of clotted roots. I recognize her companion: the man who brought Pell drowned seedlings. Today his hands are empty, hanging stiffly at his sides.

"Bera," Dain says. "Show her."

The woman pours a little of the sack onto the wall. Pale roots, black rot, a bulb that gives under her thumb.

"That row stood through last year," she says. "We raised it. Now the collector's backed over the path."

"You own that field?"

"Rent it. Rent's due whether I get a crop or not."

I look at the dead roots while black water drips from her thumb onto an old stain on her skirt.

"If you cut toward the wash," she tells Dain, "take the old barrow track. The soil beneath those willows won't carry you."

Tolliver moves a mark on his sketch to show the track.

"Will it take your field?" I ask.

"The track? No. If you open it wrong and wash half the bank through, yes."

She looks at my plate. I wait for her to object to the three.

Instead she asks, "Which bit are you doing?"

"The screen. On the prepared side. Keeping the space while Harra opens the trial cut."

"Wear boots you can pull out of mud."

She puts the roots back into her sack. It takes longer than pouring them out.

—○—

Sella sends her answer east that afternoon.

I see her at the carrier's cart while I am taking the copied contact sheets to Mara. She gives the driver a folded note, tells him which warehouse office, and waits while he repeats it. A routine message leaving with the house dispatches. I watch the cart go through the gate. Five days ago that note would have carried her toward a job; now it closes one.

When she turns, I am still standing there.

"You declined."

"Yes."

"Because of this?"

She looks at the papers in my hand.

"Yes. Mostly."

"And me?"

"Some." She pushes the sheets up before their edge reaches the puddle. "I lost the booking deposit. Two pieces."

"I could—"

"No."

I shut my mouth.

"I knew when I sent it," she says. "But don't tell me it's only three days. I have to find another opening now."

I tuck the sheets against my chest.

"Come upstairs tonight."

She looks at me.

"There's a flat roof over the pantry," I add, too quickly. "I can get food."

She looks at me for a moment and begins to smile.
“After the meal,” she says. “I’ll ask about the roof.”

—○—

The second sluicewright reaches Rook before the evening meal.

Oret is a small man with a shaved head, spectacles tied behind his ears, and ****[SLUICEWRIGHT, LV. 22]**** above him. Dain meets him with the survey. Oret doesn’t ask to see the mysterious door first. He asks where the field water comes in.

Within ten minutes they are arguing over the old wash channel. Oret forces Dain to use the actual fall; Dain forces Oret to use Tolliver’s measured points. They settle on a narrow test cut with an upstream stop board and an uphill withdrawal route. Oret watches the outlet, Dain the inlet, Harra works the screen, and I hold its end behind my shield while the guards cover the banks.

Bera offers to show the sound path. Pell agrees to pay her for the morning and keeps the remaining field hands away from the draw.

It feels different hearing my name among the jobs. I try the position with an empty frame while Harra corrects my stance and Sella drills the retreat.

No powered practice. I only have one reserve left, and tomorrow needs more than my enthusiasm.

—○—

We get permission for the roof.

It is less romantic than I imagined: a shallow platform over the pantry, reached by a short ladder, with a rail on two sides and drying onions on the third. The kitchen woman makes us promise not to step on the onions. Sella brings bread, I bring sliced turnip and the heel of cheese left from supper, and neither of us makes a claim about the view.

The shield is propped beside my bed. My day’s pay lies beneath the purse, still uncounted.

Sella sits beside me with her boots stretched out, off duty and smelling faintly of the soap she used to wash the dust from her arms. She has a mending needle stuck through a strip of cloth.

“Really?” I say.

“My cuff is coming off.”

“We’re on an outing.”

“Hold this, will you?”

I hold the cuff while she stitches. Above the yard the evening sky turns a color I don't have a useful name for, pale gold with a greenish edge. I can hear Dain and Oret still arguing below us. Oret keeps saying a number Dain won't accept.

Sella asks me about the gulls again. This time I tell her the part where my father lost the rest of his fries and tried to pretend that had been the plan. She laughs with the thread between her fingers, then waits while I remember something else.

I tell her about my mother's car smelling of sunscreen all the way home. About sand appearing in a shoe a week later. I have to stop once. She waits until I can continue.

The first moon rises above the east roof, pale and broad. The smaller one is already there. I mistook it for a star the first clear night. Tonight I can see its edge.

Sella puts down the needle.

"Does that upset you?"

"Sometimes."

She looks at the two moons, then at me. I don't know how to explain missing something as large as a sky.

"I'm not thinking about it now," I say.

She puts her hand beside mine on the roof. I move closer until our shoulders touch.

The kiss comes without an announcement. She turns, I meet her, and we discover how much slower we can make it. When her hand settles at my waist, I move closer instead of trying to turn the feeling into a sentence.

When she draws back, I follow. Her hand tightens against my waist.

"Maya."

I stop.

"Not on the onions."

I look down. My heel is an inch from a drying tray. I move it, laughing, and she rests her forehead against mine until I am quiet again.

"Come inside," I say.

She searches my face. "You sure?"

"Yes."

We climb down separately. At my door I catch my skirt on a nail and have to stop to free it. She waits behind me without making a joke.

Inside, I put the food cloth on the table. The room is smaller with her in it. There is one bed, my sack beneath it, the green shield against the wall. She reaches past me to set the lamp down, and I catch her hand before she can turn away.

This kiss is slower. She has nowhere to go afterward. Neither do I.

Her thumb drifts once along my jaw.

“Still sure?”

“Yes.”

The answer comes out too fast. I make myself breathe.

“Yes,” I say again. “Very.”

Her shoulders ease. She had been waiting for the second answer.

I catch the front of her tunic and pull her back to me.

The bed complains when her knee lands beside my thigh. The sound makes us both pause, listening for footsteps in the hall. None come.

“Romantic,” I whisper.

“Structural,” she says, and kisses me again.

I get one hand under the hem of her tunic. Warm skin. A hard line of muscle along her side. She inhales when my palm slides higher, and the little change in her breathing goes straight through me.

Her hand reaches for my shoulder, stops before touching it, and moves to my waist instead.

“I’m not glass.”

“No. You’re injured.”

“I’m sore.”

“That is an injury with better publicity.”

I bite her lower lip.

She makes a sound against my mouth that wipes the next clever thing out of my head.

Getting undressed is less graceful than I imagined. My skirt catches under me. Her belt buckle was designed by an enemy of desire. When I finally get it loose, she laughs into my neck.

Then her tunic is on the floor.

I have seen women naked before. Locker rooms. Bedrooms. Ordinary bodies I could look at without forgetting where my hands were.

Sella watches me watching her, and suddenly I have no idea where to put mine. She doesn’t look embarrassed. She looks attentive, waiting.

I put my hand on her breast.

Her breath catches.

That feels unfairly powerful.

“Again,” she says.

So I do.

She lowers me carefully, one hand behind my back, the other moving the pillow until my bad shoulder is supported instead of trapped beneath me. The tenderness of it almost undoes me more efficiently than the naked

woman in my bed.

Almost.

Her mouth finds mine. Then my jaw. Then the place below my ear that makes my entire body tighten.

“Sella.”

“I know.”

“You absolutely do not.”

She proves that she does.

Her mouth closes over my nipple and I forget the argument. Heat pulls low in my stomach. My fingers knot in the sheet. She shifts beside me, watching my face as her hand slides down my body.

The first touch between my thighs is over cloth.

I jerk anyway.

Her eyes lift to mine.

“Good?”

“Yes.”

She strokes me again, slower.

“Still good?”

“Yes. Stop interviewing me.”

“You complain when I don’t ask questions.”

“I contain multitudes.”

Her laugh warms my skin. Then her hand slips beneath the last layer between us, and the joke dies in my throat.

I am wet enough that she notices.

Of course she notices.

Her expression changes, just slightly.

I cover my face with one hand.

“Oh, fuck you.”

“That seems to be the direction of travel.”

I start laughing and then her fingers move over my clit and the laugh breaks into something else.

The heat in my face stops mattering when she moves again.

Her mouth against my breast. Her thigh warm against mine. The rasp of her breathing near my ear. Her fingers learning what makes me tense and what makes me open, not with the efficient precision she uses teaching shield work, but with patience and curiosity and obvious pleasure in the fact that I am losing mine.

When I grab her wrist, she stops immediately.

“Too much?”

“No.” I am breathing like I have run uphill. “Don’t stop. Just... stay there.”

She does.

The pressure builds slowly enough that I feel every part of it. My body gathers around her hand. My thoughts finally stop skittering. I can feel her hand, her mouth at my breast, the sheet twisted in my fist, and I don’t have to do anything except stay with it.

I come with my face turned into her neck, biting down on a sound that escapes anyway.

For a few seconds I cannot remember what language I speak.

Sella strokes my hair.

I lift my head.

She looks unbearably pleased with herself.

“That expression is going to become a problem.”

“I can live with that.”

I push her onto her back.

Her eyebrows rise.

“What?”

“Apparently I have range.”

She laughs once, then stops when I kiss down the center of her chest.

I take my time because she did.

Because I want to know her when she is not holding a shield, making a decision, giving up a road, or pretending the lost deposit does not matter. I want the ordinary soft places, the sounds she tries not to make, the way her stomach tightens when my mouth moves lower.

When I kiss the inside of her thigh, her hand catches in my hair.

Not pulling.

Just there.

I look up.

“Sella?”

“Yes.”

The word comes rougher than mine did.

I smile against her skin and keep going.

The first taste of her makes something hot and startled twist through me. Then her hips lift into my mouth, and I stop trying to notice anything except what makes her do it again.

I learn her badly at first, then better. Her hand tightens in my hair when my tongue finds the place that makes her hips lift. I stay there. She says my name once, sharp enough that I feel it in my chest, and again when she comes.

Afterward I crawl up beside her and discover that smugness is much easier to recognize from the inside.

“You’re staring,” she says.

“You were staring first.”

“I was checking your shoulder.”

“Liar.”

“Some.”

I kiss her.

The room smells like lamp oil, skin, and the faint soap from her arms. My shoulder gives its familiar ache; Sella notices and pulls the pillow higher without comment.

I wake later when she moves her arm from beneath my head. The lamp has burned low. She sits on the edge of the bed, feeling for her shirt with one foot.

“You can stay,” I say.

“I need to piss.”

“Oh.”

She finds the shirt and pulls it on. I turn my face into the pillow, listening to her bare feet on the boards. When she comes back, she puts the latch down and gets into bed beside me.

For a while I lie with my hand on her arm. I want to ask whether she will still go east. I can feel how much I would hate being asked about the gray door right now.

“Wake me before you leave,” I say.

She touches my wrist. “I will.”

Before sleep takes me again, I hear the small metal sound of her belt being set beside mine.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The saw reaches Iven before breakfast.

He has freed the bed-frame strip during the night. It stretches over the missing stair, trembling as he lowers its hooked end toward the packet on the lower stub. Harra has carried the packet through on the fork. A light cord still connects it to the rod.

I stand at the second viewing glass with Sella behind me. I can feel the warmth of her shoulder without touching it. An hour ago she woke me with a hand against my cheek. Now neither of us can look away from Iven's hook.

It catches.

He lifts the packet clear of the stone and draws it toward him, inch by inch. Mara has both hands over her mouth. When it reaches his side, he lays the strip down and unties the cloth.

A short metal saw. A needle. Clean linen. A letter folded small enough to fit beneath the blade.

He opens the letter first.

"Slack," Dain says. Harra feeds a little more cord through while we wait.

Iven reads with his head bent. Then he wipes his face on his sleeve, puts the letter inside his shirt, and holds the saw up for us to see.

Mara lowers her hands. "Tell him to keep the linen dry."

I start writing. My letters are clumsy enough that she takes the chalk and does it herself.

—○—

He has something to show us.

A board beside the gray door comes loose under his hand. It takes me a moment to understand where it was: the pale patch I had taken for wall, partly hidden by the rail. A nailed cover. He wedges the saw behind the next plank and works it until an end lifts.

Light enters the landing.

Daylight. So much that the EXIT sign fades above his head.

I lean into the hood. Harra tells me to move back, and I do, but only far enough to stop breathing on the glass.

Iven angles his mirror toward the uncovered window.

There are trees beyond it. Far below. Blue-black leaves, pale trunks. Beyond them a black cliff drops into water. Three white towers descend its face, each lower than the last, linked by something too thin to be a road.

I wait for a car, a power line, anything I can force into something I know.

The larger moon hangs above the cliff, faint in the morning sky. Its smaller companion is higher up. The same two I watched from the pantry roof.

I close one eye. The image is still there when I open it.

"Describe it," Dain says.

I can't.

Sella bends to the other glass. She begins with the towers. Her voice is uncertain; she asks Harra to move the angle once, then names the trees.

Oret is at the door. He has come for Dain, staff in hand, impatient to get to the field trial. At the word *towers* he stops.

"Let me see."

Harra makes room. He looks, straightens, and looks again.

"Fallow Reach," he says.

Dain pushes past him. "The south lift?"

"Below it. Those are the old balance towers."

They exchange a place name I haven't heard, then the name of a road. I watch Dain's finger follow the cliff in the reflection.

"How far?" I ask.

"Nine days by cart to the upper works," Oret says. "Longer since the bridge went. The lower station's been shut for years."

"The rooms?"

"I've never been inside."

"Then how do you know?"

He looks at me. I hear how loud I was.

"I laid pipe above those towers when I was an apprentice."

I turn to the mirror again. Two moons. Pale trees. Iven holds up a slate, but I keep looking past it at the sky.

His next message says he found a name cut in the stone behind the boards. Fallow Reach. He has copied it beneath the drawing of a gate. Local writing, old enough that Dain asks Mara to check one letter.

The gray door stands in front of it. Someone fitted an Earth door into this place and hung an Earth sign above it. I don't know who or how.

I know my mother is not behind it.

Sella touches my sleeve. I pull away before I can stop myself.

"Sorry."

She takes her hand back. I can't bear her being careful with me either.

Mara is writing. Her brother still needs help. I move out of the doorway so Oret can carry the location to Pell.

—○—

There may be a way down from the old lift. Oret doesn't know whether it survived the slide that took the bridge. Pell sends a letter with the house carrier, asking the upper works for an immediate reply. Even a fast answer will take days.

Iven has tried the doors away from the landing. One opens onto fallen stone. Another won't move in its frame. He can get to the upper rooms and a tank feeding the tap. The water line in the tank has fallen below an old stain.

"How much?" Dain asks.

I write the question while Mara sketches a measuring stick. Iven copies it. He will measure the tank, look for another exit, keep clear of the broken rail.

The little saw lies beside his foot. I look at it instead of the window.

Then the bright strip narrows.

Harra draws the fork back. The delivery cord trails from it, still tied to the wrapping on Iven's side. I start to tell him to free the knot, but he has seen the movement and reaches for it himself.

"Tell him to leave it," Dain says.

Mara raises the slate. Iven backs away, the cord loose on the stone between us.

The dark edge meets the linen.

Our end falls.

Nothing pulls it. It simply drops, the far end curling against Iven's boot. He stares down. So do I.

Harra brings the fork in. A few inches of cord remain tied to it, the end cut at a slant. Dain puts a finger against the cut, then takes it away.

Elena pulled back a shorter rope.

I look at Mara. She has not moved from the glass.

"We saw it," Dain says to her.

She nods once.

We send the stop message before the strip closes. Iven lifts his hand to acknowledge. Then the window, the door, the towers and her brother disappear together.

Harra lays the severed cord beside the tested washer.

—○—

Bera walks past her own gate without looking through it.

I look. There are rows under the water, visible as darker stripes where plants used to be. A bucket floats against a fencepost. Beyond it a child's red stocking hangs from a line with its toe almost touching the flood.

"Don't step left," she says.

I return my attention to the path. My boot was about to go exactly there.

"The grass holds the top," she says. "Nothing under it."

Three reserve. One Brace and one Stepguard. I count them as we leave the road, pushing away the severed cord whenever it returns.

Sella catches up beside the last fence.

"You can stay in the yard."

"I know."

"You haven't said anything since the gallery."

"I want to work."

She looks at me, then at the shield. "Keep your eyes here, then. On what we're doing."

I tighten the strap and follow her onto the track.

My wool skirt is tied clear of my boots. It feels ridiculous until Harra knots her own hem higher. She carries the tools. I carry a narrow end frame for the screen with my right hand, letting the shield rest against my left hip while we walk.

Ahead, Tolliver raises a hand.

We stop. Sella steps past me without touching my shoulder, moving toward him along the center of the old barrow track. Beyond them the willows grow crooked out of a low bank. The water beneath is almost black.

"Tracks?" Harra asks.

"Movement," he says.

He points with two fingers. Something makes a low seam through the water, then disappears beneath a shelf of roots.

I remember claws on the cart rail and grip the screen handle until it hurts.

Sella looks back at us. "Stay on the boards when they're down."

No one needs to explain what the boards are for again.

The wash channel looks too small to matter.

It runs between steep banks toward a mouth of old stone, water slipping through a gap at the bottom. A willow root has lifted one corner of the top slab. Mud fills the rest. Downstream, where Oret and a house worker wait, the channel widens toward the mill tailrace.

Dain stands at the field collector above us. Four workers have stacked clay sacks and a spare screen section beside a stop board fitted into a temporary timber frame. The little trial notch will connect the collector to the abandoned channel. It is narrower than my shoulders. Nobody is opening the whole bank today.

Harra has us lay the two screen sections downstream of the notch, making a short barrier between the work ledge and the willow pool. Water can pass through the closely spaced bars. A reed-jack should have to go around them, where the guards will be waiting.

Should.

Sella watches me watching the roots.

“Your place is here,” she says, putting her boot on the packing board behind my end of the frame. “Harra moves that section, you keep the overlap. If you have to leave, call it and go uphill. Renn covers the opening.”

Renn, the house guard, lifts his spear in acknowledgment. He has a broad nose, a gray mustache and a very comforting lack of interest in whether I look impressive.

Harra takes my right hand off the frame and places it lower.

“Lift from here. Your shield stays between the gap and your face.”

“Here?”

“Yes. Lower if it pulls.”

Her tone is ordinary. I borrow what I can.

Tolliver takes the upper willow bank with his bow. Sella guards the downstream end. Bera has shown the workers the safe track and now waits beyond the clay sacks, where she can point out a change without being inside it.

Dain calls to Oret.

A raised arm comes back from the tailrace. Clear.

Harra settles her pry bar under the clotted edge of the notch. I plant my boots, bring the shield close and look at the place where her section overlaps mine.

“Ready,” I say.

It surprises me to discover that I am.

—○—

The first water is brown and slow, a thin tongue pushing dead leaves ahead of it. Harra works a knot of roots loose. I lift my end of the screen while she shifts hers into the next slot, then lower it again when the overlap is restored.

Nothing powered. Just work.

She nods once without taking her eyes off the bar.

The little stream reaches the old masonry throat, pauses behind the packed silt, and begins to rise. I can see Oret through the gap between two workers. He has one hand on a measuring staff downstream and the other raised to tell Dain to wait.

Dain waits.

A minute passes. My left forearm starts to ache, so I lower my elbow without moving the screen.

Then the mud beneath the throat puckers and lets go.

Water pours out around Oret's staff. He steps back, raises his arm higher, and calls something I can't hear over the sudden rush. The worker beside him repeats it uphill.

"Fall holds!"

Dain grins.

Bera walks as close as the sacks allow, staring at the channel. She says something to the man beside her, and he bends to watch the mark on the collector staff. Even this small opening is beginning to move it.

"Hold that draw," Dain calls. "No wider."

Harra changes her grip on the pry bar. One root remains across the notch, catching everything the water brings. She doesn't need to take it all out. She needs the screen moved a hand's width so she can cut the part above the flow.

I check my footing. The board is firm. Renn stands beyond my right shoulder, spear facing the willow pool.

"Your end first," Harra says.

I lift.

The scream from downstream is animal, high and horrible.

Something erupts out of the roots beside Sella.

—○—

The first reed-jack lands against her shield with its whole body.

She was already turning. The impact drives her back one step on the boards, then she catches its head beneath the rim and pushes it down. Tolliver's bow sounds from the upper bank. An arrow hits the water beyond her.

"Too close," he calls.

"Hold your shot!"

The animal twists. It is larger than the one on the cart, wet fur hanging in ropes, front claws hooked around the shield edge. Sella keeps it away from her sword arm, working for a space to strike.

I turn my head. My screen tilts.

"Maya," Harra says.

I pull my attention back just as the second reed-jack hits my section from the pool.

The frame slams against the shield. My right hand loses the handle. A mouth opens between two bars, teeth scraping iron, and the pressure drives straight up my left arm.

[REED-JACK, LV. 6]

I see the plate without wanting it. I set my boots against the raised back edge of the packing and reach for Brace.

One point.

The shield holds. The frame knocks once against its face, but the load runs through my arm instead of folding it. Harra drags her hand clear of the overlap. Renn's spear comes past my right side, aimed between the bars.

I know he is there. I don't flinch this time.

One breath.

The point catches fur along the shoulder. The reed-jack lets go with its mouth and pulls sideways, dragging the screen toward the deeper pool.

"Don't follow," Harra says.

I don't. I keep the shield in the line I chose, and Renn drives the spear again. The animal drops beneath the water.

Two breaths.

Harra gets her section down. I end the hold while I still have the shape, then use my right hand to seat my end in its slot.

"Clear my side," I call.

My voice works through the blood in my ears.

Downstream, Sella has the first animal on the bank. Her sword goes in beneath its jaw. Its hind legs beat against the board twice before stopping.

Tolliver has another arrow drawn. He isn't watching her victory. His gaze is on the root shelf beside my feet.

“The other one’s under you,” he says.

The board tilts.

—○—

At first I think the animal lifted it. Then a line opens in the mud beyond Harra’s boot. Water rises through it, carrying pale sand, and the whole lower edge of our ledge moves toward the notch.

“Ground!” I shout.

Dain orders the stop board down. The men above haul on its handles. It drops partway and catches on the root Harra hasn’t yet cut.

Water continues through.

Harra pulls her bar free and steps uphill. I should follow. But my screen leans out over the pool and I still have my hand on it, as though being assigned the frame made it part of my body.

“Maya, leave it.”

I let go.

The frame slides, hanging by one upper pin. Renn shifts uphill to cover us. Beneath the tilted board a narrow head rises, whiskers pasted flat, the spear scratch bright through its fur.

My way back is one short step to the next packing board. Harra has just crossed it. There is no room to turn without giving the mouth my back.

I set the shield facing downhill, choose that step, and commit the two points I have left.

Stepguard catches.

For one breath I move exactly as Sella taught me. Shield facing the animal, one foot on the old board, the other reaching uphill. The reed-jack jumps. Its weight lands against the lower rim, and the pattern carries it through me while I shift uphill.

My left boot settles.

The board breaks through the ground beneath it.

There is nothing to pass the weight into. The hold breaks. My left ankle rolls into the hidden hollow and the shield twists hard enough that a metal edge screams against stone.

Pain flashes up the outside of my leg. I fall to one knee with the animal still against me.

Harra catches the back of my tunic.

“Let the shield turn!”

I let my elbow bend. The rim scrapes across my boot as Renn puts his spear between the animal and my face. Its teeth snap closed on the green wood. A piece tears loose.

There is no reserve. I don't waste another second searching.

"Pin it there!" I yell.

Renn leans in. I pull my arm out of the loosest strap while Harra hauls me uphill. My ankle hits the edge of the hole and I make a sound I would like never to hear from myself again.

The reed-jack lands where I was kneeling.

Sella's boot comes down on the fallen screen, flattening it across the gap. She meets the animal above my discarded shield with her own. It has nowhere to climb. Her sword hits once, catches, comes free, hits again.

Harra keeps pulling until my hips are on the sound track.

I can see Dain above us, bent over the stop frame. The root is still jammed beneath the board. Water eats at the side of the notch, digging toward the worker beside him.

"The screen," I say. Harra can't hear. I grab her sleeve. "Flat. Across the soft bit. Put the sack on it."

She follows my pointing hand. The spare screen section lies beside the clay sacks, wide enough to spread the weight. She shouts to the workers. Two of them lay it over the crumbling edge and slide a sack across it, keeping their own boots back. Another sack follows. The water folds around them instead of stripping the side bank.

Dain levers the trapped root upward. Harra reaches him, cuts the exposed strand with her hooked blade, and the board drops the last few inches.

The rush fades.

I watch until the water stops eating the mud. Then I look at my foot.

—○—

Nobody has been bitten.

Sella makes each of us say it and checks the people whose answers come too fast. Renn has a shallow cut where a splinter came through his sleeve. Harra has mud across her face and a strip of my tunic clenched in one fist.

"I may owe you a hem," she says.

"You can keep that bit."

She opens her fingers. The cloth hangs from the seam. We laugh, briefly and badly, then stop when my ankle protests.

Sella kneels in front of me. I watch her unfasten the boot and ease it off onto the mud beside us. She works gently enough that I know she thinks it might be worse than I want it to be.

"Can you feel this?"

“Yes.”

“This?”

“Yes. Fuck.”

“All right.”

She doesn’t tell me it is fine. She lifts the foot onto a folded coat and calls for a cart from the field gate.

My shield lies beside her. The lower rim has peeled away for the length of my hand. The bite tore a chunk out of the wood below it, tearing through the painted bird.

A torn strap hangs from the handle.

I reach for it.

Sella puts it within my hand without making me ask again.

“You kept the facing,” she says.

“The ground went.”

“Yes.”

“I thought because Harra had—”

“I know.”

She looks toward the hole. Water is draining out of it through the undercut bank. The board had carried one quick footfall; mine arrived with my weight and an animal on the shield. I can see the difference now. Expensive lesson.

“The first hold worked,” she says. “Renn had a place to put the spear.”

I remember breaking Brace on the road when the blade came past. Today I knew where Renn was.

I hold that memory while the ankle throbs.

Tolliver comes down from the willow bank with his bow unstrung. He has checked farther than I could see. Two animals, no more movement found. He doesn’t make that a promise about everything in the reeds.

He crouches beside me and puts his hand on the back of my neck. I lean into it without pretending to need help sitting up.

“Your arrow missed,” I say.

“Better than hitting Sella.”

“Yes.”

He looks at the bare ankle, then at Sella. “Can she ride?”

“With the foot up.”

He goes to help bring the cart down the track. I watch him clear the boards before he lets the driver move.

—○—

Oret brings the downstream staff before they lift me.

A wet mark stands well above his first notch. He has measured both the rise and how quickly it drained once Dain closed the cut. Ordinary water, with enough fall to move it through a separate route. The mill tailrace took the trial without backing up.

Dain puts the staff beside Tolliver's drawing. "It works."

"Provided that stays up," Oret says.

We all look at the old masonry throat.

The draw has washed mud from beneath the upper slab, exposing a crack that runs nearly through it. Its lower corner sits on roots. Dain wets his fingers and presses them against the exposed stone. He stays there long enough that I wonder whether he is waiting for something.

"Flow underneath," he says at last, taking his hand away. "Through the roots."

Enough water to drain the fields would scour those roots out. The slab would drop across the outlet, trapping the water again or breaking the remaining wall downstream.

"We couldn't see that yesterday," Tolliver says.

"We can today," Dain answers.

Bera comes down the track, keeping clear of the torn ledge. She has brought my abandoned screen handle, though it isn't mine and I have no idea what she thinks I can do with it.

"How much?" she asks.

"To shore and lift?" Oret looks at Harra. Harra looks at the slab.

"Long legs," she says. "Chain block. The little house tackle won't take it from this bank."

Rusk's hook appears in my head, enormous and patiently priced.

Bera pushes the handle into the dirt beside the track as a marker for where the ground is bad.

"The far bed showed," she says to me. "For a little. Before you shut it."

I look toward her field. From here I can't see the rows.

"Will it help?"

"If you keep it going after you fix this." She touches the rotted roots caught in the screen. "These won't come back. But I could put something else there."

She isn't thanking me for saving her farm. We haven't. Her next sentence is about how many boards the damaged barrow track will need, and Dain writes the number on his plan.

Then she bends, picks my boot out of the mud and puts it in the cart beside me.

"Keep the other one on," she says. "Road's not getting kinder."

—○—

The ride back is worse than Greyward.

The cart has no springs. Every rut jars the ankle no matter how carefully I arrange the folded coat under it. Sella walks beside the cart, and I can tell from the way she lets silence sit that she is exhausted too.

I open the measure when the road smooths enough to hold a thought.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 3]

[PROGRESS: 9 / 18]

[RESERVE: 0 / 5]

[RUN: WARDER]

Halfway to the next level. The zero does not swallow that. The Brace held long enough for Renn to use his spear. When I shut my eyes I can still feel that impact, the moment the pressure found the ground through me.

I want to do it again better.

The thought arrives so clearly I almost laugh. My ankle is swelling and I want another chance. I look at the number again.

At the gate Sella leans on the cart rail.

“What?”

“Nine of eighteen.”

Her mouth curves. “Look at you.”

I grin up at her.

She kisses my forehead before helping me sit up. I don’t care who sees it.

—○—

The house mender wraps the ankle after examining it and making me move my toes several times.

She finds no sign of a broken bone. When I ask whether she can close the injury the way the Greyward mender closed my cut, she has me try to turn the foot.

Pain stops me halfway.

“Skin I can join,” she says. “This needs to hold your weight. Keep off it.”

Two days off rough ground before she examines it again. She folds a pad beneath the ankle and makes me leave it there.

Pell pays for the examination and the linen as a work expense. The ankle remains hot and swollen, and my reserve stays empty.

Harra removes the bent strip from the shield before it can cut me. The wood needs a patch and a new length of rim. Pell agrees to cover that too, but Harra needs the shield until tomorrow. I make myself hand it over.

The clerk brings my day's pay before the mender leaves. I put the coins away without counting them.



They hold the discussion at the kitchen table so I can keep my foot up on a bench.

I suspect Sella arranged it. She denies nothing and steals half my bread while Dain pins the new drawing to a board.

Pell listens to the report. The independent route has enough fall. The throat needs lifting and rebuilding before a sustained draw. The damaged work ledge needs proper decking. No further trial tomorrow.

Oret places the wet staff beneath the drawing. He has carried it all the way back, proof that doesn't require anyone to trust how excited Dain sounded.

Rusk comes in with her gloves tucked through her belt.

She has finished the third day's redirected work. The outer bank is shored, the upper carrier cleared as ordered. Her crew is paid for that portion, and from tomorrow the rig costs standing time.

Harra shows her the exposed slab dimensions.

Rusk studies them. "I can lift it."

"Price?" Pell asks.

"A piece per crew member per day. Two for me and the rig. Materials yours. Minimum two days."

Sixteen pieces. Pell has six left. I watch her look toward Vey.

"Six now," Pell says. "Ten when the lift is finished."

"From where?"

Pell lays her hands on the table. The nails are dark with mud from the field. "The mill account."

"Your mill account isn't paid until the grain comes in."

Vey turns one of the coins in his purse. I can hear it striking another.

"My winter stock," he says.

Pell looks up.

"Two sealed bales in the north store. Mine, not the house's. You can have a lien to ten pieces."

Rusk pulls out a chair and sits.

"Cloth?"

"Dyed wool. The invoice is in my room."

"I'll inspect it."

"You'll break the seals in front of me. And if the house repays you, the claim ends."

Pell starts to speak. He cuts her off.

"I know you can't promise when."

She closes her mouth. For a moment I see how tired he is. He already paid for the first tests; now this could take the stock he meant to sell through winter.

Rusk checks the invoice and goes with Vey to inspect the bales. Pell sends the clerk for the six pieces. When the captain returns, a tuft of blue wool is caught on her cuff.

Mara reads the new paper aloud: two days to shore and lift the drainage throat, materials supplied by Rook, with no custody or exclusive access. The old iron claim remains disputed; this payment does not settle it.

Rusk counts the deposit into her purse. Vey signs against his bales. Pell signs beneath him.

"First light," the captain says to Harra. "I want the packing down before we move the legs."

Harra takes the drawing outside. Through the window I watch the apprentice unlock the chain chest and lift out the handle.

We have bought two days of work. The hook is coming out of the fenced rack.

—○—

After supper, Tolliver and Sella help me upstairs. I keep my weight off the bad foot, an arm around each of them, and discover how much staircase I have been taking for granted.

Tolliver pauses at the door when Sella goes for water.

"I heard about the window," he says.

I nod. I have avoided thinking about it since the cart ride.

"I'm sorry."

"I don't want to talk about it."

"All right."

But he stays. I look at his hand on the doorframe.

"Did you sign hers?"

"No."

"For me?"

He shakes his head. "I asked who owned the wagon. She wouldn't put the name in the paper."

I wait. There must be something else.

“That’s all,” he says.

I want to thank him, and know he would hate it. Instead I ask him to bring my sack closer to the bed. He sets it within reach and sits on the edge while I find the Earth shirt.

It is clean enough now. The letters have cracked where I scrubbed the mud out. I put it across my knees.

“She won’t be there,” I say.

He knows who I mean. He doesn’t answer.

“I was going to tell her I hadn’t done anything stupid.”

A laugh escapes me, hurts, and turns into something else. I press the shirt to my face before Sella comes back.

Tolliver stays until I can breathe. When she appears in the doorway, he stands and goes past her. They exchange a few words too low for me to hear. She sets the water on the table and sits on the floor beside the bed.

For a while I tell her about the board breaking. Then she tells me how the first reed-jack nearly took her sword, and I realize I hadn’t asked whether she was hurt.

“Are you?”

“Bruised. Nothing torn.”

I look at the sleeve covering her arm. This morning I knew the shape of the skin beneath it. Tonight there will be marks I haven’t seen.

Outside, Rusk’s crew are moving timber into the yard for tomorrow. Somebody calls a warning, and a heavy load settles onto boards. After that I can hear the mill again.

“I still want to go east,” Sella says.

I stare at the shirt on my knees. She waits.

“After Iven?” I ask.

“After this job. I can’t keep turning down work.”

I want a promise she hasn’t made. I want to be well enough to pack a bag and walk beside her. My foot throbs.

“Bring me the fares,” I say. “When you ask.”

She looks up at me. “You mean it?”

“I want to see what it costs.”

She nods. No smile yet. I move the shirt off my knees and fold it before setting it beside the bed.

Sella lays her hand palm-up on the blanket.

I take it and keep talking.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Harra brings my shield back before breakfast, and the green paint is gone from the lower corner.

She has cut away the splintered wood, let in a darker patch, and wrapped the new rim around it with three small rivets. The bird that somebody painted and painted over and wore through now looks as though something bit off its tail and got answered with iron.

I love it more.

"You're not using it today," she says.

"I know."

"You looked at the strap."

"I was appreciating the strap."

"You were measuring whether you could get your arm through it." She carries the shield past me and sets it against the wall beyond reach, which tells me exactly how much my face gives away before I have said anything at all.

My ankle turned the color of bad plums overnight. The swelling has gone down, which somehow makes the skin look worse, and the mender has already been in to press each bone with an enthusiasm I have decided to take personally. Flat floors. Foot up when I can. No yard, no gallery stairs, no training, and no clever interpretation of the word *flat*.

I am allowed to work. That matters more than I expected it to.

—○—

The last paid day of my agreement begins at the west kitchen table, which fills up around me while I sit with my leg on a bench like a piece of furniture nobody can move. Mara brings Iven's copied marks. Dain brings three sheets of measurements and puts his cup down on the corner of them. Harra brings the severed cord, two washers, the fork head, and a wooden box of things she is willing to lose.

Pell brings Rusk, who does not sit.

"Your six are on the north field," Pell says. "You told me you needed Harra after the packing was down."

"After midday."

"Then I need the rig terms after tomorrow."

Rusk looks at the papers instead of Pell. "My terms were departure or standing time."

"Tomorrow finishes the minimum," Pell says. "After that, I need the shear legs here."

"Then you need money."

Rusk smiles without warmth. I look at the empty place where Vey usually sits. The ten pieces against his wool fall due when the lift is finished, and beyond that the house has promised nobody anything.

Dain slides the boundary sheet across to me before I can finish assembling a debt I do not own.

"Tell me what you see."

Three columns. Time at our chamber, width at the sleeve glass, outlet pulse at the old junction. Not enough rows under any of them.

"Coincidence," I say.

"Maybe."

"Or we're measuring the wrong thing."

Mara sits down opposite me and unwraps a piece of bread. "You wanted both ends."

I did. I look at the messenger strip measurements again, because we have described the same distance about nine different ways and none of them has told us anything. Iven can reach the lower stub with the crosspiece off his bed frame. Our probe can touch the near sill. Between those two facts sits a gap we keep taking the temperature of instead of crossing.

"What can we send that doesn't matter?"

Harra opens the box.

A chalked wooden slat. A narrow copper strip. Two cords of different thickness. A wax tablet no bigger than my palm. Four clay tags drilled with holes. A child's tin cup with no handle.

"Why the cup?"

"Dain put it in."

"I thought it would roll," Dain says.

"That is not a virtue."

"It is if we want to know whether the floor slopes."

Harra looks at me. I look at Dain. He shrugs and says the cup was already dented, and for the first time since the window opened on Fallow Reach I laugh, which fixes nothing at all but makes the room easier to sit

inside.

—○—

Being barred from the gallery turns out not to make me essential to it. Mara reads Iven's slate, Dain records width, Harra works the instrument, Oret watches the outlet pulse, and Tolliver calls the collector level. Renn carries the slips between them with the cheerfulness of a man whose job involves stairs instead of judgment. Sella fills whatever gap is left while making certain nobody decides a test requires a hero.

My job is the table. I hate it until the first numbers come down.

Renn puts Dain's slip beside Oret's. Boundary narrow, outlet low. Iven reports the gray door still visible, the uncovered window bright, no change in the tank since dawn. Tolliver's note follows: collector high by two finger-widths after the night rain. I set the three slips side by side and lean closer.

"Again," I tell Renn.

He grins. "You know I don't control it."

"Tell them I said again with conviction."

The next interval is wider. Oret records a pulse at the outlet shortly before the change, and Tolliver's collector mark falls *after* Dain's width begins increasing rather than before it, which should help and does not. I draw arrows. I cross two of them out. Mara leans over my shoulder and asks what I expected.

"Something rude enough to be obvious."

"Mechanisms rarely care what you deserve."

"That sounds like something Vey says."

"He says it with worse posture."

—○—

At midday Harra puts the chalked slat on the probe and advances it to the edge. Dain records the extension. During a wider interval, the same reach carries more of the slat into Iven's view.

That settles one argument. The opening is not a fixed doorway we are failing to measure correctly; the connection itself moves.

I knew that yesterday in the way you know something after watching a cord fall in two pieces. Seeing it in Dain's columns makes my stomach tighten anyway.

"Next test," I say.

—○—

The lift begins while we are still measuring. I hear it through the kitchen wall before I see anything of it: timber knocking timber, shouted counts, the long metallic complaint of Rusk's chain taking weight.

Bera sends her eldest girl up to the house with a strip of blue cloth tied around a stick. The girl plants it on the table beside my papers like a surveyor claiming ground.

"What's that?"

"Water mark. Mam says tell Master Dain the third furrow showed."

"Today?"

"This morning."

The drainage route is still closed. Whatever we did in one trial draw before a reed-jack put me on the ground has taken enough water out of that field to uncover a third row.

The girl looks at my ankle, and then tries very hard not to look at my ankle.

"Reed-jack did that?"

"The ground did most of it."

Her disappointment arrives instantly and without disguise.

"Sorry," I say.

"I know. Less exciting."

She thinks about that for a moment, then allows, "Still counts," and goes back down the yard at a speed I resent.

I put the cloth marker beside the boundary sheets. It does not belong in the measurements. That is why I leave it there. The numbers have been getting easier to care about than Bera's drowned rows.

—○—

By afternoon we have three widenings and two narrowings, enough to kill the idea that time of day predicts anything. The widest interval comes first; the third arrives later and closes faster.

Oret's outlet readings are more useful. Each widening follows a pressure change in the loaded old works, but the delay shifts, and the boundary keeps opening after the pulse peaks before beginning to contract while the outlet is still falling.

"Hysteresis," I say.

Mara stares at me.

"It means the thing remembers being pushed."

"Things don't remember."

"Fine. It reacts differently going up than coming down."

“That I believe.”

I write it without the word. A rising threshold and a falling threshold, different, maybe. The important part is uglier than the vocabulary: a clock cannot save anyone here, and neither can waiting for the same minute tomorrow.

—○—

The copper-strip test gives us measurements from both sides without ever spanning the boundary. Harra advances her notched strip from Rook; later Iven uses his bed-frame messenger and landing stones to give us a second reference.

When Oret comes in after dusk with mud to the elbows, Dain lays his remembered Fallow Reach service floor over the plan built from Iven’s measurements. The stair turns the right way. The wall thickness matches. The dead side passage sits where Oret remembers a pressure room, and the gray door occupies a freight opening from the old plan.

Somebody changed it. Somebody carried pieces of my world into an abandoned works station nine days from here and fitted them into a wall.

But the station is here. This world. I trace the two moons Iven drew beside his window and wait for that fact to hurt harder than it does.

Mostly I want to know who put the fucking EXIT sign there.

—○—

“Last one,” Harra calls down from the upper landing when Renn brings her note.

The interval has begun widening again and Iven is ready. We have agreed on the wax tablet, because if the edge cuts it, wax will hold the shape of the cut better than cord did.

Every hand and body stays outside the marked danger distance. Harra advances the wax tablet until Iven can see part of it, then holds the fork fixed while the opening widens across it.

When contraction begins, she withdraws by the agreed increments. The tablet survives the first two. On the third, the edge catches it. Our half drops to the chamber floor and Iven’s lands on his side, divided on a clean diagonal without pull or twist.

Harra had drilled a tiny hole near the center and filled it with black pigment.

The cut passes through the hole. We know exactly where it fell, to within the width of a nail.

The room goes quiet enough that I can hear the mill. Then Iven raises his half to the glass, where he has scratched one word into the wax with the point of the needle we sent him.

ENOUGH.

Mara laughs first. Her brother is still there and still opinionated enough to tell us when to stop. She presses both hands over her face and says the word back to him, and Dain sends the stop board.

—○—

Rusk comes into the kitchen after dark with a broken root in one hand and drops it on the table. It is thicker than my wrist and black through the middle.

“Your throat was sitting on that.”

“Was?” Pell asks.

“Slab’s hanging from my tackle now. Packing’s in. We set the first new support before the light went.”

“Tomorrow?”

“Lift, rebuild, deck. If the stone behaves.”

“If it doesn’t?”

“Then it becomes three days.”

Pell’s jaw tightens, and Rusk pulls out Vey’s paper and lays it flat with two fingers, unhurried, the way you put down a card you have been holding since the deal.

“Your wool covers ten pieces. Tomorrow is already inside that price. A third day is eight more.”

“I heard you the first time.”

“I like hearing myself twice.”

Then she looks at me, and Pell looks at me, and I put my pencil down because I know what is coming.

“Your agreement ends tonight,” Pell says.

“I know.”

“Two more days. Same rate, same terms. Copy work and contact. No field duty.”

“Return cart?”

Pell gives me a look that lasts long enough to become an answer on its own. “You have nowhere you’re returning to.”

Greyward. The word has changed shape while I was not watching it, and I have to sit with that for a second before I can make my mouth work.

“Still in writing.”

“Still in writing.” Mara is already pulling a fresh page toward herself.

Pell offers Sella and Tolliver the same extension. Tolliver asks what happens after.

Pell looks at Rusk, and Rusk picks the root off the table again. "After, I leave unless somebody hires me."

Tolliver nods once. Sella says, "Two days," and I turn my head toward her fast enough that she catches me at it.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Liar."

"I'm allowed to enjoy two days."

She pushes off the hearth and comes to stand beside my chair, and her fingers brush the back of my neck on the way past. Tolliver looks away. Not angrily, which almost makes it harder.

—○—

The clerk pays today's eight bits separately because the extension begins tomorrow and Mara refuses to let two agreements blur together. I sign the new paper before bed: Maya Szczepaniak. Two days. Sixteen bits total. No new crossing duty. My handwriting looks less like a ransom note than it did a week ago.

Upstairs I open the measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 3]

[PROGRESS: 9 / 18]

[RESERVE: 2 / 5]

[RUN: WARDER]

Two points back. I do not spend them proving to an empty room that I can still stand, which may be maturity or may be fear of the mender, and either way I put my foot up on the blanket roll and leave them alone.

Sella brings the fare sheet and sits on the edge of the bed while I read the numbers. East road coach to Harrowgate. River packet beyond that. Cheaper if we walk part of it, more expensive if I insist on bringing a shield and whatever amount of shit I manage to accumulate by then.

"By then," I say.

She watches me. I tap the price with one finger, and she says, "I noticed," and neither of us builds anything on top of it.

Outside, chain links settle under load in the dark. Nine days from here, an abandoned station holds a man behind a boundary that cuts rope and wax without caring which side anybody stands on. It is not Earth, and knowing that still hurts.

The fare sheet is still in my hands.
I fold it once and put it with my own papers.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The fields begin draining before I am allowed anywhere near them. Not all of them, and not quickly, but enough that Bera comes into the kitchen with mud to her knees and puts a cabbage on the table in front of Pell.

It is a terrible cabbage. Yellow outer leaves, one side split open, a slug still attached to the stem. Pell looks at it the way you would look at a crown.

“First row above water,” Bera says. Then she turns to me. “You get none.”

“I didn’t ask.”

“You looked.”

“I was admiring it.”

“That’s what you said about the shield.”

At the far end of the table Harra makes a noise into her cup that she does not try very hard to disguise, and I understand that my crimes have become communal property. Bera takes the cabbage back and tells Pell she will be planting greens this afternoon if the lower furrows keep showing.

The drainage throat still hangs from Rusk’s chain. New stone supports stand under it, ugly and square against the older masonry, and Oret has the first sustained draw running at less than half the trial volume while the mortar takes load. The fields are not saved. But water is going where it is supposed to go, which feels suspiciously close to good news, and I have learned enough this week to hold good news carefully.

—○—

Late that morning the mender makes me walk the west passage with one hand on the wall. Six steps are fine. The seventh catches. The ankle is stiff and weak instead of sharp, which earns me exactly three indoor steps with a rail and another person beside me. Still no field, shield practice, or gallery stairs.

“I am waiting for the argument,” she says.

“I’ve developed character.”

“You’ve developed bruising.”

I take the three-step exception as a victory. Sella calls it permission to cross a room, and we disagree about scale for most of the afternoon.

—○—

The station tests continue without me climbing to the gallery. Iven measures his tank, and Dain refuses to turn the measurement into a prediction.

We know the tank dimensions, the current depth, and where the old stain sits. We do not know what he was drinking before he started marking, or whether the tank leaks, or refills, or feeds anything else in that building. So nobody tells Mara her brother has thirteen days of water, because thirteen days is a number we invented, and it is exactly the kind of number that gets a person killed by people trying to be kind.

We tell him the truth instead. LEVEL LOWER THAN OLD MARK. KEEP MEASURING.

YES, MOTHER.

Mara reads it twice before she puts the slate down. “He was forty when he started saying that.”

“Started?”

“Started saying it where I could hear.”

She writes: DRINK YOURS. DO NOT SAVE IT FOR US. His answer takes long enough that Renn has to make the trip twice, and when it comes it is only three words. I WILL DRINK. Mara does not smile. Neither do I.

—○—

At noon Rusk’s crew lowers the throat slab onto its new supports, one link of chain at a time, and everybody in the kitchen stops talking, because we cannot see the field from here and listening is all we have.

Nothing collapses.

Then Renn comes through the yard at a run to say that Oret wants another notch opened, and Pell is out of her chair before he finishes the sentence. Sella catches my eye across the table.

“No.”

“I didn’t move.”

“You thought loudly.”

I remain at the table. Ten minutes later the mill race changes pitch, which is a small thing and does not sound like anything at all unless you have spent a week learning the noise a wheel makes: a lower note underneath it, steady instead of pulsing. Dain comes in dripping sweat and

grinning like a man half his age.

“Full planned draw. Throat’s holding.”

Bera puts her cabbage back on the table, and this time she leaves it there.

—○—

Rusk gets paid at sunset.

The six pieces were already hers. Vey’s wool covers the other ten, and Pell’s clerk writes the lien release terms out a second time while the captain walks the finished draw with Oret. She comes back with mud on her boots and no expression at all.

“Good stone,” she says, which from her sounds indecently generous.

Vey signs over the two bales. Rusk signs that the drainage-lift obligation is complete and that repayment of ten pieces extinguishes her claim on the wool. Then she lays another paper beside it and says, “Standing tomorrow. Eight pieces.”

Pell does not touch it. “We don’t have eight.”

“I know.”

“Then you leave?”

“At first light unless hired.”

Harra leans against the wall with her arms crossed. “We still need the long block.”

“You need lots of things.”

“The rescue.”

“I’ve heard of it.”

Pell’s mouth tightens, and Rusk rolls the paper once between her hands, unhurried, like somebody who has had this conversation in a dozen yards and knows how long it takes.

“I’ll sell you the old lower block for three pieces.”

Harra straightens off the wall. “Sell?”

“Chain’s worn. Hook is good. Four to one. I was going to replace it in Greyward.”

“Three pieces is robbery.”

“Then enjoy being unrobbed.”

They argue about it for six minutes, and it is beautiful. For once the price is attached to iron: chain, hook, rust, a missing keeper. They settle at two pieces and four bits.

Twenty bits. Pell has almost nothing loose. I do.

I know that before anybody looks at me, and I hate the thought the moment I have it. My purse holds fifty-four bits from before the extension,

and today's eight makes sixty-two. The block would belong to Rook, not to me. It would help Iven, and it would still not be mine. I keep my mouth shut.

Vey does not.

"I will advance one piece."

Pell turns on him. "No."

"One piece. Not stock."

"You've done enough."

"Apparently not. The man remains behind a wall."

Mara places four bits on the table, and everyone looks at her, and she says, "What? He's my brother," in the voice of somebody daring the room to make it complicated. Pell closes her eyes. Harra puts down two. Dain puts down one. Renn, standing by the door with no stake in any of it, contributes one and immediately regrets it, because Rusk looks delighted.

"This is why I travel," the captain says. "Sentiment makes equipment liquid."

"Two pieces and four bits," Harra says. "Count it, or I'll start taking rust off the price."

By the end Pell pays eight bits from the house's free cash, Vey eight, Mara four, Harra two, Dain one, Renn one. Twenty-four. Rusk counts it and gives four back.

"Hook's missing a keeper."

Harra snatches the coins before she can reconsider. The block belongs to Rook. Rusk is still leaving before sunrise.

Pell looks happier about that than she did when the fields started draining.

—○—

Tolliver finds me in the pantry passage after supper, carrying the fare sheet and three copies of the station plan, because flat indoor walking has converted me into a clerk with ambitions.

He takes two of the sheets out of my hands.

"I can carry paper."

"I've seen you carry paper."

"Then this is trust."

He walks beside me, and for half the passage neither of us says anything, and then he says, "Rusk offered me the west road again."

I stop. He stops too.

"She named the wagon?"

"No. She named the missing man. Elian Vos."

The name means nothing to me. He watches my face anyway, long enough that I understand it is supposed to.

“Should it?”

“No. He hired me once. For finding his daughter.”

I lean against the wall, because I was told I could and because this has stopped being a hallway. “Did you?”

“Yes.”

“Alive?”

“Yes.”

“What happened?”

“She’d left him.” He looks down at the station pages in his hand rather than at me. “I found her in Kest. She was nineteen. He told me she’d been taken. She told me she’d run.”

The passage smells of flour and cooling stone, and I can hear somebody dragging a bench in the taproom below, and none of that is enough to fill the space where the next sentence is coming from.

“What did you do?”

“I told him where she was.”

My stomach hardens. He does not soften any part of it for me.

“He brought three men. She disappeared again before they arrived. I don’t know whether she knew I’d told him or whether somebody warned her.”

“You took his money.”

“Yes.”

“Did you know?”

“Not when I took it.”

“But before you told him.”

“Yes.”

I stare at him and he lets me do it, and the worst part is how much of the last ten days rearranges while I stand there. He decided where I would sleep because he thought he knew better. Rusk wanted custody in writing. He gave a father the location of a daughter who had run. My brain stacks the three together whether I want it to or not.

“That is why you wanted the wagon owner’s name.”

“Yes.”

“Because you finally learned not to deliver people to whoever pays.”

His jaw tightens. “Yes.”

It should feel good to hurt him with that sentence, and it does, a little, and nowhere near enough.

“Why tell me now?”

"Because you keep waiting for me to become safer without knowing the shape of what I've done."

"You don't get points for confessing after you already decided not to do it again."

"I know."

"And I don't forgive you for something that didn't happen to me."

"I know."

He hands the pages back. "I also know I want you to trust me."

"That isn't the same thing as deserving it."

"No."

I want to touch him badly enough that not doing it takes effort, and I don't, and that matters too. I tell him I will see him tomorrow, and he steps aside to let me past.

—○—

Sella is waiting at the three-step stair to the lower drying roof above the west kitchen, exactly where the mender said somebody had to be. Not the pantry roof where we sat with the onions between us. This one is three steps, a rail, and a door the mender has reluctantly approved.

She has two blankets, a bottle of watered wine, and the cabbage.

"You stole Bera's cabbage."

"Pell cooked it."

"That's less romantic."

"I brought salt."

"Recovered."

She has also brought the eastbound fares. The real ones, copied off the posting board in Greyward by a carrier who came in this afternoon. Harrowgate in six days by coach if the road is dry. Four days walking to the river cut, then packet east. Work caravans cheaper if guards are willing to sign for escort, and Sella knows two companies that may leave within a fortnight.

A fortnight has teeth. I sit with my bad foot stretched out under the blanket while she tears bread.

"When do you need an answer?"

"I don't."

"That's not true."

"It is. I need to decide whether I take a job. You need to decide whether you want to come."

"That sounds like an answer."

"It sounds like two."

She gives me half the bread. Out past the yard, Rusk's shear legs stand dark against the wall, already lashed for departure, and the new drainage channel runs beyond them toward fields I cannot see from here.

"I can't promise east," I say.

Her face does not change, so I keep going before I can pretend that sentence was enough. "I want to. I want to see it. I want to see the coast. I also want to get Iven out, and I want to know who built that station, and I don't know what happens with Tolliver."

"There it is."

"What?"

"The part you kept trying not to say."

She eats another piece of cabbage while I look at her.

"Do you want me to ask you to choose?"

"No."

"Good. I wasn't going to." Then, before the relief can finish arriving: "But I will not wait in Rook while you decide whether I'm temporary."

"You aren't."

"Then tell me what you can give me."

I look at our knees under the blanket. I have already answered this question three safer ways in my head, and every one of them is bullshit.

"The next two days. After that, if Iven isn't out, I stay until we get him or until the attempt becomes impossible."

She nods. "And if he is out?"

"Then I take a job that moves. Somewhere that isn't Greyward. Somewhere I choose."

"With me?"

"If your job still wants you."

"That's not what I asked."

I swallow. "Yes."

Her eyes close briefly. Her shoulders loosen on the breath she lets out. When she opens them I tell her I still don't know what any of it means about Tolliver, and she says she knows, and that she still wants east even if I don't come. I say okay. She says okay. We leave it there.

—○—

She kisses me before I can ruin it with another condition, and the difference this time is that there is no surprise anywhere in it.

I know the shape of her mouth now. I know she will laugh if I catch her lower lip, and that she likes my hand at the back of her neck, and that touching her ribs without warning will get me elbowed off a roof, all of

which I have decided to file as tactical knowledge. Her hand slides under the edge of my tunic and stops at my waist, and my whole body notices at once: the ankle, the cold coming up off the tiles, the rough blanket under my palm, her thumb against bare skin, somebody in the yard below arguing about axle grease. None of it makes the wanting any smaller.

She pulls back. "Room?"

I look at the three steps. "Very dangerous."

"I'll carry the wine."

"Hero."

—○—

By the time my door shuts, neither of us is pretending the wine mattered. I catch the front of her tunic before she can straighten from setting it on the table.

"Ankle," she says against my mouth.

"Attached."

"Maya."

"I'm standing on the other one."

She gives me the look, and I sit down on the bed, and she kisses me anyway.

There is less hesitation this time and not one bit less care, and I have learned the difference well enough to know which one I am getting. I know the shape of her under my hands and the places that are still new. I know she likes being kissed just below her ear, and that dragging my nails lightly down her back makes her go very still before she moves closer, and that she is ticklish behind one knee, which is information she should never have been allowed to acquire about me and has since weaponized.

Her hand slides beneath my tunic and I catch her wrist.

"Your side."

The bruises from the reed-jack have gone yellow at the edges. I saw them when the mender checked her, but that was different, practical proof that she took a hit and stayed standing. Now I touch one with two fingers and she watches my face while I do it.

"Does it hurt?"

"Not like that."

I leave my hand there anyway, and she covers it with hers, and for a moment neither of us moves. Then she lifts my fingers and kisses my palm. That hits harder than the hand under my tunic did, which is unfair enough that I pull her down with me.

She braces one knee on the mattress, keeps her weight clear of my ankle without making an announcement of it, and kisses me until my head is empty enough to stop planning tomorrow. Her mouth moves to my throat. My hands find her waist, and then lower, and she makes a quiet sound when I squeeze.

“There,” I say.

“Smug already.”

“Research.”

“Terrible methodology.”

I slide my hand beneath her waistband, and her next breath catches hard enough to stop mine. “Repeatable result,” I whisper, and kiss her before she can answer.

She is already wet, and knowing she wants me still lands with absurd force every single time, as though my body refuses to file it as established fact. My fingers move over her clit and her forehead drops to my shoulder.

“Careful,” I murmur.

“With what?”

“My shoulder.”

She lifts her head and stares at me, and I grin, and her eyes narrow, and then she takes my hand away, pushes me gently back into the pillows, and kisses down my stomach.

“Oh,” I say.

“That was a mistake.”

“What was?”

“Giving me ideas.”

Her mouth reaches the inside of my thigh and I stop smiling.

She takes her time with me because she knows exactly what that does now, her tongue moving over my clit slowly enough that I feel the anticipation ahead of every stroke. I try to keep quiet and fail. She presses my good leg farther open with one hand and slips two fingers inside me with the other, and the room narrows down to lamp light and her hair against my thigh and the sheet twisted in my fist, pressure gathering until my body stops belonging to language at all.

I come hard enough that my heel knocks the wall, and somebody in the next room thumps back, and Sella starts laughing against my thigh while I cover my face with both hands.

“I hate this building.”

“No, you don’t.”

“I hate that wall.”

“That seems fair.”

She crawls up beside me still smiling, and I roll toward her and tell her it is her turn, and she says I should rest, and I inform her that I have been resting smugly for nearly five seconds, which she declines to accept as a definition.

This time I guess less. I know how she likes my hand between her thighs, and the rhythm that makes her stop teasing me, and that she wants pressure and then less and then more again, and that the fastest way to make her swear is to slow down when she is close. She discovers that I know this at approximately the moment I use it.

Her eyes open. "Don't you dare."

I absolutely dare. She grabs my wrist, laughing and furious, and pulls me closer, and I tell her to ask nicely, and she says my name in a voice that makes the joke collapse out from under me. So I give her what she wants. Her body tightens under my hand, her mouth opens against my neck, and when she comes she says my name like an accusation and holds on until the shaking stops.

—○—

Afterward the room smells like lamp oil and salt and Sella, who lies on her back with one arm thrown over her eyes while I try not to smile at the ceiling and fail at that too.

"You're smug," she says.

"I'm resting."

"You're resting smugly."

"I've had a difficult week."

"So have I."

I turn my head. The bruises along her upper arm have gone yellow at the edges, and I touch one lightly with two fingers.

"Still hurt?"

"Yes."

"You didn't say."

"You had an ankle the size of a turnip."

"That doesn't make your arm imaginary."

She lowers her arm from her eyes and looks at the ceiling for long enough that I stop expecting an answer.

"I'm not used to someone asking twice."

I keep my hand where she put it. "Then I will," I say, and she says that is annoying, and I agree that it is frequently annoying, and she reaches for my hand and puts it back over the bruise herself. No pressure. Just there.

After a while she says, "If we go east, I won't pay your fare."

“I have money.”

“I know.”

“I own a shield.”

“I know.”

“I may own more things by then.”

“That is what worries me.”

I laugh into her shoulder. Lying there does not decide anything about Tolliver, Rook, or east. It does let me picture a future with Sella in it without pretending the rest is settled. She said *if we go east*, not *if you do*. I hear it and keep my mouth shut.

—○—

Before sleep I check the measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 3]

[PROGRESS: 12 / 18]

[RESERVE: 4 / 5]

[RUN: WARDER]

Three progress since the field. I have no idea whether it came from the station work, or the drainage decision, or surviving my own stupidity, and the System declines as always to provide a receipt.

Tomorrow Rusk leaves. Tomorrow the lower service stair opens for the first time. Harra has the used block, new rope, two anchors, and a rule written in chalk across the equipment board where nobody can miss it: NO BODY CROSSES THE EDGE.

Underneath, in Dain’s hand: THIS INCLUDES MAYA.

Sella laughed for nearly a minute when she saw it. I intend to make him regret the wording.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Rusk leaves before I wake, and her rig goes with her, and the yard looks enormous without the shear legs standing in it.

Harra's purchased block hangs beside the workroom door instead, small enough to carry in two hands and ugly enough that I trust it on sight. The hook came without a keeper. She has made one.

"Better than hers?" I ask.

"Mine closes."

"That wasn't the question."

"It was the answer."

Behind her, the lower service door stands open for the first time since it was barred four years ago, and I forget entirely about the hook.

—○—

The stair smells like wet iron, old water, and the particular dust that comes off stone when nobody has walked on it long enough for the air to settle. Nothing rotten or moldy. Nothing rank.

Dain and Harra have already marked the damaged steps, the missing rail, and the wheel recess above the chamber. Nobody crossed the boundary while the interval was moving. That is the only reason I am allowed down here at all, and *allowed* is doing a great deal of work in that sentence.

The mender examines my ankle at the top of the stair, makes me stand, makes me rise onto both toes, and then tells me I may manage indoor stairs with a handrail and another person present.

"Not carrying weight."

"I weigh something."

"She means equipment," Sella says.

"I know what she means."

"Then why are you like this?"

The mender answers before I can. "Nineteen."

Sella looks delighted. I decide to respect neither of them for the remainder of the day.

—○—

We establish the abort conditions at the kitchen table, in daylight, before anyone is frightened enough to renegotiate them. Dain writes the essentials large enough to read from the doorway: early contraction, pressure below threshold, anchor movement, lost visual contact, or a stop call means withdraw. No body crosses the edge. No improvising because something is almost there.

Mara adds one line of her own: NO SECOND TRY TODAY AFTER EQUIPMENT LOSS.

“You will want one,” she tells Dain.

He writes it down. I love her a little for it.

—○—

My job is not the rope, or the block, or stepping through a murder-slice because I happen to have a class called Warder.

My job is the test board. Dain has taken yesterday’s interval observations and made them physical: a narrow plank marked in three zones. Green for rising pressure above the first observed threshold, boundary widening. Yellow for uncertain. Red for falling below the lowest observed safe continuation mark. The colors are not a law. They are a reminder that uncertainty exists even when everybody in the room has become excited.

I stand at the wheel recess with the board, close enough to hear Oret’s runner call the outlet marks from above, far enough from the chamber that nobody can mistake my presence for permission to approach the edge. Sella stands with me. Tolliver is at the outside stair relay. Mara stays at the upper glass with Iven. Harra and Dain are below, and Renn is the extra body whose entire job is to pull Dain backward if Dain becomes stupid.

Dain objected to that description. Renn did not.

The recess itself is smaller than I imagined, a stone pocket beside the stair half hidden behind a heavy vertical spindle, with the wheel restrained at an angle by the clamp above. One tooth is missing from the old retaining gear and leaves a black gap in the ring. Nobody touches it. A chalk line across the floor says DO NOT TOUCH, and somebody has added MAYA underneath.

I look at Sella.

“That one was Tolliver.”

“How do you know?”

“His letters lean.”

“Of course you know that.”

“I have interests.”

She smiles, and then the runner calls down from the stair above that the outlet is rising, and I move the wooden marker to yellow, and Harra’s voice comes up out of the chamber to say the width is increasing. Green. My heart starts going, not because I am doing anything, but because somewhere below us the world is opening wider.

—○—

The test object is a narrow cross-braced ash frame, and it is not a bridge. Harra says so often enough that even my brain eventually stops trying to promote it.

We have measured Iven’s landing. He has cleared a place beside the gray door and braced one end of his bed-frame strip against the wall. The plan sounds sane written down: Harra advances the frame from our side, Iven catches the far nose and lowers it onto his landing, and no line stays tensioned across the boundary at any point. If the thing can rest independently on both structures, we learn something useful about geometry and load.

If it can’t, we lose a frame. That was much easier to say at the table.

“Green,” I call.

Dain repeats it below, and the chain begins to move. One link. Pause. Another. Harra calls measurements up, and Sella repeats them beside me, not because I cannot hear but because we agreed that every critical number gets heard twice.

“Two hands extension.”

“Two hands.”

“Three.”

“Three.”

The runner arrives breathless to say the outlet is still rising. Green. From above, Mara’s bell rings once: Iven has the nose in sight. The chain stops, and Dain calls far contact beginning, and I stare at the board and tell myself not to imagine the frame, or Iven’s hands, or what a moving boundary would do to fingers. I fail at all three.

“Outlet steady.”

Yellow. The boundary is still wide. Harra calls holding, Mara’s bell rings twice, and there is a long pause in which nothing happens anywhere in the world.

Then Harra says, “Far end down.”

Nobody cheers. We have learned that much.

Dain orders the near end lowered onto the Rook support block, and the frame settles, and a faint vibration comes up through the floor into my boots. Sella feels it too; her hand closes around my wrist without either of us acknowledging it.

“Anchor?”

“Sound,” Harra answers, and Renn repeats it.

For one impossible second the frame is supported on both sides, each end resting on stone while the boundary carries nothing. Nothing is tied through. Nothing is moving. I understand entirely why every stupid part of me wants to step onto it.

—○—

Then the runner says the outlet is falling, and the marker goes to yellow, and that is the test.

Harra begins retrieval. The frame has to come back before the lower threshold. Iven lifts his end with the bed strip, the near side rises, the chain takes weight. One link. Two.

“Falling faster.”

Red.

“Withdraw,” I say.

Dain repeats it instantly, and the chain moves, and then stops. Not slowly. Stops.

Harra swears. “Far nose caught.”

“Release it.”

“Iven’s trying.”

Mara’s bell from above, once and then once again. He sees the problem. The frame has dropped between two stones on the far landing, not deep, deep enough. Harra pulls and Dain says no and the chain goes slack, which is right, because we already learned what holding harder does. She feeds an inch back. The bell rings twice.

“Take,” Harra says.

One link. The runner arrives at a dead run.

“Below mark!”

Red was already red, but the runner’s face makes the color feel heavier.

“Abort,” I say, and Dain has said it before the word is out of my mouth.

Harra hauls. The frame moves half a hand. Then the chamber makes a sound I have never heard anything make, flat and enormous, like a book slammed shut by something the size of the building. The chain jumps. Harra shouts.

Sella is already moving down the stair, and I get a fist in her sleeve.

“No.”

Her whole body strains against my hand for half a second. Then she stops, because we do not break the rule just because the noise was frightening.

From below, Renn calls that they are clear. Dain shouts up that the frame is lost and the line is clear.

“People?”

“Clear.”

I let go of Sella’s sleeve, and she presses the heel of her hand against her mouth and keeps it there.

—○—

The boundary contracts through the frame. We do not see it happen from the recess. Mara does, and so does Iven, and later, when the interval widens enough to inspect from the glass, the result is obvious enough that nobody has to describe it twice.

The near half of the ash frame lies in our chamber. The far half sits on Iven’s landing. One crossbrace is gone entirely, either cut into something too small to see or thrown somewhere outside our view. The break runs clean and diagonal through one sidepiece and splinters through the other, where the load twisted at the last instant.

The guide line never crossed the edge. Harra had detached it from the frame before the independent support test, exactly as planned.

We lost a frame and nothing else. The block is intact. Every hand is intact. Every person is intact. I repeat that to myself on the way down the stairs until it begins to sound true.

Mara reaches the chamber before I do, because I am slow on the stairs and nobody comments on it. Dain is sitting on the floor with his back against the wall, staring at the cut ash, and Renn is standing over him.

“You didn’t have to drag him?” I ask.

“Didn’t get the pleasure.”

Dain gives us both a tired look. Harra is already examining the remaining metal pin, turning it against the light.

“It wasn’t timing alone,” she says, and points at the far end drawing. “The nose caught because the support face isn’t level. Iven’s landing pitches toward the door.”

“The cup would have told us.”

Dain looks up. I watch him decide whether he has the energy, and then he starts laughing, not much, but enough. “The dented cup.”

"You mocked my cup."

"I mocked nothing. Harra mocked the cup."

"I stand by it," Harra says without looking up.

The laugh hurts less than the silence did. Then she taps the pin and says it was too proud, and shows us where it extends farther than the drawing allowed. Under no load, that gave us tolerance. Under withdrawal, it hooked the stone edge.

A known weak point. Fixable. Not today, because of Mara's rule, and Dain looks as though he would like to eat the paper it is written on and does not argue.

—○—

Iven sends a message through the upper glass. FRAME HALF HERE. THREE STEPS SOUND. DOOR JAMB SOUND. I CUT PIN FREE LATER?

Harra answers: NO. LEAVE EVERYTHING UNTIL NEXT CONTACT.

YES, HARra. His local spelling of her name is terrible, and she pretends not to be pleased about it.

Then he adds another line, and Mara stops reading partway through. TELL MAYA NOT EARTH IS NOT NOTHING.

"Did he write that?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

She gives me a look so similar to my mother's that for one awful instant I hate her for it, and then it passes, and Iven writes again. FALLOW REACH EXISTS. YOU FOUND WHERE I AM.

I sit down on the gallery bench, because my ankle has begun to throb and because he is right, and I hate that too.

—○—

The mender makes me put my foot up when we get back to the kitchen. I tell her the stair was approved and she says nothing whatsoever about the number of trips I made on it, which is how I know I am in trouble.

Sella drops into the chair beside me. Her hands are still shaking slightly. I take one.

"You stopped."

"So did you."

"I had your sleeve."

“You had one hand.”

“That was enough.”

She looks at me, and then away. “You wanted to go down.”

“Yes.”

“So did I.”

“Yes.”

Neither of us tries to make a virtue out of wanting to.

—○—

Tolliver comes back from the outer relay after the equipment inventory and sets a folded page beside me.

“What?”

“Rusk.”

I open it. A receipt, not for us: for the west-road offer, declined. At the bottom he has written two names in his leaning hand. Elian Vos. Mera Vos. No explanation attached to either of them.

“You’re giving me this?”

“I don’t want to keep making you ask what I’m hiding.”

The sentence is careful rather than polished, and it does not erase anything, and it is real anyway. I fold the page and thank him, and he nods and looks at my ankle.

“You overdid the stairs.”

“I have been medically cleared to overdo a limited number of stairs.”

“That isn’t a thing.”

“Don’t start.”

“I wasn’t going to.” He tilts his head toward the stool by the hearth. “I was going to ask whether you wanted that under your foot.”

The difference is small enough to miss, and I don’t miss it. He brings me the stool, and from the table behind him Sella says he should be more offended by something, and he looks over his shoulder, and she holds his gaze, and for once nobody in this room reaches for a fight.

—○—

The house extends all three of us by one more day at the same rates. The drainage has freed enough of the works purse to manage it without touching seed, and Pell explains that part before I can ask.

Harra gets materials for a second frame: shorter pin, adjustable far shoe. Tomorrow is inspection and dry testing, not another rescue attempt.

The clerk pays today's eight bits before I sign for tomorrow. The money is becoming less important to me than the paper, which frightens me in a completely different way.

—○—

At night I open the measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 3]

[PROGRESS: 15 / 18]

[RESERVE: 5 / 5]

[RUN: WARDER]

Fifteen. Three to go. I sit with it for a while, and the word under the run has stopped feeling like a label somebody stuck on me while I was unconscious.

Warder. Whatever the System means by it, what it has cost me so far is a shield with a bite out of it, an ankle I cannot trust on uneven ground, and the specific knowledge of what happens when I hold something one second longer than I should. Today I let go of a sleeve I badly wanted to keep hold of, and the frame is in two pieces in two worlds, and Iven is still behind a wall.

Tomorrow we do not rescue him. Tomorrow we find out why we failed. For once, that doesn't feel like waiting.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

I find the discouraging observation before breakfast, which gives me nearly an hour to decide not to say it.

Harra has the cut half of the ash frame on the kitchen table. The sidepiece is smooth where the boundary passed through it and ugly where the trapped pin twisted before the cut. Beside it lies her new drawing: shorter pin, adjustable shoe, wider bearing plate. It is a better frame in every useful way except the one that matters this morning.

"The shoe wants spring steel," she says.

Pell studies the materials list. "How much?"

"Not money."

"That is rarely a comforting answer."

"Rusk had two strips in her repair chest. I saw them when we changed the keeper on the lower block."

Rusk left yesterday. Nobody says that because we all know it, and because I have another problem folded inside my copying sheets.

The near anchor did not move during yesterday's failed test. The chain did not slip. The frame did not break because we held too long. But when I copied Dain's board last night, I found the first vibration mark sitting in the wrong place: before the far pin caught, before the frame was fully supported, before any load should have transferred across the span. A little shiver in the stone, then another.

It might be nothing. I have spent enough time around old works to know that **might** is often the most expensive word available.

Pell rubs two fingers over her forehead. "Can we substitute?"

Harra shakes her head. "Iron will take a set. Wood flexes too much. I need something that returns."

"Greyward," Vey says.

"Three days if somebody rides hard, buys immediately, and comes straight back," Tolliver says.

Iven's tank is still below the old stain. Nobody turns that into a number of days, because we have already agreed not to comfort ourselves with

arithmetic we do not understand. Three days still sounds like three days.

Sella reaches across me, steals my cup, and drinks from it.

"You have your own."

"This one was closer."

"That is theft."

"Report me."

Pell says my name. When I look up, she is watching me. So is Dain.

Not accusing. Waiting.

I put down my bread.

"There was vibration before the catch."

Harra's hand stops over the drawing. Dain says, "How much?"

"Two marks on the board. Maybe three. I thought the frame was settling."

"You thought?"

"I hoped."

There is no useful way to make that answer prettier. I pull the copied sheet from my papers and flatten it beside the broken ash.

"Here. First tremor is before Mara's second bell, before far support. Then another after."

Harra bends over the page. Sella puts my cup down. Dain traces the sequence once with the blunt end of his pencil.

"You copied this last night?"

"Yes."

"And left it off the first report."

"Yes."

"Why?"

A shorter pin and a better shoe are fixable. A chamber that starts shivering before load crosses is a different kind of problem, and Iven is still over there with less water than he had yesterday. I am nineteen and tired of every answer opening its mouth to show me another row of teeth.

"I didn't want it to matter."

Dain looks at me for a second, then nods. He does not forgive me or scold me. He just pulls the sheet closer.

"Now it does."

The measure opens across my vision.

[PROGRESS: 18 / 18]

The line brightens. My breath catches, and the text folds inward before I can say anything.

[WARDER ADVANCEMENT]

[LEVEL 4]

[RESERVE CAPACITY: 6]

[CURRENT RESERVE: 5 / 6]

No refill. No miraculous ankle. No new ability arriving with fanfare. Just one more point of room inside a thing I still do not understand.

I close the measure.

Sella catches my face immediately. “What?”

“Four.”

Her smile appears before she can stop it. Then she glances at the vibration sheet. “You would level while admitting something terrible.”

“My timing remains excellent.”

“Your timing has a disease.”

Tolliver’s mouth shifts at one corner. “Congratulations.”

That is all he says, and I am grateful for the all of it.

—○—

Rusk manages to reach into the house before noon without physically being here, which feels unfair.

A carrier comes in from the west road with one folded notice for Pell and another for Harra. The first is a claim warning. The second is a price.

Harra reads hers aloud. “Two tempered strips, one new keeper set, one sixteen-link light chain. Four pieces.”

Pell laughs once. Nobody else does.

“Four.”

“She’s charging for distance,” Vey says.

“She left yesterday.”

“She knows we need it today.”

Harra turns the paper over. “There is more.”

Rusk will sell the spring strips at ordinary price if Rook recognizes her first-examination right on recovered inner iron from the lower station.

Pell’s laugh disappears.

“That claim is still disputed.”

“Yes.”

“Then the price is four.”

Harra folds the notice. I look at the severed frame and curl my fingers against the table edge until the wood bites.

Rusk has found a way to make Iven’s rescue touch her claim without touching the rescue itself. She can call it salvage law, ordinary price, examination rights, whatever respectable words she likes. The result is the

same: wait three days, pay four pieces, or give her a handhold on whatever we recover below.

Efficient. I hate efficiency when it belongs to someone else.

Tolliver takes a folded paper from inside his coat. "She also sent me something."

My stomach tightens before I can stop it. Sella sees that, and so does he. He puts the paper on the table between us instead of keeping it in his hand.

"The west-road job. Different owner this time."

Pell reads the name. "Verren Holt."

Vey swears softly.

"Who?"

"Broker. Salvage, wool, grain when he can get it cheap enough. He's bought claims from Rusk before."

Tolliver nods. "He wants me to find a wagon that left the old south cut eight days ago. Three pieces now, three on location."

"That's a lot."

"Yes."

"You could go."

"I could."

He meets my eyes. "I'm not."

The relief is immediate enough to embarrass me, so I pick up the posting instead.

"Because of us?"

"Because the wagon carried two hired cutters who quit at the cut. Holt calls them missing property."

The room goes very quiet.

At the bottom of the page is a second hand beneath Tolliver's note: witnessed, complete offer, no omitted owner, no omitted cargo.

"I asked the carrier if this was the whole posting," Tolliver says. "Then I asked him to sign that answer."

He turns the paper toward Pell.

"Holt and Rusk are working the same road. You should have a copy."

Pell takes it. Nobody praises him. Nobody needs to.

—○—

The East Relief Works are Harra's idea, which Dain hates on sight. That improves my opinion of the plan for almost thirty seconds.

"There is no reason the pressure annex still has intact flex stock," he says.

"There is no reason it doesn't."

"It flooded twelve years ago."

"The upper rooms didn't."

"The lower gallery cracked."

"We don't need the lower gallery."

"What we need is a tempered return shoe."

Harra spreads an old service map across the table. Two ridges north and east, beyond Bera's fields and a strip of coppice, a faded box sits on an old pressure line.

EAST RELIEF WORKS.

The service road washed out years ago. A footpath remains above it. Harra walked part of the approach six years back and turned around when the upper floor shifted under a pack mule.

Pell looks at her. "And this is your recommendation?"

"My recommendation is Greyward."

"And if we cannot wait three days?"

Harra taps the faded square.

Dain points to a note written beside it. "What's that?"

Harra leans closer. "Vibration warning."

I stop liking the map.

"What kind?"

"Counterweighted isolation shutters. If the main pressure line ruptured, floor sections dropped and sealed off the break."

Sella looks up. "Floor sections."

"Yes."

"You mean holes."

"They were doors when they worked."

"And now?"

Harra glances at the flood notation. "Now we find out."

Dain looks at me, then at the copied tremor marks beside the frame.

The annex used the same regional pressure system. If anything there was built to move under vibration and keep carrying load, it may contain exactly the hardware Harra needs. It may also tell us whether the shiver in our rescue chamber is ordinary old machinery or the first sign of something worse.

Pell asks, "Who goes?"

"Me," Harra says.

"Me," Sella says.

Tolliver adds, "Me."

Three heads turn toward me. My ankle contributes its opinion with a dull pulse from yesterday's stairs.

The mender arrives twenty minutes later and dislikes the plan with admirable consistency. After making me walk, turn, and rise onto my toes, she grudgingly allows one controlled trip: brace, stick, no load carrying, somebody else handles my equipment, and any sharp increase in pain or instability sends me back.

“My shield?”

“No.”

“This is not practice.”

“No.”

Sella pats my knee. I consider our relationship under review.

—○—

We define the expedition before anyone packs. Harra needs one of three things: a tempered return shoe, spring stock long enough to forge one, or a maintenance specification that gives her another answer. Anything else stays where it is unless we need it to get out.

The retreat rules are familiar now: worsening ankle, lost route, moving floor, fresh occupation, or reserve below two means leave. Harra adds one condition herself.

“If we hear repeated heavy movement we cannot identify, we do not follow it.”

“Why that one?”

She rolls the map.

“Because things live there.”

“What things?”

“Things that like vibration.”

Sella’s expression brightens in a way no sensible person’s should.

“You knew.”

“I knew there were knockers.”

“That is a terrible name.”

“They knock.”

“On what?”

Harra lifts her pack. “Usually whatever moved.”

I keep my mouth shut. Sella looks disappointed anyway.

—○—

We leave after midday for the old maintenance shelter below the annex, planning to enter the works at first light.

Before we go, Pell pays the current extension and puts a two-day expedition contract on the table at our existing rates and house terms. Job injuries are covered; rescue components belong to Rook until Iven is out; personal finds get declared before division.

Then comes the line I read twice.

NOBODY OWNS ANOTHER PERSON'S BODY, LABOR BEYOND THE TERM, OR FUTURE ROUTE RIGHTS.

Pell notices my pause. "Too much?"

"No."

I sign.

Sella and Tolliver sign after me. Harra signs as expedition lead. Pell adds one more sentence beneath the terms: FIELD DECISIONS FOLLOW THE PERSON ASSIGNED TO THAT DECISION.

Harra gets structure. Sella gets immediate fighting response. Tolliver gets route security outside the works.

"And me?" I ask.

Pell glances at the broken frame.

"When your Warder work is what keeps someone moving, you decide whether it holds or releases."

My mouth goes dry. I sign beside the amendment anyway.

—○—

The maintenance shelter is a stone box with half a roof and just enough intact wall to make the wind choose sides. We reach it before sunset.

My ankle hurts, but no more than when we left. Harra checks the brace while I sit on a fallen lintel. Sella checks it after her, because my leg has become public infrastructure by committee.

Tolliver stops beside me. "How is it?"

"Annoyed."

"That isn't a measurement."

"It is the one you get."

He considers that, then nods. "Tell me if it changes."

Then he goes to help Harra clear broken tile away from the doorway.

We eat cold bread, hard cheese, and apples in a place built for workers who have been dead longer than I have been alive. Through the missing half of the roof I can see the first stars. Sella lies beside me under one blanket. Harra snores near the door. Tolliver takes first watch.

I am almost asleep when something knocks from the ridge above us.

Once.

A pause.

Again.

Then three quick taps.

Tolliver is on his feet before the third. Sella's hand closes around mine, and Harra wakes without making a sound.

The knocking comes again.

Not from the door. Not from the trees.

From underground.

My measure flickers at the edge of sight. No notification, just a nameplate far below where no person should be visible.

[HOLLOW KNOCKER, LV. 6]

Then it vanishes.

Beside me, Sella whispers, "Tomorrow should be fun."

"Your standards are diseased."

She smiles in the dark.

I do not.

Tomorrow we go inside.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The East Relief Works has a front door, which is disappointing. I was promised a dungeon.

The door is iron-banded oak, swollen in its frame and hanging low enough that one corner has carved a crescent through the stone threshold. Somebody painted a red hand across it years ago.

The hand has six fingers.

“That seems encouraging.”

Harra pushes once on the door. It does not move. Sella touches the faded paint with one fingertip.

“Worker mark?”

“Warning.”

“What does six fingers warn about?”

Harra considers the hand. “Usually that whoever painted it was frightened.”

“Specific.”

“More specific than no warning.”

Tolliver crouches beneath the overhang and studies the mud. The last rain has softened everything enough to hold tracks: deer, something broad-footed, our own boots from the slope. Nothing human and recent.

“No one came through since the rain.”

One retreat condition cleared.

Harra takes a pry bar from his pack while I stand nearby with the walking stick the mender inflicted on me. My shield is back at Rook because medical authority has won its argument with dignity.

She works the bar toward the latch side. I look at the door again.

“Not there.”

Harra pauses.

“The top hinge block is cracked. Force the latch and the door twists into it.”

She studies the stone, then shifts the bar to the low corner. Tolliver puts his shoulder where she points. Sella joins him.

Wood groans. The door opens an inch.
Something knocks from inside.
Everybody stops.
Knock. Knock. Knock.
Not close. Not far either. Somewhere under us.
Harra glances back. "Still want your dungeon?"
"I would like to revise my complaint."

—○—

Inside, the air tastes of wet stone and old iron.

The first room is almost ordinary: benches, hooks, three cracked helmets, a drainage groove furred white with mineral crust. Then I notice the skeleton under a collapsed shelf.

The bones are brown with age. Anything useful was taken long ago, though a ring of green corrosion still stains one wrist. Sella stops beside it. Harra removes her cap. Tolliver does the same, and I copy them half a second late.

Nobody prays. I do not know the right prayer anyway.

We step around the bones and go on.

The next doorway opens onto a maintenance corridor ribbed in black iron. The floor is built from square stone plates, each with a metal pin at one corner.

Harra crouches.

"Isolation floor."

"So the holes really are doors," Sella says.

"When pressure failed, selected plates dropped into the trench. Kept workers from crossing into a rupture zone."

"By removing the floor."

"Yes."

"Old engineers were cheerful people."

Harra ignores that and ties a stone to a thin line.

The stone lands on the first plate. Nothing. She drags it back and throws again. Nothing. On the third impact, the plate drops six inches.

Something below hits it hard enough to make the stone jump.

Sella's knife is in her hand before the second strike.

The plate settles. In the dark seam around it, pale fingers appear. Too long, too many joints.

A nameplate flickers.

[HOLLOW KNOCKER, LV. 6]

“Creature,” I say.

“Level?”

“Six.”

Tolliver has his bow out, but no arrow nocked. There is nothing to shoot except stone and fingers that have already vanished.

The plate rises slowly back into place.

We all look at Harra.

She sighs. “So. Holes and occupants.”

—○—

It takes less time than I expect to understand the corridor.

Movement makes the things below curious. Weight makes them test a plate. Repeated impact gathers them. Harra marks a route along the wall, testing each stone enough to know which ones shift and which ones stay put. We do not need a taxonomy. A chalk circle means a person has crossed it safely. An X means nobody steps there.

Tolliver goes first, Harra second, me third, Sella last.

Six plates hold.

On the seventh, Tolliver eases one foot forward and the stone lowers beneath him by the width of a finger.

“Stop.”

He stops.

A pale hand slides into the seam.

I can feel the argument in the floor: his weight, the old mechanism, something below pushing up where the stone wants to go down. Sella mutters something behind me as another knock answers under the plate behind Tolliver.

“Back,” I say.

He shifts onto his rear foot. The plate steadies.

“Again.”

Another inch. The hand slaps stone.

They are building a rhythm.

“Stepguard,” I say, mostly to remind myself what I have.

I have no shield, but Sella taught me the pattern as a line through the body before she ever taught me to hide behind wood. I move onto the sound plate behind him.

She catches the back of my coat.

“Ankle.”

“Straight line.”

Her hand opens.

I commit.

Reserve pulls.

5 / 6 → 3 / 6

The pattern catches around my stance. My back boot stays on the chalked sound stone while my forward foot takes the edge of Tolliver's shifting plate. Pressure comes up through that step hard enough to buckle an ordinary transfer, but the grounded foot gives Stepguard somewhere real to send it. My facing holds.

I grab the back of Tolliver's belt.

"Do not help me."

"I wasn't."

Good.

"Move when I say."

Another knock. The plate drops.

"Now."

He steps backward past me. I let the pattern go and follow him onto sound stone.

The plate falls as our weight leaves it. A pale head punches into the gap. Sella's knife flashes once across reaching fingers, and the thing jerks back just before the stone slams shut.

For several seconds nobody speaks.

My ankle holds. My reserve does not refill. My heart is making an escape attempt through my throat.

Tolliver looks at the dead-marked plate, then at Harra.

"X that one."

Harra does.

Sella gives me a look that says she noticed everything and intends to be unbearable about it later.

—○—

We take the upper route around the failed section.

It climbs a maintenance stair cut into the wall and crosses a narrow gallery above the isolation trench. My ankle tolerates the first flight, complains through the second, and becomes specific at the landing.

I stop.

The fact that I stop without being ordered earns me three simultaneous looks from people pretending not to look.

"Five minutes."

Harra nods.

I sit, loosen the wrap, and check the joint. No swelling. No instability.
Just more ache than I started with.

Sella kneels beside me. “Sharp?”

“No.”

“Loose?”

“No.”

She hands me water. “Then five.”

Tolliver stays three paces away, facing the gallery while Harra studies the next stair. Nobody hovers. It is almost peaceful, if I ignore the level-six things under the floor.

By the time we move again, the extra ache has settled.

—○—

The gallery ends at a pressure room with an open door, which is our first warning.

The second is a curved line of red mineral stain across the floor.

The third is the dead knocker pinned beneath a fallen wheel.

It is roughly human-sized if a human had been assembled by somebody with a grudge against joints: pale skin, long forearms, flat face, no visible eyes.

Sella crouches near it without touching.

“Old?”

Harra studies the dried tissue. “Years.”

Tolliver points to three long gouges high on the wall.

“Those aren’t from the wheel.”

Something larger, then.

At the far side of the room stands an isolation shutter frame mounted vertically in the wall.

Its return shoe is intact.

Harra makes a sound of pure mechanical joy and takes two steps before I notice what is wrong.

“Wait.”

She stops.

The red mineral line arcs from the shutter to the opposite wall. On one side of it, dust. On the other, clean stone.

Something crosses this room often enough to polish a path.

“Drag mark,” Tolliver says.

Sella looks at the dead creature. “Wheel killed it.”

Harra touches the pipe beside the shutter frame.

It hums.

Very faintly, but it hums.

"There is still pressure."

The works are not dead. They are injured and still trying to function, which somehow feels worse.

We test from the doorway.

First stone, nothing. Second, nothing. Third impact and the shutter arm fires.

A black iron bar sweeps waist-high across the room and smashes into the far stop hard enough to pulverize the test stone.

Sella stares at the dust. "I dislike old engineers."

Harra is staring at the mechanism. "It resets after load."

"Can we disable it?"

"Yes."

"From here?"

"No."

That answer lands exactly where I expected it to.

The return shoe we need is on our side of the sweep. The isolation lever is across the room.

Tolliver studies the clear path behind the arm. "I can cross after it fires."

"Unknown reset," Harra says.

"I can," Sella says.

"No," I say.

Her head turns toward me, annoyance immediate and useful.

"We know movement excites the knockers and load fires this. We do not know what resets it."

Harra looks from the arm to the frame. "What are you thinking?"

"Treat it like a machine."

The iron bar rests against a fixed sill after the sweep. Behind it, out of the path, there is just enough room for me to set my forearms against the back of the arm.

"I Brace it at the stop. Sella crosses behind the sweep path and pulls the isolator. If the mechanism overdrives, I release after she is behind the pier."

Harra studies the sill, the bar, my feet.

"You hold the arm, not the floor."

"Exactly."

Sella's mouth tightens. She looks from me to the iron arm and back. "And if you cannot?"

"I tell you."

Tolliver opens his mouth. Harra points at him before he gets a word out.

"Bow stays useful from this side. Sella is faster at the lever."

He nods.

Harra clips a loose retrieval line to Sella's belt, slack enough that it will not tighten unless Sella gives the agreed pull. Then we set the sequence once and only once.

Stone. Sweep. Brace. Cross. Isolate. Verify. Remove the shoe.

No one crosses a moving mechanism.

I am beginning to hate plans that sound reasonable.

—○—

The stone lands.

The arm sweeps.

I plant my forearms against the back of it at the stop and Brace.

3 / 6 → 2 / 6

Pressure comes through iron, shoulders, spine, boots. The arm is dead-still under the pattern, but the mechanism behind it is not. I can feel gears trying to complete something they began twelve years ago.

"Sella."

She runs low behind the sweep line.

A pale hand appears at the floor seam behind her.

Tolliver says, "Left."

He fires once. The arrow pins the hand against the seam. The knocker makes a high, thin scream that brings answering knocks from beneath the whole room.

Sella reaches the far pier and yanks the lever.

Nothing.

Again.

Nothing.

"Safety catch!" Harra shouts. "Under the handle!"

Sella drops to one knee.

The arm surges against my Brace. The pattern bites down so hard my teeth click together.

"Now," I say, and keep the word flat enough to be useful.

Sella finds the catch and throws the lever.

The pressure vanishes so fast the iron bar becomes ordinary weight against my arms. Brace releases by itself and I rock backward.

Tolliver catches my upper arm.

"Sound?"

I set both feet. "Yes."

His hand is gone immediately.

Across the room, Sella comes around the pier, crosses after Harra clears the mechanism, and kisses me hard enough to steal the next breath.

“Good call.”

Then she turns to Harra. “Take the damned shoe.”

—○—

Harra removes the return shoe.

Then the spring strip.

Then the specification plate, because it is riveted to the frame and she looks prepared to commit crimes against history if we leave it.

We have what we came for, and the sensible thing is to leave.

Then Tolliver raises one hand.

“Listen.”

Three knocks come from beyond the far door.

Pause.

Three more.

Underneath them is a different sound.

Metal striking metal.

Regular. Patient.

Harra looks toward it. “Maintenance forge is through there.”

“We have the shoe,” Sella says.

“Yes.”

The striking continues.

Tolliver looks at me.

My reserve is two. My ankle is worse than it was at the entrance. We have the objective, the specification plate, and a route home.

“We leave.”

Harra exhales. Sella nods. Tolliver turns toward the corridor.

The far door slams shut.

Below us, every floor plate starts knocking at once.

The room shudders. Three stones on our return route drop one after another, black gaps opening where the corridor used to be.

Sella draws her knife. Tolliver nocks an arrow. Harra grabs the recovered shoe against her chest.

I stare at the missing floor, and the word *dungeon* stops being funny.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The first thing I learn about being trapped underground is that nobody else is willing to call it a dungeon.

Harra calls it route loss. Sella calls it bad. Tolliver says nothing because he is listening to the floor.

I keep *dungeon* for myself. Three plates are down in the corridor behind us, and the gaps beneath them are black and busy. Pale hands slap the neighboring stones hard enough that the rhythm travels through my boots.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

My ankle answers with its own pulse.

Two reserve. Objective acquired. Exit unavailable.

No game I ever played put that sentence on a loading screen.

Harra points toward the far door. "Forge route."

Sella looks at her. "You said we leave."

"We are leaving."

"That door is the other direction."

"The maintenance forge had a service vent to the upper spill gallery."

"Had?"

"Twelve years ago."

Sella closes her eyes for a second.

Behind us, one of the dropped plates begins to rise.

A pale head appears in the gap. Then another. Nameplates flicker too quickly to count cleanly, all level six. The stone stalls halfway up under the weight of whatever is gathering beneath it. That way is gone.

"Forge," I say.

Nobody argues.

—○—

The far door has a wheel instead of a latch.

Of course it does.

Harra turns it a quarter rotation. Metal screams somewhere inside the wall, and the knocking under the floor immediately speeds up.

“Stop.”

She stops.

The stone beneath the door trembles. Sella crouches and puts two fingers to it.

“They’re coming toward the vibration.”

“So opening the door rings dinner.”

Tolliver glances toward the broken corridor. “They already know we’re here.”

“Knowing and being summoned are different problems.”

Harra studies the wheel. Slow would mean longer vibration. Fast would mean more of it at once.

Sella points back toward the pressure room. “Can we make noise somewhere else?”

We all look at her.

“What? They live under floors. I am comfortable assuming poor judgment.”

Tolliver unhooks his hammer, but I point instead to the test stone still tied to its line.

“Throw that into the iron stop. Repeatedly. While they move toward it, we open.”

Tolliver nods. “Better.”

“Gamer,” Sella says.

“Sometimes employable.”

We do it once.

Tolliver snaps the stone into the far stop.

CLANG.

The floor erupts with answering blows.

Again.

CLANG.

The movement beneath us shifts away.

“Now.”

Sella spins the wheel. Harra shoulders the door as soon as the seal breaks. I cross behind her, then Tolliver. Sella comes last.

A hand shoots from the seam beside her boot.

Tolliver starts forward.

“No.”

He stops.

Sella stamps the wrist, twists out of its grip, and crosses under her own power just before the door closes.

For half a breath nobody moves.

Then Sella points at both of us. "I appreciate you having this revelation after I kept my foot."

She is joking.

Mostly.

—○—

The forge is enormous in the way industrial spaces are enormous: not grand, just built for things heavier than people.

Three cold furnaces line one wall. A central trench runs black with water. Chains hang from ceiling tracks, and the wooden parts of the old worktables have rotted away, leaving iron frames standing by themselves.

At the far end, a narrow stair climbs toward a square of gray daylight, the exit we need.

Between us and it, half the floor is gone.

The spill channel cut through the forge years ago. Water runs twenty feet below. Two iron rails still span the opening where a plank deck used to sit, but every plank is missing.

Harra tests the nearest rail with the pry bar. Rust flakes into the dark.

"Maybe."

"That is not a bridge," I say.

"No."

"Good. Our terminology is improving."

Something scrapes below us, slow enough that each drag feels heavy.

Nobody looks down immediately. This is the best decision we make all morning.

Sella eventually leans over the edge. "What the fuck is that?"

I join her, which is not wisdom.

Something pale moves beneath the black water, far longer than a person.

A plate flashes into view.

[SILT BORER, LV. 9]

I step back from the edge.

"Level nine."

Harra looks at the missing deck. "That may explain the planks."

"It explains where they went. Not why there is a monster in the drain."

"No."

The water bulges as the creature turns beneath us.

Everything in these works advertises location through impact. The knockers hear it. The old mechanisms answer it. Whatever is in the channel has just learned we are standing above it.

I am beginning to resent the educational value of this place.

—○—

Bare rails are not enough.

Sella might cross them. Tolliver probably could. Harra is carrying the return shoe and specification plate, and my ankle has advanced from complaint to written grievance.

Harra walks the near edge until she finds the remains of a traveling work platform.

A ceiling track crosses the channel. Halfway out hangs a chain trolley with an iron frame suspended beneath it. The deck is gone, but the frame survives.

Tolliver traces the drive chain back to a capstan.

“Manual.”

“Two people,” Harra says.

The creature bumps the channel wall below. The floor gives a small, ugly shiver.

I look toward the furnaces. One chimney still has a heavy damper plate hanging from a chain.

“Can we make that move?”

Harra follows my finger. “Yes.”

“More than once?”

“With enough weight.”

Tolliver understands before I finish. “Give it something louder than us.”

Exactly.

We pull the empty trolley to the near landing, then build what I privately name the liar.

Harra calls it a vibration decoy, which proves engineers should not be allowed to name anything.

The heaviest loose furnace door becomes our weight. Tolliver hauls it up. Sella wedges a broken stool leg beneath the release. When kicked free, the door will drop in three short jerks as damaged links pass the hook, then leave the damper swinging against the chimney frame.

Three large impacts followed by smaller ones should, we hope, tell the borer the wrong story.

Harra will ride the trolley frame with the salvage and two iron table rails for a temporary deck. Once she reaches the far landing, she can secure the

return line and bring the frame back for us.

I do not volunteer to cross first.

This is personal growth and I hate it.

Harra looks at me. "You call continue or release."

I look at the track, the suspended frame, the water.

"That is becoming a suspiciously specific job."

"It suits you."

There are several possible responses to that, none useful.

I take a position where I can see both the track and the channel.

"Ready."

Sella puts both hands on the capstan. Tolliver takes the other side.

"Ready."

I kick the stool leg.

The furnace door drops.

BOOM.

Water erupts at the far wall as the borer lunges toward the impact.

"Turn."

The capstan moves. The trolley creeps out over the gap.

Second drop.

BOOM.

The creature hits stone. Dust sifts from the ceiling.

"Turn."

Harra is ten feet out, then fifteen. The track flexes, but not enough to frighten me yet.

Third drop.

BOOM.

The damper begins its smaller rhythm.

Clang. Clang. Clang.

The borer hesitates between the false vibration and the real one.

Then the trolley catches at a damaged joint a yard short of the far landing.

"Brake," Harra calls.

Tolliver locks it.

Harra hooks one leg through the frame and starts lashing the first table rail across the bottom.

The damper slows.

Clang.

A longer pause.

Clang.

The water beneath us turns.

Tolliver reaches for his bow.
 “An arrow is not stopping that.”
 “I know.”
 “What are you shooting?”
 “Eyes.”
 “Does it have eyes?”
 “I am choosing optimism.”
 The borer rises.
 It is worse in air: long plates of pale armor, a mouth at the front opening
 in concentric bone.
 No eyes.
 Tolliver lowers the bow. “Optimism revised.”
 Sella draws her knife.
 I stare at it. “And your plan?”
 “Emotional support.”
 Fair.
 The borer slams the near wall.
 The ceiling track jumps. Harra nearly loses her grip.
 I set both forearms against the low diagonal stay beside the capstan and
 Brace before I have finished deciding to do it.
 $**2 / 6 \rightarrow 1 / 6**$
 The track steadies.
 Pressure comes through iron and bone into the stone beneath my boots.
 Harra catches the upper bar and hauls herself upright.
 Another impact.
 I can hold.
 That is the problem.
 The track is stable because the force is going somewhere else, and the
 bracket above me is bending farther with every hit. I can keep the line
 straight until the bracket tears itself out of the wall.
 The first ash frame flashes through my head, cut in half because holding
 harder felt safer than releasing.
 “Harra.”
 “I need ten breaths.”
 “No.”
 She looks at me.
 The bracket groans.
 “Five.”
 The borer circles for another strike.
 I release Brace.

The track drops four inches.

Harra swears, but the bent bracket gives instead of snapping. The changed angle lifts the trolley wheel over the damaged joint.

The frame starts rolling toward the far landing.

“Let it run!”

Tolliver’s hand is on the brake. He looks at me once.

Then he opens it.

The trolley rolls.

Harra hits the far stop hard enough to curse us all, but she stays in the frame. The borer launches where she used to be and smashes into the underside of the channel.

Water blows upward.

Sella laughs, breathless and a little wild.

My arms are shaking.

Tolliver looks from the bent bracket to me. “You saw it failing.”

“Eventually.”

“You let the track move.”

“That was the idea.”

He keeps looking at me for one beat too long.

Sella notices. Her laughter stops first.

—○—

Harra finishes the temporary deck on the far landing.

We send the trolley back empty and cross one at a time. Sella goes first to help Harra with the return line. I go next.

Stepping into the frame makes my ankle hurt. The first sway makes it worse.

The channel opens beneath me.

I decide not to look down.

I look down.

The borer’s plate moves under the water.

Level nine. I am level four. It feels personally rude.

Harra pulls from the far side while Tolliver controls the brake. Halfway across, the borer strikes the wall again. The frame swings and my bad foot slips.

Pain flashes white through my ankle.

I make a sound I plan to deny forever.

The trolley stops.

Tolliver has locked the brake.

“No.”

"You slipped."

"I'm still in the frame."

Below me, the borer turns toward the fresh vibration.

"Keep me moving."

He releases the brake.

Immediately.

The trolley reaches the far landing. Sella waits until the frame touches stone before catching my forearm.

When I step out, the ankle nearly folds.

She holds me upright.

"Worse?"

"Yes."

The word costs more than the pain.

"Sharp?"

"Yes."

Harra does not even look up from the line. "You are done walking."

"I had reached a similar conclusion."

Tolliver crosses last. By the time he reaches us, Sella has my boot loosened and the wrap half off. He looks once at the ankle, jaw tight, and turns to help Harra secure the trolley.

I am grateful enough not to make a joke about it.

—○—

The spill stair is blocked by a fallen beam at the first turn.

Harra can shift it with the trolley chain and the recovered shoe, but not quickly. We need a room while she works.

The old foreman's office has one door, stone walls, and no floor seams.

Harra checks the ceiling. Tolliver checks the ventilation opening. Sella looks under the desk, because this is who we are now.

Clear.

I sit on a rolled coat with my foot elevated while Harra and Tolliver go back to rig the beam. Sella stays and rewinds the ankle wrap.

"The rest at the gallery helped," she says.

"Yes."

"When did it start getting worse again?"

"Pressure room. Before we tried to leave."

Her hands stop.

I look at her.

"Tell me then, next time."

"I will."

“Not after it becomes a problem.”

“I said I will.”

She ties the knot.

Too hard.

“Ow.”

“Good.”

I glare. She sits back against the wall.

For a while the room contains only our breathing and the sound of chain moving somewhere outside. Old ledgers have fused together on the shelves. One loose page lies near my boot with half a column still legible.

I leave it there.

Growth.

Eventually Sella says, “He listens to you.”

I know who she means.

“Yes.”

“He didn’t before.”

“No.”

“He looks at you differently when you’re right.”

Heat climbs my neck.

“This is a terrible time.”

“I know.”

“Then why are we doing this now?”

“Because later you’ll pretend you didn’t notice.”

I open my mouth and discover she has removed every useful answer.

Sella pulls at a loose thread on her glove.

“I like him more now.”

That surprises a laugh out of me. “You do?”

“No.”

I stare at her.

“More than before.”

“Low bar.”

“Underground.”

The smile fades.

“He makes you angry.”

“Frequently.”

“He also makes you...” She gestures vaguely at all of me.

“Please do not diagnose me in a dungeon.”

“Works complex.”

“Traitor.”

Her expression softens.

"I don't need an answer today."

My chest tightens. "To what?"

"That."

There it is: a thing between us that has become too large to pretend is furniture. She is not giving me an ultimatum or permission. She is making sure I stop pretending I missed it.

I reach for her hand.

She gives it to me.

"I meant what I said on the roof," she says.

"I know."

"I want to go with you."

"I know."

"And I don't know what he is."

"I know."

She squeezes my fingers.

"That is the problem."

There is nothing to solve in this room. I lean my head against her shoulder.

She lets me.

—○—

Harra finds another specification plate while Tolliver is freeing the beam.

Not the one we came for. This one is a pressure-isolation notice in old local script, and the System has made the writing familiar enough that I can read more of it than she can.

Repeated load cycling may wake dormant isolation sections after long disuse. Damaged pressure lines can transmit false activation through connected stone.

I read the passage twice.

The rescue chamber shivered before the frame caught.

The East Relief Works woke under load.

Same regional system. It proves nothing yet, but I want Harra to see it.

"We take it," Harra says.

"Yes."

"More weight."

"Yes."

Her eyes flick toward a coil of spare chain we found in the office.

We leave the chain.

It is worth money. Useful money. I feel the loss when Harra sets it back on the floor, and that is probably good for me.

We came for Iven.
Not for everything that glitters under a ruined roof.

—○—

We reach the spill gallery near dusk.

The exit opens onto the ridge above the front entrance. Harra carries the return shoe wrapped against her chest. Sella has my pack. Tolliver takes Harra's heavier tools.

I make it down the first part of the ridge using the stick and one good leg, then stop before pride turns into a second injury.

Tolliver waits.

"Can I?"

I look at the slope, then at him.

"Yes."

He puts my arm over his shoulder and an arm around my waist. He could lift me. He does not. We go down slowly, with Sella on my other side and Harra ahead muttering about daylight.

The arrangement is absurdly intimate for four people who smell like rust and stagnant water.

Harra glances back once. "If you three fall over, I am leaving you."

"Professional leadership."

"Move."

—○—

At the shelter I open the measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 4]

[PROGRESS: 9 / 22]

[RESERVE: 1 / 6]

[RUN: WARDER]

Nine progress.

No level five, which is fine. I am too tired to become anything else today.

Then another line appears.

[TECHNIQUE RECOGNITION: RELEASE UNDER LOAD]

It is not an ability, just the System putting a name to something I did.

Across the shelter, Tolliver rebuilds the fire. Sella cuts cheese with the same knife she offered as emotional support against a level-nine monster. Harra has set the return shoe beside her like a baby.

We went into the works for one piece of metal.

We came out with it, a pressure plate, a worse ankle, almost no reserve, and evidence that the old infrastructure may still be talking to itself across miles of stone.

For a successful dungeon, the accounting feels appropriately terrible.

I close the measure.

Tomorrow we get back to Rook.

Then we find out whether any of this gets Iven home.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

I wake because my ankle has developed a religion. Its central doctrine is pain, and its sacred text appears to be a complete record of yesterday's decisions.

Gray light leaks around the shelter shutters while I lie under two blankets and wait for my left foot to stop throbbing in time with my pulse. It does not. Somewhere nearby, a knife whispers against wood.

Breakfast, not murder. Sella cuts food like she expects it to insult her.

"Morning," she says.

"Debatable."

She comes into view with bread in one hand and cheese in the other. Her hair is tied back badly, soot streaks one cheek, and one sleeve is torn at the elbow.

Beautiful, which is annoying.

Some reckless part of me supplies *mine*. I put a lid on that before it grows teeth.

She crouches beside the bedroll. "How bad?"

"Worse."

"Sharp?"

"When I move it."

"Hot?"

"Not really."

"Can you put weight on it?"

"I can put weight on anything once."

Her expression goes flat.

"No," I admit.

Yesterday I could limp. Then I could lean. Then Tolliver helped me down the ridge because I asked. This morning, standing sounds like a negotiation I am not going to win.

Sella hands me the bread.

"Harra says we make Rook by afternoon if we stop pretending you're walking."

"I'm not being carried."

From the dead hearth, Tolliver says, "All right."

He is restringing his bow and does not look at me. That should make the answer easier.

It does not.

Sella takes a bite of cheese. "You can ride the salvage."

Harra looks up from the recovered return shoe. "No."

"It has a harness."

"It has a carrying frame. For iron."

"I'm lighter than iron."

"Not enough lighter."

"Very reassuring."

Harra returns to the specification plate.

In morning light, the old incisions are clearer: pressure isolation, resonance faults, connected stone. Iven's chamber shivered before the frame caught. East Relief woke under repeated load. Not proof, but the first explanation we have that does more than repeat the symptoms.

"Show me the fault section again."

Sella points the cheese at me. "Eat."

"Both."

"Food first."

"You are becoming controlling."

"Yes."

She smiles without apology.

I eat.

—○—

An hour later, we leave the shelter.

I do not walk.

Tolliver kneels in front of the steps with his back to me. "If you want."

The path is wet, steep, and broken enough that a walking stick would be theater. My ankle pulses while I look at his shoulders.

Sella raises both eyebrows. Harra has already vetoed every method involving the salvage frame.

There are choices that exist mostly so you can resent them before making the obvious one.

"Fine."

Tolliver waits.

Right. The rest of the sentence.

"Yes. Carry me."

He glances back. "On my back?"

Heat crawls up my neck. This should not be remotely erotic. My ankle is swollen, my clothes smell like old water, and I have mud dried into places mud should never reach.

My body declines the argument.

"Yes."

He braces one knee. I put my arms around his shoulders. His hands settle behind my thighs, firm and careful, and he stands with an amount of effort I find insulting.

Sella walks beside us.

Her eyes go to his hands, then to my face.

She smiles.

I hate her.

"Comfortable?" she asks.

"No."

"Liar," Tolliver says.

I tighten one arm around his shoulder. "Do not become confident."

His laugh moves through his back into my chest.

This is going to kill me before the ankle does.

—○—

The ridge path gets one final vote on our expedition.

A section has slumped overnight where runoff passed beneath an old retaining wall. The drop is only three feet, but the surviving shelf tilts toward the ditch and crumbles when Harra tests the edge.

Tolliver sets me down on sound ground.

I look uphill. Three old iron eyes are sunk into the retaining wall. Two are rusted through. One is not.

"High line," I say.

Harra follows my gaze. "Handrail."

"Stay against the wall. The outer edge is going."

Tolliver clips in first.

"Because?" Sella asks.

"If the eye pulls, I'm cheapest."

Harra glances at his bow. "Objectively false."

He crosses anyway. On the second step, the shelf shifts.

He freezes.

"Left shoulder in."

He leans into the wall. The load settles toward the stone instead of the crumbling edge, and he reaches the far side without anything dramatic

happening.

Harra crosses with the shoe. Sella follows.

Tolliver comes back.

“For me?”

“For the pack.”

He takes mine, then waits.

I look at the shelf, then at my ankle.

Choice is not the same thing as proving I can suffer.

“Back,” I say.

He kneels.

When we reach the far side, Sella takes my hand while he lowers me. She does not need to. I squeeze once. Her fingers answer.

We keep moving.

—○—

Rook sees us before we reach the yard.

Mara comes out first, then Pell, then two workers, then enough people to make returning from an abandoned works complex feel like a public performance.

Mara’s eyes go directly to my foot.

“No.”

“I haven’t said anything.”

“Inside.”

Harra lifts the wrapped return shoe. “We have it.”

Mara points toward the kitchen.

“The specification plate too.”

“Harra.”

Harra goes inside.

I feel much less singled out.

The house mender is waiting in the west room. Tolliver carries me to the bed, then leaves when ordered. By the time the wrap is off, the verdict is obvious: more swelling, no fracture sign she can feel, and three days without stairs, rough ground, shield work, Stepguard, or powered loading.

“I can Brace without walking.”

“Can you Brace without your body taking load?”

The forge track answers for me.

“No.”

“Then no powered work today.”

The word *today* is the part I hold on to. She splints the ankle and makes me promise to call before I stand.

I promise.
I even mean it.
Mostly.

—○—

The expedition contract ends over stew.

Harra puts the recovered return shoe in the middle of Pell's table on folded cloth. It is ugly in exactly the right way: tempered metal, a deep spring seat, nothing glowing, nothing mystical, just engineering that survived twelve years underground with creatures trying to eat our feet.

Pell touches the edge. "This fits?"

"Not directly," Harra says.

Pell's face falls.

"It gives me the geometry. The spring strip gives me the temper."

Then she sets down the specification plate.

"And this may tell us why the first frame felt wrong before it caught."

Dain and Oret are at the table now. I explain the vibration marks again, briefly this time. Harra shows them the passage on resonance faults.

Dain rests two fingers on the plate. "Can wake isolation sections."

"Can," Harra says.

"Not will."

"Correct."

Oret leans closer. "So the chamber could be feeding load into something we cannot see."

"Or receiving it from the far side."

Pell looks toward the floor as though Iven is directly below us. "Does that make this worse?"

"It makes it less unknown."

Everyone looks at me.

I wish I had said something more comforting.

Harra turns the return shoe in her hands. "If the frame is transmitting load into old stone, stronger is not automatically better."

"A rigid bridge couples both sides," Oret says.

The phrase lands.

I look at the shoe, then at Harra's earlier drawing.

"What if the far foot can move?"

"Move how?"

"Not come loose. Give."

I use my hands because the words are not enough.

“Short pin. Shoe under it. Spring behind. If the landing pitches or the stone moves, the foot takes the change instead of levering the whole span.”

Harra pulls scrap paper toward herself and starts drawing.

Oret stands.

Dain leans over her shoulder.

Pell forgets the stew.

On the third sketch, the support becomes a short steel nose seated in a shallow shoe with a bounded spring behind it.

“Adjustable foot,” Harra says.

“That was already the next design.”

“Yes.”

She taps the spring.

“This makes the adjustment live under load.”

“Good?”

“It can be.”

“That is a dangerous phrase.”

“If the travel is bounded, the pin cannot escape, and the spring is replaceable—”

“Back up.”

Harra smiles.

“We can build it.”

The room shifts around the possibility.

The thing we carried out of East Relief is no longer just salvage.

It is a way forward.

—○—

Pell pays the expedition after lunch: sixteen new bits for my two days. Mara records it separately from the earlier extension because she has correctly identified arithmetic as one of the most dangerous forces in the house.

Pell keeps our existing rates and house terms for frame work, contact, and the rescue. I ask for it in writing.

Mara is already pulling out paper when a runner arrives with a message for Sella.

She reads it once.

Then again.

Her mouth changes.

I wait.

Finally she hands it to me.

A team out of Dower Ford needs a route guard and second scout eastbound. Departure in four days. Two weeks guaranteed, with an option

to continue farther.

I read the note twice.

"You wanted moving work."

"Yes."

"You should answer."

"I know."

Four days.

My ankle gets three days of no loading. The rescue does not have a date.
Iven is still behind the boundary.

Sella sits beside me, leaving more space between us than usual.

"I can ask them to hold my answer one day."

"For me?"

"For my answer."

I fold the paper along its old crease.

"Do you want the job?"

"Yes."

No hesitation.

The clean certainty in her yes catches under my ribs.

"Then take it."

Her eyes lift.

"That easy?"

"No."

I put the note on the table.

"I said I wanted to go with you after Iven is out, if the opportunity still exists. I meant it. I am not asking you to turn down a job because our rescue keeps moving."

"Maya."

"I'm not."

The forge yard rings with three hammer strikes, a pause, then two.
Harra's rhythm.

Sella puts her hand on my knee, above the splint.

"I can accept and still leave in four days."

"Yes."

"You might come."

"Yes."

"You might not."

That one hurts more.

"Yes."

"And if you do, there is still him."

She does not look toward the yard.

She does not need to.
I cover her hand with mine.
“Yes.”
Sella closes her eyes for one second.
“Good.”
“That did not sound good.”
“It sounded true.”
She stands. I catch her fingers before she gets away.
“I want you.”
Her face softens.
“I know.”
“I don’t want you to feel temporary.”
“Then don’t make promises for me because you’re afraid I’ll leave.”
That lands exactly where it should.
“Okay.”
She bends and kisses me.
Slow enough that I stop trying to solve it.
When she pulls back, her forehead rests against mine.
“I’m taking the job.”
“Okay.”
“I’m not leaving today.”
“Okay.”
“And if you make me drag the truth out of you later, I will throw you
into a ditch.”
“There are kinder relationship models.”
“Not ours.”
She leaves to send her answer.
My chest hurts in a place the mender cannot splint.

—○—

By late afternoon, Harra has built a table-sized version of the new far foot.
Of course she has.
I am summoned to the forge yard. Mara says no. Harra says she only
needs me to look. Mara says that is what people say before Maya stands.
I am offended by the accuracy.
They carry the chair.
Not me.
The chair.
Tolliver and Pell lift the whole thing down the kitchen steps with me
still in it.

“This is worse than being carried.”

Tolliver says, “You chose the chair.”

“I did not choose the procession.”

Pell grunts beneath the back legs. “Complain lighter.”

The forge yard has become a model of the lower chamber: two stone blocks, an ash rail between them, a short pin entering a scrap-steel shoe copied from the recovered piece. Behind it sits a spring built to the same dimensions, but not from the salvage strip itself.

Harra points.

“Finger and a half maximum travel. Side lips stop escape. Pin cannot project through the shoe.”

Oret has a hanging test weight. Dain has a measuring cord. Mara has crossed arms. Sella returns from the runner post and stands behind my chair. Tolliver takes the near block.

The first two tests are beautifully boring.

Harra shifts the far block on the third, adding a rough stone under one side to mimic Iven’s sloped landing.

The pin seats crooked.

The spring compresses unevenly.

The ash rail starts to twist.

I feel it in my stomach before I can explain why.

“Stop.”

Harra freezes on the weight line.

Tolliver checks the near support. “Holding.”

“That is the problem.”

Harra follows the twist.

The misalignment is traveling back through the rail toward the near block. Stronger material would only carry more of it.

“Unload the far side,” Oret says.

He reaches for the weight.

“No.”

Everyone looks at me.

I point at the shoe latch.

“Release the shoe first. If you lift the weight now, the twisted rail snaps back through the pin.”

Harra’s eyes sharpen.

“Near side?” she asks.

Tolliver checks the clamp. “Sound.”

Harra looks at me.

“Call it.”

My pulse jumps.

There is no ability or nameplate to hide behind, only people with their hands on real things waiting for my decision.

“Release far latch.”

Harra pulls it.

The shoe jumps an inch. The spring takes the twist, the rail settles, and only then does Oret remove the weight.

Nothing breaks.

Harra stares at the model.

Then at me.

“That is the order.”

Dain nods. “Release before unload.”

Otherwise the structure carries the stored turn.

I look down at my splinted foot.

The dungeon lesson followed me home whether I wanted it or not.

—○—

They rebuild the test.

Harra wants one powered run.

Mara says no.

I say no first.

That surprises everybody, including me.

“My reserve is not the limiting resource. My foot is.”

Mara’s expression changes by about one degree.

Approval from Mara feels like being knighted by weather.

Oret runs the loaded sequence manually. Harra releases in the new order.

Three times.

The foot gives.

The rail survives.

The near block stays quiet.

I open my measure.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 4]

[PROGRESS: 22 / 22]

I stop breathing.

Sella sees my face. “What?”

The next line appears.

[ADVANCEMENT AVAILABLE]

Then:

[WARDER, LV. 5]

Something in my chest opens wider.

I check reserve.

[RESERVE: 3 / 7]

No refill.

No miracle ankle.

Good on both counts.

I flex my toes.

Mara points at me. "Do not test it."

"I moved my toes."

"You were about to do more."

Sella says, "She absolutely was."

Tolliver is looking at me even though he cannot see the measure.

"Level?"

"Five."

Harra smiles. Pell swears softly. Oret studies the prototype as if the answer might be written there.

"From the model?" he asks.

"I don't know."

That matters enough that I leave it alone.

I do not know whether the System counted the spill channel, the shoe, or this moment when what we survived becomes something another person can build. I cannot tell where one lesson ended and the next began.

Tolliver steps closer.

His eyes move over me with an intensity that makes my skin remember this morning.

"You earned that."

My mouth goes dry.

"Do not make it weird."

One corner of his mouth lifts. "I did not say anything weird."

"You thought it."

"Yes."

Sella laughs behind me.

Harra bangs a tool against the table. "Take your romance away from my prototype."

Pell looks scandalized. Mara does not. Oret suddenly finds the spring fascinating.

I cover my face with one hand.

At least nobody mentions my expression.

—○—

At dusk, Iven gets the news.

Not the level.

The shoe.

Renn carries pages between the kitchen and the upper glass while Mara copies Iven's replies. Harra sends the short-pin drawing, the bounded travel, the release order, and the rule that no person crosses until the full frame survives dry tests and a chamber test.

Iven's first response is written beneath the drawing.

You went into East Relief?

"Unfortunately," Sella says.

Mara writes that back.

The next reply asks about the forge. Harra tells him we found enough of it.

Mad, Iven writes.

"Yes," Harra says.

Renn reports that he laughed, then coughed hard enough to brace himself against the rail.

The room changes.

His water is lower again. We still refuse to turn the tank into a false deadline.

Harra needs two days to build and test properly. Mara sends the estimate exactly as it is.

Iven underlines *two days*.

Then asks about me.

Is the girl still hurt?

"I have a name."

Mara's pen waits.

"Tell him I am improving strategically."

She writes it with obvious disapproval.

Renn comes back smiling. "He laughed."

Then, quieter: "Coughed again."

Sella's team leaves in four days.

My ankle gets three days.

The numbers line up badly.

I take the pencil.

We do it right.

On Renn's last trip, Iven sends one word back beneath mine.

Good.

—○—

Night settles over Rook with two moons above the yard.

Mara permits me exactly this much rebellion: chair in the west kitchen doorway, foot up, no stairs.

Sella sits on the threshold beside me.

Across the yard, Tolliver and Harra carry the prototype under cover. He lifts one end. She lifts the other.

No one needs me.

A week ago, that would have felt like failure.

Tonight it feels almost peaceful.

Sella rests her head against my knee, carefully above the splint.

"I accepted."

"The job."

"Yes."

"Four days?"

"Yes."

I look across the yard.

Tolliver sets the prototype down, looks up, and catches me looking.

Neither of us turns away immediately.

Sella sees.

Of course she sees.

Her head stays against me. I put my hand into her hair because I want the contact, not because it can fix or claim anything.

Four days. Two to build. Three off the ankle. Iven waiting across a boundary that cuts rope, wax, and ash. Rusk somewhere out there with a claim she has not abandoned. Level five. Three reserve out of seven.

Sella turns her face and kisses the inside of my wrist.

"Do not spend tonight solving all of it."

"I wasn't."

"You were already halfway through tomorrow."

I stare down at her.

"That is an accusation."

"It is an observation."

"Treason everywhere."

She smiles.

Across the yard, Tolliver hears none of it.

Good.

Some things are still mine.

I lean back and let the night remain unfinished.
Tomorrow Harra builds. Tomorrow I rest. The day after, we test.
After that, if the old works allow it, we go back to Iven.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Rest is work.

People say this to injured people because the true sentence is meaner: rest is watching everybody else work while your body takes the credit.

I hate it.

On our first full morning back at Rook, Harra carries the rescue frame past the west kitchen window in pieces. Two ash rails. Cross-bracing. Near anchor head. New far shoe. Spring housing. Oret forged what looks like half of it before breakfast. Level twenty must come with an exemption from sleep.

I sit at the table with my left foot on a stool.

Mara has moved the stool farther from the door so I cannot, in her words, “accidentally supervise from the yard.”

Harra passes the window. I raise my hand.

She raises one finger.

Not that finger. Just one.

Stay.

“This place has become authoritarian.”

Sella does not look up from sharpening her knife. “Your ankle staged the coup.”

I look at Tolliver, who is repairing a leather strap at the other end of the table.

“Nothing?”

“I have learned when not to enter a discussion.”

“Disturbingly healthy.”

“Yes.”

Sella snorts.

I return to my actual job: the failed-frame vibration board, the East Relief resonance plate, Iven’s receiving-side sketch, the old pressure map, and Harra’s charcoal notes. The questions are narrower now: how much movement the shoe can absorb, how much vibration reaches the anchor, and what happens if the boundary moves under a person instead of sand.

Iven is not a test weight.
I read the first board again.

—○—

By noon, I have made myself useful enough that Mara notices.

“What are you doing?”

“Reading.”

“You have the face.”

“Everyone needs to stop saying that.”

She sets stew beside my papers. “What did you find?”

I turn the copied vibration board toward her.

“The first frame transmitted movement before the pin caught. East Relief says repeated loading can wake connected isolation sections.”

“Yes.”

“If we install the full frame and leave it sitting while we wait for the boundary, we may start the dangerous part before anyone steps on it.”

Mara studies the sheet, then me.

“That sounds like Harra’s problem.”

“It is.”

“Good.”

I wait.

She waits longer.

“You are not going outside.”

“I know.”

Her eyes narrow.

“I said I know.”

“That sounded rehearsed.”

“It is a common phrase.”

She takes the paper to Harra.

I hate that this victory walks away without me, but it is still a victory.

—○—

Harra comes back with the full-size far shoe and sets it on the table.

It is less elegant than the model: a steel cup with side lips, a short nose pin, a spring block behind it, and two stop bolts limiting the travel.

“The stops are too close,” I say.

Harra raises her eyebrows. “I have not explained them.”

“I can see them.”

“Then explain.”

"If Iven's landing slopes more than we estimated, the shoe hits the stop before the rail settles. Then we are rigid again."

"Yes."

I hate tests where the right answer is also bad news.

"Can we change the limit?"

"Before load, yes."

She shows me three settings: one finger, one and a half, two.

"Why not just use two?"

"Too much travel and the nose can climb out of alignment."

"So the right setting depends on the landing."

"Yes."

I look at Iven's sketch.

"He can measure the slope."

"He has no level."

"He has a bed-frame strip."

Harra smiles.

We send the question to the upper glass.

Five minutes later, Renn comes back with Iven's reply copied beneath it.

You people have become very bossy.

I give Renn my answer. "Experience."

Two more trips get us the measurements. Iven uses the bed-frame strip and the edge of a wall block, then measures again near the stair remnant. The slope is slightly worse than our estimate.

Not much.

Enough.

Harra moves the stop bolts to the two-finger setting.

One uncertainty smaller.

At this point, I will take my miracles in fractions.

—○—

Sella's eastbound team sends another note.

Departure remains the fourth day after acceptance, but not until after midday.

She reads it by the window. I can see the arithmetic happening behind her eyes.

"I can do the rescue and still leave."

"If the rescue happens that morning."

"Yes."

"If it goes clean."

“Yes.”
“And if it doesn’t?”
She folds the paper carefully.
“That is why I am telling you now.”
I make myself say it.
“If it runs long, you go.”
Her head comes up. “Maya.”
“You go.”
“Iven—”
“Has Harra, Oret, Dain, Tolliver, and me, assuming Mara eventually returns my leg from state custody.”
“Maya.”
“You already delayed one job because of the rescue.”
“That was my choice.”
“Yes.”
“So is this.”
I look at her.
I want to tell her she is wrong and make it sound like love.
The desire has claws.
Instead I say, “I don’t want you staying because you’re afraid I’ll think leaving means you chose me wrong.”
Sella goes very still.
“That is almost emotionally competent.”
“Do not ruin it.”
She sits beside me, thigh against mine.
“You are not temporary.”
Her eyes drop to our knees. “I know what you mean.”
“That sounds ominous.”
“It is supposed to sound complicated.”
She takes my hand.
“There are things I want,” she says. “Roads. Moving work. Places I haven’t seen. Enough money that I can stop pretending terrible contracts are interesting.”
“Reasonable.”
“It is.”
Her thumb moves across my knuckles.
“And I want you.”
My throat tightens.
“I know.”
“No. Listen.”

So I do.

"I want you. I don't want to become the reason you cut every other part of yourself away so I can feel safe."

I look toward the yard even though Tolliver is not there.

Sella follows my eyes anyway.

"Exactly."

"I hate this conversation."

"So do I."

"Good. Mutual suffering."

I lean my forehead against her shoulder.

She kisses my hair.

No solution appears.

Nothing resolves just because both of us are being reasonable. Terrible design choice.

—○—

The second day of rest is worse because I feel better. The swelling is down, the ankle moves without making me see God, and the mender rewards this triumph with flat indoor walking and a stick. Still no stairs, rough ground, or powered loading.

"You are learning," she says.

"Do not sound surprised."

"I have evidence."

I make three laps of the kitchen because freedom has become humiliatingly small. On the fourth, Tolliver appears in the doorway with a coil of new line.

"You are limping."

"You are observant."

"You limped less on the second lap."

I stop. "You were not invited to audit my limp."

"Still true."

He puts down the line.

Outside, under canvas, the full rescue frame is finally assembled: longer than the first one, not much heavier, and built to come apart instead of dragging two pieces of stone into an argument.

I am allowed to watch the dry tests from the doorway, in the chair again with my foot up while everyone else gets to touch the machinery.

Harra has written the roles on a board. Iven controls the far catch. Harra the near release. Tolliver the haul line. Sella the person crossing. I call hold or release.

That last line makes my stomach feel hollow.
Nobody comments.

—○—

The dry test uses wet sand: Iven's weight, then gear, then extra load for the way frightened people grab whatever is near. They skew the frame and cycle the release until, on the fifth run, the near brace squeaks.

I raise my hand. Harra stops.

The frame has not moved. The anchor has, less than a nail-width.

Oret points to the packing wedge. "Wood compressed."

Harra swears. A shim moved while everybody was staring at the machine, exactly the sort of small thing that kills people. They replace it with an iron-backed wedge, and the next cycles stay quiet.

My measure flickers at the edge of sight.

I ignore it.

For once, I am not interested in being rewarded for paying attention.

—○—

Captain Rusk returns before sunset with three crew instead of six, no shear legs, and one mule carrying tackle and a covered bundle.

Pell meets her halfway across the yard.

I am still in the kitchen doorway, Sella behind my chair. Tolliver is at the pump. He sees Rusk and stops.

Rusk sees him.

Then me.

"Warder."

"Captain."

Her eyes drop to my ankle. "East Relief?"

I dislike competent enemies.

"Tourism."

"You found something."

Pell cuts in. "What do you want, Rusk?"

Rusk takes a folded notice from her coat.

"My claim has been acknowledged for hearing."

Pell does not take the paper immediately.

"By whom?"

"District salvage clerk."

"That is not a ruling."

"No."

“What does it give you?”

“Preservation rights over disputed recovered inner iron until the hearing.”

My stomach drops before I fully understand why.

Pell takes the notice.

Vey appears from nowhere, which seems to be his relationship with paper.

Rusk looks toward the covered frame. “Any inner-works fitting recovered through the lower station falls under the hold.”

Harra steps out of the forge yard.

“Iven is not a fitting.”

“No.”

“The frame is ours.”

“Yes.”

“The East Relief shoe is not from your claim.”

Rusk’s mouth tightens. “Correct.”

She is not here to steal everything.

That almost makes it worse.

Pell reads the notice twice. “You cannot block a human extraction.”

“No.”

“But?”

Rusk looks at me.

“If the extraction brings disputed fittings across, you leave them in place or put them into joint hold pending hearing.”

There it is. Rusk has not put a wall in front of the rescue. She has put a hand on the box we may open afterward.

I think of the gray door in Iven’s room. The EXIT sign. The Earth-made fasteners. The objects that should not be here and therefore might be the only physical proof that somebody, somehow, crossed the same impossible distance I did.

I have been treating them like clues.

Rusk’s paper turns them into material.

Recovered iron.

Tagged property.

A list in somebody else’s handwriting.

The anger arrives so quickly I taste metal.

Vey says, “You chose excellent timing.”

“I chose the hearing schedule.”

“You filed after you left.”

“Yes.”

Pell keeps reading.

I stare at Rusk's notice and see the EXIT sign taken down, wrapped, numbered, argued over by men who have never heard of Missouri.

Something in my chest goes tight enough that Sella's fingers touch the back of my chair.

I do not look at her.

Rusk says, "I want a witness at the lower works."

"No," Pell says.

"I have preservation rights."

"To disputed material. Not automatic access to my works."

"Then every claimed item comes to the yard for inspection."

Pell says nothing.

Because that is probably close enough to legal to become expensive.

I hate expensive enough.

—○—

The meeting runs until moonrise.

We end with terms ugly enough to be useful.

Rusk does not enter the lower chamber before the extraction. One of her crew may wait at the upper works with Vey as witness.

Recovered iron that is not necessary to keep Iven alive is tagged and held at Rook pending the hearing.

Personal papers, clothing, food, letters, and ordinary effects stay with Iven.

Then Vey writes the line I care about most.

EARTH OBJECTS ARE NOT AUTOMATICALLY SALVAGE
SOLELY BECAUSE THEY CONTAIN METAL. PROVENANCE
REMAINS DISPUTED.

Rusk reads it.

"That is broad."

"So is your claim," Vey says.

For once in my life, I could kiss a factor.

Rusk adds a condition of her own.

"If the route opens into recoverable inner works after the man is out, nobody strips the site before hearing."

Pell agrees.

Harra says we were not planning to strip anything.

Rusk looks at me.

"You went to East Relief."

"Not your claim."

“No.”

Her expression almost becomes a smile.

“You learn quickly.”

“I get injured quickly too.”

“I noticed.”

She camps outside Rook instead of taking Pell’s room offer.

Good.

I do not want the person who nearly turned the only Earth objects I have ever seen in this world into an inventory sleeping under the same roof.

—○—

On the third morning, the mender lets me walk to the yard and back. The ankle stays sore but stable, which finally earns me limited loading tomorrow: flat route, no running or jumping, no Stepguard unless the alternative is worse, and one planned use of Brace.

“That is strangely specific.”

“Because you turn permission into philosophy.”

Unfortunately, that tracks.

“If pain sharpens, you are out.”

“Out how?”

“Carried.”

“Medical cruelty.”

“Medical consequence.”

I agree.

Tomorrow is rescue day. Sella leaves after midday. The pressure trend near dawn may give us a widening interval, and the frame has passed its dry tests.

I write three letters on my wrist in charcoal.

P. V. L.

Pressure. Vibration. Landing.

Sella sees them.

“Very sophisticated.”

“Field notation.”

“You wrote three letters on yourself.”

“I am a professional.”

She kisses my temple.

Tolliver comes in carrying the haul line and sees her mouth leave my skin.

He puts the line down.

“Harra wants you to call the final sequence.”

I look at him. "Me?"
"She says this part is Warder work."
I hate how much I want that.
Sella's hand stays on my shoulder.
I stand carefully.
The ankle holds.
"Fine. But if I say release, you release."
Tolliver's gaze sharpens. "Yes."
"No heroic correction."
"Yes."
"No deciding I am wrong because I am the person on the frame."
He goes still.
Good.
That one needed to land.
"Yes."
Sella looks between us.
Something in her face hurts to see, but she does not take her hand away.
Tolliver steps close enough to be heard quietly and no closer.
"You call. I follow."
Heat moves under my skin.
Sella squeezes my shoulder.
"Tomorrow," she says, "try to keep your professional face."
"I hate both of you."
"No," she says.
Tolliver wisely does not answer for me.
Tomorrow we go back to Fallow Reach.
Tomorrow we bring Iven out, or we learn exactly why we cannot.
After midday, one way or another, Sella leaves east.
There are too many clocks in the room.
I stop looking at all of them.
Pressure, vibration, landing. Three things to watch, and beneath all of them one job: bring him home alive.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

At dawn, the boundary is wide enough to show Iven's whole face.

That should feel like good news.

Instead it scares me.

He is thinner than the first time I saw him clearly. Beard longer. Cheeks sharper. The left sleeve of his shirt is patched with the linen we sent, and that stupid little square of cloth nearly undoes me.

He used the needle.

He has been there long enough to mend things.

Down at the near ledge, with the sleeve glass no longer bending his voice into something distant, Dain says his name.

"Yes, I heard you the first time."

Thin voice.

Ordinary voice.

Alive.

Dain makes him repeat one number, then answers another. Slates stay ready for when the opening narrows, but for now we can speak.

Harra looks toward the gauge.

"Pressure?"

"Rising. Slow."

Oret watches the waxed pointer fixed to the near wall. "Vibration quiet."

Iven raises his measuring strip on the far side. "Landing dry. No new shift."

I touch the letters on my wrist.

P. V. L.

Pressure. Vibration. Landing.

Sella stands to my left with the rescue belt and board hook. Tolliver is on my right with the haul line and brake. Harra kneels beside the frame. Oret has the spring housing. Dain watches the stone.

The mender waits above with Mara and Pell.

Rusk's witness is at the upper works with Vey, where the agreement says he belongs.

Iven looks through the opening.

"Everyone ready?"

"No," I say.

He smiles.

"Good."

—○—

We measure everything again, then run one loaded cycle before any person goes near the frame. Iven catches the guide without taking load. Tolliver feeds the line, Sella controls the swing, and the short nose crosses into wrong air until the far shoe reaches his landing.

Pressure rising. Vibration quiet. Stone quiet.

"Seat."

The spring takes one finger. Harra loads the board to Iven's weight plus gear. The pointer moves two scratches and stops; the spring compresses and returns cleanly.

"Recover load."

Iven releases the far latch first. Tolliver brings the weight home. One clean cycle.

Nobody cheers.

We are getting very good at being terrified professionals.

—○—

The second cycle sends the rescue belt across. Sella has rebuilt it twice: chest loop, hip loop, two quick releases, nothing around the throat and nothing Iven cannot reach himself.

She makes Iven prove both releases, reset them, and prove them again until he groans.

Sella does not blink.

I love her.

The thought arrives without warning and feels less like discovery than getting caught by something I already knew.

Sella glances toward me, eyes softening for half a second, then turns back to Iven.

"Good. Leave it on."

—○—

A runner comes down from above at exactly the wrong moment.

Pell's voice follows.

"Hold operation."

Everything stops.

Nothing crosses. Tolliver ties off the haul line. Sella's hand settles on her knife.

I know who is upstairs before Pell says the name.

"Rusk moved her witness."

Harra closes her eyes.

"What?"

"She is at the upper works with two crew."

Agreement broken.

Vey is already arguing.

Rusk's voice carries faintly through the stone, calm enough to be worse than shouting.

"I have not entered the lower chamber."

Pell says, "You entered the works."

"The preservation order requires observation."

"The agreement did not."

"I have reason to believe disputed inner iron is being prepared for removal."

I look through the boundary at Iven's room.

The metal cabinet.

The old rail.

The Earth hardware.

Things I have spent days imagining as answers.

Rusk is not trying to stop the rescue.

She is making sure I know the answers may stay behind.

Harra says my name.

I look at her.

"The legal decision is not yours," she says. "The sequence is."

Pell comes down to us, face hard.

"Rusk says anything disputed that crosses gets seized into joint hold in the upper gallery."

Sella's voice goes flat. "And Iven?"

"No custody right."

"Paper does not stop hands."

"No."

Tolliver looks at me and waits for my call.

Iven has heard enough.

“What iron do I need?” he asks.

Harra answers immediately. “None.”

“Then I leave it.”

Behind him, the imported cabinet catches the gray light.

I have no idea what it holds, and the uncertainty is the part that hurts.

“Iven comes with clothes, papers, food, water, and non-iron personal things,” I say.

Pell nods.

Iven lifts the bed-frame strip. “This?”

“Leave it,” Harra says.

He lets it fall.

The small sound of metal hitting stone makes the cost immediate: today, the mystery stays on the far side so Iven can come out clean.

“Continue,” I say.

—○—

Rusk does not stop us.

That would be easier.

One of her crew comes down only as far as the last permitted landing. Vey follows him.

Witness on witness.

Pell stands between them and the lower stair.

The frame goes out again and seats cleanly. Iven stands in the belt with letters and papers tied flat to his chest, no iron. Sella confirms both releases; Tolliver checks the haul, Harra the anchor, Oret the spring, Dain the vibration.

Pressure continues rising.

Iven is one step from the board.

I stand.

My ankle aches inside the brace, but not sharply.

Sella notices.

“Same?”

“Same.”

She nods.

Tolliver looks over.

“Same,” I tell him.

He accepts the answer and looks back to the line.

The fact that he accepts it without taking over lands somewhere inconvenient. I put it away.

Iven steps onto the board.

The spring compresses to one finger.

Then a little more.

“Good,” Oret says.

The vibration pointer moves two scratches and stops.

Dain nods.

Iven shifts.

The rail twists slightly.

“Center.”

He does.

The twist eases.

Sella takes the rescue tether without pulling it. Tolliver has the board haul. Harra has the release.

I have the call.

Iven steps again.

Half his body crosses.

My brain rejects the sight.

His front is here.

His back is there.

I know that sentence is nonsense.

My brain does not care.

“Pressure?”

“Rising.”

“Vibration?”

“Three.”

“Spring?”

“One and a half.”

Still inside limit.

“Move.”

Tolliver takes one controlled draw.

Iven advances.

Then the boundary narrows.

Not much.

Enough.

Dain says, “Stop.”

Everybody stops.

The gauge has not fallen.

The delay.

We knew about the delay.
Knowing it on paper is not the same as watching the edge descend
behind a man's shoulder.
"Vibration four," Oret says.
"Frame stable," Harra says.
"Boundary still narrowing," Dain says.
Iven is exactly at midpoint.
Of course he is.
The rule says reverse before midpoint. After midpoint, continue only if
the near route is clearly shorter and the supports remain good.
"Distance?" I ask.
Sella judges the board.
"Same."
Perfectly unhelpful.
The boundary narrows another finger.
"Spring one and three-quarter."
"Vibration five."
The numbers are no longer reassuring.
From above, Rusk says, "Do not bring claimed hardware with him."
Sella's head snaps toward the stair.
Iven says, "I have none."
One breath lost.
Then another.
I look at the board.
"Back."
No one argues.
Tolliver reverses.
Sella feeds tether.
Iven steps toward his room.
The far shoe compresses to two fingers.
Hard stop.
The rail goes rigid.
My stomach drops.
"Release far."
Harra pulls the latch.
Nothing.
Again.
The line jumps but does not travel.
"Bound."
The loaded shoe has twisted against the side lip.

The pointer jumps to six.
Then seven.
Something far below the chamber answers with one heavy knock.
Not a creature.
A mechanism.
Old.
Large.
Another knock follows.
The connected stone has woken up.
With Iven still on the frame.
Tolliver hauls harder.
The rail grinds.
“Stop.”
He stops immediately.
The vibration does not.
Stored twist.
Exactly what the release was supposed to prevent.
I can Brace the near anchor.
I know before I do it why that is wrong.
Holding the near end still will make the far jam take more.
The frame does not need to become stronger.
It needs somewhere to move.
“Near clamp. Open one notch.”
Harra stares at me. “That adds motion.”
“Yes.”
“The boundary is contracting.”
“Give the twist somewhere else.”
Her face changes.
She sees it.
“Near clamp one.”
Tolliver reaches for the catch.
Harra says, “Not you.”
His hand stops.
Roles.
She opens the clamp one notch.
The near rail shifts half a finger.
The frame rotates.
The far shoe comes free.
“Now.”
Harra yanks the release.

The spring discharges into the shoe instead of through the rail.
Iven drops to one knee.
Sella catches the tether.
Tolliver waits.
The boundary keeps contracting.
“Back.”
He pulls.
Iven scrambles for his landing.
The empty front section of the frame stays inside the boundary one heartbeat too long.
The edge passes through a crossbrace.
Clean cut.
The frame jerks.
Iven falls clear on his side.
He is alive on the far side. The rescue failed. He did not.
The severed brace disappears into whatever exists between here and there.
Silence.
Then the old mechanism below gives one final knock and stops.
Iven rolls onto his back.
Raises one hand.
“I’m fine.”
Sella sits down hard.
Tolliver closes his eyes.
Harra’s hands are shaking.
Mine are too.
Mara comes three steps down before Pell physically stops her at the safety line.
“What happened?”
“Abort worked,” I say.
My voice sounds like somebody else’s.
Harra looks at the frame.
“Barely.”
I look at the released far shoe.
At the shifted near clamp.
At the empty section that got cut.
“No. It worked because we stopped trying to save the frame.”
Everyone looks at me.
“We can replace a brace.”
Harra’s breathing slows.

"The spring housing took side load."

"Can you inspect it?"

"Yes."

"Then inspect it."

Dain watches the pointer settle back to one.

The boundary has already stopped narrowing.

Lag.

Again.

Sella gets to her feet.

"What now?"

I look at Iven.

He is sitting up, angry enough to be healthy.

From above, Rusk says, "Operation is concluded."

I laugh.

It comes out sharp.

Pell says my name.

I am looking at the near clamp.

The one notch that saved the release.

"We made both sides too fixed."

Harra follows my gaze.

"We need support."

"Yes. But not a locked near head."

Oret understands first.

"Captured guide."

Harra turns to him.

"A floating head," he says. "Near end can travel without leaving the cradle."

Dain nods. "Decouple the sides."

We kept saying *independent support* and then built a frame that still wanted to behave like one rigid object.

Iven calls through the opening.

"Can you change it today?"

Nobody answers immediately.

Harra studies the damaged brace.

"One hour to replace that and convert the near head. Less if Oret already has the sleeve stock."

"I have it."

Mara says, "No second human attempt without full inspection."

"Yes," I say.

She looks at me, surprised.

“Full inspection. Dry cycle. No person until it passes.”
Sella exhales.
Tolliver looks at me.
“You’re not rushing.”
“I’m trying not to.”
A small smile touches his mouth.
Pride, maybe.
It hits harder than I want it to.
Sella sees.
She takes my hand anyway.
“One hour,” she says.
Her team leaves after midday.
The rescue is not done.
The first human crossing failed.
Iven is still trapped.
But he is alive, and the failure showed us where the frame lied.
Above us, Rusk and Vey begin arguing over whether a severed
crossbrace counts as recovered inner iron.
I start laughing again.
Sella leans into me.
Tolliver shakes his head.
Harra says, “If you’re finished losing your mind, I need the drawing
board.”
I am not finished.
But I get the board.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The second frame is less of a frame.

That is progress.

Harra replaces the rigid near clamp with a captured sleeve that can travel one finger along the anchor bar. The far shoe still has two. Both ends can move; neither can come free without a deliberate release. Oret replaces the cut crossbrace while Dain watches the stone for any answer from below.

The first dry cycle is ugly. The near sleeve slides too fast, so Harra adds friction leather. By the fourth, a deliberately skewed load settles instead of twisting and the vibration falls on its own. They run it twice more.

No knock comes from below.

By the sixth cycle, the frame moves the way it was supposed to move yesterday.

My measure flickers at the edge of sight.

I ignore it.

I am becoming excellent at ignoring divine user interface.

—○—

Captain Rusk loses patience at exactly the moment we become ready.

She comes down to Pell's safety line and stops with her boot toes at the chalk mark. Vey is beside her. One of her crew stands behind.

"I will not permit a second extraction attempt while the site is unstable."

Pell turns toward her. "You do not permit rescue."

"I permit my crew to withdraw from unsafe work."

"They are not working."

"I am a recognized claimant in an active works hazard."

Harra keeps her hands on the spring housing.

Rusk points toward the chamber. "You woke an isolation section."

"We stopped it," Dain says.

"You triggered it."

"The frame triggered it."

"The distinction will comfort the dead."

Harra flinches.

Tiny.

I see it.

Rusk sees it too.

That makes me angry enough to become calm.

"The boundary nearly reached Iven," I say. "We aborted before it did."

Rusk looks at me. "And now you want another attempt."

"Yes."

"Why?"

I point to the new sleeve, then the far shoe. "Because the release bound under rigid load. Now both ends can travel, and the changed design has six clean dry cycles."

"You are injured, level five, and you attempted a human crossing after one day of prototype work."

"State your demand," Pell says.

"Wait until tomorrow. Let my rigger inspect the site. Then proceed jointly."

There it is.

Jointly.

Safety and custody wearing the same coat. Maybe she means the safety part. That does not make the custody part disappear.

I look through the opening.

Iven sits against his wall, exhausted from the failed attempt. His water tank is lower than yesterday.

We do not turn that into hours.

Sella checks the sun mark on the stair.

Her team leaves after midday.

Harra finally stands.

"Your rigger uses rigid shear loading."

"He knows his work."

"So do I."

"You nearly cut a man in half."

Harra goes still again.

I answer before she has to.

"We nearly lost him because our release bound. We changed the part that bound."

Rusk studies the frame.

"What if you are wrong?"

The room becomes colder.

There is no clever answer.

"We abort."

"And if abort fails?"

I swallow.

"Emergency cut. We send him to whichever side is closer."

Rusk's brows lift.

Sella knows about the sacrificial joint. Harra built it after the first attempt. A narrow pin divides the rescue board so the structure can be sacrificed without asking a person to stay attached to it.

Rusk looks at Harra. "You built that today?"

"Yes."

Silence.

Then Rusk says, "I still advise waiting."

Advise.

Different word.

Pell hears it too.

"So noted."

Rusk steps back from the line.

Rusk is not defeated, only contained, and I can live with that for the next hour.

—○—

Sella finds me alone for perhaps thirty seconds before the second attempt.

Today romance gets exactly thirty seconds.

I am checking the rescue belt when she takes it from my hands.

"Maya."

"What?"

"If this runs past midday."

My chest tightens.

"You go."

"You already said that."

"I need to know you are not lying now."

The lower chamber is twenty steps away.

Iven is waiting.

Tolliver is checking the haul brake.

Harra is tightening the sacrificial joint.

Sella is leaving.

All of those things are true at the same time.

"If the rescue is stable and I am not the only thing keeping someone alive, you go."

Her face changes.

“And if you are?”
“Then you decide.”
She hates that.
Good.
It belongs to her.
“I love you,” I say.
The words leave before I can build anything around them.
Sella stops breathing.
So do I.
Perfect. I confess love with a rescue crew waiting twenty steps away.
“You absolute asshole.”
“That seems unfair.”
“You waited until a rescue attempt.”
“I did not schedule it.”
“You schedule nothing.”
She has me there.
She catches my face and kisses me.
Hard.
Brief.
Not a kiss for privacy or patience. A kiss for thirty seconds.
When she lets go, her forehead touches mine.
“I love you too.”
My chest hurts.
“And I am still leaving.”
“I know.”
“And you are still falling in love with him, or already there, or whatever disaster this is.”
I close my eyes.
“I know.”
“Good.”
“That word is carrying too much today.”
“It can manage.”
A terrible Warder joke.
I laugh anyway.
She gives me the belt.
“Bring him home.”

—○—

The second attempt begins almost quietly.
Pressure rising. Vibration still. Landing dry.

The frame seats with one finger at the far shoe and half at the near sleeve. Iven wears the belt, one cloth water flask, and his papers tied flat against his chest. No cabinet. No bed-frame strip. No salvaged answers.

Sella checks the belt, Tolliver the haul, Harra both releases. I rest one hand lightly on the near rail and feel only ordinary movement.

“Call,” Harra says.

“Move.”

Iven steps onto the board.

The far shoe gives.

The near sleeve gives.

The rail stays straight.

He steps again.

Tolliver draws.

Slow.

Sella feeds tether.

Iven reaches the boundary and crosses.

One step.

Then another.

Midpoint.

Vibration two.

The near sleeve reaches its one-finger stop.

The far shoe is at one and a quarter.

Harra says, “Near limit.”

“I know.”

Iven is still moving, but we have spent the near travel.

“Pause.”

Everything stops.

The visible edge trembles.

Not contraction.

Something else.

Dain looks at the gauge. “Pressure spike.”

Oret says, “Vibration four.”

A heavy knock comes from below.

My stomach drops.

The frame is not twisted this time.

Dain puts his hand to the wall.

“Not us.”

“What changed?”

“Below.”

Another knock.

Then grinding stone.
The old isolation system is moving because of the pressure itself.
We fixed one problem.
The works kept another.
The far landing shifts.
Iven feels it first.
“Stone moved.”
“Spring one and three-quarter,” Oret says.
No room at the near sleeve.
Almost none at the far.
Iven is past midpoint now.
Closer to us.
“Continue.”
Tolliver draws.
The board moves one hand.
The boundary contracts.
Fast.
Dain shouts, “Pressure falling.”
“Iven, move.”
He moves.
Sella takes the tether hand over hand, enough to keep him centered without dragging him.
The far shoe hits its two-finger stop.
The near sleeve is already at one.
The frame goes rigid.
The design did what it could. We have simply used every inch of travel we gave it.
Vibration climbs to six.
Another knock shakes the stone.
Harra reaches for the far release.
I see the problem.
If she opens it now, Iven is still standing on that section.
“Wait.”
She freezes.
The boundary edge drops behind him.
Too close.
Iven is nearer us.
The sacrificial joint is nearer him than the far landing.
There is only one useful piece of arithmetic left.
“Break the joint.”

Harra goes white.
 “His back foot—”
 “Iven. Forward.”
 He lunges one step.
 His rear boot clears the marked segment.
 “Now.”
 Harra slams the release lever.
 The sacrificial pin shears.
 The far third of the rescue board drops out of alignment just as the
 boundary reaches it.
 The edge cuts through the falling section.
 The remaining frame jerks toward us.
 Iven falls forward.
 The belt snaps tight.
 Tolliver hauls.
 Sella pulls tether.
 The near sleeve is still hard against its stop, and the frame begins to
 wrench sideways.
 I set both forearms against the near anchor shoe and Brace.
 6 / 7 → 5 / 7
 I am holding the anchor shoe, not the whole frame.
 One breath of load so Harra can open the near release.
 “Near.”
 She slams it.
 The captured sleeve opens.
 The frame shifts.
 The boundary drops behind Iven’s hips.
 Tolliver hauls again.
 Iven slides across the near board.
 Hand.
 Elbow.
 Shoulder.
 Almost through.
 The old mechanism below slams.
 The anchor bucks beneath my Brace.
 Pain flashes through my ankle.
 Sharp.
 I can hold another breath.
 That is exactly why I do not.
 I release.

The near frame jumps free.

Harra lets it go.

Tolliver gives the haul line one hand of slack so the structure can move instead of transferring the force into Iven.

Then he hauls again.

Sella never lets go of the tether.

Nobody wastes a hand trying to preserve the frame; every adjustment serves Iven.

The boundary cuts the last empty piece of board.

Iven comes across on his stomach.

Sella catches one arm.

Tolliver catches the belt.

I catch absolutely nothing because my ankle gives and I hit the floor.

For one terrifying second, all I can see is boots.

Then Mara is shouting.

Harra is shouting.

Somebody is laughing.

Somebody is crying.

Possibly me.

I push up on my hands.

Iven is on our side, all of him, alive. There is no music or light or System announcement, only a tired man face-down on wet stone while Sella tries to roll him and Tolliver says, "Wait for the mender."

Iven lifts his head and looks at me.

"You fall a lot."

I start sobbing hard enough to laugh through it.

"Fuck you."

He smiles.

Then Mara reaches him.

—○—

Medical work is mostly people being rude for excellent reasons.

The mender orders everyone back except Mara. She checks Iven's pupils, pulse, hands, feet, breathing. Makes him say his name. Gives him two mouthfuls of water and takes the cup away.

He tries to sit.

She pushes him flat.

He looks offended, so ordinarily irritated that relief almost knocks the breath out of me.

My ankle is still screaming.

The mender notices because bodies have no secrets from her.

“You.”

“I’m fine.”

“You are on the floor.”

“I like floors.”

She looks at Tolliver.

“No.”

He stops.

I point at the mender. “I can move.”

I try.

My ankle votes.

“Fine. He can carry me.”

Tolliver waits.

“Can I?”

“Yes.”

He picks me up, one arm under my knees, one behind my back, with a care that does not make the lift look difficult.

My body chooses now to notice that.

Deeply unserious.

His face is not.

“You released,” he says quietly.

I know what he means.

The last breath.

“Yes.”

“You knew I had him.”

I look toward Iven.

Sella and Mara have him sitting now.

Harra is checking the ruined frame.

Dain is watching the dead pointer.

“You had him.”

Tolliver’s eyes meet mine.

The trust between us has changed temperature. I can deal with that later, when nobody is bleeding or vomiting.

I rest my head against his shoulder for exactly one breath.

Then Sella is beside us, exhausted and bright-eyed and sad around the edges.

She touches my boot.

“Alive?”

“Unfortunately.”

“Good.”

Tolliver lowers me onto the treatment bench.
Sella kisses my forehead and turns back to Iven.
Professional first.
Always.

—○—

The System arrives while Iven is throwing up.

Perfect.

I am sitting with my ankle elevated and holding a cup the mender will not let me drink from yet when the measure opens.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 5]

[PROGRESS: 26 / 26]

I blink.

I had not checked the target since level five.

The text folds.

[WARDER ADVANCEMENT]

[LEVEL 6]

[RESERVE CAPACITY: 8]

[CURRENT RESERVE: 5 / 8]

More room.

Same ankle.

Good.

Then another line appears.

[TECHNIQUE RECOGNITION UPDATED]

[RELEASE UNDER LOAD → CONTROLLED RELEASE]

I stare at it.

The phrase itself is plain. What catches me is knowing exactly which moment the System means.

The measure closes.

Sella is leaving today.

Iven is home.

The Earth objects are still on the far side.

Rusk still has her claim.

Tolliver is standing ten feet away with somebody else's blood on one sleeve.

The list of unsolved problems is still ridiculous, but the shape of my life has changed anyway.

“Level?” Sella asks.

“Six.”

She laughs.

Actually laughs.

Then Iven vomits again.

She points at him. “You level during that.”

“I do not control presentation.”

Harra glances over. “Ability?”

“No. Capacity eight. Five current.”

The mender says, “And none of it gets used today.”

“I know.”

Her eyebrows rise.

“Stop looking surprised.”

—○—

Rusk enters the lower chamber only after Pell gives permission.

By then, Iven is wrapped in blankets and sitting against the wall on our side.

Alive.

Rusk stops when she sees him.

Then looks at the severed frame.

Then through the boundary into the room he left.

“Successful extraction.”

Iven looks up. “Apparently.”

“I am Captain Rusk.”

“I gathered.”

“You left iron material on the receiving side.”

“Yes.”

“By instruction?”

“Yes,” I say.

Her eyes move to me.

The preservation fight she came for has nothing physical to seize.

We paid that cost before the crossing.

Vey steps down with the written agreement.

“Personal papers and non-iron effects remain Iven’s.”

“I am aware.”

Iven pats the cloth packet against his chest.

“Good.”

Rusk looks through the opening.

The cabinet remains.

The bed-frame strip.
The old hardware.
All the things I wanted to touch.
Her claim is preserved.
For now.
But she did not gain custody of Iven.
She did not gain exclusive access.
She did not get the papers against his chest.
That matters enough that I can live with the rest today.
Rusk looks at the ruined frame.
“You will not get another person through that route.”
Harra says, “Not with that frame.”
Rusk’s gaze sharpens.
Future problem.
Pell says, “Captain.”
Rusk nods once.
“I maintain the claim.”
“I assumed.”
She leaves without a speech or threat.
Paperwork survives everything.

—○—

The mender lets Iven walk the final yard with one person on each side.
Teren and Lio are waiting outside Rook.
I have seen them wait before.
Never like this.
At first, nobody moves.
Iven freezes.
So do the boys.
Then Lio runs.
Teren follows.
Mara says something about careful and is ignored by everyone with
blood in the argument.
They hit Iven hard enough that Sella takes one step forward.
Mara stops her.
He stays standing.
Barely.
His arms close around both boys.
No System text.
Just a father making a sound I have never heard from a grown man.

I look away because I cannot take all of it at once.
Tolliver is beside me.
Sella is on my other side.
Her departure pack waits against the west wall.
Of course it does.
The world is cruel enough to put goodbye beside reunion.
Sella finds my hand.
Tolliver does not touch me.
Good.
This moment is not about him.
It is not really about me either.
Iven kneels despite Mara's protest. His sons cling to him.
Pell cries openly.
Harra pretends to inspect a strap.
Oret does not pretend anything.
Dain sits on a stone and covers his face.
I think of Earth.
My mother.
Liam.
Everyone I cannot simply haul through a boundary if I build the right
frame.
The grief is still there.
I have stopped expecting it to leave.
Sella squeezes my hand.
Her wagon leaves in less than an hour.
I let that hurt too.
Across the yard, Iven laughs into his sons' hair.
We brought him home.
His home.
For today, that is enough.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Sella's wagon is late. Seven minutes. I know because I ask three different people what time it is, and the third looks at me as though I am trying to intimidate the sun into moving faster. I cannot defend myself. My ankle is wrapped again. The mender has upgraded me from *do not be stupid* to *do not stand unless the building is on fire*, which she insists is an important distinction in medicine. Iven is inside with Teren and Lio.

Pell is in the counting room with Rusk and Vey arguing over drainage rights, salvage holds, and which pieces of our ruined rescue frame count as evidence. Harra is asleep at a worktable with her cheek on a coil of rope. Tolliver is somewhere I cannot see him. Good. Sella's pack is beside the west wall. Bad.

She has changed out of the clothes she wore into the lower works. Clean shirt. Dark trousers. Soft leather coat. Bow across her back. The knife at her thigh is the same one she wore the first night we slept together. I stare long enough that she catches me.

"Really?"

"I was looking at the sheath."

"Liar."

"Tactically."

"With terrible timing."

That hurts because it is funny. For the last two weeks she has touched me whenever she wanted: hip, shoulder, back of my neck, fingers under a table, mouth against mine in hallways. Small things that became ours by repetition. Now there is a foot of air between us. I feel every inch.

"Walk with me," she says.

From across the room, the mender says, "No." Sella turns. "Outside."

"No."

"Five steps."

"No."

"Three."

The mender points at the bench. "You can sit outside with her if Tolliver carries the bench." I close my eyes. Sella laughs. The mender does not.

"This is why healers drink," I say.

"This is why healers poison patients."

Tolliver appears in the doorway at exactly the wrong moment. Of course he does. He looks at the bench. Then at the mender.

"No."

Good man. The mender raises one eyebrow.

"I'll carry Maya," he says. "The bench is stupid."

"Thank you."

She points at me. "You are the stupid part." She has a point. Tolliver does not move until I nod. That still catches under my ribs in a way I have stopped pretending is accidental. He lifts me. Sella takes my pack because my official role has become decorative object. Outside, the afternoon is thin and bright after the rain. Rook smells like wet stone, horse sweat, boiled grain, and the sharp oil Harra uses on metal. The wagon is still not here. Seven minutes becomes nine.

Sella leads us to the low wall beside the east herb beds. Tolliver lowers me onto it, careful with the bad foot. Sella puts my pack beneath my heel. He straightens.

"Do you need anything?"

"No."

His eyes move to Sella.

"I need ten minutes," she says.

He nods and walks away. He knows what those ten minutes are. I watch him cross the yard. Sella watches me watch him. There it is. No rescue to hide behind. No monster. No pressure gauge. Just us. She sits beside me. For a while, we say nothing. The yard continues around us. Somebody carries bread from the kitchen. A mule objects to being a mule. Pell comes out of the counting room, sees us, and immediately turns around. Bless her. Sella rubs both palms over her thighs.

"I meant what I said."

"I know."

"I love you."

I look down at my wrapped ankle because looking at bandages is easier than looking at her.

"I love you too."

"And I am still going."

"I know."

Her jaw shifts.

"You keep saying that."

"What do you want me to say?"

"I don't know."

That surprises me. Sella usually knows exactly what she wants people to say, or at least what she wants them not to say. She leans forward, elbows on her knees.

"I thought this would be easier if you didn't ask me to stay."

My throat tightens.

"I almost did."

She turns.

"I almost asked before the second crossing. Then when Iven came out. Then when you picked up your pack."

"Why didn't you?"

"Because you might have."

Her face goes still.

"That is what you think of me?"

"No."

I turn toward her despite the pull in my ankle.

"I think you love me. I think you already gave up one road when I was hurt. I think you have been standing still while I tried to decide whether this place could become a life."

She says nothing.

"If I asked today, after you watched me get carried out of a hole and heard me tell you I love you, there is a real chance staying would feel like kindness."

Her eyes go away from me. That is answer enough.

"And in a month," I say, "you would still want the road."

"Yes."

"Two months."

"Yes."

"And every time I looked at you, I would wonder whether I had turned the fact that you love me into a rope."

Sella swallows.

"So you decided for me."

"No."

Her head snaps back. I lift both hands.

"No. I refused to ask while the answer was tilted."

"That is still a decision."

"Yes."

"About us."

“Yes.”

She laughs once without humor.

“You are infuriating.”

“I know.”

“You don’t get points for knowing.”

I almost say it again. Stop myself. Her eyes fill. Not dramatically. Just water gathering faster than she can blink it away. I have seen her naked. Bleeding. Laughing into my mouth. Holding a knife against someone who deserved worse. I have not seen her cry. I reach toward her and stop halfway. She sees the pause. Then takes my hand. The permission hurts too.

“I wanted you to make it hard,” she says.

My thumb moves over her knuckles. “I am making it hard.”

“No. I wanted you to be selfish.”

“I am selfish.”

“Not with me.”

That lands cleanly. Maybe she is right. Maybe I have been brave enough to want her body and careful enough to avoid wanting her future out loud. Or maybe loving her future means not swallowing it. Both thoughts fit. Neither helps. She wipes her cheek with the heel of her hand.

“I can live with you wanting him.”

I say nothing.

“I mean it.”

Her voice cracks. She hates it and keeps going.

“I can live with you sleeping with him. I can live with you loving him if that is where this goes. I can live with you having things with him that you don’t have with me.”

My pulse jumps. She looks directly at me.

“But I cannot build my life around being the woman who waits for you to decide when you are done standing between doors.”

There is nothing to defend against in that. She is not asking me to erase Tolliver. She is not asking me to pick a person. She is telling me what kind of waiting would hollow her out.

“I don’t want you to wait.”

“I know.”

I flinch. She almost smiles. “Sorry.”

“Asshole.”

“Yes.”

The wagon rattles through the outer gate. My whole body reacts before my mind does. There. Horse. Canvas cover. Two people already seated in back. A woman driving. Departure made physical. Sella looks at it. Then at

me.

“We could stop,” she says.

I tighten my hand around hers.

“I don’t want to.”

She closes her eyes.

“Me neither.”

I breathe out.

“What does that mean?”

“For today?”

“Yes.”

“It means I go east.”

“Yes.”

“It means you figure out what you’re doing here.”

“Yes.”

“It means if I come back and you still want me, you tell me.”

My chest tightens.

“And if you meet someone?”

“I might.”

I nod. That hurts exactly as much as it should.

“If I do?”

“You tell me.”

“I will.”

“No noble silence because you think it protects me.”

“Fuck.”

“Maya.”

“Fine.”

She squeezes my hand.

“And him.”

“What about him?”

“Do not make me into an excuse not to touch him.”

Heat rises straight up my throat.

“Sella.”

“I mean it.”

“You are leaving me and giving me instructions about somebody else’s bed.”

“I’m saying if you want him, do not turn me into a dead wife in your head.”

“You are not dead.”

“Then stop looking at me like this is my funeral.”

I laugh. It comes out broken. She leans in until our foreheads touch. For another minute, I know exactly where she is.

"I love you," I whisper.

"I love you too."

"I'm sorry."

"For what?"

"Everything."

"Useless answer."

"You're right."

She kisses me. Not hard. Not desperate. Slow enough that my mouth recognizes every part of it. Her lower lip. The small catch in her breathing when I touch her cheek. Her fingers sliding into my hair and staying there. My body remembers bed with brutal precision. Her thigh over mine. Her mouth lower. My hands on her hips. This kiss does not try to become sex. It is trying to remember itself. When she pulls back, neither of us is dry-eyed. She wipes my face with her sleeve.

"Terrible."

"What?"

"You're ugly when you cry."

"I was going to say something nice."

"Suspicious."

The driver calls her name. Sella stands. I do not. The mender would kill me before the ankle gets the chance. She shoulders her pack. Then looks across the yard. Tolliver is by the stable arch, far enough away not to hear us. She walks over to him. I almost tell her not to. I don't. They speak for less than a minute. Tolliver's face gives me nothing. Sella says something that makes his eyes move toward me, then back to her. He nods once.

She punches him in the chest. Not hard. Probably. He looks offended. She says one more thing and walks away before he can answer. I stare at her when she comes back.

"What did you say?"

"Private conversation."

"I am the obvious subject."

"Still private."

"I hate both of you."

"You love at least one of us."

"I am reconsidering."

She bends and kisses my forehead. Then my mouth. One last time.

"Do something with your life, Maya Szczepaniak."

"I rescued a man this morning."

“Tomorrow too.”

The driver calls again. Sella turns. Walks to the wagon. Climbs in. She does not look back immediately. I am grateful. If she did, I might ask. The wagon starts toward the gate. At the last turn, she twists around and finds me. Two fingers touch her mouth and lift. Not exactly a kiss. Our stupid signal from the East Relief safe room. Still here. I raise two fingers back. The wagon passes through the gate. Gone. The yard looks larger.

I sit on the wall until the sound of wheels disappears. Then longer. Tolliver does not come over. Nobody does. Good. For once, everyone lets something hurt without trying to fix it.

—○—

Iven wakes after sunset. Mara allows me upstairs only if I am carried. I am becoming furniture. Tolliver takes me. He does not ask about Sella. In the long room, Iven lies beneath two blankets with his sons asleep on pallets beside him. Teren has one hand wrapped around his father’s wrist. Lio has stolen half the blanket. Iven looks exhausted. Human exhausted. The kind that belongs after surviving.

“Warder,” he says.

I stop.

“No.”

His eyebrows rise.

“Maya.”

“Better.”

Tolliver settles me into a chair. Iven watches him. Then me.

“Your friend left.”

The word *friend* is doing criminal labor.

“Yes.”

“Sorry.”

“Me too.”

He shifts against the pillow.

“I wanted to thank you while I was awake enough to mean it.”

“You already insulted me after I fell.”

“That was gratitude.”

“Cultural difference.”

Teren moves in his sleep. Iven looks down at the hand around his wrist like he still does not believe it is there.

“You told them to leave the iron.”

“Yes.”

“Even the strip with the stamped marks.”

“Yes.”

“That hurt.”

I look at the blanket.

“I could see your face from across the room,” he says.

Traitor face.

“I wanted answers.”

“And you chose me.”

I do not know what to do with that sentence. So I shrug.

“You were easier to carry.”

He smiles. Then sobers.

“I heard the captain. The claim is still active.”

“Yes.”

“She will want me at the hearing.”

“Probably.”

“Do I have to go?”

Tolliver answers before I can.

“No one has said that.”

Careful. Precise. No promise he cannot keep. Iven studies him, then looks at me.

“You trust him?”

The question is simple. The answer is not.

“Yes.”

Tolliver goes completely still beside the door. I do not look at him. Cowardice has uses. Iven nods.

“Good.”

“That is a lot of confidence for a man who met me through murder architecture.”

“You brought better people every time.”

That gets under my armor. Harra. Sella. Tolliver. Dain. Oret. Mara. Pell. Vey. Even Rusk, in the irritating way opposition forced every claim into daylight. I did not rescue Iven by myself. The thought is not humbling. It is relieving.

“I’m glad you’re here,” I say.

He looks at his sons.

“Me too.”

—○—

The mender orders me off the ankle for six more days.

Six.

I negotiate that into five and a half by walking perfectly on the sixth morning while she watches me with open hostility. Flat ground first. Then stairs. Two days later, light shield work. Normal walking comes back in pieces so small I almost miss how much I missed it.

The first morning I cross from my room to breakfast without anybody carrying me, I nearly cry over a hallway.

I do not.

Barely.

Sella sends no message.

There is no reason she should. Her crew is moving, and roads here do not come with little blue bubbles over people's heads. Knowing that does not stop me from looking toward the gate whenever wheels enter the yard.

On the third day, I find one of her hair ties under my bed.

It is a stupid thing. A strip of dark cloth knotted once where she shortened it. I sit on the floor with it in my palm until my ankle starts complaining and the mender catches me there.

She looks at the cloth.

Then at me.

For once, she does not say anything rude.

Worse.

"Don't," I tell her.

"I did not speak."

"Your face did."

"My face is medically neutral."

"Your face is a crime."

She helps me up anyway.

I put the tie in the top drawer beside my Earth shirt. Then I leave the drawer open while I wash my face, because closing it feels too much like deciding what the cloth means.

—○—

On the eighth evening, after the mender clears the short ladder, I take bread to the pantry roof.

The onions are still there.

Of course they are.

The world has the decency to ruin relationships and the indecency to preserve vegetables.

I sit where Sella sat the night she told me she would leave. The roof tile is colder now. My ankle tolerates the climb. I can still point to the place my heel nearly landed in the onions when she made me laugh.

For a while I eat bread and look east.
Then I take out one of my notebooks.
I write:
Sella.
Nothing else comes.
I try again.
I miss you.
Too small.
*I love you and I am furious that you are gone and proud that you went
and I hate that those are all the same sentence.*
Too much.
I scratch nothing out.
That is new.
I add:
*Iven is sleeping through the night. Teren cheats at cards. Lio has stolen
two more pens from Vey. Harra says the frame can be rebuilt but not before
the hearing. My ankle is mostly functional. Tolliver is being infuriatingly
respectful.*
I stare at that last line.
Then below it:
I hate that I noticed.
My face gets hot even though nobody is here.
I close the book.
There is still nowhere to send it.
Loving someone on a road has terrible administrative support.
I leave the page intact anyway.

—○—

At breakfast the next morning, somebody asks if the place across from me
is free.

I say yes before realizing it had become Sella's without either of us
deciding that.

A stoneworker named Nemm sits there and spends ten minutes
explaining why the kitchen ruins oats.

I hate him for three of those minutes.

Then he makes a good point about salt and becomes merely unfortunate.

Grief is petty enough to care about benches.

I work.

Harra makes me catalog the surviving rescue parts. Pell makes me sit
through hearing preparation over Rusk's claim. Vey brings copies. Iven

gives a formal account. Teren interrupts twice. Lio steals Vey's pen again.

Life continues with insulting competence.

Tolliver is around without orbiting me. He eats at the same table. Helps Harra move iron when asked. Takes route jobs that keep him away most of the day.

He does not touch me.

At first, I am grateful.

Then I am annoyed.

Then I become annoyed that I am annoyed.

I almost use Sella as a reason to stay that way.

She would hate that.

—○—

On the ninth night after Sella leaves, I find Tolliver in the yard splitting kindling.

His shirt sleeves are rolled. His forearms are doing deeply unnecessary things.

I have survived another world, a dungeon, a collapsing rescue frame, and emotional honesty. None of these provide immunity to forearms.

He looks up.

"Maya."

"I need to ask you something."

The axe goes down immediately.

Full attention.

Dangerous man.

"Ask."

I step closer. No limp. No wrap.

"What did Sella say to you?"

One corner of his mouth moves.

"No."

I stop.

"No?"

"She said it was private."

"I am almost certainly the subject."

"That does not make it yours."

I stare at him.

Infuriating.

Correct.

Worse because correct.

"Fine."

He waits.
I should leave.
Instead I look at his hands.
“Why haven’t you touched me?”
He goes still.
The question sounds different in the yard than it did in my head.
“Because you were hurt.”
“I’m not now.”
“Because she left.”
My chest tightens.
“That is not contagious.”
“No.”
“Then what?”
He leans the axe against the block.
“When you lost Earth, you grabbed whatever made the floor stop moving.”
The words sting because they are true enough to be dangerous.
“I am not grabbing you.”
“I know.”
“Do you?”
“Yes.”
He does not soften it.
“I wanted you before she left.”
My pulse jumps.
“I want you now.”
Worse.
“But I am not going to make the first night after you stop crying about someone else into proof that you chose me.”
Anger arrives fast enough to be useful.
“I have not been crying every night.”
“I know.”
“How would you know?”
“Your walls are not that thin.”
That almost makes me laugh.
Almost.
He takes one step closer and stops outside reach.
“If you want me, tell me when you can answer one question.”
I fold my arms.
“I already hate this.”

“Would you still want me if Sella’s wagon came back through that gate tomorrow?”

The yard goes quiet.

Not actually.

Somebody laughs inside the kitchen. A horse shifts in the stable. Wind moves a loose shutter.

But inside me, quiet.

I picture it because he made me.

The wagon.

Sella jumping down.

Her mouth.

Her hands.

The stupid hair tie in my drawer.

The ache is immediate.

I look at Tolliver. Nothing about him disappears.

My mouth opens.

Nothing comes out.

He waits, then nods once.

“That’s why.”

I hate him.

Specifically.

With focus.

“You’re very pleased with yourself.”

“No.”

“Your face is.”

“My face is medically neutral.”

I stare.

He stole that from the mender.

The bastard.

A laugh escapes me before I can stop it.

His mouth moves.

“Go to bed, Maya.”

“Do not tell me what to do.”

“Stay up, then.”

“Asshole.”

“Yes.”

I turn away furious enough to walk perfectly.

At the door, I look back.

He has picked up the axe again.

Not watching me leave.

Not making the moment bigger.

I go upstairs alone.

The hair tie is still in the drawer. The unfinished letter is still in the notebook.

I leave both where they are and go to bed.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The next night, Tolliver is in the same yard.

Different shirt.

Same woodpile.

I resent the consistency.

He sees me crossing toward him and sets the axe down before I say anything. I have spent most of the day inventorying bent iron with Harra and pretending I was not also inventorying my own motives.

It was not efficient.

"You told me to answer a question," I say.

His expression changes by almost nothing.

"I did."

"Ask it again."

He studies me for one long second.

"Would you still want me if Sella came back tomorrow?"

"Yes."

His shoulders go still.

I keep going.

"I would want her too."

"I know."

"I might be very confused."

"I know."

"I might cry again."

"I assumed."

"Rude."

"Accurate."

I step closer.

His eyes drop to my mouth.

Then come back.

"What are you doing tonight?" I ask.

"Nothing I cannot change."

Heat opens low in me. He has not made one move toward me in ten days.

“Change it.”

Tolliver does not move.

For one terrible second, I think I have miscalculated so badly that I will need to leave the region.

Then he says, “To what?”

The bastard knows.

He also knows I need to say it.

“You.”

His pupils widen. I keep going before courage discovers an exit.

“I want to be with you tonight.”

“With me.”

“Yes.”

“Not because Sella left.”

Her name still hurts. Less sharply than ten days ago, but enough.

“No.”

“Not because you owe me.”

I step into his space.

“You absolutely do not want to finish that sentence.”

One corner of his mouth moves.

“Why?”

“Because I am already doing something difficult, and if you turn this into a consent interview in the yard, I will push you into the woodpile.”

His eyes darken. Unfair.

“Maya.”

“What?”

“One more.”

I fold my arms. “Fine.”

“What do you want from me?”

My body knows before my pride does. Weeks of him asking. Waiting. Following the call instead of deciding it. Weeks of knowing exactly how much stronger he is and exactly how carefully he has chosen not to use that.

“I want you to stop being careful with me.”

He goes very still. I swallow.

“Not with my choices.”

His eyes stay on mine.

“With me.”

The words come quieter.

“I want to know what it feels like when you don’t have to pretend I can overpower you.”

His breathing changes. Mine follows.

“I can,” he says.

“I know.”

“You have reserve.”

“Eight.”

“Abilities.”

“Two.”

“Training.”

“Some.”

“You can stop me.”

“Yes.”

“Say it.”

“I can stop you.”

“How?”

“Words. Hands. Knee to the groin if you become stupid.”

That smile appears. Brief. Dangerous.

“Good.”

I am so turned on that I resent the existence of architecture. He steps closer without touching me.

“Your ankle.”

“Cleared.”

“Shield work?”

“Light. Full stairs. No powered-load restriction.”

“Stepguard?”

“The mender cleared it this morning.”

His gaze sharpens.

“You didn’t tell me.”

“I’m telling you now.”

He takes one slow breath.

“If you say stop?”

“Everything stops.”

“Slow?”

“You slow.”

“If you change your mind?”

“I tell you.”

He nods. Then, softer, “Last chance to walk away from the woodpile threat.” I grab his shirt and kiss him. For half a second, he lets me. Then his hand closes around my wrist. Not hard enough to hurt. Hard enough to

show me exactly how little my grip matters if he decides it does not. He pulls my hand away from his shirt. My pulse detonates. His other hand catches my jaw, and the kiss changes. Not rough. Controlled. Worse. Better.

His mouth moves against mine with the patience of someone who has spent weeks learning the difference between wanting and taking. I push into him. He gives me one step, then turns us. My back meets the stone wall beside the stable arch, cool through my shirt. His body is heat in front of me. He pins my wrist beside my head. One hand. One wrist. I test him. Actually test him. Pull. His arm barely moves. Fuck. He feels it. His mouth leaves mine.

“Again.”

“What?”

“Try.”

I yank harder, shoulder engaged, weight shifted. I could stop this. I do not. His eyes track the effort, hungry rather than smug.

“That what you wanted?”

I hate the tremor in my voice.

“Yes.”

He releases me immediately. The absence of pressure is almost worse. He waits while I rub my wrist, not because it hurts but because the skin remembers his hand.

“Inside,” I say.

“Your room?”

“Yes.”

“Door?”

“Locked.”

“By you?”

“Yes.”

His eyes burn.

“Lead.”

I do.

—○—

My room is not Greyward. Different bed. Different walls. My own boots by the door. My shield beside the washstand. Two notebooks on the table. A shirt Sella stole and returned badly folded over the chair. There are pieces of Earth here too, though not all of them. The shirt from my apartment is folded under the mattress. I have stopped hiding everything I came with as though owning it will get me arrested. Tolliver closes the door. I slide the

bolt myself. He watches.

The memory of Greyward comes anyway, sharp and ugly. He sees it.

“What?”

“I remembered the gate.”

His expression closes.

“Do you want me to leave?”

“No.”

“Maya.”

“No.”

I cross the room until I am standing in front of him.

“That is why this matters.”

He does not touch me.

“I hated when you said I was yours.”

“I know.”

“I hated you deciding things before I understood them.”

“I know.”

“I hated how much I wanted you anyway.”

His jaw tightens.

“That part was inconvenient.”

A breath of laughter escapes him. I put my hand against his chest.

“I am not yours because you said it at a gate.”

“No.”

“Or because you paid for a room.”

“No.”

“Or because you found me first.”

“No.”

I look up at him.

“But tonight I want to give you control because I want to know what you do with it.”

His focus settles on me with a new weight, dangerous and somehow safer because I put it there. He takes my hand from his chest and kisses the center of my palm. Then says, “Take off the boots.” I stare at him.

“That’s your opening?”

“Do you want a speech?”

“No.”

“Boots.”

Heat crawls up my spine. I sit and pull them off. He watches without helping or rushing me. When I stand, he points at my shield.

“Move it.”

“Why?”

"I don't want you falling into it."

Practicality, ruining everything beautifully. I move the shield. He points at the table corner. I shift that too.

"You are deeply romantic."

"I am planning to throw you onto the bed."

My knees nearly fail. He notices. Of course he notices.

"That," he says quietly. "I want that."

"What?"

"The part where you try not to react."

I recover enough to glare. His gaze moves over me.

"You do it when you're frightened. Angry. Hurt. You lock everything down until your face becomes a lie."

"That is an accusation."

"Observation."

"And your plan?"

He walks toward me slowly.

"Make the lie impossible."

My stomach flips. He stops close enough that I can feel his heat.

"Still yes?"

"Yes."

His hand goes into my hair. Not gentle. Not painful. Enough to tip my head back. The first kiss destroys every clever answer I had. He kisses me like he has been rationing it for weeks. I grab his waist. He catches both wrists and pins them behind my back with one hand. My breath breaks. There. That. His mouth moves to my jaw, then my neck. He bites just below my ear. A small sound escapes me. He stops moving for half a heartbeat, listening.

Then I feel his mouth curve against my skin.

"Oh."

"Do not."

"That was fast."

"Fuck you."

"Later."

I laugh despite myself. His grip tightens. The laugh catches. His free hand slides under my shirt, warm against my stomach, then higher until his palm covers one breast through the thin wrap beneath. My body leans into him before I make any decision at all. He notices that too.

"You want this off?"

"Yes."

He releases my wrists. I pull the shirt over my head. The wrap follows. I stand bare from the waist up. I have been naked in front of people before. Sella. Healers. Mirrors. This is different. Tolliver's gaze is not greedy in the way I expected. It is focused. Like he is memorizing a route he intends to ruin. His hands settle at my waist, move over my ribs, then to the underside of my breast. His thumb brushes my nipple. I inhale. He does it again.

"You are watching my face."

"Yes."

"That is creepy."

"Do you want me to stop?"

"No."

His thumb circles until the nipple tightens beneath it. Then he pinches. Not hard. Enough. My mouth opens. No sound. His eyes sharpen. Again. Harder. A broken noise gets out. Satisfaction moves through his face. Not because I cannot stop him. Because I reacted. I grab his shirt. This time he lets me.

"Off."

He pulls it over his head. I have seen him shirtless. Not enough. Lean, but not slight. Shoulders, chest, old pale scar along one side. The body that carried me like I weighed nothing. The body that spent weeks refusing to use that fact against me. I put both hands on him. He lets me explore for three breaths. Then catches my wrists again.

"Bed."

I glance over my shoulder. Three steps.

"I can walk."

"I know."

That should warn me. He bends, wraps one arm around my thighs, and the world tilts. I yelp when he lifts me over his shoulder. Actually over his fucking shoulder.

"Tolliver!"

"You said you wanted to know."

"I hate you."

"No, you don't."

I smack his back. He laughs. Then his hand lands on my ass. A sharp slap. My whole body jolts. He stops.

"Too much?"

"No."

"Again?"

I cannot believe this is my life.

"Yes."

The second slap is harder. Heat blooms across my skin. A pulse answers between my legs. He carries me the remaining step and puts me on the bed. Not drops. Puts. Then stands over me. I push up on my elbows.

“You are enjoying this too much.”

“Not yet.”

The words go straight through me. He kneels between my knees. Hands on my thighs.

“Can I take these off?”

My trousers.

“Yes.”

He does it slowly. No tearing. No performance. I lift my hips to help. My underwear goes with them. Then I am naked on my own bed while Tolliver still has his trousers on, looking at me with enough concentration to make nudity feel like a tactical error. I close my knees. His hand lands between them.

“Don’t.”

I stare at him. His voice stays calm.

“Open.”

I do. The choice itself lights something low in my body. His eyes drop. My face burns. He touches the inside of my thigh, lower than I need him. Then higher. Still avoiding. I swear. He looks up.

“What?”

“You know.”

“I want to hear it.”

I could refuse. Instead I say, “Touch my pussy.” His eyes close for half a second. Good. Not the only one suffering. When he opens them, his restraint has thinned. Two fingers slide through me slowly. I am already wet enough that the sound is obscene. My head falls back. He traces around my clit without touching it directly. Past. Back. Every pass makes my hips chase his hand. He catches one thigh and presses it into the mattress. Not both. Just enough.

“You keep moving.”

“You keep missing.”

“I am not missing.”

I glare. He smiles. Then touches my clit. Direct. Steady. My whole body contracts.

“There.”

He watches me.

“Fuck.”

“There too.”

I cover my face with one hand. He catches my wrist and pulls it away.

“No.”

“What?”

“I want to see you.”

The words are quiet. Serious. They hit harder than the slap. I stop fighting my own expression. For perhaps four seconds. Then one finger slides inside me and I lose the ability to conduct experiments. He curls it and adds another. My hips lift. He braces one forearm across my lower stomach, not crushing, simply making it impossible to pretend I am not moving. His other hand works between my legs while his eyes stay on my face. Everything narrows. Fingers. Pressure. His forearm. His stare. I reach for him.

He catches my wrist and pins it beside my head. One hand. Again. My body reacts so hard he notices.

“Is that it?”

I cannot answer. He slows his fingers.

“No.”

The offended sound I make is humiliating.

“Answer.”

“You know.”

“I want you to say it.”

“Yes.”

His grip tightens around my wrist. His fingers move again, harder now, more precise. I am close far too quickly. He knows.

“Toll.”

“Mm?”

“Don’t stop.”

“I wasn’t planning to.”

He changes the angle. My orgasm hits before I can protect myself from it. No graceful rise. No warning. One second I am holding together. The next I am shaking under him, clenching around his fingers and saying his name much too loudly. He keeps going through it. Not faster. Steady. My free hand fists in the blanket. My pinned hand cannot move. The loss of control is not the restraint. It is that he has made control useless. When the shaking starts to ease, he slows. Lets me breathe.

Releases my wrist. I stare at the ceiling. He kisses the inside of my knee.

“Still with me?”

“Unfortunately.”

He laughs. I lift my head.

“Pants.”

His eyebrows rise.

“Now.”

“I thought I was in control.”

“You’re not allowed to be stupid with it.”

“Accepted.”

He stands and unties them. I watch. Every bit of composure he stole from me becomes revenge fuel. He is hard. Very. My mouth goes dry. Tolliver catches exactly where I am looking.

“Problem?”

“No.”

“Lie.”

“Shut up.”

He steps out of the trousers. I sit up and reach for him. He catches my wrist again. I look up.

“What?”

“Tell me what you want.”

“You.”

“Specific.”

I consider murder. Instead I take his hand and put it against my throat. Not squeezing. Just there. His face changes.

“No.”

I blink.

“No?”

“Not tonight.”

Embarrassment flashes hot. He sees it before I can hide it.

“Not because I don’t want to.”

His thumb moves lightly against the side of my neck.

“I want your face. Your mouth. Your hands. Your hips. Every sound you keep trying to swallow. I am not adding your airway to the list the first night you give me this.”

The embarrassment disappears. Trust can be filthy.

“Fine,” I whisper.

“Good.”

I pull him closer.

“Fuck me.”

His eyes close again. That little fracture in his control. Mine. Then he climbs onto the bed and kisses me. I wrap my legs around him. His cock presses against me. He stops there.

“Last check.”

“Yes.”

“Condom?”

I stare. He reaches toward his discarded trousers. Of course he planned. I start laughing. His forehead drops to mine.

“What?”

“You planned.”

“I hoped.”

“How long have you been carrying that?”

He refuses to answer. I laugh harder. He bites my lower lip. The laughter breaks into a gasp.

“That works.”

“I noticed.”

He handles the sheath quickly and settles between my thighs. He looks at me. Waits. I hook my heel behind him and pull. He enters slowly. Even as wet as I am, the stretch empties my head. His jaw goes tight. Mine probably does too. He stops halfway.

“Okay?”

“Yes.”

“More?”

“Yes.”

He pushes deeper. I breathe through it, hands sliding over his shoulders. He is bigger than I expected. Not absurd. Enough that my body has to make room deliberately. When he is fully inside me, he stays still. The room contracts around my pulse, his breathing, the faint scrape of a chair somewhere downstairs. I look at him. This is Tolliver. The man who found me barefoot in the rain. The man who lied. The man who fed me. The man who scared me. The man who learned.

The man I chose tonight.

“Move.”

He does. One slow stroke out. Back in. My eyes close. His fingers catch my chin.

“Open.”

I do. He keeps the pace slow until I start meeting him. Then he hooks one hand under my knee and pushes it higher. The angle changes. Deepens. I cry out. He watches. There. Again. Every thrust lands where my thoughts scatter. I claw at his shoulder. He catches both wrists and pins them above my head with one hand. His body keeps moving. Power without hurry. I test his grip again. Not because I want free.

Because I want to feel that I could fight and still be choosing not to. He holds. My hips chase every thrust.

“Toll.”

“You can tell me to let go.”

“I know.”

“Do you want me to?”

“No.”

His mouth comes to my ear.

“Then stop pretending you do.”

Fuck. I turn my face and bite his shoulder. He grunts. Finally. A reaction I caused. I bite again. He drives into me harder. My back arches.

“That was rude,” I gasp.

“You started it.”

He lets my wrists go. Before I can decide what to do with my freedom, he rolls me. Suddenly I am on my stomach.

“Wait.”

He stops. Instantly. Hands off. Nothing moving. The speed of it cracks something soft open in my chest. I push up.

“My ankle.”

“Position?”

“Fine. Just don’t fold the left one under me.”

He nods.

“Show me.”

I arrange myself with my knees apart and the left foot extended enough not to torque the joint. He touches my hip.

“Good?”

“Yes.”

“Continue?”

“Yes.”

His hand slides into my hair and gathers it. Not yanking. Holding. The other closes around my hip. When he enters me from behind, the sound I make is not remotely dignified. He stops deep and waits.

“How?”

I know what he means.

“Harder.”

He does. The bed knocks the wall. Once. Twice. I bury my face in the blanket. His hand tightens in my hair and lifts my head.

“No hiding.”

I swear into the room. He laughs low behind me. Then his free hand slides under my body and finds my clit. My arms nearly collapse. He slows his thrusts enough to keep me balanced. Fingers circling. Cock deep. Grip in my hair. There is nowhere to put the sensation. I make sounds I will deny under oath. He says my name whenever I try to disappear into the blanket.

Not praise. Not command. Recognition. Maya. Here. Maya. This. His fingers press harder. Thought ends.

I come again with one hand braced against the wall, hard enough that my knees shake. He holds my hips through it. Does not chase his own finish until I stop trembling. Then his rhythm changes. Less controlled. Finally. I look back over my shoulder. His face is wrecked. Something viciously satisfying moves through me.

“You’re losing it.”

He opens his eyes.

“Careful.”

I smile.

“Make me.”

His hand leaves my hair and closes hard around my hip. He pulls me back onto him. The smile disappears. Again. Again. I grab the headboard.

“Tolliver.”

“Yes?”

“Asshole.”

“Yes.”

I laugh and moan at once. Then he bends over me, mouth against my shoulder, and comes with one broken sound that I feel more than hear. For a moment he stays there, breathing against my skin, heavy enough that I understand exactly what he meant when he said he could overpower me. Not hurting. Never accidental. He moves first, careful with my leg. Careful with everything now. He disposes of the sheath, brings me water, and waits until I drink. Then he sits on the edge of the bed.

Suddenly there is space between us. I hate it. The realization is embarrassing enough that I almost say nothing. Instead I touch his back. He turns.

“What?”

“Come here.”

He does. No hesitation. He lies beside me and I put my head on his chest. For a while, neither of us speaks. His fingers move slowly through my hair, nothing like the grip from before. My body is loose and pleasantly sore. My ankle is fine. I check because I am not an idiot. Mostly.

“Was that what you wanted?” he asks.

I think about it.

“Yes.”

“Anything you didn’t?”

“The interrogation.”

“You answered every question.”

“Under protest.”

“I noticed.”

I trace the scar along his ribs. He catches my fingers, not stopping me, just holding them for a moment.

“Was I too rough?”

“No.”

“Too careful?”

I laugh against his chest.

“Possibly.”

His hand tightens in my hair just enough to remind me. My body reacts immediately. Traitor. He feels it.

“Interesting.”

“Do not become unbearable.”

“Too late.”

I lift my head. He is smiling. Small. Real. I kiss him. This one has no game in it. No proving. Just mouth, warmth, choice. When I pull back, the smile is gone.

“Maya.”

“What?”

“What happens now?”

There it is. We are still required to speak after sex. I roll onto my back and stare at the ceiling.

“I don’t know.”

He nods. No flinch. No punishment. I turn my head.

“I want this again.”

His mouth twitches.

“Useful data.”

“I want you.”

That ends the joke.

“I’m not promising forever.”

“I didn’t ask.”

“I’m not promising I stop loving Sella.”

“I would think less of you if you did.”

My chest tightens.

“She might come back.”

“Yes.”

“I might want both of you.”

“Yes.”

“You might decide you hate that.”

“Yes.”

I blink.
“Very supportive.”
“You asked for truth.”
That lands cleanly. He looks at the ceiling.
“I don’t know what I can live with until I’m living with it.”
“That is annoyingly mature.”
“I have other qualities.”
“I saw one.”
He covers his face with one hand. Victory. I grin. Then the grin fades.
“I need one thing from you.”
He lowers his hand.
“What?”
“No disappearing into decisions again. If something affects me, you tell me before you choose for me.”
“Yes.”
“Even if you think you’re protecting me.”
“Yes.”
“Even if you know better.”
A pause. Then, “Yes.” I believe him because he has spent weeks practicing the answer before tonight.
“Your turn.”
He looks surprised.
“What do you need?”
His eyes move across my face.
“When you’re angry, tell me what I did.”
“That seems obvious.”
“It is not obvious to you.”
Accurate enough to sting.
“I communicate through atmosphere.”
“You communicate through violence toward furniture.”
“One chair.”
“Two.”
“The second deserved it.”
He waits.
“Fine.”
“And if you want me to take control like this again, say so.”
Heat returns to my face.
“You can’t tell?”
“I can tell when you’re aroused. I cannot tell what you consent to tomorrow from what you consented to tonight.”

That shuts me up. He kisses my forehead. Tenderness after being pinned to a mattress turns out to be a weapon.

“Fine.”

“Fine?”

“I’ll use words.”

“Tragic.”

I bite his chest. He laughs and catches my chin.

“Again?”

I should sleep. Harra wants inventory in the morning. Vey wants a statement. Pell wants to reconcile the retained workdays since the expedition contract ended. My life is an administrative fire with bedding. Also, I am naked with Tolliver. Priorities.

“Yes.”

His eyes darken.

“But this time,” I say, “I’m on top.”

One eyebrow rises.

“I thought you wanted me in control.”

“Both can be true.”

“Convenient.”

“Extremely.”

I swing a leg over him. He lets me. For now. The knowledge makes me smile. Tomorrow I will still be Level Six. Warder. Homesick. In love with a woman somewhere on the east road. Falling harder for the man beneath me. Still mine, even when I choose not to be.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The first thing I do after sleeping with Tolliver is argue about payroll. This is not how romance novels work. Nobody wakes after life-altering sex to find a factor, a keeper, a landholder, and one terrifyingly awake clerk downstairs with thirteen days of retained labor arranged in four columns. Yet here we are. Tolliver sits beside me at the long table with damp hair and the offensive appearance of a man who slept normally. I know what that mouth did last night. He looks like he ate breakfast.

Pell pushes the first sheet toward me.

"You said you wanted every day separated."

"I did."

"You refused a summary."

"I did."

"And you made Mara reconstruct which days you were medically restricted, which days you were consulted anyway, and when the original agreement should have ended."

"Yes."

Pell leans back.

"You are exhausting."

"Pay me."

Mara coughs into one hand. Suspiciously close to laughter. Vey does not bother hiding his. Tolliver keeps his eyes on the sheet. Smart man. Mara has separated everything: planning under restriction, equipment review, far-side coordination, rescue work, statements, measurements, copies. Two entries read REST RESTRICTION, RETAINED FOR CONSULTATION, which feels unfair until I remember making Harra carry the spring shoe into the kitchen so I could criticize it with my foot on a stool. The expedition days and the earlier paid day are marked separately so nobody counts them twice.

This sheet begins with the first unpaid recovery morning and ends yesterday. Thirteen days. Eight bits each. One hundred and four bits. Thirteen pieces. I read the total three times because another world has not

cured me of expecting paperwork to bite.

“Both rest entries count?”

Pell looks almost offended.

“You remained under my instruction and unavailable for other work because of an injury sustained here. You were also consulted.”

“That is nearly reasonable.”

“Do not spread it around.”

A small sealed purse lands in front of me with the soft, dense sound of money that belongs to me. I do not touch it yet.

“Property damage?”

“None charged.”

“Treatment?”

“Covered.”

“Room?”

“Through today under the unused return-passage term.”

“Food?”

“Covered.”

“Return cart?”

Pell looks at me.

“To where?”

Greyward, technically. The original agreement assumed I would go back there after the reading work. Then I stayed. Then a trapped man and a boundary capable of cutting people in half rearranged the calendar.

“I want the value instead.”

Vey lifts one eyebrow. Pell says, “For what?”

“My room.”

The room goes quiet. Mara stops her pen. Tolliver turns his head. I keep looking at Pell.

“The contract owes me return travel. I am not using it because Greyward is not automatically where I belong. Credit the value here.”

“How long?”

I have done the math. That is the frightening part.

“Four weeks.”

“The west rooms are not leased by the month.”

“Then start.”

Vey laughs. Pell looks at him. He becomes fascinated by the wall.

“Same room if possible,” I continue. “My lock stays mine while I occupy it. My possessions remain mine while I am away on paid work. No House claim because I store equipment under your roof. Renting the room does not make me Rook service.”

Mara is writing now. Fast. Pell rubs one hand over her mouth.

“You came here with six bits.”

“I have improved.”

“That is one description.”

“I also accept impressive.”

Beside me, Tolliver’s mouth moves. I kick him under the table. He catches my ankle between his boots before I can pull it back. Not the injured one. Of course. His hands never leave the table. Nobody notices. My face heats anyway. Bastard. Pell names a price. I counter. She points out that the room is furnished. I point out that it is above a kitchen and the west shutter sticks in rain. She points out three gouges in the floor from my shield fittings. I blame the shield.

The shield is not present to defend itself. We settle at twenty-eight bits in cash after the unused return fare is credited. Four weeks. Same room. A locked storage chest in the records annex while I am traveling. Mara adds the property language. I read every line before signing. Only then do I open the purse. Thirteen pieces. I count them. Pell watches.

“You think I shorted you?”

“No.”

“You are counting.”

“Yes.”

She nods. She knows exactly why. I slide three pieces and four bits back across for the room. The rest goes into my purse. It is heavier than any amount of money I have owned here. Not enough to make me rich. Enough that tomorrow does not belong to whoever feeds me. Mara turns the next page.

“Now the card.”

Everything in me sharpens. Vey stops smiling. Elena Ruth Mercer has been in this room for months without ever physically being here. Missouri. Independence. A face on flexible plastic. Proof that I was not the first person from Earth to end up somewhere impossible. Mara sets the card on the table inside a folded square of clean linen. I do not reach for it. I have learned at least one thing about disputed property.

“The local review is complete,” Pell says.

“Local.”

“Rusk may dispute recovered iron from the receiving station. She has no claim to this.”

I look at Vey.

“The card was classified as personal identification retained in error with survey-associated material.”

“In error.”

“Yes.”

“You signed the retention.”

“Yes.”

No defense. Interesting. Mara rests two fingers beside the linen.

“Elena’s personal effects remain Elena’s. The original stays in recorded custody here unless she returns, gives lawful instruction, or a higher authority orders otherwise.”

“And my copy?”

Mara slides another sheet toward me. Both sides, carefully reproduced in ink. Her name. The address. Dates. The little outline of Missouri. My English transcription beneath the local notes. My chest hurts. I know a highway ten minutes from that address. I know what gas stations smell like at two in the morning. I know winter salt drying white on black floor mats and fluorescent grocery aisles where people are choosing cereal right now, probably angry about prices. For one dangerous second, the paper is not paper.

It is a hole. Then Tolliver’s thumb presses once against the side of my boot beneath the table. Tiny. Here. I breathe.

“The copy is mine?”

“Yes,” Mara says.

“No claim if I use the information to look for Elena?”

Vey answers.

“No ownership claim on a name.”

“Good.”

I fold the copy and put it inside my notebook. Mine to carry. The original stays where it belongs until Elena says otherwise. Mara brings out the final packet. Iven’s testimony. Harra’s measurements. Dain’s diagrams. My notes. Pressure observations. A clean drawing of the receiving station. The disputed iron remains on the far side under preservation claim. The information does not. Rusk argued about that yesterday. She lost. I am sorry I missed it. Not very sorry.

“What happens to her claim?”

“Hearing in Greyward when the district clerk can take it,” Pell says.

“Exclusive access?”

“No.”

“Custody of Iven?”

“No.”

“Can she stop another survey?”

“Not outside the preserved chamber, and not on my land without a separate right.”

Good enough. Rusk gets metal nobody is currently touching and a future appointment with clerks. Mara taps the diagram.

“One more thing.”

There is a mark in the upper corner I do not remember. Three short strokes beneath a hooked symbol.

“Where did that come from?”

“Iven.”

The door opens behind us. Iven walks in carrying a cup. Actually walks. Slowly. Still too thin. Still gray around the eyes. Alive enough to be annoyed by stairs. Teren follows him like a bodyguard who has not yet reached my shoulder. Lio follows Teren, because nobody in this family gets to move alone again. Iven lowers himself into the empty chair across from me.

“That was on the wall behind the shelves.”

“The Earth shelves?”

“The ugly metal ones.”

“They are beautiful.”

“They are ugly.”

“They are from home.”

“That does not improve them.”

I take that personally. He points at the symbol.

“I thought it was a mason mark. Dain says it is not.”

Mara pulls an older sheet from beneath the diagram, copied from a Rook route register. The same hooked symbol appears beside three lines. I read them automatically. RIDGE SERVICE ROAD. SECOND RECEIVING HOUSE. NORTH APPROACH UNSOUND AFTER SPRING FLOOD. My skin prickles. Not Earth. Not Missouri. A road in this world leading toward another place connected to the thing that caught me. The difference should disappoint me more than it does. That is new enough to frighten me.

“How far?”

Vey answers.

“Three days beyond Greyward by the ridge road in good weather.”

“And bad?”

“Longer.”

“Remarkably useful.”

Pell’s expression has become too innocent.

“There is a caravan leaving Greyward in six days.”

I look at her.

“What caravan?”

“Six wagons. Two family groups. Wool, lamp oil, seed stock. Bound for the ridge settlements. Their regular guard company withdrew after the washout report.”

My pulse picks up.

“The caravan master wants escort through the lower ridge road,” Pell continues. “And someone to inspect whether the old receiving-house approach is passable enough to serve as emergency shelter.”

Vey places another paper on the table. Of course he already has the offer. I do not touch it.

“How much?”

His smile appears. I hate that smile.

“Negotiable.”

“So the number is bad.”

“It is a starting number.”

“Which is?”

“Four pieces for escort lead. Two for the station inspection if completed without entering sealed lower works.”

I stare at him.

“For the whole party?”

“For you.”

That shuts me up. Briefly.

“Other hires separate?”

“Yes.”

“Authority?”

“Caravan movement. You do not own the guards.”

“Good.”

“Reports?”

“One to the caravan master. One to Rook if Rook funds the inspection. You keep your own copy.”

“Recovered property?”

Vey pauses. I point at him.

“No.”

“I did not say anything.”

“You paused criminally.”

Tolliver finally speaks.

“She knows you now.”

Vey looks wounded. I feel nothing. We work through the rest. No automatic claim to personal finds. No entry into sealed lower works without

a separate agreement. No exclusivity on route knowledge. Food and lodging covered. Return allowance can become cash. Assigned-work injuries covered. I can stop if the road becomes materially different from what the contract describes. The questions come easily now. Months ago, I would not have known to ask half of them. The System has never given me progress for reading a contract twice.

Probably for the best.

"I'm not signing today."

Vey looks almost proud.

"Good."

"Do not look pleased with yourself."

"I am merely attentive."

"You're taking credit for me becoming difficult."

"I would never."

Liar. I turn to Tolliver. He has not asked to come.

"Are you free to leave in four days?"

"Yes."

"For the ridge job."

"Yes."

"Do you want it?"

His gaze stays on mine.

"If you take it."

My chest does something inconvenient. I look at Harra's empty chair.

"Harra?"

Pell says, "She already asked about the equipment allowance." I laugh. Of course she did. Iven raises his cup.

"I am not going."

"I did not ask."

"Good."

His sons visibly relax.

"I will help you read the far-side notes before you leave," he says.

"Only if you want to."

"I want to know what was under my feet for seventy-one sleeps."

Teren says, "He counted badly." Iven looks offended.

"I was trapped between realities."

"You still counted badly."

Lio nods solemnly. I cover my mouth. Iven points at both boys.

"This is what I survived for."

"Unfortunately," Mara says.

The room breaks into laughter. For half a second, it feels wrong. Then nobody dies from laughing either.

—○—

By afternoon, I own a chest. It is a box. It should not be emotional. Harra found it in storage, declared the hinges insulting, replaced them, added an iron loop, and charged me four bits for materials after refusing payment for the labor. I tried to argue. She threatened to remove the hinges. I stopped. The chest sits at the foot of my bed. My bed. Four weeks, paid. Longer if I decide to pay again.

My green shield leans beside it, the repaired bite along the edge still visible if I know where to look. I do. My Earth clothes are folded inside the chest. Not hidden. The copied Missouri card rests in the top tray beneath my notebook. My money is split between my purse and a cloth packet under the tray because I have finally learned that carrying every asset on my body is a game mechanic, not a financial plan. Sella's badly folded shirt is still on the chair.

I leave it there. I am not ready to put it away. That is allowed. Someone knocks.

"Open."

Tolliver enters with two practice sticks. I look at them.

"No."

"You asked about sword training."

"I asked about swords."

"You need footwork before someone gives you one."

"I have footwork."

"You have Stepguard."

"That is literally magical footwork."

"That is reserve expenditure covering bad decisions."

I narrow my eyes. He smiles.

"Outside."

I glance at the chest. Then the room. Then him.

"Wait."

He does. I take my key from the table and lock the chest. Then lock the room behind us. No one tells me to. No one keeps the other key. Mine. In the yard, Harra has drawn three chalk lines beside the stable. She waves without looking up from a buckle she is repairing. Tolliver tosses me a stick. I catch it. My ankle holds. I still test the weight before trusting it.

"Rules?"

"No Stepguard."

“Coward.”

“No Brace.”

“Afraid?”

“Yes.”

That makes me pause. He twirls the stick once.

“If you Brace through bad stance, you learn bad stance.”

Annoyingly sensible.

“Fine.”

“If the ankle hurts, we stop.”

I lift the stick. He hits me in the shoulder in under three seconds.

“Fuck.”

“Again.”

Second attempt lasts five. Third, seven. On the fourth, I stop trying to beat his hand and move my body out of the line. His stick passes my ribs. Mine taps his wrist. Not hard. I freeze. He looks at the contact. Then at me. There is that expression again. Interested.

“Again.”

Heat crawls under my collar. Broad daylight. Fully clothed. Three people in the yard. Still dangerous. I smile.

“Try not to lose control.”

His eyes narrow. Harra snorts from across the yard. Tolliver attacks. I last nine seconds. Improvement.

—○—

At sunset, I sit on the west wall with my shield beside me and the ridge-road offer across my knees. I have not signed it. Yet. The sky has finally cleared after three days of broken cloud. From here, Rook looks less like a problem I am trying to solve and more like a place with particular bad masonry. The repaired drainage channel catches the last light beyond the lower field. Water moves through it. Pell’s people are still arguing over the final retaining stones.

A cart comes through the gate with flour. Somebody in the kitchen drops a pan. A child screams because another child has committed a serious crime involving mud. The world refuses to become symbolic for me. Good. Tolliver sits beside me. Not touching. Close enough that our boots nearly do. He looks at the paper.

“Decided?”

“Mostly.”

“Dangerous.”

“The station is the part.”

He waits. I trace the route mark with one finger. Three strokes. Hooked symbol. A road to another receiving house. Maybe Elena went that way. Maybe she did not. Maybe the place is empty. Maybe it is full of monsters. Maybe it smells like mold and old iron and contains absolutely nothing I can use. The job matters anyway. Six wagons. Families. Seed stock. A damaged road. People trying to arrive somewhere alive. That matters even if Missouri never appears at the end of it.

"I want to go."

Tolliver nods. No warning. No list of reasons I should stay. I look at him.

"That's it?"

"What do you want?"

"A little resistance. For drama."

"No."

"Terrible boyfriend."

His head turns. The word hangs there. I did not plan it. My mouth has started accepting side quests. Tolliver studies me.

"Is that what I am?"

I consider pretending I never said it. Old habit. Bad habit.

"If you want to be."

He looks toward the yard. Then back at me.

"Yes."

Simple. My chest goes warm.

"No exclusivity promise."

"I remember."

"No deciding my jobs."

"I remember."

"No making me ask permission to leave."

His expression sharpens.

"I remember."

"And if Sella comes back..."

"We talk."

"Yes."

He puts one hand on the stone between us, palm up. Offering. I put mine in it. Still dangerous in daylight.

"What do I call you?" he asks.

"Warder Supreme."

"No."

"Your devastatingly competent employer."

"You are not employing me."

“Good catch.”

His thumb moves across my knuckles.

“Maya works.”

I lean into his shoulder for maybe ten seconds. Then sit up. One more thing. I open my measure. The familiar awareness settles over me.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 6]

[RUN: WARDER]

Eight reserve, full after days without spending. Brace. Stepguard. Controlled Release in the strange category where the System has named something I learned without turning it into a button. Origin still blank. It bothers me less. Once, that empty place looked like proof that I belonged nowhere. Now there is a key in my pocket. A room behind me that I paid for. A shield I bought. A chest full of things I chose to keep. A woman I love somewhere east under the same sky.

A man holding my hand because I put mine there. People downstairs who will notice if I miss breakfast.

Blank does not mean empty.

I let the measure close. Then I sign the ridge-road offer. MAYA SZCZEPANIAK. My handwriting is still ugly. Tolliver watches the ink dry.

“Six days,” he says.

“Four. Two days on the cart. I want to reach Greyward before the caravan leaves and see Ordway.”

His eyebrows lift.

“You planned that.”

“I occasionally plan ahead.”

He groans. Below us, Harra shouts that if we are really taking the ridge job, she wants two pack frames, a proper rope inventory, and written authority to refuse any idiot who tries to make her carry decorative iron. I lean over the wall.

“Are you coming?”

She looks up.

“You paying?”

“Yes.”

“Then probably.”

“Romantic.”

“Fuck off.”

Tolliver laughs. I look east. Somewhere beyond the road, Sella is moving toward the life she chose. Somewhere beyond Greyward, Elena

may still be alive. Somewhere under a ridge, another old station is waiting. None of those things are mine yet. That is fine. I fold the contract and tuck it into my notebook. Four days from now, I leave Rook. Not because somebody bought my service before I understood the terms. Not because a man found me in the rain.

Not even because I am chasing a door back to Missouri. I am leaving because there is work I want, a road I have not seen, and people I have chosen to walk it with. For the first time since I woke under the trees, forward feels like a direction instead of a threat. I stand with my shield in one hand. Tolliver's hand stays in the other for exactly three steps, until Harra yells at us to stop being useless and help with the inventory.

Home, apparently, has chores.